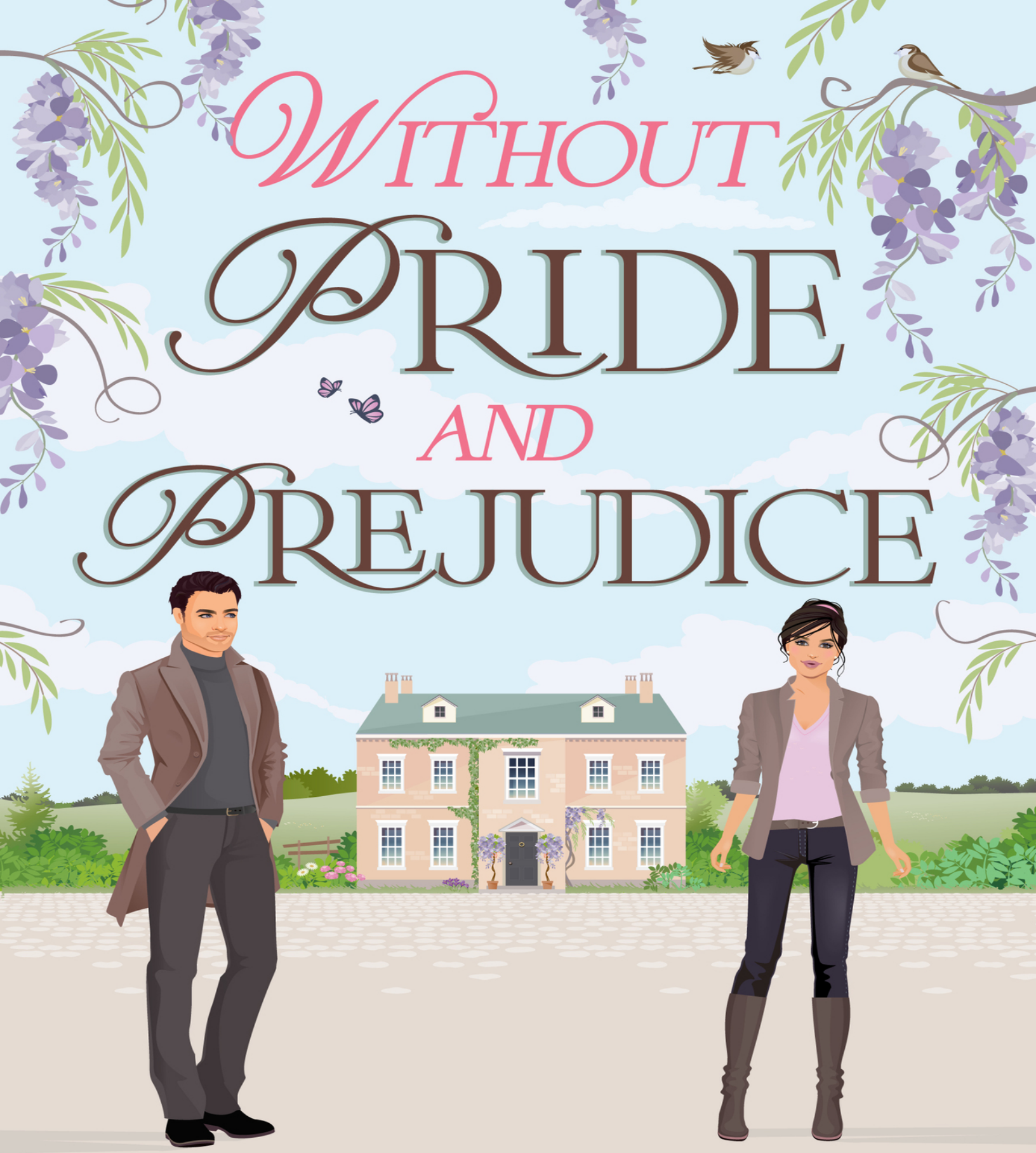
# Without Pride and Prejudice



*USA TODAY* BESTSELLING AUTHOR

JENNIFER PEEL

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***OceanofPDF.com***

# WITHOUT PRIDE AND PREJUDICE

*USA TODAY* BESTSELLING AUTHOR
JENNIFER PEEL

OceanofPDF.com

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**Dedication**

To Mr. Darcy—I love you. That is all.

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# PRIDE & PREJUDICE PARK

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# Meet the Cast of Pride and Prejudice Park

**Monroe Wilde**
Her life goal is to be an Elizabeth, but she's afraid that she might be more of a Kitty. Has a cat named Mr. Darcy.

**The Duke of Blackthorne, Alastair Fitzroy**
Talks Darcy a little too well. Secretly irritated that he was named only the second hottest man in the UK.

**Macey Bennet**
Wishes she was born in the Regency era but only if she didn't have to wear a corset.

**Zane Porter**
Guilted into this by his sister.
Secretly likes how good his butt looks in breeches.

**Laila Gray**
District Attorney by day, major Pride and Prejudice enthusiast by night.

**Davis Gray**
Wanted to go on cruise for his 25th wedding anniversary,
ended up cosplaying Mr. Bennet.

**Lady Winnifred Roberts**
Has the uncanny ability to look down on everyone with her nose stuck up in the air. Finds destitute plumbers strangely attractive.

**Tony Baker**
Considers corn nuts a food group. Has no idea who Jane Austen is.

**Calliope Griffin**
Would love to sign up for a lifetime of boiling potatoes for Mr. Collins.
Has her own copy of Fordyce's Sermon for Young Women.

**Ava Higgins**

Watches White Nights at least once a week and dreams of becoming a professional tap dancer.

**Carla Higgins**
Pretends like she's the leader of a girl gang, but secretly has a heart of gold.

**Lily Hawthorne**
Is ashamed to be Agatha Smythe's niece. Has the worst taste in men.

**Agatha Smythe**
She claims to be related to Jane Austen, but no one can substantiate it. Hates romantic pursuits.

**Sebastian Fairfax**
Handsome enough to tempt anyone. Despises boiled potatoes.

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# VOLUME ONE

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# PROLOGUE

**Thirteen Years Ago**

***"There are very few of us who have heart enough to be really in love without encouragement."***

## MONROE

"OKAY, YOU GOT THIS," I whispered to myself, even though I felt more out of place than ever. I swore the necktie I had to wear as part of my school uniform was trying to strangle me. Never in a million years would I have thought I'd be attending some fancy private school in the UK during what should have been my junior year in high school. The school doubled as both a day school and a boarding school, but thankfully I was only attending the day school.

This new school of mine was so fancy, I'd heard rumors that nobility and movie stars' children attended. I didn't care how famous any of the students were—I just wanted to be back home in Kansas, hanging out with my friends on the lawn before school, laughing and talking about our new class schedules and the boys we were crushing on.

I'd had high hopes that Finn Cavanaugh would ask me to homecoming this year. We'd flirted all summer while working together at one of the local ice cream shops. But then my dad got this opportunity to work in the UK. His company offered to pay for what they touted as a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity for me. I knew Dad really wanted to do this and that it would look great on his résumé. He's the best dad in the world, so I wanted to support him. But now, looking around at the school's courtyard full of a hundred total strangers, I was feeling less supportive.

*Just play it cool. Find someone who's lonely, just like you*, I silently told myself. I was testing out a theory: Maybe in the UK I could actually help

people without it going all wrong. Back home, I'd been a tiny bit of a disaster. Okay, maybe more than a tiny bit. For some reason, I was jinxed in the assistance department. Dad said it was part of my charm. I guess I was about to see how charming I could be in a foreign country.

I slowly walked across the cobblestone path between the buildings with ivy climbing up the brick walls, looking like something out of a Jane Austen movie. It calmed my heart a little. I loved all things Jane Austen, especially Mr. Darcy. My goal in life was to be Elizabeth Bennet. I wasn't quite there yet, meaning I had about a million miles to go.

I bit my lip as I walked, feeling like everyone was staring at me, as if they knew I didn't really belong here. But somewhere, amid all the discomfort, an unseen magical force magnetically drew me to the most beautiful boy I'd ever seen, making me forget where I was and how out of place I felt. Strangely, his presence made me feel a weird comfort I'd never known before.

The godlike creature sat on a wrought iron bench near a large oak tree, immersed in a leather-bound book. I was grateful the book didn't cover his gorgeous, chiseled face. I hadn't realized boys his age could have such flawless features—they certainly didn't where I came from. Maybe he was a movie star himself, with his gray broody eyes and light scruff. The eyes and scruff went perfectly with his immaculately styled hair that was longer on top with neat, trim sides. The preppy tie and jacket didn't hurt either—I guess school uniforms weren't all that bad, even if I was missing my comfortable jeans.

I was so drawn to him, I knew I had to talk to him. But that was a crazy thought, given he appeared to have the attention of almost every girl in the courtyard—no shock there. The shocking thing was that he didn't seem to care. The boys I knew back home would have jumped at all the attention. Whoever this demigod was, he seemed unbothered or even bored by their regard. That probably should have stopped me from approaching him, but his pull was too strong, even when I saw a beautiful girl with long ebony hair sit on the bench and slide right up next to him like a suction cup.

He leaned away from her, obviously not thrilled with the attention. It made me second-guess myself even more. But the call refused to be ignored. Too bad that in my haste, I let my heavy book bag slip and then managed to trip over it. It might have been okay, except gravity took over and I couldn't steady myself. Instead, I face-planted on the grass, missing

the cobblestone by inches. It was my worst nightmare come to life. Knowing my luck, my skirt was probably up around my waist, showing off my panties. With that lovely thought, I did the only thing I could under the circumstances: I jumped up as fast as I could, threw my arms in the air, and said, “Ta-da!” like an idiot.

Unfortunately, that got everyone’s attention.

*Way to start your first day*, I thought to myself as everyone gaped at me, some laughing and pointing.

Feeling like I wanted to crawl under a rock, I reached down to pick up my bag, but to my surprise, someone was already handing it to me. And not just any someone—it was the beautiful boy.

“Are you all right?” he asked in his charming British accent.

A nervous giggle escaped. “Uh . . . yeah . . . I was just warming up,” I teased.

The corners of the beautiful boy’s lips ticked up as if he wanted to smile but refused to.

Everyone in the courtyard still stared at me, but instead of laughing, I heard them whispering things like, “Does Lord Alastair know her?” and “I’ve never seen him help anyone before.”

Was he really a lord? Lord of what? Lord of the Flies? Lord of the Rings? I took my book bag from him. “Thank you. Um, I’m Monroe, by the way.” *PS: I think I’m going to fall in love with you.* Thankfully, those words didn’t escape, but it was true. I couldn’t stop staring at him; it felt as if I knew him already.

“You’re welcome. I’m Alastair Fitzroy.”

He didn’t provide a title with his name. “That’s a fancy name, Alastair Fitzroy. I think I’m just going to call you Fitz.”

His gray eyes widened while a deafening hush went through the courtyard. I’d obviously committed a big faux pas, although that was to be expected. My middle name could be *social blunder*. I waited for him to correct me or to humiliate me.

But he didn’t. Instead, he tilted his head and studied me, making my heart pound harder than Coldplay’s drummer beating out “Viva la Vida.” What was he trying to decide about me? I’d never had someone stare at me so intensely. He finally said, “If we are going to be friends, you can’t call me Fitz.”

I smiled and swung my book bag around my shoulder, feeling as if my day—and life—had somehow just gotten better. I nudged him with my hip as I walked past him. “You’ll get used to it, *Fitz*.”

**Eleven and a Half Years Ago**

# FITZ

THE SMELL OF HOMEMADE CHEESEBURGERS wafted through the modest flat while I sat on an old rickety piano bench with Monroe. I loved hearing her angelic voice as she played and sang my favorite Billy Joel song, “And So It Goes.” I wished, like the song says, that I could be with her—if it were my choice to make. But my father’s title, which would one day be mine, didn’t allow me that luxury. And I would never subject Monroe to the kind of scrutiny my family encountered. Or worse, the scrutiny my parents had already given Monroe after her first, and so far only, visit to our estate. My parents didn’t care for her brand of quirkiness. Normally I didn’t either, but there was just something about her that I was drawn to. Her crazy was growing on me, even though we were complete opposites. She had this way of making me feel like a real person and not just the son of a duke.

Monroe stopped playing abruptly and turned her gorgeous head toward me. I’d tried to stifle these thoughts about her, knowing we could never be more than friends. But there is no denying her beauty. She has the silkiest dark hair, and her brown eyes shine all the time, no matter her mood, which was mostly good. I’ve never known anyone as happy as Monroe. The odd thing was, she and her father were living in what I would consider a cramped flat with rented furniture—even Monroe’s out-of-tune piano was a rental. And from what Monroe said, their small, comfortable home in the States was outdated, yet she loved it all the same. My family, meanwhile, has had every luxury in life and we are mostly a miserable lot.

“You’ll come visit me in America after the school year is over, right?” she begged to know.

I shrugged noncommittally, not wishing to think about her leaving. The past year and a half had been the best of my life—not that I would admit it. I didn’t do well with emotion—it was a family trait. I’d been attending boarding school since I was eight, and sneaking out to visit Monroe and her

dad almost every evening made me feel like I finally belonged somewhere. “I’ll be preparing to attend Oxford,” I reminded her.

She rolled her pretty eyes. “I think you’ve been prepared to attend Oxford since birth. Come on, you have to visit. We can watch all the old musicals I have on DVD—some even on VHS. My grams has an old VCR we can use.”

Monroe and her obsession with musicals. I’d watched more musicals with her than I’d ever cared to, but there was something about seeing her face light up or hearing her sing along that made it worth it. Well, most of the time. I could have done without *Starlight Express*.

When I said nothing, she continued. “And I can introduce you to some of my cute friends. Oh, wait,” she giggled. “I forgot you can’t be with an American because we don’t appreciate history,” she mocked.

I’d only said that in order to keep my feelings for Monroe at bay. I figured if she never thought we had a chance, she wouldn’t tempt me. But it hadn’t worked. She tempted me like no girl ever had. “Exactly,” I lied.

“Okay, fine, but you should still come. Grams would love to meet you, and we can go to the OZ Museum.”

“That sounds riveting,” I said dryly.

“Listen, Fitz,” she emphasized the nickname she’d given me—I was less than fond of it, but I’d come to terms with it, only because it was she who had given it to me. If anyone else called me Fitz, they would rue the day. “We take *The Wizard of Oz* seriously in Kansas.”

I couldn’t help but laugh.

“I like your laugh. You should laugh more often.” She turned and went back to playing the piano, her delicate fingers gliding across each key with grace. You could tell she felt every note.

It was maddening how she knew exactly what to say—not because it was necessarily profound, but because she made me see things about myself that no one else noticed, not even myself. She was the first person in my life who didn’t seem to want anything from me other than my company. She didn’t even care that I was part of the peerage here in the UK, other than asking me to teach her how to curtsy. Monroe was the oddest, most wonderful person I’d ever met. And I was going to miss her.

I flipped some hair off her shoulder. “I’ll see if I can come in August.”

Instantaneously, she threw her arms around me. “Yay! I can’t wait.”

Admittedly, neither could I. Cautiously, I hugged her back, trying not to breathe in her sweet scent or think about her soft skin or how my heart raced every time we touched. *It's just boyhood infatuation*, I would tell myself. We were only seventeen and from two different worlds. Friends was all we could ever be.

"I can't either." Those might be the most frightening words I had ever spoken.

**Seven Years Ago**

# MONROE

"YOU SOUND TIRED," FITZ'S SEXY voice echoed through the phone.

I immediately reminded myself not to think of the word *sexy* when it came to him. Our friendship was too important for me to go messing it up with those kinds of thoughts—thoughts I knew Fitz would never have about me, and ones I had long buried deep inside the most precious parts of my heart.

I pressed the cell phone closer to my ear as I sprawled out on the motel room bed, not caring that it squeaked something awful and smelled faintly of cigarette smoke. "We played two gigs tonight."

I'd gone on the road with a supposedly up-and-coming band out of the Kansas City area as a backup singer and piano player. I'd thought it would be an adventure to tour the country the summer after I graduated from college. It was certainly adventurous, sleeping in dives and traveling in a beat-up bus from city to city, hardly knowing what day it was.

"I'm exhausted," I admitted. "How are you? It's early for you."

"I'm working on a paper about the influence of Victorian morality in the works of Charles Dickens."

"Of course you are," I laughed. Fitz had graduated from Oxford in May. I'd been there to cheer him on, to the dismay of his dear mum and dad, who refused to even sit by me during the ceremony. Then, at their request, a maid followed me around the graduation party they'd thrown on their large estate in the village of Blackhaven, ensuring I didn't help anyone or break anything. Sheesh. You shoot one arrow through a window and bleed on a carpet gifted by the Queen, and no one trusts you again. Okay, so I totally understood it. Admittedly, I could be a hot mess, unlike Fitz, who was

starting his doctoral program at Oxford in October. He was anything but a hot mess. Except for the *hot* part. Dang it, I needed to stop that line of thinking. Anyway, my not-thinking-about-how-hot-he-is best friend was taking some summer courses at Cambridge because not studying all summer seemed like a travesty. Hence the paper. Not to say he wouldn't write the paper just for the fun of it.

"I sent a collection of books to your father's house that I believe Mr. Darcy would have read," he rushed to say, as if his thoughtful gesture embarrassed him.

"Aw, look at you being sweet. And here I thought you believed my obsession with Mr. Darcy was ridiculous."

"It is. He doesn't exist."

"Excuse me—just because he lives in my head and heart doesn't mean he isn't real."

"Actually, I think that's exactly what it means."

"Agree to disagree," I giggled. "Anyway, are you doing anything fun this summer besides studying and writing papers that will no doubt be published in some fancy journal that I'll read only because you're in it?" He'd already had a few papers published, which was a pretty big deal for an undergraduate student. "What about Jocelyn?" She was his latest girlfriend. "Don't you have any fun plans with her?" I could ask these questions now without jealousy, even though Jocelyn was perfect and demure and she knew what it was like to kiss Fitz and hold his hand and who knows what else. So maybe there was a prick of ouch there, but definitely not jealousy. Fitz was my person, and I wouldn't jeopardize that with unwanted notions about us being more than friends. Especially considering I wouldn't do well in his world, even if Fitz ever were to see me as an option.

Fitz cleared his throat. "No. We called things off."

"Oh. Because of Lady Winnifred?" Or Lady Whiny, as I liked to call her in my head. She was my nemesis, and not just because her life goal was to marry my best friend. There was just something about her self-righteous attitude that got to me. I always felt like less of a human around her.

"Why would you think that?" He sounded disgruntled.

"Please. You have to know why."

"Well, it's not why," he said hastily, obviously not wanting to acknowledge it.

Huh. "Then why?" I was more than curious.

“Jocelyn and I are not a good fit, and I need to focus on my studies,” he murmured.

I knew there was something he wasn’t saying, but I didn’t press. They’d seemed like a good fit to me when I saw them together during my last visit. She was perfectly gorgeous, just like Fitz, and her family had all the right connections, just like Fitz’s family, except Jocelyn’s family held no titles. “All right, if you say so.”

“I do,” he stated flatly. “Are you still dating that, what’s his name, Leif?” Fitz thought his name was ridiculous.

“You of all people should know that Leif is a strong name. It comes from the Vikings.”

“There was one famous Viking named Leif, and the name means *heir* or *descendant*. It’s not all that powerful.”

“Well, that famous Viking was one of the first to people to colonize Greenland and the first European to set foot on North America, as far as we know.” I said it with a *take that* attitude.

“Are you saying your Leif has followed suit?” I could picture his eye roll.

“First of all, he’s not my Leif. We broke up a—”

“Why?” Fitz interrupted, sounding oddly chipper. I hadn’t even known he could be chipper.

I turned to my side, still clutching the phone. “If you must know, it’s because of you.”

“Me?” he said, astonished.

“Yes, you. Apparently, Leif didn’t like you. He thought we were too close to be only friends.”

“That’s rubbish.”

“Exactly what I told him. But then he said I had to choose between him or you, and obviously that didn’t go well for him.” He wasn’t the first boyfriend of mine who didn’t appreciate Fitz. For some reason, no one could believe Fitz and I were totally platonic—like so, so platonic. If you looked up *platonic* in the dictionary, there would be a picture of Fitz and me, not touching.

Fitz was silent for a few beats before he said, “I’m sorry I cost you a relationship.” He didn’t sound all that sorry, but I went with it. It’s not like Fitz was a touchy-feely kind of guy, so I could have read him wrong.

“It’s all right. I kind of accidentally set his parents’ lawn on fire during a barbecue when I tried to help his nana, who was wobbling too close to the grill. The good news is I was able to push her away before she got burned. The bad news is their dog tripped me up, and I got burned while knocking over the grill. Next thing I knew, the fire department had to be called.” It’s not the kind of thing you really come back from. Even though Leif’s parents were super nice about it, I couldn’t really look them in the eye anymore.

“You never said anything. When did this happen? How badly were you burned?” Fitz sounded panicked, which was weird because he was always so calm.

“I didn’t want to mention it because, you know, I have a track record with these kinds of things. Anyway, it happened a few weeks ago, and it was just a tiny first-degree burn on my arm.” I looked at the small rectangular patch of fleshy pink skin on my arm, which was healing nicely.

“You should have told me,” he scolded. “And you never mentioned breaking up with Leif.”

“You didn’t mention breaking up with Jocelyn,” I countered, wondering why neither of us had mentioned such gigantic pieces of information, especially since we shared everything with each other. Well, not exactly everything. I shared most of my heart with him, but not all of it. I had to reserve the part that protected me from ever crossing the line Fitz had drawn and made clear he never wanted to cross. And we were only emotionally intimate with each other, which is more valuable than physical intimacy, anyway. Not to say I’d never thought about, well . . . physical intimacy with Fitz. And I supposed I’d kept a few embarrassing stories from him now and then. Don’t get me wrong—he’d heard and witnessed his fair share of my embarrassing tales. I just felt like maybe it was okay to leave this one out.

“I wasn’t that serious about her, so it didn’t seem important to mention it,” he defended himself.

“Oh,” was all I could think to say.

“What’s your excuse?” he prodded.

I sat up and ran a hand through my overly styled hair that one of my “bandmates” had done for tonight’s performances. She thought I needed to look a little more like an eighties poster girl. The honest answer was that I didn’t know why I hadn’t told Fitz about Leif. The only thing I could think

of was, “I guess I didn’t think you cared one way or the other about my love life.”

“I care about your life,” he snapped.

His tone caught me off guard. “Why are you angry with me?”

“I’ve never been angry with you. But for you to think I don’t care about what happens in your life is an insult.”

“I didn’t mean to insult you. From here on out, I’ll be sure to keep you informed about all aspects of my love life,” I said with an air of brevity, still shaken by his reaction.

“I don’t need or want gory details,” he deadpanned.

“Darn it. And here I was thinking you wanted to know that Leif did this __”

“Monroe, please don’t go any further.”

I giggled. I hadn’t planned on saying anything salacious. “On that fun note, I should probably get some sleep. I’m living the rock star life now.”

“It’s not the life you want, is it?” he asked, concerned.

“No. I’m still trying to save up to open my studio. That takes time. But when the summer is over, I’ll go back to giving private piano and voice lessons to my previous students. Hopefully I’ll add more students as time goes on. In the meantime, I’ll look for a full-time job that will allow me to do both.”

“Let me help you.”

We’d had this conversation before. “You know I adore you for wanting to help, but I never want money to come between us.”

“It wouldn’t.”

“You don’t know that. I’ll figure it out. If not—”

“We’ll revisit my offer.”

“Oh fine, but only because I’m too tired to argue.”

“Get some rest. I’ll call you tomorrow.”

“Sounds good. By the way, thank you for the books. I can’t wait to get home and read them. Maybe we could start our own little book club.”

“I would like that.”

“You would?”

“Why do you sound so surprised?”

“I don’t know. Maybe because I’m not smart like all your other friends.”

“Monroe, you are intelligent, and the only real friend I have.”

While I loved that he thought I was smart, I was sad knowing he had dozens of people who considered themselves his friends but didn't know the real him because he wouldn't let them. I don't know how I'd gotten so lucky to earn his trust. "Well, since you put it like that, I guess we'd better start our book club."

He laughed a rare laugh. "I look forward to it."

"Me too. I miss you."

"I miss you." He always said it with some hesitation. Almost like he shouldn't, or didn't want to admit to missing me, as if it made him weak somehow. But I knew he meant it all the same.

"Goodbye, Fitz." Those words always hurt.

"Goodbye, Monroe." Those words hurt even more.

**Eighteen Months Ago**

# FITZ

*PLEASE TELL ME YOU'RE AWAKE. I have the best news to share with you!* I read Monroe's text repeatedly in the dark, feeling more unsettled than ever and fearing the worst. Scrubbing a hand over my unshaved face, I sat up in bed and flipped on my bedside lamp as if the light would help the situation. Unfortunately, it only amplified the words glaring back at me on the screen while the pit in my stomach grew.

As many times as Monroe had told me she thought this Tony bloke was The One, and that she had a feeling he would be proposing, I didn't want to believe it. I didn't believe it. The knobhead drove a van with a toilet pictured on its side. Tony wasn't the one for her. He didn't appreciate Monroe, and he didn't deserve her. He'd never watched any musicals with her. I'd watched dozens, and she'd subjected me to their soundtracks whenever we were together in a car. Hell, she'd even convinced me to sing along with her a few times, though I would never admit it. Her enthusiasm was too infectious sometimes. She was just plain infectious.

I was the one for her, not Tony.

Before I could compose myself enough to call her, she texted again, this time with a photo of her delicate hand, an unmistakable, glaring engagement ring on her left finger. *He popped the question, and I said yes.*

*I'll only be a happy bride if my best friend is by my side. Please be my maid of honor. Or best man of honor.* Several laughing emoji faces followed.

I tossed the phone to the side and fell back on my pillows, feeling as if I couldn't breathe. For years I'd told myself I could watch her get married and be happy for her and the lucky guy, but it was a lie. I couldn't watch the woman I loved marry another man. Especially the likes of Tony. I probably should have said something about him before now, but I couldn't be sure if my misgivings about him were because of my feelings for Monroe or whether the man really was a prat. Something about him just didn't sit right, even though Monroe had never once complained about him. No, she'd gone on nauseatingly about what a right chummy fellow he was. *Tony brings me a latte every morning at the studio on his way to work. Tony takes me on picnic lunches. Tony took me stargazing. Tony likes to cook with me in the kitchen.* He was a damn saint who could apparently walk on water, and I wanted to beat him to a bloody pulp.

But the man I was most upset with was me. All these years I'd kept Monroe at arm's length. My reasons were noble—I was protecting her from the unbearably bright spotlight that was always on me as the son of a duke, the heir to the title.

My phone buzzed. Monroe was calling. I wanted to ignore it, but I always answered her calls, no matter the time or place. Steeling myself, I clicked the green button and put her on speaker.

"I'm engaged!" she squealed before I could even say hello.

"Congratulations," I said stiffly, not meaning a word of it.

"I'm sure I woke you up. I'm so sorry, but I had to tell you first. Did you see the ring? Isn't it beautiful? I love the floral halo design. It's perfect, don't you think?"

"I haven't looked at it, but I'm sure it's lovely." My mouth felt drier with every lie. But I couldn't tell her the truth. Not when she was so happy.

"We haven't set a date yet, but when we do, you have to, *have to* be my best man of honor. We'll get you like a peach tux or something, because you know that I've always wanted my bridesmaids to wear peach. And that means you have to throw me a bridal shower." She laughed that glorious laugh of hers.

There was no way in hell I was throwing her a bridal shower or being her best man of honor. Certainly, you would never find me in a peach tux. "Monroe, please ask one of your girlfriends to take my place."

“But no one can take your place.” She said it so sincerely, it pricked my stony heart.

Someone *had* taken my place, and I hated him. “They’ll have to for this.” I stood firm. No matter the date of the wedding, I would find any excuse not to attend.

“Oh.” She sounded deflated and hurt. “I understand. Peach isn’t your color. Blue looks good on you,” she teased. “I’ll change my colors for you.”

I chuckled half-heartedly, trying to play off this bloody mess. “That won’t be necessary. I’m not wearing a blue tux or being your maid of honor.”

“As long as you’re there,” she said brightly.

I cleared my throat, not wanting to lie to her again or to get her hopes up. “Let me know when you decide on a date.”

“You’ll be the first to know. Maybe you can come help me pick out my wedding dress.”

Was she trying to kill me? If I had to witness her in her wedding gown, there was no telling what I might do. “You have Grams and your father for that. And my teaching schedule is busy.”

“Oh, right, Mr. Professor. Or I guess I should call you Dr. Fitzroy. Or Dr. Fitz?” She giggled. “I know I’ve said it a hundred times before, but I’m really proud of you. One of the youngest professors at Oxford. I brag about you all the time.”

Her kindness made the heavy weight of my guilt and lies feel crushing. “Thank you, Monroe. It means the world to me. You mean the world to me.” It was the closest I could come to telling her how much I loved her.

“You know, sometimes you’re the sweetest.”

“Monroe, let’s go tell your dad,” Tony called in the background. What a prick.

“I guess I’d better go. Sorry to call so late, or early for you.”

“You can call me anytime. I mean that. Day or night if ever you need anything.”

She paused for a moment. “You make it sound as if we’ll never talk or see each other again.”

I feared that was going to be our future—a life without each other. “I’d never wish that.”

“Me neither, silly. Get some rest. I’ll call you later.”

“Very well. Good night.” My thumb hovered over the red button to end the call.

“Fitz,” she rushed to say. “I love you, best friend. Good night.” She hung up. She knew I wouldn’t reciprocate. What she didn’t know was why. She believed it all centered on my being an emotionally stunted Englishman, which was true. Given my upbringing, it would be hard to be anything but. However, I could never tell her I love her because she knew me too well—if ever I said those words to her, she would know I was *in* love with her. And that, now, was a moot point.

I’d lost the love of my life. It was a crushing blow I knew I would never recover from.

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# ONE

***"A girl likes to be crossed a little in love now and then. It is something to think of, and it gives her a sort of distinction among her companions."***

## MONROE

"THE WEDDING IS OFF," I stuttered out between sobs into the phone, hardly believing it was true, but my empty finger that just an hour ago sported a dazzling diamond ring spoke to the truth of it.

"It's about bloody time," Fitz said in his alluring British accent.

I sank deeper into the pillows on my bed in the dark. I hadn't even had the energy to turn on the lights after the big breakup that had gone down in my condo's living room. "What do you mean, it's about time? I thought you liked Tony." While Fitz wasn't the warmest of men, I was hoping for at least a little sympathy.

"Whatever gave you that impression?"

"Well, you never said you *didn't* like him. For you, that's huge."

"That was only me not stating the obvious," he said dryly.

"Why didn't you like him?" I asked, almost offended, even though Tony had just broken my heart.

"Where do I start?" Fitz exclaimed with more glee than was customary. "Let's see: First, his name is generic. Second, he drives a van with a toilet painted on the side. And that's just the tip of the iceberg. Shall I go on?"

"Not everyone is blessed with a regal name like yours, Alastair Fitzroy, Duke of Blackthorne." It was a newish title for him. His father had passed away less than nine months ago. He wasn't all that comfortable with his new role. To him, it was just something he'd received because of the family he'd been born into and because his father had passed away. He hadn't earned it. Not like the professorship he was rightfully so proud of. To make him feel better, I'd teased him that he was probably the only duke in world

history to have a best friend from Kansas. It made him more distinguished in my opinion. “And the toilet thing is only because he’s a plumber,” I defended Tony. “And a very successful one, mind you. Well, at least he was,” I mumbled, guilt creeping in.

Fitz paused for a couple of beats. “What did you do this time, Monroe?” He knew me all too well.

I twirled some of my long brown hair and curled my shoulders into myself, gripping the phone tightly. “I thought I was helping.”

“That’s usually how it starts for you,” he teased.

He wasn’t wrong. I’d decided over the years that if someone were to ask me what my toxic trait was, I’d have to say jumping in to help anytime I see a problem. While most would normally consider that an admirable attribute, it’s usually cruel and unusual punishment for the recipient in my case, seeing as I always seem to make things worse no matter what country I reside in. Logic would suggest I should just give up trying to help people, but I couldn’t bring myself to do it. I have my reasons—well, really, one big reason.

“How was I to know that his dad would fire him after I told him Tony thought he should have a bigger share in the company’s profits, seeing as he did most of the heavy lifting and it’s his pretty face on all the commercials and ads?”

“He wasn’t that pretty.” Fitz yawned.

“I’m sorry, it’s the middle of the night for you,” I apologized, forgetting he was several hours ahead of me and I’d most likely woken him up. I just needed to hear his voice, as broody as it was. He was always the calm in my storms. “We can talk later.”

“Monroe,” he said gently, “I wouldn’t have picked up if I hadn’t wanted to talk to you.” Fitz really was the sweetest sometimes, but he didn’t want that character *flaw* to get around—heaven forbid anyone realize he was human.

“I know,” I sniffled, so thankful for him.

“So, tell me why this pillock just discarded the best thing to ever happen to him?” See? Sweet.

“He said I was always sticking my nose in where it didn’t belong.” I hiccupped. “I know I can be a little much, but I figured since I loved him, my nose belonged with him.”

Fitz chuckled.

“You know what I mean. I just thought that if he was unhappy, I should try to fix it if I could. Why does it seem that every time I try to do a good deed, it backfires?”

“Monroe, you help people all the time—your students, your father, me on occasion when I need a good laugh,” he teased. By *students*, he meant my voice and piano students, whom I taught in my little studio here in Overland Park, my hometown. I’d finally given in and let Fitz help me acquire the studio I’d dreamed of for so long. I was still paying off the loan to him, even though he said to consider it a gift. But I couldn’t do that. Never did I want our friendship to be about money.

I rolled my eyes. “Are you having a laugh now at my expense?”

“I’d like to think I’m laughing *with* you. The man is a prat, and you are bloody well better off without him.”

“Why didn’t you say something sooner?”

If Fitz had disliked him, it would have given me pause. I couldn’t have my best friend and husband hate each other. Granted, it hadn’t exactly thrilled Tony either that Fitz is my BFF. Just like every other guy in my life. Why can’t a girl have a dishy best friend? Sure, it’s probably off-putting to a boyfriend or fiancé to come face-to-face with Fitz’s gorgeous asymmetrical face, prominent cheekbones, and strong jawline. And then there are his haughty gray eyes that seem to view everyone with disdain. But to those fortunate enough to get close to him, his eyes reflect not only specks of the night sky, but a thoughtfulness like you’d never known or expect. So maybe I understood Tony’s misgivings.

But I’d made sure that Tony unequivocally understood that I didn’t have any romantic notions about Fitz. Or at least I hadn’t in a long time. So, maybe I didn’t mention that. But to be honest, I’m not even sure Fitz realizes I’m a girl, so it didn’t seem necessary to mention long-ago hopes and desires.

Besides, Fitz was meant to be with the Lady Winnifred Roberts’ of the world. And oh, did Lady Whiny want to be Fitz’s one and only. I imagined she someday would be, seeing as the dowager duchess, a.k.a. Fitz’s mum, was dead set on their union. It would be a sad day, to be sure, but Fitz needed an accomplished woman who didn’t make a mess of everything. And then there was Fitz’s declaration that he could never be with an American because we don’t appreciate culture and history enough as a people. And I think he was still salty that the Brits lost the American

Revolutionary War. He couldn't imagine people not wanting to be subjected to a royal monarchy.

All this meant was that Fitz and I were still just friends with the biggest capital *F* of all time. We'd set an unspoken boundary and adhered to it with precision. And our picture was still in the dictionary under *platonic*. Or at least it should have been. I should probably give Merriam-Webster a call.

"I couldn't say anything," Fitz responded uneasily after an abnormally long pause.

"Why? You've always been vocal before about the men I've dated." Come to think of it, he hadn't liked any of them.

"This was different, Monroe."

"How?" I wondered aloud.

"That's neither here nor there."

I didn't agree, but my gray short-haired cat jumped up on my bed and curled up next to me, interrupting us. "Hello, Mr. Darcy." I scratched his head, picturing Fitz curling his lip. He still thought my obsession with *Pride and Prejudice* was ridiculous. He believed most people failed to grasp the subtle nuances of the beloved novel and therefore had no business fawning over it. I could picture him preaching this tidbit to his students at Oxford. I'm surprised he hadn't written a book about it yet. Although he had written a history book about Victorian morality, and he'd won some prestigious award—the Wolfson History Prize. Regardless, I didn't need to understand all the complexities of *Pride and Prejudice* to know that Mr. Darcy was yummy. But if I said that out loud, Fitz would throw up in his mouth—again.

"You and *Pride and Prejudice*," Fitz grumbled.

"Don't mock me," I cried, thinking of my planned honeymoon at Pride and Prejudice Park that would never happen now. It was my dream to visit the beautiful place in Grantham, where all my *Pride and Prejudice* fantasies would come true. The park was basically Disneyland for Jane Austen superfans who wanted to pretend for a week to live in her world. As soon as I'd learned of its existence, I knew I had to go there.

"Monroe," his tone softened. "I apologize."

"You do? That's so unlike you."

"I'm making an exception, given your fragile state."

I giggled. "Thank you for your concession on my behalf. But what am I going to do?" I lamented, thinking of everything I needed to cancel and all

the extended family and friends I had to notify that the wedding was off . . . and my beautiful dress that I'd already picked out and paid for . . . and that honeymoon. I couldn't stop thinking about it.

"What do you want to do?" he asked cautiously. He was behaving oddly. Normally, he was someone to give his opinion freely. I guess just not his opinion about Tony. That would have been a nice heads-up.

I gathered Mr. Darcy closer to me, considering Fitz's question. "Don't make fun of me, but just today I received my letter from Pride and Prejudice Park informing me they'd chosen me, based on my application and questionnaire answers, to play the coveted role of Elizabeth Bennet." For one week I would have the chance to live as my favorite heroine, the woman I longed to be like, learning everything from needlework to dancing the cotillion and the English country dance. It was cosplay at its finest. Even though, admittedly, I was probably more of a Jane or maybe even a Kitty. There are some who found me to be silly, forever making a mess of my good intentions to help others. Fitz probably counted himself among those who thought I was ridiculous.

"I suppose that means they were giving the part of Darcy to that imbecile ex-fiancé of yours," he scoffed.

"Well, yes. But begrudgingly, and only because it was supposed to be our honeymoon and we'd bought a couple's package," I stuttered, hardly able to say the word out loud. "In full disclosure, there was a note with the letter that said he was more of a Mr. Wickham, but a member of their staff always plays that part." I winced.

"Hmm." Fitz sounded pleased. "Maybe this place has some credibility after all." He'd made fun of it when I told him a few months ago that I'd begged Tony for it to be our honeymoon destination.

"You thought Tony was a Mr. Wickham, and you said nothing?"

"What did you want me to say? That you were marrying a self-centered arse?"

"Yes," I raised my voice. "Wait, that's what you really thought of him?"

"Monroe," he breathed out. "The man gave little thought to your interests, and worse, he believes Corn Nuts are a food group."

That last part made the corners of my lips twitch into an almost smile. Granted, the Corn Nuts thing was disgusting, but it wasn't a deal breaker. "We just had different likes is all," I protested half-heartedly. But upon further reflection, maybe my love and Tony's all-American-boy good looks

had blinded me to the fact that we weren't all that compatible. He loved every kind of sport and watched them incessantly, while I loved the theater and music. Which was fine. Once in a while, it was fun to catch a game with him. But only once had he attended a musical with me, and chick flicks were totally off the table. Although, he had agreed to the honeymoon of my dreams—sure, he'd complained about it, but he said he wanted to make me happy.

"As far as I could tell, he didn't even try to learn to enjoy what you treasure."

Oh. Wow. That pricked me. "Can you learn how to enjoy something you don't care about?" I'd never wanted to force my interests on anyone.

"Obviously. How many musicals have I seen with you?" he playfully grumbled.

"So, you are admitting you like them now?"

"Perhaps," he conceded.

"If that's the case, get ready for a night of *Grease* and *Grease 2* via Facetime." I hated that we lived so far apart.

Fitz groaned, and I laughed.

"I should probably go. I have a night of crying ahead of me, and I need to call my dad to let him know the wedding's off." Part of me wondered if he would be relieved. Like Fitz, he'd never indicated his feelings about Tony one way or another. All Dad had ever said was if I loved him, that was all that mattered.

"Yes, of course. Tell Foster hello for me."

Dad loved Fitz. I think the feeling was mutual, even if Fitz would never admit to it. They both shared a fondness for fishing and fencing.

"I will. Thank you for listening to me. I'm sorry I woke you up."

"I'm not."

His words warmed me in ways only he seemed capable of. "Well, good night."

"Wait," Fitz sounded panicked. He'd never sounded that way before—he was Mr. Calm, Cool, and Collected. "What will you do about the honeymoon? I'd been hoping to see you when you came to the UK."

Fitz had informed me that he couldn't come to my wedding that had been scheduled for September, three months from now, since the university required him to be at faculty meetings. I'd been disappointed, to say the least, but I understood—even though I'd purposefully scheduled my fall-

themed wedding for September, knowing that Oxford started school in October. I'd even offered to change the date of my wedding, but the venue I wanted couldn't accommodate my request.

"I don't know," I replied. "It's nonrefundable, but it seems depressing to go on my honeymoon all by myself." Tony had told me tonight that I could do whatever I wanted with our honeymoon since it was paid for. I'd brought it up, thinking perhaps it might make him reconsider throwing away our relationship, but apparently *Pride and Prejudice* wasn't magical enough to save our wedding.

"Don't look at it as your honeymoon," Fitz suggested. "Consider it your dream trip—you should take it."

I nibbled on my lip and mulled it over. "I suppose I could. The park could probably recast the role of Mr. Darcy. Would that be weird to pretend to fall in love with a stranger on my would-be honeymoon?" What did that say about me? About my feelings for Tony?

"What if it wasn't a stranger you were pretending with?"

"Who could I convince to go? That's a big ask. And it might be even weirder to pretend with someone I know."

"I could go with you," he coughed out.

I sat up, stunned, jostling my poor kitty out of his slumber. "Did I hear you right? You want to pretend to be Mr. Darcy for a week?" I couldn't help but snicker, trying to imagine Fitz doing such a thing. I would almost pay money to see it—you know, if I had a lot of money to spare. Then again, he was very much a Mr. Darcy type—intelligent, wealthy, a well-established owner of an estate, and very self-assured. Okay, he was proud—very proud—but also endearing, at least to me.

"It's not that I want to," he defended himself. "I'm trying to be a good friend to you. Help you in your time of need."

"I thought you said you couldn't take any time off in September."

He cleared his throat. "Circumstances have changed."

"How so?" I was a bit miffed, considering he'd been adamant about having to miss my wedding. And he'd been dead set against being my maid of honor and wearing the cute peach tux I'd picked out for him that matched the other bridesmaid dresses.

"Does it really matter? Do you want me to come as your Mr. Darcy or not?"

I leaned back against my headboard and thought for a moment. “It could be a lot of fun, at least for me. I know this isn’t your kind of thing, and you’ll probably mock it the entire time and tell them how inaccurately they’re depicting the time period.”

“Jane Austen is probably rolling over in her grave knowing such a place as Pride and Prejudice Park even exists,” he quipped.

“Or she could really dig it.” I mean, I would. How cool was it that over two hundred years later, she was still an icon and influencing love stories? And her wit is second to none.

“Jane Austen did not dig things. She appreciated them.”

“Pardon my mistake, Duke of Blackthorne.” I only called him by that title to get under his skin. To be honest, it would be most proper to call him *Your Grace*, but he said he’d never speak to me again if I addressed him that way.

“Monroe,” he huffed, “do you want me to come or not? Of course, I would be happy to pay for my half, or all of it.”

“You don’t have to do that. You do too much for me as it is. Besides, Tony’s already paid for it,” my voice cracked. I still couldn’t believe he’d so easily let me go. He hadn’t even wanted to discuss it. He’d said it wasn’t worth his time since he wouldn’t be changing his mind, which I translated into, *You aren’t worth it*. Honestly, he seemed to care more about making sure he got the ring back. The more I thought about it, the more I wanted to have the time of my life on my honeymoon with my best friend, just to spite Tony. It might even be our last big hurrah, considering Fitz would probably settle down soon with the likes of Lady Winnifred.

“Are you sure you want to do this?” I asked.

“I wouldn’t volunteer if I didn’t.”

“You realize you’re going to have to dress like Mr. Darcy and memorize a script, which means you will be ‘talking Darcy’ to me and dancing with me at the balls, right?” I would so giggle if Fitz said things to me like, *“In vain have I struggled. It will not do. My feelings will not be repressed. You must allow me to tell you how ardently I admire and love you.”*

“I’m well aware, considering how often you’ve mentioned the place in the last several months.”

“And you still want to go with me?” I had to make doubly sure.

“Yes, Monroe,” he said with such sincerity, it caught me off guard.

Huh. Well . . . “Okay, Mr. Darcy. I’ll see you in three months.”

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# TWO

**Three Months Later**

***"It is a truth universally acknowledged, that a single man in possession of a good fortune, must be in want of a wife."***

## FITZ

I DRIFTED AMONG THE HORDE of people in Terminal 3 at Heathrow Airport, waiting for Monroe to arrive early Monday morning. She was, of course, a day late because another one of her attempts to help someone went awry. She just had to guide a single mother flying by herself with young children to their gate at JFK Airport. In typical Monroe fashion, not only had she taken the woman to the wrong gate, making her miss her flight, but she'd missed her own flight as well while trying to correct the mistake.

Originally, I was supposed to pick her up at Manchester Airport and we were to spend the day together at my estate before heading to this forsaken Pride and Prejudice Park, but perhaps it was for the best she was late. Mother still lived on the estate and didn't care for the woman from whom I've carefully guarded my true feelings for the past thirteen years. And I wanted nothing to come between Monroe and me for the next week—or ever, for that matter. I was past pretending I didn't love her, even though nothing about us made sense. Monroe is maddening, chaotic, kind to a fault, and lovely. So lovely. I, on the other hand, am broody, meticulous, and frequently coldhearted—unless it comes to Monroe. She has a way of bringing out my human side.

For her, and only her, would I wait among the sea of gawking eyes. Ever since that blasted magazine named me one of Britain's hottest, most eligible bachelors, I've felt as if I lived in a fishbowl. People, mostly

women, seem to always be snapping pictures of me now with their phones while giggling and whispering to their companions. It irritated me to no end. If only I could sue the magazine for libel and make them remove that ridiculous article. I wasn't available for anyone except Monroe—that was, if she would have me. We'd never ventured outside the lines of friendship. My mother would be categorically against the union—which was regrettable—but ever since Monroe had gotten engaged to that idiot Tony, I realized I couldn't stand by and let her slip away. For all these years, I'd deceived myself that I'd be able to wish her well and love her secretly from a distance, understanding that a romantic relationship between us would be complicated, perhaps even unwise, but I was utterly mistaken. When she became engaged, it gutted me. On the flip side, a relief like none other consumed when me when the wedding was called off. I'd been hoping our time together this week would prove to us both that while we were probably a study in contradictions, we could overcome the obstacles standing in our way.

There was just something about Monroe. From the first time I met her—when she'd tripped over her book bag, jumped up, and said, "Ta-da!", smiling nervously at the catty girls ready to eat her alive—she'd sparked something in me. A protectiveness I'd never felt before washed over me as I went to her aid, knowing that despite my standoffish nature, I had influence because of my name and title. And let's not forget the money. I knew if those girls thought Monroe was a friend of mine, it would at least give her a fighting chance, especially given that Monroe was not the typical student. Despite the uniforms we all had to wear, it wasn't hard to tell which students were there on scholarship or receiving some type of financial assistance. And being a foreigner made Monroe an even easier target.

That one act forged us together in ways I hadn't foreseen, and now I couldn't imagine my life without her. Even if I was standing near a group of tittering women pointing at me.

"Your Grace, can we get a picture with you?" one of the silly women had the audacity to ask me.

I turned, my face already pinched into what Monroe referred to as my resting Darcy face, ready to tell the woman to bugger off, until a commotion stirred among the crowd. No doubt it meant Monroe had arrived—chaos was her constant companion.

I turned to see what the woman, who vexed me in ways she was completely unaware of, had done this time.

The crowd was pointing, some standing on their toes, making it hard for me to see, so I stepped around the throng to find Monroe with several articles of clothing draped around her shoulders and at least three bonnets on top of her head, lugging a large pink suitcase behind her.

I shook my head and walked over to help her, bracing myself for the story behind her odd appearance. I was sure it involved her helping someone.

Despite her unconventional deportment, there was no denying the beauty beneath the layers of clothing and bonnets. Her dark wavy hair spilled out of the bonnets and cascaded past her shoulders. I'd had the pleasure a few times of running my fingers through her thick, silky mane while trying to comfort her. I longed for more opportunities to gaze into her deep-brown eyes that shone with kindness, curiosity, and at times, mischief. Even more, I wanted to cup her creamy cheeks in my hands and capture the supple pink lips that had taunted me over the years.

When Monroe noticed me, she smiled and waved her arms, making one bonnet fall off her head, even while two remained. "Fitz!"

A collective gasp sounded from those nearby who recognized me and were aghast that anyone would address me so informally in public. Admittedly, her annoying nickname for me had taken some getting used to on my part, but now I couldn't imagine her calling me anything but Fitz. I certainly didn't wish her to call me *Your Grace*. It was a title I, myself, wasn't yet used to. Not quite a year ago, it had belonged to my father, God rest his callous soul.

Whispers followed me as I made my way to Monroe: "Does His Grace actually know that woman?" "Please tell me he's not dating her." "Could you imagine her as the Duchess of Blackthorne?"

If I were being honest, the answer was no, I couldn't imagine Monroe as a duchess. But as irreverent and maddening as she was, she was the only woman to whom I wished to give the title. No doubt we would both face ridicule for such a choice, and it certainly gave me pause. I had to wonder if we could survive the scrutiny. The biggest question was: Would she want the title and all that came with it, including me? Not knowing the answer to that question was disconcerting—it was the most unsure I'd ever been in my life.

I brushed past several people to make my way to Monroe, who was losing still more articles of clothing as she rushed toward me.

When I finally reached her, she laughed her melodious laugh while announcing, “I have a story to tell you.”

“No doubt you do.” I took the remaining bonnets off her head.

“Grams helped me make those, and the dresses,” she said proudly as she began discarding the items and handing them to me.

I took the neoclassical empire-waist dresses with as much dignity as I could muster, knowing the spectacle we were making. “Perhaps we should exit,” I suggested, feeling every eye on us.

“I want to see how Harper fares. I gave her my carry-on before we exited the plane because the wheels on hers completely fell off, and the poor thing has a sprained ankle and has to wear one of those medical boots. And she’s nervous because she’s meeting her boyfriend’s parents for the first time and wants to make a good impression, so I told her she could have mine. I forgot I had no room in my checked bag for my costumes, so I had to carry them, naturally. The customs officials gave me such funny looks.” She finally took a breath, allowing me time to respond.

“Monroe, you don’t need to save every person you come across.”

“If only I could.” She gave me a meaningful look.

I knew exactly what she was trying to convey. She’d watched her mother choke when she was a small child and had been unable to save her. It had made her feel completely helpless. She never wanted to feel that way again, so she wonderfully (sometimes ridiculously) tried to help everyone she could.

There was no arguing with her or changing her mind about it, so I stood there holding the dresses and bonnets, knowing the risk we ran of some awful photog taking our picture. But I knew Monroe would not move from her place until she knew the outcome, which, given her track record, would most likely end in disaster.

As Monroe waited with bated breath for this Harper to appear, completely oblivious that many in the crowd were ridiculing her, she smiled over at me. “I forgot to hug you,” she realized, then immediately remedied the oversight by wrapping her arms around me, albeit awkwardly, since my arms were full of her costumes. But if there was a will, there was a way, and Monroe always found a way. She burrowed right into me, and I couldn’t help but wrap my arms around her, dresses and all.

“Hi there, friend. I missed you.”

I did my best to ignore the unflattering chatter around us, or even that she’d referred to me as her *friend*, and tried to focus solely on the way Monroe’s body contoured perfectly against mine as I breathed in her delicate floral scent, wishing to be alone with her and away from prying eyes. But I failed miserably to enjoy the moment with her. Throughout my life, my parents had trained me strictly in decorum—how to look and behave in public. And I was breaking every rule with Monroe at the moment. I wished I could say that I didn’t give a damn, but my title required me to care. But more importantly, I wanted to save Monroe from the cruelty of the public and the press. Didn’t she hear them whispering loudly about her?

The anxiety of the situation prevented me from responding to her the way I wanted to.

She looked up with those gorgeous dark eyes of hers, so full of goodness. “What’s wrong? You didn’t miss me?”

“Of course I did.” But like a fool, I let go of her. My father’s dying words reverberated in my head that I needed to put my title before my feelings. I wasn’t sure what he knew about feelings, as he had none, not even for me or my younger sister, Anna. As a result, I could barely acknowledge emotions myself, except for how I felt about Monroe and occasionally Anna. My sister, like me, had a hard time expressing emotion.

Monroe nudged me playfully. “Give me the dresses and I’ll meet you at the car. I know this is embarrassing you.”

The last thing I wanted was for Monroe to believe I didn’t wish to be by her side, even during her crazy antics. She didn’t embarrass me, per se. Not to say I wasn’t uncomfortable. But hadn’t I accused her moron ex of not valuing the things she treasured? Monroe, above all, treasured helping people, even if she was awful at it. Case in point: Harper finally appeared.

“There she is.” Monroe pointed at a scowling, bedraggled woman with a limp, trailing a pink carry-on behind her that matched Monroe’s large suitcase.

A man ran toward her, carrying wilting flowers.

I should have thought to bring Monroe flowers. Admittedly, romance wasn’t my strong suit. Women threw themselves at me all the time, so I’d never needed to woo anyone, much less my best mate.

“Oh, look,” Monroe squealed. “That’s so romantic!”

Just when I thought for once Monroe's good deed hadn't taken a bad turn, Harper and her boyfriend began arguing loudly.

"Thank you for the dead flowers," Harper snipped.

"If you hadn't taken so bloody long, they would still be fresh."

"You have no idea what I've been through. Some crazy Jane Austen fan offered me her carry-on, and she left a small pair of embroidery scissors in them. I just spent the last several minutes being questioned, probed, and prodded by two customs officers."

Monroe began to rush over to her. "Oh gosh. I totally forgot about those. I thought I packed them in my checked bag. How did those get through security the first time? I need to fix this."

I grabbed Monroe's hand, knowing it would only exacerbate the disaster. "Monroe, please, this once, let it drop. They are clearly not a good couple if they're bickering about wilting flowers."

She nibbled on her bottom lip pensively. "But what if—"

"Did you hear what she called you? She's not worth your time. Please, we're going to be late." Truthfully, I wanted to march over to the woman and give her a piece of my mind. How dare she belittle Monroe after what she'd done for her? But decorum prevailed, as always.

"Well, I am a crazy Jane Austen fan."

"Yes, you are." I couldn't help but smile. She somehow managed to bring out a softer side in me, even if it disconcerted me. "Shall we go live out your Austen fantasy?"

She nodded, although I could tell it disappointed her that her endeavor to save someone hadn't had the outcome she was hoping for.

I breathed out a sigh of relief, ready to be done with prying eyes, and looking forward to the few hours of alone time I would get to spend with Monroe on the drive to Grantham. Perhaps then I could begin to convince her that I wished to do more than just pretend to be her Mr. Darcy.

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# THREE

***" . . . for it is many months since I have considered her as one of the handsomest women of my acquaintance."***

## MONROE

"THANK YOU FOR PICKING ME up and changing our plans last minute." I admired Fitz, dressed impeccably as usual in a tweed jacket and jeans that he'd probably purchased at his favorite shop, the House of Bruar. Given the early hour, the sun had yet to make its appearance as he drove us adeptly out of Heathrow in his Land Rover, the lights of oncoming traffic shining brightly in our eyes. Fitz was awfully quiet, even for him, and it made me wonder if I had annoyed him—again. I knew he didn't exactly appreciate my, let's say, eccentric ways. And I'd heard what the people in the airport crowd had said about me. I should probably have been more embarrassed than I was. Sure, it bothered me, but I'd learned after my experience at our fancy private school that people were going to talk no matter what I did. Might as well live my life. Although, I did feel bad knowing that Fitz didn't and couldn't live his life with that freedom. I understood his new title brought with it a strict code of conduct.

"Are you upset with me? I'm sorry we didn't get to visit your estate. I was hoping to see Anna and Kingston." Kingston was his estate manager, and I adored him. He was Fitz's confidant and one of his few friends, even though Kingston was ten years his senior. "And maybe your mum," I added, but squinted while saying it. Even though I loved saying *mum*. I'd just adopted the phrase when it came to his mother. Beatrix, the dowager duchess, admittedly terrified me. From our very first meeting years ago, she'd decided she didn't like me. Maybe it was that her beloved dogs, both Cavalier King Charles spaniels, seemed to prefer me over her. Or more than likely, it was that I was just a commoner who lacked proper breeding, in her

estimation. Apparently she didn't love that I had the audacity to hug her at our first meeting and say, "It's so nice to meet you, Mum B." She'd coolly replied that I should address her at all times as *Your Grace*. I wasn't sure now if that still applied, given her husband's recent passing. I had a hard time remembering the formalities of English nobility, which didn't work in my favor, at least not where Fitz's mum was concerned.

Fitz glanced my way. "I'm not upset with you. Only disappointed that our time has been cut short."

I felt terrible about that. But that poor pregnant mom with two toddlers had looked so exhausted, I'd felt compelled to rescue her. Of course, it turned out to be the opposite of helpful. I really should give up trying to improve people's lives. But then what if I stopped and something truly horrific happened that I could have, should have, prevented? I wasn't sure I'd ever forgive myself for not stepping in. I still hadn't forgiven myself for Mom. "Maybe I can stay an extra day and let your mum berate my appearance and manners," I teased.

Fitz's lips twitched into an almost smile while he reached over and took my hand. "I'd like that."

Our fingers intertwined with ease, as if it were natural for us to do. Except it wasn't—I couldn't think of a time we had ever held hands. Fitz wasn't normally one for physical affection unless I pushed it on him. I looked down at our clasped hands on my thigh, and a comfort like none other washed over me. This was a nice addition to our friendship. I liked it. A lot. "You like the idea of me staying an extra day, or the thought of your mum berating me?" I jested.

"I think you know the answer to that." He'd been apologetic about his mum's behavior in the past. It grated on him, but he knew there was no changing her mind about me.

I had to wonder why she so vehemently despised me. Fitz and I were only friends, after all. It wasn't like I was trying to take the place of her favorite candidate for daughter-in-law. Beatrix couldn't extol the virtues of Lady Winnifred Roberts enough, from her elegance in every way to her accomplishments—she spoke ten languages, including Latin—to her pedigree and connections. Lady Whiny's father was the 10th Earl of Alexander, and her mother was one of Beatrix's dearest friends. I think both mothers had been salivating at the thought of a union between the families since Fitz's birth a month following Lady Winnifred's. The thought of Fitz

marrying her made me squeeze his hand, knowing that one day we could no longer be so affectionate with each other. I had a feeling that our time together this next week would be one to treasure, our last big hurrah as the best of friends. There was something in the air that intimated things would be changing between us. I supposed it was inevitable.

"How are Anna and Kingston?" I asked.

Fitz chuckled. "You tell me. I think you talk to Anna and Kingston more than I do."

That was probably true. "Well, let's see. Anna is doing well. I'm hoping to see her when she comes to the States on tour—one of the benefits of having a famous concert pianist as a friend." I smiled. "She also let it slip that you were just named one of Britain's hottest, most eligible bachelors. Congratulations, by the way." I'd been waiting to talk to him about it so I could see his disdain in person. "Anna thinks you're upset because you lost the top spot to Viscount Phillips," I goaded him, knowing exactly how much he hated this kind of attention, that he couldn't care less who garnered the top spot as long as it wasn't him.

"That ridiculous list," he grumbled.

I giggled and reached over with my free hand to grab his chin and shake his handsome face. It was a little awkward, but I didn't want to let go of his hand. After the past few months, I needed this connection. I needed him. "I'm sorry you have to bear the heavy weight of dashing good looks *and* wealth."

As soon as I dropped my hand, Fitz gave me an aggravated look.

"In other news," I sang, "I called Kingston last week, and he refused to tell me if you'd been practicing your script. Are you ready to *talk Darcy* to me?"

Fitz cleared his throat uncomfortably. "I've memorized all my lines."

"Ooh. Very good. Let's practice them."

"Absolutely not." Fitz switched lanes, barely glancing in the mirrors. It was as if the surrounding traffic knew the Duke of Blackthorne needed to get over and gave him the respect he was due.

"Why not?" I asked.

Fitz thought for a moment, shifting in his seat. "If we say them now, it will ruin the experience for you."

I scrunched my nose at him. "Uh, do you even know me? I'll enjoy it both now *and* when we act out those scenes. Besides, the schedule has

rehearsal times listed on it. Might as well get a jump on it—we are the main characters, after all."

"Monroe," he breathed out, clearly agitated.

I didn't get to ask him why he was so upset because a call came through the car's audio system. Kington's name popped up on the in-dash screen.

Fitz took the out and released my hand to click on the answer button. "Hello, Kingston."

"Your Grace, I'm sorry to disturb you."

"Kingston, how many times do I need to tell you that you can address me by my first name?"

"Or just call him Fitz," I interjected, mischievously grinning at Fitz, who looked affronted at the thought of anyone else calling him by the nickname I had given him.

"I would never, madam," Kingston said, as dignified as possible.

"You know I'm just teasing you." I would tell him to quit calling me *madam*, but I knew he would refuse.

"Yes, Miss Monroe. You arrived safely, then."

"I forgot to text you. I'm so sorry. Yes, I'm here with His Grace." I winked at Fitz, who didn't look amused at all. He hated it when I was so formal with him. Although he hadn't made good on his threat of never speaking to me again if I called him *Your Grace*.

"Very good, madam. That was the reason for my call. You weren't answering your phone, and I wanted to make sure all was well."

"You are the sweetest. I love you."

Fitz threw me a scathing glance. "Is that all, Kingston?"

"Yes, Your Grace. I mean Alastair, sir."

"Don't go yet," I interjected quickly. "You need to tell me if you heard Fitz practice his lines. Does he make a good Darcy?" I giggled.

"I wouldn't know, madam," he stammered.

"That's too bad. Well, I'll let you know how he did when the week is over. I'm going to extend my stay so I can come to Blackhaven. I can't wait to see you."

"I look forward to it, Miss Monroe."

"That will do. Goodbye, Kingston." Fitz hung up on him unceremoniously.

"Why did you do that?" I complained. "I didn't get to say goodbye."

Fitz whipped his head my way, taking his eyes off the road for the briefest moment. “Are you in love with Kingston?”

“What? No,” I laughed. “Why would you think that?”

“You just said *I love you*, and you talk to each other more than is necessary.”

I tilted my head. “More than is necessary?”

“You know what I mean,” he said, flustered, so unlike his usual dignified demeanor.

“Clearly, I don’t.” I could hardly keep from snickering. I’d never seen Fitz like this. It was almost as if he were jealous, but that couldn’t be the case.

“It’s just not proper. He’s my estate manager and you’re my best mate. Not to mention, he’s too old for you.”

I broke out into fits of giggles, so much that I could hardly say, “Not proper? Why? Because I’m American and he’s British? And I don’t think a ten-year age gap is enough to raise any eyebrows.”

“This isn’t funny.”

“Actually, it is.” I got my snickering under control. “But there’s no need to worry. I don’t have any designs on Kingston. Besides, Anna loves Kingston, and he loves her.”

Fitz’s eyes widened incredulously. “That’s impossible. He’s twelve years older than Anna, and he’s . . . well . . .”

“He’s not of Anna’s station,” I stated what he was reluctant to say. Fitz, while proud, wasn’t a snob, as evidenced by the fact he encouraged his estate manager to call him by his given name. You wouldn’t find one employee of the estate who would say a negative thing about him. And it wasn’t because they were afraid of losing their positions—they genuinely thought him to be a good man. And he was, albeit a tad grumpy.

“It would be complicated,” was all he would offer. “But it doesn’t matter, because those feelings don’t exist between them.” His grip on the steering wheel told a different story than his lips.

I shrugged, knowing I was right, but seeing no need to argue about it—Anna was reluctant to admit her feelings, and Kingston would feel it a disgrace to do so. It was a sad situation. I’d offered to help move things along, but Anna had begged me not to. Probably because she knew of my terrible track record when it came to assisting people. Yet the longing I’d witnessed between the two was heart-achingly beautiful. I wasn’t sure a

man had ever gazed as adoringly at me as Kingston looked at Anna. There had to be something I could do—perhaps if I got Fitz to give his blessing, it would help. I'd try to work on it this week, but first, I needed his opinion on my costumes.

I unbuckled my seat belt. "I want to try my costumes on for you while it's still dark outside."

Fitz startled, alarmed. "Put your seat belt back on. It's not safe."

"I'll be fine." I carefully climbed into the back seat. "I need you to tell me if the dresses show too much cleavage."

"You're going to undress in the back seat?" he spluttered.

"That's the plan." I situated myself in a luxurious captain's seat and grabbed one of the dresses Fitz had laid on the seat next to me.

"In front of me?" His shocked eyes met mine in the rearview mirror.

"Just keep your eyes on the road. And even if you peek, it's not like I've ever been handsome enough to tempt you." I threw in a little *P&P* reference for the fun of it.

"Is that what you think?" He sounded upset.

"Uh . . ." The bite in his tone took me aback. "I just assumed you didn't find me attractive."

"Of course I find you attractive," he spat before his tone softened. "It is many years since I have considered you one of the handsomest women of my acquaintance."

"Oh my gosh. You did memorize your lines. You *speak Darcy* well," I gushed, feeling a little fluttery. Which was weird—not a bad weird, but definitely strange. I hadn't felt that way around him for a long time. I'd buried those long-ago hopes deep, deep down in my heart, knowing any romantic notions would only torment me and place a wedge in our friendship. And to be honest, any other romantic attachments as well. It would have been wholly unfair to compare another man to Fitz. In a picture dictionary, Fitz's photo would be next to *demigod*.

"That's not Darcy," Fitz said, offended. "That's me." He exhaled dramatically. "Monroe, you're beautiful."

I reached up and placed a hand on his shoulder. "You really think so?"

Fitz patted my hand. "I've always thought so."

"Wow. I had no idea. Thank you, Fitz. Honestly, I've been feeling a little down on myself lately." Not that looks should define you, but I had

questioned if maybe I was unattractive. When your fiancé breaks up with you, it kind of messes with your head.

“Please don’t tell me it’s because of that prat Tony.”

I sank back into the seat and sighed. “Maybe. You know, I was supposed to get married two days ago.”

“Are you still trying to get over him? Do you still love him?” Fitz steeled himself, waiting for my reply.

“Weirdly, no. Which I know doesn’t reflect well on my character. Ugh,” I lamented. After some serious soul-searching the last few months, I’d realized that Fitz was right—Tony didn’t treasure the things I did. Our relationship had been pretty superficial, and I cringed, knowing I’d thought myself in love. “What if I’m really a Lydia?” This question had plagued me, especially since Pride and Prejudice Park deemed Tony a Mr. Wickham. I could totally live with being a Jane, perhaps even a Mary or Kitty. But never Lydia. Of course, like most women, I wanted to be an Elizabeth, and I hoped I was. But I bet she wouldn’t have shown up to the airport to meet a duke wearing three bonnets with dresses draped around her shoulders.

“Monroe,” Fitz said my name with some of the tenderness he rarely showed. “You’re no Lydia. She was selfish, and you are anything but.”

“But am I an Elizabeth? What if they cast me wrong and I ruin the entire experience for everyone?” It was the last thing I wanted to do.

Fitz caught my eye in his rearview mirror, his lips ticking up into an almost smile. “As long as you don’t try to help anyone, you should be fine.”

“Oh, ha ha. I’m being serious.”

“So am I, love.” There was zero hint of teasing in his tone.

Huh. Fitz had never called me *love* before. Not that it meant anything—plenty of Brits used the term casually. Fitz wasn’t usually flippant about these things, so I was sure it was just a slip of the tongue. Hmm. “Fitz, please. Do you think I can be Elizabeth?”

He thought for a moment. “Monroe, you are headstrong, and you do have fine eyes.”

I smiled at the compliment, more so that Fitz had even noticed I have eyes.

“You adore your father, and you don’t let anyone tell you how to live your life,” he continued. “And her own Mr. Wickham even managed to fool Elizabeth Bennet for a time, despite being warned about him. You had no

such warning. The only thing you lack is her pride and her prejudices, but I've always admired that about you."

He had no idea how much better he was making me feel. Especially since . . . "I think Tony did fool me. I ran into his mom last week, and she made a weird comment after telling me how much she missed me. She said that as much as it pained her not to have me as a daughter-in-law, her son didn't deserve me after what he'd done to their family. When I asked what she meant, she wouldn't say, and just ran off crying. I've been wondering what he did ever since."

Fitz breathed out loudly, to the point of almost snarling. "The man is a bloody knobhead. Don't let him consume any more of your thoughts."

"Knobhead?" I giggled, even though I knew it meant an idiot.

"Yes. Knobhead." He grinned.

"Fitz, thanks for coming on my honeymoon with me." It was the best I could do to express how much this meant to me, how much *he* meant to me.

"It's my pleasure."

"Well, I should probably make this the best honeymoon ever, just in case I never get another. Which means I need to be the best Elizabeth ever, so you need to tell me if I have too much cleavage going on in these dresses."

Fitz groaned, and I laughed. It was pretty much how our friendship went. And now, more than ever, I was thankful that Fitz was my very best friend. Especially when he said, "Monroe, this will not be your only honeymoon."

"You don't know that."

Fitz stopped at a light and turned my way, owning me with his gaze in a way he never had before. "I promise you, this won't be your only honeymoon."

I opened my mouth to say he couldn't promise something like that, but before I could utter a word, he said, "Trust me."

I nodded because it was the only thing I could do. Something in his tone told me he spoke the truth. But how could he know that?

"Can you tell me if the groom will be cute?" I joked.

He gave me an impish grin before turning around. It was almost as if he knew this mystery man.

"Do you have someone in mind?" I couldn't help but ask.

He said nothing, just drove on.

I sat back and pondered whom he had in mind to be so sure. Was he thinking? No . . . it couldn’t be. Could it?

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# FOUR

***"I cannot fix on the hour, or the spot, or the look, or the words, which laid the foundation. It is too long ago. I was in the middle before I knew that I had begun."***

## FITZ

I KEPT STEALING GLANCES AT Monroe in the passenger seat, who, thankfully, was dressed again. She wore a form-fitting jumpsuit and jacket that showcased her perfectly shaped body. I'd talked her out of wearing one of the period dresses for our arrival. The dresses did indeed show off an ample amount of cleavage, but in my estimation, I wouldn't change a thing. In fact, I couldn't wait to see her in them again. She had no idea how much I'd wanted to pull over and show her exactly how handsome I thought she was when she, with no regard to my hidden feelings, had undressed in front of me like I was one of her girlfriends. Her smooth skin and the curve of her perfect body were almost the death of us. My eyes hadn't been on the road like they should have, and I had to swerve to miss a car that had suddenly stopped in front of us.

Unfortunately, Monroe just thought it was funny she could distract me in such a manner.

I hadn't realized I'd been so good at hiding my feelings for her that she hadn't even known that I found her beautiful, or that changing in front of me would undo me in ways I didn't know were possible. Monroe was more than beautiful to me—she was intoxicating. And now that I was determined to cross the line of our friendship, I wanted her more than ever. Yet, the fact remained that I had my work cut out for me. If Monroe had not even an inkling about how I truly felt about her, we weren't off to a good start. At

least she seemed to be over that blighter, Tony. I had half a mind to find out what he'd done.

"We're getting close." Monroe squealed while reaching for my hand. Perhaps that was a good sign. She seemed to take well to this new aspect of our relationship. I curled my fingers around hers, hoping she would realize this was no casual gesture on my part.

She squeezed my hand and smiled at me, a question in her gorgeous eyes.

I wanted to answer her and tell her exactly how I felt, but I knew I needed to ease into it. This was a significant shift for us. And if she didn't reciprocate my feelings, it had the potential to make this next week even more awkward than it already could be. Only my love for Monroe would have me acting the part of a fool, pretending to be Mr. Darcy. The most torturous part would be reciting Darcy's love and admiration for Elizabeth to Monroe, when all I wanted was to make love to her myself, as Jane Austen would say. Except I didn't mean it as innocently as Ms. Austen's usage. But I would do my best to properly court Monroe. Never would I want her to think I was looking for a friends-with-benefits type situation.

"Oh. My. Gosh. Oh. My. Gosh." Monroe jumped up and down in her seat. "Look!" She pointed at the large country estate behind the wrought iron gate. The house, with its Carolean architecture, stood majestically amidst meticulously manicured formal gardens and a stately wooded park. Admittedly, my estate wasn't as grand, but I would like to think my gardens and park were more elegant.

"You know what happened here, right?"

"Didn't the rules state we weren't supposed to mention it?" I reminded her. Granted, I thought most of the rules were beyond ridiculous, especially the one that prohibited us from discussing any of the shows that had previously been filmed on location there.

"Oh fine, I won't say what or who." She waved her free hand in front of her face. "But just to be here and know what happened here is better than I could have ever imagined. *You-know-who*, king among men, walked the very ground here."

"He's not that amazing," I countered, hoping she didn't begin listing her 101 ways the man of her dreams was superior to all other men.

"Don't worry. I won't judge your acting skills against his." She grinned. "But if you don't give me some goose bumps when you tell me how much

you ardently admire me, I might be a little, or a lot, disappointed."

No pressure there. Give the woman I love goose bumps while using another man's words. "I'll do my best."

"That's all I ask." She leaned over and pecked me on the cheek. This wasn't unusual for Monroe. She was an affectionate woman, but now that I'd decided to open the door to my feelings, her soft, warm lips on my skin had me wanting to turn my head and capture those lips with my own. I would show her I was far superior to any character she'd watched or read about.

"Huh." She paused, leaning on the console as if in a daze.

I glanced her way before turning into Pride and Prejudice Park. "Is something amiss?"

"No," she said breathily while her eyes blinked erratically. "Um . . . I was just thinking that you have really great cheeks. Very taut, and your stubble is perfectly stubbly." Her face turned a lovely shade of red.

"Perfectly stubbly?" I questioned.

She sat back in her seat, laughing nervously. "Yep, perfectly stubbly."

"All right." If it were anyone else, I would question her odd behavior, but this was Monroe, and odd behavior was her MO. Our country's history was rife with quirky nobility, I reminded myself, not wishing to think of the scrutiny and complications a relationship between us would create. Not now when she looked so adorably sexy, teeming with excitement as two men dressed like Regency footmen swung open the wrought iron gates for us.

"Oh, Fitz, this is happening. My *Pride and Prejudice* dreams are about to become reality," she whispered. "Look at those cute men, all dressed up." She rolled down her window, letting in the cool September air that smelled of damp earth and leaves. "Hello," she called to the men.

The footmen looked confused at how they should respond. They probably didn't want to break character, but Monroe had a way about her that made people, men in particular, want to act uncharacteristically unlike themselves. Case in point: I was at a blasted Jane Austen fan's Disneyland.

The footmen gave in, smiled, and waved at Monroe.

If I thought the footmen made her happy, it had nothing on our arrival at the house, where she noticed several other Regency period–dressed individuals lining the gravel drive that crunched underneath the tires of my car, waiting to greet us.

“Look at them!” she shouted. “See? I should have worn one of my dresses. I feel like I’ve died and gone to Jane Austen heaven. This is the best day of my life. Hello, hello, hello!” She waved out of the window.

The staff looked taken aback by Monroe’s enthusiasm. I hoped my presence didn’t play into their behavior. Agatha, the park director, had personally reached out to say how thrilled she was that I would be attending and asked if there were any special accommodations they could make for me. I’d told her it wouldn’t be necessary. I wanted to make sure Monroe had the experience she’d been hoping for, and the last thing I wanted was for my title to impede that. Even if it meant me pretending to be Mr. Darcy all week.

When the staff didn’t reciprocate, Monroe bit her lip. “I suppose that wasn’t very Elizabeth of me.”

I placed my hand on her thigh and squeezed, not knowing what to say. Part of me wished to hint it might behoove her to behave in a more reserved manner, but that made me feel like a bastard, knowing I was doing it for selfish reasons. I knew asking her to change made me the worst sort of person, so I said nothing. Even worse, I didn’t encourage her excitement.

Monroe patted my hand in a mollifying fashion, as if she knew what I was refusing to say. Blast. I was a prick. Only she could make me feel that way. But I said nothing to ease the tension that pervaded the car. Instead, I pulled up and stopped the car in front of the grand house as two of the cast members opened our doors. A severe-looking older woman wearing what I assumed was a gray wig appeared before I could exit the car. Her dress consisted of an obscene amount of purple silk velvet showcasing more of her chest than I cared to see. It appeared she was pretending to be a part of King George III’s court. That poor chap had gone as mad as a hatter.

“Welcome, Your Grace. I am Lady Catherine de Bourgh.” The silly woman, whom I knew to be Agatha, the director, curtsied. If she’d wanted to stay in character, she should never have done such a thing or called me by my title. I was to play her nephew, after all.

Monroe giggled, which earned her a scathing glance from Agatha. She certainly had the haughtiness of Lady Catherine de Bourgh down.

Monroe shrugged, not letting it get to her as she hopped out of the car. In this way, she was every bit an Elizabeth Bennet, and I silently applauded her for it.

I stepped out of the car as well. “Please, there is no need to be so formal. I wish to be treated like any other guest.”

“Yes, Your Grace.” Agatha curtsied again.

My crinkled brow did nothing to disguise my displeasure.

Apparently my disdain for her didn’t temper her admiration. “You honor us with your presence, Your Grace.” Agatha swept around the car, her enormous dress swishing. She stopped and waved her arm toward the house. “Please wait in the marble hall and enjoy the refreshments and tea until all the guests have arrived. We will take care of your car and have your luggage delivered to your rooms.”

“Be sure to take extra care of the costumes in the back seat that belong to Ms. Wilde,” I directed before offering an arm to Monroe, who was gazing in awe at the stately mansion made of brick and Ancaster stone, which gave it a golden hue.

“I can’t believe I’m actually here,” she whispered.

“Shall we go in?”

She nodded and strung her arm through mine. “How courteous of you.”

It wasn’t courtesy; it was love and a need to have her close, not only so I could feel her body next to mine, but so I could protect her from the Lady Catherine de Bourghs of my world. I placed my hand over hers, which delicately held my bicep.

“I like it when you touch me. Wait. That sounded salacious.” She laughed. “I just meant that I like this.”

“I do too.” I gave her a meaningful look, hoping to convey that I wouldn’t mind some salacious touches between us.

The way she tilted her head spoke to her attempt to grasp this change in my behavior. The rosy tint in her creamy cheeks revealed she was flirting with the idea I might wish to be more than friends, but then she shook her head as if she couldn’t believe such a thought. Or perhaps she didn’t wish for a change in our relationship, or for an association with my title and all that it would entail. Monroe had never shown any fascination with my title or even my money—to her, they were of no consequence, and I loved her all the more for it. But perhaps it was her way of telling me she didn’t want to live in my world. I wouldn’t blame her if that’s how she felt. It would, without a doubt, be a daunting endeavor for her.

I brushed a thumb across her smooth skin as I ushered us forward up the large stone steps leading to the slender double doors of the house, testing

the waters and unwilling to let go of the thought of us. She gripped my arm tighter, giving me hope.

A man wearing a white shirt with a turned-up collar and a dark waistcoat with tails opened the doors for us. “Welcome.”

“I can’t wait to see you in a cravat,” Monroe whispered in my ear.

I chuckled, looking forward to seeing her back in her dresses.

There were two things I was not looking forward to seeing—or should I say, hadn’t expected to view. As Monroe and I entered the house, there in the marble hall stood the last two people I wanted to see: Tony and Winnifred.

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# FIVE

**“Angry people are not always wise.”**

## MONROE

“TONY,” I SPLUTTERED, HARDLY BELIEVING my eyes. I wished I could say my peepers were lying to me, but there, standing near the gold-plated fireplace, was my ex-fiancé. If that weren’t horrible enough, none other than Lady Winnifred Roberts, a.k.a. Lady Whiny, was walking our way across the black-and-white-checkered marble floor, her enviable wavy auburn hair bouncing like she was starring in a shampoo commercial. Her steps were even and deliberate as she zeroed in on the prize—Fitz. Fitz, who gripped my hand tighter. Fitz, who was making me feel things I wasn’t sure I should be feeling.

Winnifred’s steely amber eyes homed in on the way Fitz and I clung to each other, incredulity and outright loathing swirling inside them. Believe me, I was just as surprised as she was. I wasn’t sure what to make of Fitz’s affection either, but oddly, I got the feeling he meant it to be more than friendly. And it had me behaving oddly around him as well. On the drive here I’d allowed myself, for the first time in ages, to truly marvel at how beautiful he is. But did Fitz really want to cross the friendship line? Did I want to? Our backgrounds weren’t exactly a match made in heaven. The only noble thing I knew how to do properly was curtsy, and I knew that wasn’t enough to flourish in the kind of circles Fitz lived in. Those circles scared me.

I didn’t have time to think about it—not only was Lady Winnifred quickly closing in, but Tony wasn’t far behind her. He didn’t appear happy to see Fitz and me looking as if we were a couple either, judging by his splotchy red face, set to explode. But he also didn’t seem surprised to see us here together, as if he knew we were both coming. How could he have

known that? And why did he seem upset by it? He'd broken up with me, and I hadn't spoken to him in three months. Tony hadn't wanted to come here when we were together, so maybe he was just upset I'd brought another man on our would-be honeymoon he'd paid for. Best parting gift ever.

"Darling," Winnifred said breathily in her smooth-as-silk voice. "I'm so happy to see you." She kissed Fitz's cheeks while not so subtly trying to push me out of the way.

Fitz tightened his hold on me, which came as a surprise. I'd always figured he would end up with the daughter of the earl. She was beautiful and had all the right qualifications, none of which I possessed. Which made me think Fitz's odd behavior was just that—odd. I didn't really belong in his world, and although Fitz had never come out and said that, he no doubt believed it as well.

"Winnifred, what are you doing here?" Fitz snarled.

"Your mother told me you would be here, and she arranged this surprise. So, surprise!" She laughed a perfectly delicate laugh. "I'm playing the part of Caroline Bingley."

Was this a joke? If so, I didn't find it funny at all. This was my last big hurrah with Fitz. Well, maybe. From the way Fitz held on to me and the way he glared at Winnifred, there was a possibility he was planning more hurrahs in the future. Or maybe I was just delusional. One thing was for sure: Fitz's mum hated me. This confirmed it loud and clear. She'd sent Winnifred here to ruin my honeymoon. Or friendmoon. Whatever you wanted to call it. Why did she care so much? And how was I supposed to enjoy Fitz *talking Darcy* to me with Winnifred around?

Tony swaggered in front of us, landing next to Winnifred, who sneered at him for having the audacity to stand so close to her. He looked just the same as he had three months ago when he'd called off our wedding. Tony still had his hair cut high and tight, patterned after his hero, Ryan Reynolds, and had donned his favorite fit-me-right jeans that showed off his tapered waist and a tight tee that revealed his muscular build. Apparently he was still hitting the gym at least two hours a day. While he was still gorgeous, I wasn't the least bit attracted to him. Something had changed in his countenance. It no longer held the sweetness that once existed. The way he'd so cruelly broken up with me didn't help.

"Hey." Tony looked between Fitz and me, a vein popping in his neck.

“What are you doing here?” I asked, flabbergasted at this strange turn of events.

“Well, I thought it would be romantic if I showed up for our honeymoon.” That sounded like a lie. “But it looks like you’ve already replaced me. I should have known,” he scoffed. “Or should I say, I always knew there was something between you two.”

Before I could say anything, Winnifred guffawed in derision. “Are you having a laugh? Alastair and her?” She pointed at me as if I were so low on the food chain, she couldn’t even speak my name. “It’s impossible.”

That snapped something in me, and instead of telling Tony he was off his rocker and that there had never been anything romantic between Fitz and me, these words fell out of my mouth: “Oh really? For all you know, Fitz and I stopped off in Vegas and tied the knot in the prettiest little bow before coming here.” I don’t think that was actually possible, given we lived in different countries and we’d have to do a bunch of legal things to make that work, but I went with it.

A collective gasp from guests and staff rang through the marble hall. Oops. I guess I’d said that a little too loudly. I’d overlooked the fact that Fitz was widely recognized—not sure why I’d forgotten that, seeing as moments ago Lady Catherine de Bourgh had practically slobbered all over him. And she clearly shared Winnifred’s belief that I was beneath him, judging by the withering looks she’d given me as we’d arrived. Honestly, it had never bothered me before because I’d always known my place in Fitz’s life, but for the first time, I wasn’t so sure. Something had changed between us. I could feel it.

“Please, Alastair, tell me you didn’t make her”—Winnifred pointed her shaky finger at me—“the Duchess of Blackthorne.”

*The Duchess of Blackthorne* rang in my ears like someone had shouted it through a bullhorn. It was so jarring, it hurt. I knew what came with that title, and I’d never wanted it.

“I knew it,” Tony spewed under his breath. “Friends my a—” He got cut off by the exaggerated voice of Lady Catherine de Bourgh, a.k.a. Agatha.

“Welcome to Pride and Prejudice Park.” She did her best Dame Judi Dench impression.

I dropped Fitz’s arm and turned around to see Agatha sweeping in with a gorgeous couple trailing behind her. The woman with beautiful red hair wearing a blue dress looked around in awe at the beloved place I’d dreamed

about visiting since I was a teenager and watched . . . well . . . the miniseries I'd been forbidden to mention, even though it had changed my life. In all the weirdness, I hadn't had time to admire the grandeur of the opulent mansion with gleaming marble floors reflecting the light of the crystal chandeliers. Exquisite artwork adorned the walls, and there was a grand staircase, which I'm sure led to heaven. Instead, I'd made a fool of myself, per usual. This time, I hadn't even been trying to help anyone. And this time, I felt the sting of my blunder more acutely—even more than when Tony had left me.

"I'm sorry," I whispered to Fitz. "I know you wouldn't wish me to be your duchess. Could you imagine?" I laughed, even though I didn't feel all that happy.

Fitz stared blankly at me, his mouth opening and closing several times as if he didn't know what to say. I'd never seen him at a loss for words. Sure, I'd seen him use very few words, but this was different.

"Are you married?" Winnifred demanded while she seethed on the other side of Fitz.

"I am not," Fitz breathed out so only those next to him could hear.

I couldn't tell if he sounded relieved or if he was angry with me for having placed him in such a position.

"Very good." Winnifred patted her heart as if telling it to calm down. All was well. She still had her shot at the title she'd been scheming with Fitz's mum to obtain.

I stepped a pace away from Fitz, feeling as if every eye were on me. It wasn't a good start on my Elizabeth journey. Which I supposed I'd been on for years. So far, it hadn't turned out so well. But I was hoping here I could prove myself to be worthy of my heroine's legacy.

Fitz surprised me when he removed the distance I'd placed between us and took my hand. Maybe it shouldn't have shocked me. He was doing the same thing he'd done back when we were in school together. "You don't need to protect me."

"This isn't protection," he whispered in my ear, sending a shiver down my spine.

What in the world? Was I crazy to get shivers? Did he mean to give them to me? "What is it?" I stuttered out.

He didn't get the chance to tell me.

“Gather round, everyone,” Agatha called out, sweeping through the hall in her extravagant purple dress.

The attractive couple that had come in with her landed near us. Tony stood to the side, shooting daggers at Fitz and me with the deep-blue eyes I used to get lost in. I couldn’t fathom why he was here. And his excuse wasn’t sitting right with me. He wasn’t a romantic guy, and it was clear when he broke up with me that it hadn’t hurt him to do so. Who was he even playing? I’m pretty sure he still didn’t know who Jane Austen was. I bet he’d spell her last name with an *I* instead of an *e* if asked.

In all the weirdness and uncertainty, I gripped Fitz’s hand tighter, even though I had no idea what was going on between us. And I was too afraid to hope my schoolgirl fantasies could become a reality.

Agatha came to stand in front of the gold fireplace. “Greetings, honored guests.” Her eyes landed squarely on Fitz. “We look forward to making all your *Pride and Prejudice* dreams come true. To that end, from here on out, we invite you to leave the world behind and immerse yourselves in this glorious experience. We have done our best here to recreate Jane Austen’s world, save a few modern conveniences like bathrooms and electricity. We had an unfortunate candle event several years ago and too many complaints from guests and staff about the chamber pots and bourdaloues.”

*Thank goodness for that*, I thought. If they told me I had to use a chamber pot or bourdaloue, I would hightail it out of there.

“With that said, there will be no use of other technology except for the fifteen minutes you’re allowed for leisurely pursuits each night. Except for you, Your Grace.” Agatha smiled and fluttered her eyes at Fitz. “Of course, you are free to do as you please.”

Fitz stiffened and stood as regally as possible, his jaw pulsing, holding back his verbal attack.

Agatha plowed on, making Fitz’s Adam’s apple bob repeatedly as he swallowed down his tirade.

“For those of you who don’t know, His Grace the Duke of Blackthorne, Alastair Fitzroy, is joining us this week. Please, show him the proper respect he is due.”

Fitz had had enough. “I wish to be treated like any other guest.” He looked around the room, his eyes boring into every person, trying to make it clear he meant business. “I will tolerate nothing else.”

“Well,” Agatha said, taken aback. “We will respect your wishes.” She hurried on, stuttering a bit. There was nothing like Fitz taking you down a notch. I’d seen him do it to plenty of people. “As part of the experience from this moment forward, you will go by your character’s name, and you will speak in proper English accents,” Agatha trilled. “You should all have memorized your scripts and studied your character’s traits and demeanor.” She zeroed in on me. “Be sure to behave accordingly.”

*I can be an Elizabeth. I can be an Elizabeth*, I chanted repeatedly in my head.

“It is now time to introduce all our players for this week. I will start with Mr. Darcy and Elizabeth Bennet.”

The woman next to me squealed a little bit. She was my kind of woman. And obviously a team player. I would squeal for her when they announced who she was playing.

“His Grace, I mean, you know . . . um . . . him.” She pointed, spluttering at Fitz. “He will play Mr. Fitzwilliam Darcy. And Monroe Wilde,” she spat out my name, “will play Elizabeth Bennet.” She limply shook her hand in my direction.

I waved uneasily at the rest of the guests, who all stared at me, some surely wondering how I’d won the coveted role, as some jaws dropped and lips curled. It was then I noticed the woman next to me fretting and speaking low and frantically to the man she was with. I didn’t hear everything, but it appeared she thought she was supposed to be Elizabeth Bennet.

Oh no. I felt awful, especially given that the amount you paid for the experience was based on which role you would be playing. Obviously, Elizabeth Bennet was much more expensive than the other roles—we are talking about ten grand kind of expensive. And then there was memorizing the script.

“Fitz,” I whispered in his ear. “I think the woman next to me thought she would be playing Elizabeth. We need to fix this.”

“Monroe, please let it be,” he begged.

“But—” I made to argue.

“Don’t you want me to *talk Darcy* to you?” he said in a sexy manner, his eyes dancing. Or at least I thought so. I mean, it sure sounded sexy to me, and I’d never seen his broody eyes light up the way they were now.

The way he was tenderly looking at me had my insides stirring with, well, you know the things men can stir inside of you. Was this for real? Or was it this place making us act uncharacteristically toward each other? Surely Fitz didn't see me as his future duchess. But not even that thought quelled the stirrings. "Uh-huh," was all I could articulate.

"Next we have Jane Bennet, played by Macey Bennet."

The woman next to me, who I assumed was Macey, looked drained of color, her face pale as porcelain. The man next to her was whispering furiously in her ear.

Oh dear. I really was going to have to fix this. She looked devastated.

"Maybe," I whispered to Fitz, "there can be two Elizabeths this week."

Fitz pinched the bridge of his nose and shook his head, knowing I wouldn't let this go. But I showed some decorum and let Agatha introduce the rest of the cast members. That's what Elizabeth would do, right? But Elizabeth also seemed to enjoy needling Lady Catherine de Bourgh. I was sure I would do a good job of that.

Charles Bingley was going to be played by the man next to Macey, although he grumbled that he'd already been working on memorizing Mr. Darcy's lines. Something had obviously gone wrong. Maybe I really was supposed to play Jane. It was odd the park had chosen me to be Elizabeth. Honestly, who would think I would make a good Elizabeth?

Agatha introduced the rest of the Bennet sisters next. Weirdly, they all kind of looked how I imagined Mary, Kitty, and Lydia would look. Mary had a studious air about her, with her mousy brown hair tied back in a neat ponytail. She looked like she was out to prove something to herself. Kitty absentmindedly twirled a lock of her blonde hair, strands slipping through her fingers. The sound of a gentle swat echoed as the woman playing Lydia playfully smacked Kitty's shoulder. I assumed they knew each other—at least I hoped so. Especially since Lydia laughed about it like she was so hilarious.

Winnifred's introduction was next. She haughtily waved to the group until her gaze fell on me. Her sneer said that she planned to rewrite the story and steal Mr. Darcy for her own. To be fair, I'd always assumed Fitz would be hers. Not that Fitz had ever confessed to being in love with her, but he always spoke well of her. And since his mum was all for it, I just expected it would eventually happen. But more and more I was realizing

that if Fitz married Winnifred, she would make sure to push me out of his life. The thought sickened me.

Fitz was my person. *Huh.* I'd never thought of Tony that way—that probably should have said something to me. Maybe it should say something to me now. Would I ever find another person in my life whom I felt so wholly connected to? My friendship with Fitz meant the world to me. Which also meant I didn't want to screw it up. If we opened the door to romance, would our friendship survive? Assuming Fitz even shared the same desires. The way his thumb brushed across my skin certainly felt more than friendly.

I stared right back at Winnifred, letting her know she didn't intimidate me and that I wouldn't allow her to steal Fitz from my life.

Her tsk said, *Watch me.* I almost mouthed, *Game on,* but to my ever-loving surprise, it was announced that Tony would play Mr. Wickham.

"Normally," Agatha pontificated, "a staff member plays George Wickham, but this week we've had a change of plans. Tony Baker will fulfill that role for us." Paid staff members played some of the smaller or less attractive roles like Wickham and Mr. Collins.

Tony winked and waved. The women playing Kitty and Lydia blushed and giggled while whispering between themselves. They could have him.

Tony craned his neck, flashing a toothy grin. "Baby, I can't wait to do our scenes together." It seemed like he was just taunting me, not actually excited about it.

Before I could respond, he turned back around. "Who would pay to play Mr. Wickham?" I wondered out loud.

"Someone with the character of a charlatan," Fitz replied.

"Charlatan?" I nudged Fitz with my hip, eliciting a small smile from him.

"Next we have Mr. and Mrs. Bennet, played by—"

"He looks like Idris Elba." Macey fangirled next to me.

We were so meant to be friends. "I totally think so. Should I feel guilty for being wildly attracted to the man playing our father?" I said out of the side of my mouth.

Macey snorted out a laugh. "Probably. But then I should feel guilty too."

Yep, we were going to be besties this week.

If I thought Mr. Bennet was attractive, he had nothing on Mr. Collins. I nudged Macey with my arm after his introduction. “Um, I’d boil potatoes for him any day,” I said for only Macey to hear. His dark, curly hair gave him a whole Adonis vibe. Not that either man held a candle to Fitz’s good looks, but that was an unfair comparison, seeing as Fitz had just been named one of the hottest, most eligible men in the UK. Truly, he should have been number one. Maybe even number one in the world.

Agatha finished out with Charlotte Lucas and a few more minor roles, like the Gardiners and Sir William Lucas, who were all played by staff members. “There you have it. Now begins your *Pride and Prejudice* journey. Remember, you are here to emulate the qualities that our beloved Jane Austen valued, such as love and friendship, honor and integrity. With that said, this is not the time for you to be seeking romantic pursuits outside of your characters. This is not that type of experience. Do not besmirch Ms. Austen’s good name by going off script or breaking the rules. There will be severe consequences if you do, which could include you being asked to leave.” Her eyes landed on me for the second time.

I wanted to be like, *“Listen, lady, if any character was going to go off script and* should *go off script, it probably would have been Elizabeth.”* She was the one who hadn’t been afraid to walk in the mud and get dirty. I felt like that was a great analogy for her entire life. We loved her character because she was true to her heart and not the societal confines of her day that valued her worth solely on her role as someone’s wife. She held out for love, even if it meant she might have nothing in the end. Elizabeth went off script for her day and age. But I said none of those things. Instead, I kept them in my heart and hoped I could be such a woman.

When Agatha finished staring me down, she said, “Now let us proceed upstairs for your wardrobe fittings and character briefings.”

“Come on.” I tugged on Fitz’s hand, wanting to not only get away from Tony and Winnifred, but to see if I could help Macey. I don’t know how the mix-up occurred, but it seemed so unfair. “Let’s catch Agatha, I mean Lady Catherine. I want to talk to her about maybe changing the rules a bit.”

“Monroe, I don’t think she’s someone you want to trifle with.”

“Really? I’m pretty sure Elizabeth would love to trifle with Lady Catherine.” I gave him a knowing grin.

“You are maddening,” Fitz sighed.

“I bet that’s how Darcy felt about Elizabeth.”

“Probably,” Fitz conceded with a hint of a smile. “Just promise me you won’t give up your dreams for this week.”

“Well, I feel like Tony and Winnifred kind of ruined those dreams.” I’d never said anything against Winnifred before in his presence, since I believed she would one day become his wife and I didn’t want to put any barriers between Fitz and me. But her showing up here for my honeymoon had me wanting to take the gloves off.

Fitz raised our clasped hands between us, intimately holding them against his chest. “They have certainly put a damper on things, but they don’t have to come between us.”

“Us?” I breathily questioned. “Is there something you want to tell me?” I had to know if I was crazy or if Fitz’s feelings for me ran deeper than our friendship. I knew mine could if I was brave enough to unlock the door I’d slammed shut many years ago in the name of preserving our relationship.

“Yes.” Fitz drew closer until I could see the thoughtfulness I’d always loved swirling in his eyes.

I waited with bated breath for him to answer all the questions whirling in my head and heart. I admit to fearing his response, knowing it was going to change everything. Change could be good, very good even, but sometimes it was downright awful.

“Come now, hurry,” Lady Catherine demanded.

“Let’s talk later,” Fitz said, frustrated.

I let out the breath I’d been holding. “Okay. I’ll be the woman in an empire-waist gown showing off my cleavage. Just in case you don’t recognize me,” I teased, needing a lighthearted moment.

“You could do nothing that would prevent me from recognizing you.” He kissed my hand in Regency fashion. I wondered if that was against Lady Catherine’s rules or if it was okay, since Mr. Darcy might actually kiss Elizabeth’s hand.

The touch of his warm lips on my skin had nothing on his words. Don’t get me wrong—his touch had me feeling fluttery. But no man had ever said anything so beautiful to me.

Maybe this week would bring dreams I’d long forgotten and been afraid to dream.

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# SIX

**“I am excessively diverted.”**

## MONROE

I EAGERLY LOOKED THROUGH THE dresses on the “Elizabeth” rack, even though I was a little miffed Lady Catherine had nixed me wearing the costumes I’d made with Grams. She’d also told me there couldn’t be two Elizabeths, and since there was no way she would allow the duke to play Bingley, I had to be Elizabeth. Under her breath I heard her say, “I can’t believe the park’s committee picked you to be Elizabeth.” That made two of us. She also berated me for not speaking with the proper accent. In my defense, I’d been acting as Monroe, not Elizabeth, when I made my request.

Regardless, I couldn’t help but smile at the array of empire-waist gowns before my eyes, made of cotton, silk, gauze, crepe, and sarcenet in varying soft shades of white, blue, and pink, many with wide, square necklines. To add to my enjoyment, the large, light, and airy dressing room smelled of roses and freshly pressed linens.

I smiled over at Macey, or should I say *Jane*, perusing her rack. “Hello,” I said as properly as I could. If you asked me, I thought I articulated a pretty good British accent. After all, I’d lived in the UK for two years while in high school. “We haven’t had a proper introduction,” I said, moving closer to her. “I’m Monroe,” I whispered, so no one could hear me stepping out of character.

“I’m Macey,” she said, just as quietly and in a great British accent.

“I’m so sorry about the mix-up. I tried to get Lady Catherine de Bourgh,” I exaggerated her name using the haughtiest tone I could muster, making Macey giggle, “to agree to let us both be Elizabeth or to let me be Jane, but she won’t hear of the duke being Bingley.”

“That’s so sweet of you. It will be fine.” She couldn’t quite hide the quiver in her voice, revealing how disappointed she was, which made me feel even worse. If only there were a way to fix it.

“I really am sorry.”

“It’s not your fault. Besides, I won the trip. So it’s not like I paid for it.”

“Still, I’m sure you’re disappointed. And in all sincerity, you’d probably be a better Elizabeth than me.”

“The fact that you tried to help me shows you’ll be a great Elizabeth.”

I wanted to hug her. “Thank you. I needed to hear that.”

“Sooo, is the man you’re with really a duke?” she asked.

I nodded.

“Wow. How is it dating a duke?”

“I wouldn’t know. We’re just . . . well . . . I think we’re just friends. Well, maybe. I’m not really sure right now.” I said, flustered. Fitz was throwing me for a loop, and my mind was racing with the possibility of being quite *friendly* with him. But then I remembered I didn’t exactly fit into his noble world. It was all confusing, mostly because I loved no one more than Fitz. It was the purest kind of love, like I would throw myself in front of a moving train for him if I had to. And I know he would do the same for me. Did we risk our *safe* friendship for that kind of love? Or would it be a shame not to build upon something so profound? Do friends really make the best lovers?

“Oh. I’m sorry, I just assumed. You looked like . . . well . . .”

“I know. It’s a recent development. Like as of today, recent.”

“That’s pretty new,” she laughed.

“Yeah. To make it weirder, this was supposed to be my honeymoon, and my ex-fiancé, who I haven’t seen in months, showed up and is playing Mr. Wickham. And . . .” I pointed covertly at Winnifred, who was perusing her rack, complaining that she wanted to bring her own seamstress since the material and colors weren’t to her liking. “That’s Lady Winnifred Roberts. She’s totally in love with Fitz.”

“Zane and I wondered what was going on when Mr. Wickham called you *baby*.”

“Ugh,” I said, disgusted, hating myself for ever thinking that was a cute term of endearment. “It’s a total mess.”

“I know what you mean.” She sighed. “Zane, the guy I’m with, is my best friend’s brother and he totally surprised me by joining me on the flight

here. I thought I was coming alone."

"And that's a bad thing?" I asked.

"It's a long story, but let's just say I've been in love with him for more than half of my life, and it's not reciprocated."

"Hmm. Well, what should we do to change that?" I smiled conspiratorially. "Oh, you should probably know I try to fix all problems, but I'm awful at it, like catastrophically terrible. But I'll try anyway."

She giggled. "I like you. I think we are going to make great sisters."

"Me too. So, should we pick out some dresses?"

"Definitely." Macey pulled out an elegant ivory dress. "What do you think?"

"You should totally wear that to the Netherfield ball. You know, I think I've wanted to go to that ball my entire life." I sounded like an obsessed schoolgirl, but I didn't care. This was my dream. I was going to dance with Mr. Darcy at the ball and pretend to be annoyed with him. Could I do that now? I had a feeling I might just gaze into Fitz's eyes and wait for every touch to see how it made me feel. Oy vey, this was going to be interesting. I would just have to see how our talk went before I got my hopes up.

Mrs. Bennet, our mother for the week, walked over. She was a beautiful Black woman with a lively, kind face. If I recalled correctly, her real name was Laila Gray. I definitely remembered she was married to the Idris Elba look-alike. His name was Davis Gray. "My lovely Jane and dearest Lizzy," Laila said, ever so sweetly but in a terrible British accent. It sounded more like a mix of Australian and Bostonian dialect, but I liked it.

"Hello, ma'am," I tried to phrase it the way Elizabeth would have.

"Oh, don't be so formal. You can call me Mama." She did her best to make *Mama* sound like she was in a *Pride and Prejudice* movie, but it sounded more like a Southern mama.

"Don't let Lady Catherine hear you being so nice to me. I am your least favorite daughter," I teased her. And obviously Agatha's least favorite person.

"She's full of herself, now isn't she?" Laila's Boston accent became even more pronounced. "Listen, my husband and I came here for our twenty-fifth wedding anniversary. We are here to have some fun, and we're going to be nice to anyone we want to."

"Happy anniversary," Macey and I said at the same time.

Laila wrapped her arms around us for a quick squeeze. “My dearest daughters.” She let go of us and grinned. “I’m off to get fitted. They are having a hard time squeezing my chest into the dresses. The old ‘girls’”—she pointed to her ample chest—“aren’t being very cooperative.”

Macey and I giggled as we watched her walk away.

“She’s fun,” I commented.

“Very,” Macey agreed.

However, the woman playing Mary—real name Calliope—did not seem to be having fun. She stared pensively at the plain dresses on her rack. They were quite dowdy. How unfair was that? That, I couldn’t have. “Come here.” I gestured for her to join Macey and me.

“Hi there. I’m Monroe.”

“And I’m Macey.”

“You’re Calliope, right?” I confirmed.

Calliope nodded, but she looked unsure about us—maybe because we were breaking the rules and using our real names.

“Where are you from?” I asked.

“Idaho. I run wellness retreats there,” she replied in a shaky British accent. She was doing a pretty good job of it. She just needed more confidence.

“That’s great,” said Macey.

“I’ve always wanted to go on a wellness retreat,” I said. “One of my students’ moms swears by them.”

“What do you teach?” Macey asked.

“Piano and voice. I own a little studio in Overland Park.”

“Nice.” Macey grinned. “I’m an admin assistant for a creative art center, and I live in California.”

“A Cali girl. I like it.”

“Um . . .” Calliope seemed reluctant to join in the conversation. “I play the piano too. Not very well,” she added.

“I’d be happy to help you during those scenes. We could practice on one of the pianofortes in the house—you know, like the one in Mrs. Jenkinson’s room, since we would be in nobody’s way in that part of the house.” I winked at her.

She smiled at the *P&P* reference and then bit her lip. “You’d really help me?”

“Of course. We are sisters, after all.” I grinned. “Which also means you should pick a dress off my rack.”

“I don’t know.” She shook her head warily. “I don’t want to get in trouble.”

“Don’t worry.” I waved my hand around. “I’ll take all the blame. Lady Catherine would be so happy to have something else she could berate me for.”

“I think she’s just jealous of you,” Macey surmised. “She has a crush on the duke.”

“Who doesn’t?” I quipped.

Calliope raised her hand, surprising me and, I think, surprising herself too. “I kind of think Mr. Collins is cute.”

“Uh, yeah he is,” Macey agreed. “It seems so wrong that he’s playing Mr. Collins.”

“And that he ends up with Charlotte,” Calliope whispered.

“I’ve always thought that too. He and Mary totally belong together.”

“Yes,” Calliope said emphatically, letting down her guard. “She would have appreciated him more. I know I would, now.”

We all giggled.

“Too bad romantic pursuits are against the rules this week,” Macey lamented.

I pursed my lips together, an evil glint in my eye. “What Lady Catherine doesn’t know won’t hurt her.”

“’ello, ladies,” the woman playing Lydia interrupted us with her cockney accent—definitely a native Brit. “I’m Carla, and this is my sister, Ava.” She sounded like she was introducing her girl gang.

Ava waved, looking us over and sizing us up.

“Hello,” Macey, Calliope, and I said politely.

“You’re the one ’ooking up wif the Duke of Blackthorne, aren’t ya?” Carla asked with blunt force.

“Uh . . . no.” Not that it was any of her business, but I worried she would hurt me if I didn’t answer.

“So, is he still up for grabs?”

“He most certainly is not.” Winnifred crashed the party, holding a royal-blue velvet gown, her nose up so high in the air, it had to hurt her neck. “Alastair and I are meant to be together.”

I had a feeling Fitz didn't share her sentiment. "Then why aren't you already?" I sported a smug look. The more I thought about it, the more I realized there was nothing holding Fitz back from pursuing a relationship with Winnifred, so why hadn't he yet?

Winnifred's mouth fell open, and she emitted a tiny squeak before she realized she'd shown any weakness. She pressed her lips together and stood rod straight. "We had separate goals to accomplish first."

I offered her a placating smile, knowing she was grasping at straws.

Winnifred didn't appreciate my cheeky attitude. "If you think for one moment that he wants you, you are mistaken. The society Alastair and I associate with would never accept you. You would make him a social pariah."

Those words stung, even though I knew they were true. Now more than ever, I remembered all the reasons I had quashed my dreams of ever moving beyond friendship with Fitz. Everyone in the room stared at me, waiting for my comeback, while my cheeks blazed. But what could I say? She spoke the truth.

Feeling proud of herself, Winnifred spun around and walked off more haughtily than ever.

"That one finks *'ighly* of *'erself*, don't she?" Carla commented. "Didn't see the duke *'*olding hands wif her."

Lady Catherine swept in. "Thinks, and with," she elocuted perfectly. "We must speak properly, Lydia." She called Carla by her character's name.

Carla/Lydia curled her lip, none too happy about being called out. I was going to have a hard time of keeping track of all the names. Perhaps it would help to just use the character names both in my head and when speaking.

Lady Catherine gave Lydia such an icy stare, it felt ten degrees colder in the room. It appeared I wouldn't be the only one trifling with Lady Catherine this week.

Lydia, feeling beat, retreated to her rack of costumes.

"Now, ladies, hurry." Lady Catherine clapped her hands. "We have a schedule to keep, and you must look the part."

As soon as Lady Catherine left, Macey, I mean Jane, patted my arm. "Are you okay?"

I nodded even though I felt sucker punched.

“I’m sure Winnifred is lying. She’s just jealous,” Jane tried to comfort me.

“She’s not lying.”

“Oh,” Jane said, stunned.

“Yeah. Oh.”

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# SEVEN

***“There are few people whom I really love, and still fewer of whom I think well.”***

## FITZ

I ADJUSTED THE CRAVAT AROUND my neck before I slipped into the dark-blue coat with tails. Every eye seemed to be purposely avoiding me in the dressing room full of costumes and strangers—every eye, save one: Tony. The man’s gaze followed me wherever I went, even when one of the staff members shuttled me out for my character briefing. That had been a pointless exercise; I’d turned the tables and schooled the employee on the intricacies of Darcy’s character, who in my estimation should have equal the sympathy that Elizabeth Bennet garners. After all, he’d endured the torment of unrequited love and felt compelled by his obligations and society to conceal his feelings for the woman he loved. He was the true victim of the story, not to excuse the abominable way the world treated women in that era.

Tired of Tony’s cowardice and glowering stares, I turned toward him as he finished buttoning up his militia regiment uniform. “Do you have something to say to me?”

His face exploded in red. “As a matter of fact, I do.”

“Then say it already,” I dared him.

He paled, giving me immense satisfaction. I freely admit I enjoyed intimidating people; it saved me from many ridiculous conversations. But I knew I could not avoid this one. For Monroe’s sake, I needed to put her ex-fiancé in his place, to prevent him from ruining this experience for her—for us.

Making it easier for the fool, I walked his way.

Tony swallowed hard and cleared his throat, his muscular figure shrinking.

“Yes?” I waited for him.

He clenched his fists and steeled himself. “I always knew there was something between you two. Friends,” he jeered.

I stepped a pace closer. “I will not allow you to dishonor Monroe. She never deceived you. For some reason I cannot fathom, she loved you. Loved—past tense—being the key here.” I made sure to drive that point home.

Tony curled his lip. “I’m sure you were more than happy to nurse her broken heart.”

“I will always be there for Monroe.”

“We’ll see,” Tony said arrogantly. “As far as I can tell, you’ve had plenty of time to make your move. The question is, why has it taken you so long?”

Bastard. Of course he was right, but it was a complicated situation and none of his damn business. At least I could claim that I’d been trying to protect her. “You only need to know that what’s best for you and for Monroe is for you to stay away from her.”

“What are you going to do to stop me?” Tony spat.

I’d been hoping he’d ask. “I already called my estate manager and tasked him with finding out exactly what you did to your family.” As soon as I’d departed from Monroe, the first thing I did was call Kingston. I didn’t care if I was breaking the rules. Tony showing up here spoke to something nefarious going on. Why would he show up for his honeymoon after rejecting the bride-to-be?

Tony faltered, clearing his throat. “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“Hmm. Interesting. I suppose that makes your mother a liar, then.”

“Don’t you talk about my mother.”

“Then leave Monroe alone. You don’t deserve her. You never did.”

“And you think you deserve her?” he seethed. “You think she wants your life? She won’t want to leave her family and her studio. She doesn’t fit into your world, and I think you know that.”

Yes, I knew that, but my world would never be complete without Monroe. I’d loved her like none other, and I couldn’t imagine my life without her. We had to try to make it work, if she was amenable. I had to

believe our bond would make us the most passionate lovers, passionate enough to withstand the storms that would come our way.

When I didn't answer, Tony added, "Look how your so-called friend and some of the staff treated her today. Is that what you want for her?"

Certainly, I didn't want that. "Monroe will choose whom and what she wants. Here's a clue: It's not you." I turned from the idiot to head for the scheduled lunch in character.

"I'm not done talking to you," Tony called.

The other men in the room gaped wide eyed as I strode out, wondering what the hell I was doing. Then Monroe's lyrical voice called from behind, echoing in the cavernous hall lined with priceless artwork and intricately carved statues.

"Mr. Darcy," she seemed delighted to say.

I turned to see a vision in a soft-pink gown, smiling and walking my way. Her graceful movements only added to the allure of the sensually cut dress that enhanced her figure. Delicate white flowers wove through her silky dark hair. Behind her, unfortunately, was a group of the other players, including Winnifred. Mother would have to answer to me. I knew she was unhappy that I was spending the week with Monroe, but I hadn't expected her to stoop so low as to send Winnifred here. As much as I admired Winnifred, I didn't love her. I never had. She lacked a certain warmth I wished to have in a partner, which I knew was hypocritical of me, considering I am as cold as they come. But I wanted the comfort my childhood lacked, the warmth that Monroe showed me was possible.

As Monroe neared, I could see that something troubled her. No doubt Winnifred had gotten ahold of her. Our mothers had filled Winnifred's head with fanciful ideas for the two of us. Perhaps I should have done a better job of quashing those ideas, but I'd hoped she would have realized by now that I had no interest in her romantically.

Monroe landed next to me, her eyes roving over my costume while her cheeks pinked.

"Do I look so ridiculous to you?"

"No," she said, breathlessly. "It's like an actual fantasy come to life." She reached up tentatively and brushed her fingers delicately across my cravat. "Hello, Mr. Darcy," she purred.

It took everything in me not to pull her flush against my body and show her I could be her fantasy and much more. Instead, I replied, "You're

stunning.”

She giggled.

“What?” I asked, confused by her response.

“I’m still wrapping my head around the fact that you realize I’m a girl.”

I took her hand and pulled her to me. “You’ve always been a woman to me.”

“Oh,” she squeaked.

I smiled at my ability to render her almost speechless. Unfortunately, the group of women trailing behind her caught up to us, Winnifred at the forefront. Her eyes zeroed in on Monroe’s and my hands clasped together, and a look of horror washed over her face. Surely Winnifred knew my intentions toward Monroe, given my behavior in the marble hall. And she was smart enough to know that I wouldn’t come to a place like this in the name of friendship only. I knew I would have to address the matter at hand with Winnifred, but it would have to wait. First, I needed Monroe to know how I felt about her, and more importantly, I needed to know how she felt about me—about the thought of us.

“May I escort you to lunch, madam?” I offered my arm to Monroe, doing my best impression of Mr. Darcy, although I felt ridiculous. But I knew this was her dream, and I wished to be part of all her dreams.

When Monroe’s beautiful eyes lit up and she took my arm, it was worth feeling ludicrous. It gave me hope that despite all the obstacles in front of us, we could make it work.

Winnifred clucked her tongue and skirted off, while some women oohed and aahed. Several of the men walked out of the costume room, including Tony, who looked enraged to see us together. That was my cue to lead Monroe toward the stairs.

“We really need to talk,” Monroe whispered as soon as we were away from the group. “Lady Roberts,” she said formally, “said some things. Harsh things,” her voice hitched.

“What things?” I seethed, having a good idea of what Winnifred might very well have said.

We took a few steps down the grand staircase.

“Things we both know are true.”

Internally I winced, knowing full well how wicked Winnifred’s tongue could be. And while she had never come right out and told me she despised

Monroe, she'd delicately danced around it, fearing my reaction if she pushed it too far.

I wanted to ask Monroe what Winnifred had said, but the insufferable Lady Catherine wannabe waltzed up the steps. "Now, now, we must stay in character." She ripped Monroe from me. "Elizabeth and Mr. Darcy would not be so comfortable around one another just yet. Every player must behave accordingly. Remember, this is no place for romance, except for the sake of our characters. We all must give them their proper due." She pursed her lips so tightly, her entire face folded in on itself.

Monroe gave me a pained look as Lady Catherine whisked her away down the stairs.

Tony looked up at me from several steps below and sneered. What an arse.

The man playing Mr. Bennet—I believed his name was Davis Gray—patted my back. "Tough break, man. That Lady Catherine is something else." He didn't even attempt to hide his Boston accent.

I nodded in agreement.

"I'll tell you this—she won't stop me from any romantic pursuits with my wife." He nudged me playfully.

As much as I didn't need to hear that piece of information, it got me to thinking. "You and your wife are lodging in the Longbourn house on the property with all the Bennet sisters?"

Davis grinned as if he knew what I was thinking.

"Perhaps," I spoke low, "I could trouble you to help Monroe take a late-night stroll with me." It was imperative that we talk, and maybe Monroe would find it romantic if I slipped a note to her and asked her to sneak out. I had a feeling Lady Catherine would do her best to keep us apart today, just like she had in the story, so I needed a plan of attack.

"It would be no trouble at all." He winked.

"Excellent."

"Let me know if you need any help with that Wickham guy. Something about him doesn't seem right."

No doubt Davis had heard the row between Tony and me. I should have been more discreet, but the git needed to be put in his place. He had no right to be here. "I agree with you," I replied. It was unsettling that he had shown up here after cutting off all contact with Monroe and never even hinting at a desire to reconcile.

“Well, good luck.” Davis dashed down the stairs.

I had a feeling I was going to need more than luck. With all the obstacles in our way, it was going to take a miracle for Monroe and me to ever be together.

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# EIGHT

***"To be fond of dancing was a certain step towards falling in love."***

## MONROE

I STARED ACROSS THE BALLROOM at Fitz during our etiquette lesson, unable to take my eyes off him. If I'd thought he was dishy before, I'd been sorely mistaken. The man was officially a demigod. Sadly, that evil Lady Catherine was determined to keep me away from him. She refused to even let him sit across from me at lunch, even though Fitz tried to insist that Mr. Darcy's silent fascination with Elizabeth and her fine eyes would certainly make him want to sit across from her. The argument did not persuade her. In fact, she sat Fitz and Winnifred at the opposite end of the table from me, while the miserable woman sat at the head of the table, doing her best Lady Catherine impression. Which meant she placed Mr. Darcy right next to her, as he was the highest-ranking guest. Winnifred cozied up right next to him and whispered continuously to him throughout lunch. Well, that was when Lady Catherine didn't steal his attention. I could only imagine that both women were doing their best to point out all my flaws. It was funny, or maybe not so funny, how the *Pride and Prejudice* story mirrored my life. If only I could channel my inner Elizabeth, assuming I had an inner Elizabeth. *Please, let me have an inner Elizabeth.*

With Fitz's attention being diverted elsewhere, that left me trying to ignore my ex-fiancé leering at me from across the table, all while I tried making polite conversation with those sitting next to me, including Mr. Collins, who seemed so bored to be there. Not once did he mention the excellent potatoes or pontificate about James Fordyce's *Sermons to Young Women*. The latter I was more than grateful for, especially because all I could think of was running my fingers through Fitz's dark mussed hair, styled after Colin Firth's beloved version of Mr. Darcy. These thoughts

scared me, considering what Winnifred had said in the dressing room. I couldn't make Fitz a social outcast. That was, of course, if he truly wanted to be more than friends. He was sure acting like it. His beautiful line about always seeing me as a woman had me all sorts of fluttery. And don't even get me going about how I wanted to live out every Mr. Darcy fantasy I'd ever had with him. Fitz had to be the most beautiful Mr. Darcy there ever was. Sorry, Colin.

"A lady must always speak with elegance and propriety," Lady Catherine expounded, shaking me out of my torrid thoughts, as she walked between the rows of chairs that separated the men from the women. Oh yes, she refused to let the men and women sit together during this portion. It was weird, considering we'd sat together during lunch. I had a feeling she was doing it purposely to keep the duke away from me.

"To add to that, a lady must never force a man to pay attention to her." Lady Catherine's commanding voice reverberated through the grand, opulently adorned ballroom, filling the air with an authoritative tone. The room itself was a sight to behold, adorned with intricate decorations, everything from Chinese porcelain vases to solid gold candlesticks. The air was heavy with the scent of fresh flowers, the smell of rain, and polished wood.

"That's hypocritical of her to say," I whispered to Jane next to me, "considering all she did during lunch was force Mr. Darcy to pay attention to her."

Jane giggled, and Lady Catherine whipped her head in our direction, her face so pinched that her wrinkles pleated. It was even scarier than when she'd scolded me earlier for letting Calliope, a.k.a. Mary, wear one of my dresses. Of course, that kind gesture on my part had ended in disaster. The dress I'd given her, and assisted in tying up the back, came loose—let's just say it mortified the poor woman.

"As I was saying, a lady must never do anything that would give rise to gossip," Lady Catherine pitched her voice higher.

That piece of etiquette pierced my heart a bit. I knew if Fitz and I became a romantic item, the gossip would run rampant, and it would be cruel. And while I tried not to care what other people said about me, I had a feeling that the situation would be different if the press and media made jokes about me here in the UK—or worse, about Fitz.

Lady Catherine droned on about how well-bred people walked uprightly, moved with grace and ease, and never used vulgarity. Apparently I wasn't well bred, because I was thinking some choice words about her and Lady Winnifred, who whispered in my ear from behind, "I hope you're listening and taking notes."

I wrung my hands together, silently asking myself: What would Elizabeth do? Yes, that was going to be my new mantra—WWED. I knew one thing for sure: She wouldn't draw attention to herself, but would think of something witty to say that got her point across. Sadly, I couldn't think of anything along those lines. Ugh. I was letting Jane Austen down in a big, big way. She obviously disliked the Carolines of her day, but I could only sit there and hold my tongue. *Sorry, Jane.* This wasn't the experience I'd been hoping for. I wanted to just pretend not to like Caroline Bingley, not actually hate her.

"Now let's practice the art of the curtsy and bow, as well as properly addressing those within your family, your peers, and those above your station."

"That would be me," Lady Winnifred whispered in my ear again.

This time, I turned around and replied with a comeback I thought worthy of Jane Austen. "Not here, Miss Bingley," I said in my best British accent. "My father is a gentleman and owns an estate. Can you say the same?"

Winnifred tsked at first, affronted, but then she smiled like an evil Cheshire Cat. "I meant in all the ways that count, dear." Condescension stuck to every word like molasses.

Dang. She. Was. Good. Awful, but good.

I turned around after that brutal takedown, and Jane squeezed my hand, offering me some sympathy. More and more, I empathized with Elizabeth and all she had working against her. I was probably my own worst enemy, but Elizabeth was at times too. She was too proud to hear anything against Wickham at first, and look at the harm that caused. I didn't feel ready for the Carolines of my world. Sure, I'd learned to laugh them off back in school. But this was different. There would be an enormous cost to be with Fitz. Was I willing to pay for it? I didn't have time to think about it.

"Everyone, stand and turn to the person next to you," Lady Catherine instructed. "We will start with the ladies. For a proper curtsy, shift the weight to your left foot while you bring the ball of your right foot behind."

She demonstrated perfectly. “Then you slightly bend your knees while doing a gentle bow of the head. Nothing dramatic, but also don’t rush. And be sure to look down when bowing the head, but when the head lifts, make eye contact.” She made it look easy enough.

I looked over and caught Fitz’s eye, wondering if he remembered the night back in school when I’d made him teach me how to do a proper curtsy—you know, just in case I ever ran into the Queen. Obviously, that had never happened, but it was still a fun night, even if Fitz pretended to grumble about it. But he’d made sure I could curtsy with the best of them. A knowing smile ticked up on his handsome face, telling me he remembered as well.

I thought back to all the nights Fitz would sneak over to our small flat, which was not far from the school. Our alma mater was a boarding school and a day school, and Fitz was part of the boarding crowd. My dad would play us his old Billy Joel records and make us American-style cheeseburgers and fries. Then I would play the old out-of-tune piano Dad had rented for me to practice on while we lived in the UK. While I played, I’d sing my little heart out. Often Fitz would sit on the piano bench with me, not saying much of anything, but occasionally he’d request his favorites. Often it would be something by the Beatles, like “Hey Jude.” But oddly, his most requested song was “And So It Goes” by Billy Joel. Of course, it pleased Dad that he’d made a Billy Joel fan out of Fitz. But I’d always wondered why he loved that song so much. I mean, it’s beautiful, but kind of sad, about a man who guards his heart. Had Fitz been guarding his heart around me? All I know is that each time he left, my dad would say, “I like that kid,” and I would think how much I liked him too.

“Practice,” demanded Lady Catherine, intruding in my thoughts once again, “while I teach the men the proper way to bow.”

“She’s just a ray of sunshine,” Jane snickered as soon as Lady Catherine diverted her attention to the men.

I giggled and did a perfect curtsy, if I did say so myself.

“Impressive.” Jane clapped. “I’m going to try. I’ve been watching Regency-era YouTube videos for days now, learning how to do it.”

Yep, she was definitely my kind of woman. If I hadn’t had Fitz to teach me, that’s what I would have done too. But I did have Fitz, and I wanted to keep it that way, even if that meant staying just friends.

Jane executed the perfect curtsy, and I clapped for her. “Good job.”

Our poor *mama* was not having the same luck, and being paired with Winnifred didn't help matters.

"You're doing it all wrong. Straighten your back, and don't be so dramatic this time."

Mrs. Bennet was better at being assertive than I was. "I don't know who you think you are." She snapped her fingers right in front of Winnifred's face. "But you'd better drop the attitude. Most of us are here to enjoy ourselves, so stop trying to ruin it. Maybe if you jumped off your high horse, you might have some fun too."

I loved Mrs. Bennet. She was my new hero.

Winnifred blinked and blinked, so stunned someone would call her out. "Well, I was just trying to help you not look like a fool." She spun on her heel and marched off.

"That was amazing," I sang as I curtsied to her. "I bow down to you."

"That stick thing probably just needs to eat some carbs." Mrs. Bennet laughed. "Glucose is a beautiful thing."

While I agreed about glucose, I wasn't sure carbs were going to make Winnifred any nicer. I don't even think landing Fitz would fix her attitude.

Mrs. Bennet wrapped her arms around Jane and me. "You just come to me if that one bothers you."

Oh, I had a feeling Winnifred had more in store for me, but I wasn't sure if Mrs. Bennet could protect me from her wrath. Regardless, I truly appreciated her willingness to try.

I leaned my head against Mrs. Bennet. "Thank you."

We broke apart when Lady Catherine began listing when and to whom we should bow or curtsy. Apparently, all children in that era bowed or curtsied to their parents the first time they saw them each day. I could never imagine doing that to my dad, but it would be fun to do it for the next week. I really wanted to immerse myself in the experience—and especially in Mr. Darcy.

"Now, let's speak of dance etiquette before the dance lessons begin. We will be learning the English country dance and the cotillion. There will be no waltzing," Lady Catherine said shrilly. "It is scandalous to embrace one's partner so closely, as is standing up with the same partner more than two times in a row."

I had to press my lips together so as not to laugh at how outraged she sounded. It was almost as if she weren't playing a part, but actually

believed it to be true. I caught Fitz staring at me with a look of disappointment. Was he as sad as I was that we wouldn't be waltzing together? Butterflies erupted in my stomach when I thought about being in his arms and twirling romantically to the music. I knew Fitz was an excellent dancer—he'd taken dance lessons when he was younger because the British still have a social season in which he was expected to participate. If we became an item, I supposed I would have to as well. Oh gosh—that was a daunting thought. Fitz had literally rubbed shoulders with royalty. We are talking about the Queen and now the King of England. Knowing me, I'd probably step on their royal toes or maybe try to straighten their crown if I saw it was askew. Just the thought of making a fool of myself on an international stage gave me heart palpitations. I was just a simple girl from Kansas, and I liked it that way. But I loved Fitz, and I knew it wouldn't take much for me to fall *in* love with him—he only needed to knock on that door and I would open it wide. But it wasn't just Fitz that I had to consider—there was the duke.

"We are going to start with the English country dance. For tonight, we will pair you together. For the rest of the week, you will follow your script."

Ugh. I knew that meant I wouldn't be dancing with Fitz tonight. No way was Lady Catherine going to let that occur. Sure enough, I was right; first up was Mr. Collins. It could have been worse—could have been my ex.

Of course, Lady Catherine paired Caroline and Mr. Darcy together. Winnifred looked more than smug about it and practically ran to Fitz, all the while looking elegant. But Fitz surprised me when he dashed over to me, looking as determined as I'd ever seen him. Not even Lady Catherine could stop him, although she tried. She literally stepped in front of him. "Now, Mr. Darcy, we must stay in character."

"Believe me, madam, I am." He pushed past her and landed next to me.

Oh. My. Gosh. That might have been the sexiest thing I had ever seen. Fitz was rewriting *Pride and Prejudice* for me, and I was here for it in a big, big way. Judging by the way my "sisters" and "mother" were all figuratively drooling, they loved this new version too.

Fitz's eyes roved over me, so slowly and sensually, it was as if he were physically touching me. I held my breath until his eyes had gone the length of my body, leaving a trail of sparks. No man had ever elicited such a reaction with just a look.

"Miss Bennet." He stepped so close I could feel the heat rolling off him.

“Yes, Mr. Darcy?” I stammered, so overcome by him. I felt as if we’d not only crossed the friendship line, we’d erased it.

He leaned in closer and discreetly placed a folded note in my hand. “You would honor me if you read this,” he whispered between us.

Oh, I was going to honor him all right. “I will.” I beamed, hardly believing this was happening. Every concern I had about being more than his friend faded away.

“Until later, then.” Fitz strode away, and I stared after him, keeping the note completely secreted in my hands.

Best. Honeymoon. Ever. It was like I had died and gone to that old show, *Fantasy Island*, that my dad loved to watch in reruns. Except, horrible things always happened there before the happy ending. Scratch that. We were not on *Fantasy Island* . . . I dared to hope.

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# NINE

***"The more I see of the world, the more am I dissatisfied with it; and every day confirms my belief of the inconsistency of all human characters, and of the little dependence that can be placed on the appearance of merit or sense."***

## FITZ

I FELT AS IF THIS day would never end. The last thing I wanted to do now was play whist in the drawing room, especially because the woman who fancied herself the real Lady Catherine was determined to keep me away from Monroe. She made Monroe sit at a table across the room from me. Monroe's intoxicating laugh that I could never get enough of called to me like a siren in the stuffy drawing room with an inordinate number of blue velvet settees and chaises. Little did she know how much she was beguiling me and had me wishing that we were alone together. Had she read my note? The smiles she had given me at dinner from down the table would indicate she had. But would she risk the wrath of Lady Catherine and sneak out to meet me? I felt like a schoolboy waiting for her to check the box to say she liked me.

To add to my irritation at being kept away from Monroe, Tony sat at my table. I found it odd and unsettling that he hadn't tried to weasel his way near Monroe. Wasn't that why he'd come to this wretched place? Not to say I wasn't glad he was keeping his distance from her, but he'd purposely sat at the table with me. Why was that? What was his game? I knew he was playing at something.

"Should we make an actual wager?" the idiot Tony asked the table. Winnifred and the woman who played Charlotte Lucas were seated with us. Charlotte, who I believed was really named Lily, sat near me and across from Tony, serving as his partner. She'd taken every opportunity to catch

his attention and smile at him flirtatiously. To make it more uncomfortable, she had a ghastly, high-pitched laugh, and she found everything the moron said to be humorous. Tony didn't seem to mind the attention, which only made me more suspicious of his motives for being here.

"I don't think that would be appropriate." I didn't bother to look up from my cards.

"Are you afraid to lose?" Tony tried to bait me.

I scoffed at his audacity. Whist was in my blood.

"A word of caution—do not trifle with Alastair," Winnifred commented.

"Don't you mean Mr. Darcy?" Charlotte corrected.

"I meant what I said," Winnifred responded coolly, trying to catch my eye.

Trying not to encourage her, I ignored her attempt to engage me. It had been difficult, given that Lady Catherine was constantly pairing us together. It made me wonder if Lady Catherine was in league with my mother, or perhaps Winnifred.

"If you are so confident, what do you have to fear?" Tony wouldn't let it drop.

This time, I zeroed in on the parasite.

His eyes gleamed with malice.

I took a moment to study him as I would a historic piece of literature. He was much easier to read. "The question is, what are you afraid of?"

He cleared his throat and held his hand closer to his chest. "Nothing," he stammered. "I just thought it would be nice to win back some of the money you stole from me."

Both women at the table gasped.

I carefully laid my cards down, holding back the desire to destroy him with more than a verbal assault. "I'm going to give you the opportunity to apologize for your unfounded accusation before I make you sorry for ever uttering it."

Tony's face reddened as he shifted uncomfortably in his seat. "I only meant that I paid for this trip for you and Monroe."

"I think what you mean is you threw away the best thing that ever happened to you."

Winnifred stiffened, her expression begging me not to confirm her worst fears.

I couldn’t do that. It would be crueler to give her hope where there was none. Unfortunately, I had probably done that by trying to spare her feelings over the years.

“The relationship had run its course,” Tony defended himself.

“How odd for you, then, to tell Monroe this was a romantic gesture on your part, showing up for your would-be honeymoon.”

“Ooh, really?” Charlotte squealed, quite interested by this information.

I abhorred people like her who lived for gossip almost as much as I hated being the subject of gossip.

“Uh,” he stuttered. “It was,” he lied.

“Right.” I stood, tired of these games. Before I walked off, though, I couldn’t help but warn him again. “Stay away from Monroe.”

“Why? Because you want her?” Tony spat.

With some regret, knowing it would hurt Winnifred, I gave her a meaningful look. “As a matter of fact, I do want Monroe.” I wanted to tell Monroe in person first, but surely from my behavior today, she had to know that I wished for us to be more than friends.

Winnifred’s lower lip quivered.

For that I felt awful, but I didn’t appreciate her showing up here unannounced like it would be some sort of treat for me. “You can pass that along to my mother as well.” I strode off, eager to speak to Kingston and to escape the warm room with the roaring fire that made me feel suffocated in the wool jacket my character was required to wear.

Before I exited, I took a moment to watch Monroe at her table with Jane, Bingley, and Mary. She was smiling and laughing too loudly for Lady Catherine’s liking, judging by how often the woman glanced at her from her own table and shook her head. It pained me to see how the ill-tempered woman treated Monroe, because I knew if Monroe and I dated, it would only expose her to more censure. One part of me wanted to discreetly whisper to Monroe that her behavior was being watched, while the other part of me admired her and even longed to be as carefree. No one was as happy as Monroe. Perhaps it was because she always thought of others. Even now she was doing her best to help Mary learn whist, though I was sure it would end in disaster somehow. But at least she tried. For that, I loved her, even if her incessant need to fix what was broken drove me mad at times.

Monroe caught me staring at her and waved, a question in her eye as to why I was leaving.

I tried to convey with my smile that there was nothing for her to worry about.

“Your Grace, I mean Mr. Darcy.” Lady Catherine came running over. “Where are you going? Are you unhappy? What can I do?”

I steeled myself and held back the biting remarks I had on the tip of my tongue. Foremost, her treatment of Monroe that went beyond the scope of her character as Lady Catherine. The woman playing Mrs. Bennet treated Monroe warmly, even though it was out of character for her part. I understood the park’s aim of wanting to make this as realistic as possible. Well, not quite—I found it preposterous. But the point was, there was no need for the woman to be blatantly rude to Monroe. Even Lady Catherine had done her best at first to welcome Elizabeth Bennet.

“I’m not in need of your service,” I replied bluntly. “I need to speak to my estate manager.”

“Oh, yes, of course,” the silly woman responded. “I would never get in the way of that. You enjoy as much leisure time as you need.” She curtsied. “I myself will take your place at your whist table.”

“Thank you,” I said dryly before escaping out into the hall. I went only ten steps when I heard Monroe loudly whisper, “Fitz.” I turned to see her peeking her gorgeous head out the door, knowing her act of rebellion was going to get her in trouble with Lady Catherine. In fact, I believed the horrible woman was currently tugging on her, as Monroe’s head kept jerking back and forth while she tried to speak.

“The answer is yes,” Monroe managed to say before Lady Catherine pulled her back into the room and scolded her. “There will be no romantic pursuits outside of the script,” she screeched. The woman had an overinflated sense of self.

A great sense of relief washed over me, knowing in a few scant hours I would be alone with Monroe. Yet there was trepidation and guilt. I was going to ask Monroe to cross a line we could never come back from. And for her, the line would lead into enemy territory. Was I wrong to follow my heart instead of my cold, calculating head for once? I loved no one like I loved Monroe. To carry on as only her friend was an unbearable thought. We would make it work, I told myself, attempting to assuage my guilt as I walked down the dimly lit corridor in the main house we’d been in all day.

Apparently, this house was where the Rosings Park and Pemberley scenes would occur. Monroe was staying across the park in the Longbourn house. Tomorrow I would have to move to the Netherfield house to stay in character.

As soon as I entered my suite with walls covered in geranium-leaf wallpaper, I sat on one of the fabric chairs in front of the fireplace, taking a moment to breathe before I called Kingston. I hoped he'd been able to find any information about why Tony was here. I was sure it wasn't because he was nursing a broken heart, which filled me with ire. How could he not realize what he'd had with Monroe? For her sake and for my own, I was grateful that the half-wit had let her go. Sometimes I wondered if I was any better, though. I had been willing to let her go, but it was to protect her. That had to count for something.

With that thought, I pulled out the phone I had concealed inside the pocket of the cream silk trousers I wore. I had to admit, they were quite comfortable. Wearing them outside this place was out of the question, but I didn't mind them.

Kingston answered on the first ring. "Your Grace, I mean Alastair, sir. I suppose you saw the photo on *Daily Mail*'s site," he asked uneasily before I could say a word.

A sinking feeling fell over me. I knew I had to know, but I feared asking. "What photo?"

Kingston hesitated to respond. "Perhaps it should wait."

"Kingston, please, I must know."

"Sir, it's of Miss Monroe and you at the airport. It paints her in an unflattering light."

"Damn it." I threw myself back against the chair. It was my worst nightmare coming to fruition. "What did it say?"

Kingston swallowed so hard I could hear it over the phone. "Just that she seems a tad quirky, and the article questioned if she was suitable for you and your title."

No doubt Kingston was sugarcoating it. I was sure the author of the article hadn't called her *quirky*.

"Shall I make a threatening call on your behalf?" he offered.

"No. That will only add more fuel to the fire. Hopefully it will blow over. Is my mother having kittens over it? No doubt she has seen it." She would never admit it, but she thrived off gossip in any form.

“She has delivered two litters over it,” Kingston quipped.

I couldn’t help but chuckle, even though this was no laughing matter.

“I hope Miss Monroe doesn’t see it. She is . . . if you don’t mind me saying, incredible. Quirky”—there was a smile in his voice—“but incredible.”

“I know, Kingston,” I sighed.

“I was hoping you would figure that out.”

His admission surprised me. Perhaps I hadn’t hidden my feelings as well as I thought. But he had to know I wouldn’t be here if I didn’t have more than friendly feelings for Monroe. I didn’t miss faculty meetings for anything. “Actually, I’d been hoping to confess my feelings for her tonight. Perhaps I should wait.” I didn’t know why I was admitting this to Kingston. But he was the closest thing I had to a friend outside of Monroe. His advice was always thoughtful, and I valued it.

“Permission to speak freely?” Kingston asked.

“You never need to ask that. Just know I might not like what you say.”

“I will take your warning to heart, yet I must tell you that women like Miss Monroe don’t come along every day. It’s obvious she sees you, not your title or what you have to offer her. And I’ve known no one as caring and loving as she is.”

Nor had I. But . . . “Can she be the Duchess of Blackthorne?”

“I believe she can be anything she wishes to be, but that is a question only you can answer.”

I felt as if Kingston were politely putting me in my place because he knew what I was really asking. His rebuke, as gentle as it was, made it no less uncomfortable, so I changed the subject. “Were you able to find out anything about Monroe’s ex-fiancé?”

“I’m still working on it. You’ll be the first to know when I find something.”

“Very good.” I knew he would find *something*. What, I wasn’t sure.

“Will there be anything else, sir?”

“No, Kingston. Wait . . . Perhaps you could send me the photo and the article.”

Kingston paused before he responded. “I will, but . . . I hope it doesn’t change your plans for tonight. Good night, sir.” He abruptly and uncharacteristically hung up on me.

I scrubbed a hand over my face before loosening the cravat around my neck, knowing I'd just come off as an insensitive berk. Yet, I stared at the phone in my hand, waiting and dreading the photo and article that would appear. I had to know what Monroe and I were up against. It didn't change my feelings for her, but it did give me pause. She didn't deserve this kind of treatment, no matter how quirky she was. Her quirks were part of her charm.

It didn't take long for the photo and the unflattering article to appear. The photo showed Monroe handing me a dress, wearing a bonnet, with dresses still wrapped around her shoulders. Whoever took the photo had captured her with her mouth wide open, which made her appear deranged. The caption read, *Could this be the new Duchess of Blackthorne? Please, no.*

I tossed my phone on the chair next to me, knowing damn well what the rest of the article would say. *Unflattering* was probably the kindest word Kingston could have chosen. No doubt they'd ripped Monroe to shreds and questioned why I would choose someone like her.

I closed my eyes, and several visions of Monroe ran through my mind. Everything from her singing and playing duets on the piano with my sister, Anna, to her being covered with puppies and giggling with delight, to her knowing every song to every musical and belting them out like the star she was in my life. The brightest star. The night sky would be grim indeed without her in my life. If not for her, I would just lose myself in my work and research. I would be more of a selfish bastard than I already was. Or did trying to thrust my life on her make me even more of one?

It was a question that deserved an answer. But for the first time in my life, I was going to ignore all the evidence.

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# TEN

***"A lady's imagination is very rapid; it jumps from admiration to love, from love to matrimony in a moment."***

## MONROE

"READ IT AGAIN," MACEY, I mean Jane, squealed. I really needed to stay in character before Lady Catherine had an aneurysm. She did seem to love to hate me, though, so perhaps she wouldn't be too disappointed to pin a medical emergency on me.

"Okay, okay." I dreamily sighed and held out Fitz's letter in front of us as we lay next to each other on the beds we'd pushed together in our room. When we'd initially walked in and seen the two twin beds, we knew we couldn't have that—we wanted the full Jane-and-Elizabeth experience. Aside from the separate beds, though, the Longbourn house and our room were everything I'd hoped they would be. With a vestibule, drawing room, parlor, and library, it was heaven. Our room had a low-burning fire in the fireplace, and the handcrafted furniture was divine. I was absolutely in love with the pink parfait-and-cream flowered wallpaper. So in love, in fact, I was determined to hang the same wallpaper in my own bedroom when I returned home. The best part, though, was the complete absence of a chamber pot and the room smelled like the rose water women of the Regency era used to wash with.

I still couldn't believe Fitz had written me such an affectionate letter. I hadn't even known he could be romantic. Boy, was I ever wrong. Fitz was a romantic genius.

Jane and I put our heads together before I read the letter—which was written on a blend of cotton and linen paper that Fitz had folded as if he were Mr. Darcy himself—out loud for the fifth time.

*My dearest Monroe,*

*I hope my behavior today gives you license to suspect that my feelings for you run much deeper than our friendship, which I have valued above all relationships in my life. In vain I have struggled to conceal my heart from you, for fear that my heart is unworthy of you; I am loath to ruin what we already share. But I am losing the fight. My feelings will not be repressed. I've come to realize that only time ceasing to exist would put an end to my feelings for you.*

*If these feelings are unwelcome, I will say no more on the subject, for I cannot imagine my life without you in it, and though it would be difficult, I will ever remain your friend. But if you wish to explore a deeper aspect of our relationship, meet me at midnight near the stables for a late-night stroll. All you need do is say yes, and I will be there waiting for you. My greatest hope is that one day we will be in possession of each other.*

*Ever thine,*

*Your Mr. Darcy*

"Holy swoon." I fanned myself. If Fitz wanted to make me fall in love with him, he had me at *I've come to realize that only time ceasing to exist would put an end to my feelings for you.* Whoa. Like, whoa, whoa, whoa. I could hardly believe this was real, but it had to be. Fitz would never toy with my feelings like this. How long had he felt this way? Was this a sudden development? Did he just wake up one morning and think, *You know what? I love my best friend*?

"You're telling me," Jane said, as if she needed a moment. "I have the holiest of envy."

"Well, Fitz is a history of literature professor, so he was basically born to write well. He'd give Captain Wentworth a run for his money. But don't worry—I think Charles Bingley will come around." I nudged her. I'd seen Zane, a.k.a. Bingley, checking her out a few times that day.

"Ugh. Zane," she said his name on a sigh. "I don't even know what to think about him. He's trying, but I feel like he felt coerced into coming here with me. I can't help but feel guilty that he's here."

I wasn't so sure about that. He seemed into the dancing when we were paired together, even though he stepped on my toes twice. And I was pretty sure it was because he was looking for Jane. "I'm sorry. Do you want to talk about it?"

"No." She smiled. "I want to read your letter again." She took it from me.

I wondered if she hesitated confiding in me because she was afraid I would try to help her and she'd witnessed my earlier helpful efforts today. Poor Mary not only had a wardrobe malfunction thanks to me, but I'd tried to help her get Mr. Collins's attention before we started playing whist. I thought it would be cute if she accidentally bumped into him, so I gave her what I thought was a little push. Unfortunately, I ended up pushing her into our table instead, knocking over a bottle of wine and splattering her. So she had to change once again, and I got another lecture from Lady Catherine about how I wasn't acting like a well-bred young lady. Thankfully, Mary was kind enough to forgive me, but I still felt awful about it.

"You really had no idea he felt this way about you?" Jane asked while repeatedly perusing the letter.

"None at all. Like I said, I'm not really duchess material. You've seen how some people, a.k.a. the Ladies Catherine and Winnifred, treated me today, not to mention a few others from the gentry. It's been the same since our school days—I don't fit in with his crowd. But it's never bothered me, until now," I admitted.

"So you're not going to meet him?"

"Of course I am. I love him and, honestly, could easily find myself in love with him. But I'm afraid," I admitted. "What if things don't work out and I ruin his social standing?" My chest seized just thinking about it. "What if I ruin the best relationship I've ever had?"

Jane squeezed my arm. "What if you make it better? I've never had a man say the words your duke used in this letter—his sentiments are heart-achingly beautiful. He obviously thinks it will work out; I don't think he'd risk it otherwise."

I nibbled on my lower lip. She did make a lot of sense, so I turned and hugged her. "Thank you, dear sister." I sat up. "Okay, I guess I'm doing this. What should I wear?"

She sat up too and smiled. "Hmm. I'm not sure Elizabeth ever snuck out for a midnight tryst."

"Tryst?" I laughed. But . . . "Could you imagine how amazing it would have been for Mr. Darcy and Elizabeth to have a few sexy stolen moments in the book?"

"That's not canon." Jane did her best Lady Catherine voice. The insufferable woman had been saying that phrase all day. Also, *"I know it's not canon, but we must make some allowances."*

“I’m going totally off script tonight.” I jumped off the bed and headed for the wardrobe, feeling three parts elated and one part pukey. This had the makings of being the best night of my life and the realization of dreams buried long ago, or it could ruin the life I already loved with Fitz in it. That wouldn’t happen, right?

I pulled out one of my “civilian” outfits that included a tweed highland jacket Fitz had given to me last Christmas. I felt like such an aristocrat in it. Oh wow. That’s exactly what I would be if Fitz and I became a forever kind of thing. The thought gave me heart palpitations. *Let’s just take one step at a time,* I tried to calm myself.

“That’s a beautiful jacket,” Jane commented, but she looked a little pale.

“Are you all right?”

She bit her lip. “It’s silly, but your jacket sort of looks like a riding jacket and it reminded me we have riding lessons tomorrow. I’ve got this stupid fear of horses from an incident when I was younger. It’s kind of the reason I didn’t want to be Jane. Elizabeth isn’t a horsewoman.”

I felt even worse now that Lady Catherine wouldn’t let me switch parts with Macey. “Well, this Elizabeth is a horsewoman, thanks to Fitz. He has a stable full of prize-winning horses, and he taught me how to ride and how to handle myself around a horse. Granted, I’ve never ridden sidesaddle, but I’ll help you. Wait, that probably isn’t a very comforting thought.” I laughed nervously. Would I ever be able to help anyone?

“You’re so sweet to offer. I’m sure it will be fine,” she said, super pitchy. But I also noted she wasn’t keen on taking me up on my offer for assistance. Not that I blamed her. It proved she had excellent judgment. “Let’s get you ready for your date with Mr. Darcy.”

A date with Mr. Darcy. It had a nice ring to it.

Before I knew it, I was ready and downstairs. Mr. and Mrs. Bennet peeked cautiously out the front door, scanning the surroundings. It was hard to tell if anyone or anything was lurking about because of the thin veil of mist that enveloped the area. The dim glow of gas lamps struggled to penetrate the low-lying fog. Just standing in the doorway, I could feel the chilly air seeping through my tweed jacket. But not even the chill or eerie weather would stop me tonight.

Mrs. Bennet wrapped me up tight when she believed the coast was clear. “Have fun tonight, my darling girl.” Her British accent was still awful, but I appreciated her motherly warmth. It had been a long time since

I'd had a mother's hug. Don't get me wrong: my dad did his best to be both father and mother—and he was amazing—but sometimes you just need a feminine touch. Tonight was one of those nights.

"I'll wait in the parlor to let you back in," Mr. Bennet offered.

"You don't have to do that." I felt awful, especially since this was their anniversary and their romantic pursuits were safe from Lady Catherine's regulations, given they shared a bedroom.

"It's my pleasure." Mr. Bennet waved away my concern. "After all, you're my favorite daughter." He winked.

"I suppose I am." I hugged him. "Thank you. I guess I'm off." My stomach felt as if I had walked off a step and missed the entire flight of stairs. With a deep breath in and out, I fled into the night, still hardly believing Fitz had romantic feelings for me. Honestly, it sounded as if he was in love with me. How had I missed that?

Carefully, I tiptoed across the well-kept lawns, praying I didn't accidentally fall into the lake or trip and face-plant before I made it to the stables. It was hard to see more than a few paces ahead of me. I wanted to look pretty and not wet and muddy when I saw Fitz. Normally, I didn't care how I looked around him—he had definitely seen me in my natural state. We are talking about a just rolling out of bed, hair tangled, mascara-smudged-eyes kind of state.

Every little sound made me jump. If Lady Catherine caught me, she'd for sure send me packing. She was probably hatching a plot already to kick me out, which made me think she might just be prowling the grounds herself, looking for rule breakers and romantic pursuits. So when I saw the stables up ahead, barely illuminated by two gas lamps, I made a mad dash for it. As I reached the stable gates, they creepily opened, and a hand grabbed me, making me screech.

"Who's there?" a man's gruff voice that I didn't recognize demanded, while I found myself being pulled through the gate.

The hand thankfully belonged to Fitz. He unceremoniously pushed me against the stone wall to which the gate was attached. "Shh," he whispered low in my ear while his body nuzzled against mine as if he were my lover, not my best friend, shielding me from the chill of the night air and whoever was prowling around the park.

A violent, goose bump–producing shiver went through my body, even though it felt at the same time like someone was pointing a blowtorch at

me. I held my breath and gazed into Fitz's broody gray eyes, which were already searching my own in the dark, murky night.

"I said, who's out there?" the man bellowed again.

I bit my lip, praying we didn't get caught.

Fitz pressed me harder against the wall while his eyes drifted toward my mouth. For what felt like an eternity, he stared longingly at my lips, his eyes fixed on me with a mix of desire and yearning. The air around us grew heavy with anticipation as the soft sound of Fitz's uneven breaths filled the silence. It was as if time stood still, the world fading away, and all that remained was the intensity of his gaze, filled with the promise of what felt like a forbidden kiss.

I gripped his wool coat, aching for his teasing lips to capture my own, to taste the mint on his breath and feel his stubble against my cheeks, all the while fearing the repercussions if things didn't work out between us.

Footfalls sounded near us. I let out a barely audible squeak, which gave Fitz the last bit of incentive he needed. His mouth covered mine. The magical spark of our lips uniting made me forget the possibility of being caught. Fitz completely enveloped every sense I owned as his lips moved over mine so reverently, as if he cherished me above all. I melted into him, and naturally, my lips parted.

His chilly hands cradled my warm cheeks as he deepened the kiss, the best kiss of my life. He knew all the right things to do, from the way his thumbs caressed my cheeks to how he varied the pressure of his lips, to the way he swirled his tongue with mine, as if we'd done this a thousand times before. In between breaths, he brushed my lips with his and then nipped my lower lip with his teeth. His powerful hands ran up into my hair, his fingers immediately tangled in the strands, damp from the fog, as if holding on for the ride of his life.

At that moment, all my dreams for this trip changed. Forget Mr. Darcy—I wanted Fitz.

Minute after beautiful minute, we tasted and knew each other in ways never known to us before. Passion and love, pure love, flowed between us. So much so, a few tears leaked out of my eyes and trickled down my cheeks. They were the happiest and saddest of tears. How had we missed out on this for so long?

"Monroe," Fitz whispered ever so intimately. "Why are you crying? Did I do something wrong?"

I shook my head. “No. This feels like the most right thing I’ve ever done.” I knew it with my soul.

Fitz flashed me one of his rare wide smiles.

“I know someone is out here,” the unknown man’s voice called again, interrupting the best moment of my life.

“Let’s get out of here.” Fitz grabbed my hand and ushered us around the stable, housing several neighing horses, to a back gate that led to the forested area of the property. The rusty gate screeched loudly, assaulting our ears, as we hurriedly dashed toward the safety of the dense trees. I could feel the adrenaline course through my body as we sought refuge in the forest. Though I was afraid to get caught, I’d never been happier or more excited in my life. Lady Catherine could kick me out if she wanted to—I had zero plans to miss out on this romantic rendezvous. Although, the thought of sneaking around all week with Fitz sounded dang sexy. Of course, we needed to talk about what this meant for us, but all I wanted to do for now was kiss Fitz to my heart’s content.

When we felt like we were safe, we slowed to a moderate walking pace, breathing hard and even laughing, our hands clasped and swinging between us. I’d never seen Fitz so carefree.

“Fitz,” I said breathlessly.

“Yes.” He raised our clasped hands and kissed mine. It was so romantic.

“How? When? Why? Where?” I giggled, needing to know everything.

Fitz halted near a tall Scots pine tree, his face radiating adoration. “How could I not fall for you, beautiful friend? You, who knows me better than anyone, even myself. You, who have looked past my title and money and seen only me, never wanting a thing other than the pleasure of my company. Who wouldn’t want a woman like you?”

Oh. He. Was. Good. Like, really, really good. “How long have you felt like this?”

He pulled me to him. “How long have we known each other?”

Whoa. “That’s a long time. Why didn’t you say anything? I had the biggest crush on you in school, but I hid those feelings because I didn’t think you would ever reciprocate them.” My fingers danced across his lips, waiting for his response and aching for another kiss.

Fitz captured both my hands, our fingers intertwining naturally. He held our clasped hands to my sides, steadying me before skimming my lips with his own.

“You’re really good at that.”

“I know,” he whispered against my lips.

I tittered like a schoolgirl, so enamored with him and this moment. “You didn’t answer my question.”

He swallowed hard. “Monroe, we come from different worlds. I didn’t want to thrust mine on you. I know how cruel and unforgiving it can be. And you . . .” He cleared his throat.

“I’m not duchess material,” I stated flatly, voicing the thing he didn’t wish to say, the thing that his kiss had made me forget.

“Not at all.” He let out a heavy, disappointed breath.

“Not at all?” I questioned. That was harsh. I mean, yes, it was true, but he could have softened it a little. The man had, after all, just administered the kiss of all kisses—he’d basically ruined the prospect of all future kisses from anyone but him. Plus, I’d made him watch *Mary Poppins* at least ten times. He was aware that a little bit of sugar made the medicine go down.

“Yes, Monroe.” He seemed as if it pained him to say it, but he continued anyway. “You’re . . . unconventional.”

“What does that mean?” I leaned away from him.

“Like today at the airport. You came waltzing out wearing three bonnets with dresses wrapped around your shoulders.”

“What else was I supposed to do? I gave away my carry-on to help someone.”

He sighed. “You didn’t have to give away your carry-on. That’s what I mean about unconventional.”

“Oh.” I pulled away from him. “I see. I embarrass you.”

“No.” He reached for me, but I backed farther away. “I just want to protect you from the vultures who have already started circling around.”

“You mean Lady Winnifred and Lady Catherine?”

“Well, yes, but there are others.”

“Your mother?”

“Monroe, the *Daily Mail* posted a picture of you at the airport. It was unflattering, to say the least.”

“Oh.” My heart sank, dropping down to my toes. The entire world could see that *unflattering* picture if they wished to.

“We can smooth it over. You’ll just need to be more careful in the future when we’re out in public. We can do this together and create the right image for us.”

Did he just say *the right image for us*? “You want me to change who I am?”

“Of course not. I adore who you are. All I’m saying is, if we want to make this work—and I do more than anything—we just need to make some adjustments.”

“Adjustments? Like what?” I was both curious and honestly a tad furious that he was being so cavalier with my feelings.

“For starters, you just need to be more discreet in public and not draw so much attention to yourself.”

I felt like Lady Catherine’s instructions were coming right out of his mouth and he was giving me an etiquette lesson.

Fitz paced back and forth. “We definitely need to buy you a new wardrobe. And it would serve us well if you didn’t dash to everyone’s rescue.”

He might as well have stabbed me in the heart. In fact, my heart stung so badly, I reached up and rubbed it as I stared in disbelief at the person I loved and admired most in the world basically telling me I wasn’t good enough for him. As he kept listing all the adjustments I needed to make, from thinking before I acted to no more pajama pants while grocery shopping, all I could see and hear was Mr. Darcy telling Elizabeth Bennet, *“In vain I have struggled. It will not do. My feelings will not be repressed. You must allow me to tell you how ardently I admire and love you.”* And then proceeding to detail her inferiority in every way, and why he basically loved her against his will.

“You *talk Darcy* better than anyone I know,” I stammered, doing my best to keep my feelings in check. Fitz was obviously just as proud and arrogant as Mr. Darcy.

Fitz stopped pacing and paused his list of all the things I needed to change about myself. He looked surprised at my emotion. “What do you mean?”

“I mean, you obviously think having a romantic relationship with me goes against your better judgement and is below you. Clearly, any connection with me outside of friendship is reprehensible.”

“Bloody hell. You’re taking this all wrong.” He rushed my way.

I held my hand up, telling him to keep his distance. “I don’t think so.”

He halted in his tracks, mere inches from me. “Can’t you see that I’m just trying to protect you?”

“Funny. It sounds like you’re trying to protect yourself and your image,” my voice hitched.

“That’s not true.”

“It is. If not, you would have acted on your *supposed* feelings years ago.” Fitz not coming to my wedding was all making sense now. He had feelings for me, but he didn’t want to act on them because even he couldn’t see me as an Elizabeth. “Well, guess what?” I raised my voice, feeling crushed. Absolutely crushed. “I never wanted to be a duchess or live in your noble world. And I don’t want to be with someone who I embarrass and can’t be myself around. As far as I’m concerned, you and the Lady Winnifreds and Catherines of the world can go to h-e-l-l.” I don’t know why I spelled it out instead of just saying it. But I’d never really told anyone off, much less my best friend.

“Monroe.” Fitz grabbed my hand. “It was never my intention to hurt you.”

I yanked my hand away, tears streaming down my cheeks, feeling as if I’d just lost my best friend—probably because I had. “Wow. If that wasn’t your intention, I can’t imagine how awful it would have been if you really had been trying. Good night, Fitz.” I turned and sprinted through the forest. Thankfully, the jerk didn’t follow me. Racking sobs erupted from my chest, making it hard to breathe. I should never have agreed to meet him. I don’t care what Mr. Bennet said. A girl does *not* like to be crossed in love now and then, especially by her best friend.

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# ELEVEN

***"Pride relates more to our opinion of ourselves, vanity to what we would have others think of us."***

## FITZ

I STARED OUT THE WINDOW at the well-manicured grounds in the early light, seeing my behavior more clearly than I had the night before, even though I was exhausted. I hadn't slept a wink. Visions of a hurt and angry Monroe had tormented me all night. After our first kiss that had set my world aflame, I had consumed myself with the thought of making us work. In her eyes last night, I saw my future—days and nights filled with love and laughter and children. I knew she'd felt it too, so I'd assumed she and I were on the same page about what needed to happen. I couldn't have been more wrong.

Not only had she berated me in the forest, but when I realized the magnitude of what had happened, I'd chased after her, only to have her call me an arse and to tell me to sod off. For a split second she'd grinned at using what some deem to be vulgar language here in the UK, but she bounced back to hating me in no time at all. So much so, she told me she wouldn't have to pretend to despise me when we rehearsed the Meryton ball reenactment later this afternoon. Worse, she said I'd ruined our friendship and there was no going back now. Then she threw the letter I'd written in my face. "*You can keep your pretty words,*" she'd cried. Those written words were the most honest I'd ever been in my life.

To say I felt gutted was a vast understatement. Her tears and the way she'd trembled from pain tormented me, especially since she wouldn't allow me to comfort her. I thought she knew me well enough to understand I only wanted to protect her. But perhaps she was right—I'd been looking to protect my own image as much as hers. And I concede that I probably

didn’t choose the right words. I’d just wanted her to see the extent of how some of her *quirky* behaviors might hurt her in the press. If ever she read the article in the *Daily Mail*, it would mortify her. I didn’t want that. But instead, I’d hurt and mortified the woman I loved myself, and probably ruined any future happiness we could have had together. Bloody hell, what a mess I’d made of all of it.

I had to fix it—I needed to talk to Monroe. Without a second thought, I put on my coat with tails and strode out of my room, intent on setting off for the Longbourn house. Unfortunately, I ran into a roadblock in the form of Winnifred, dressed in a pale-peach silk dress and wearing an evil grin.

“Alastair, did you see?” she asked gravely, while elegantly prancing my way.

“See what?” I asked, annoyed, knowing exactly what she was referring to.

“Well,” she tried to seem concerned, but her body language revealed ulterior motives in every part. “I know this might come as a shock to you, but I fear you must know. There was a nasty article about Monroe in the *Daily Mail*.” There was no hiding the delight in her eyes.

“I am aware. And you are correct, it was nasty, and I found it utterly distasteful.” Why hadn’t I said this to Monroe last night instead of telling her she was unconventional? I was a complete knobhead.

“You have to admit, she did look ridiculous,” Winnifred changed tactics.

“I don’t have to admit a thing.”

Growing desperate, she said, “Your mother is quite upset and fears what this will do to your family name and your social standing. As do I.”

“I don’t believe it’s anything you need worry yourself about.” I brushed past her.

“Alastair,” she cried, her voice echoing down the cavernous corridor. “You can’t actually be serious about her.”

I spun on my heel to face her so there would be no doubt about my feelings for Monroe. “I’m more serious about her than I’ve ever been about anything in my life. If that hurts you, I apologize. It was never my intention to give you false hope.”

She stood tall and proud. “Whatever gave you the impression that I want you?” She sniffled, her voice hitching, before turning and escaping in a less-than-elegant manner.

Perfect. How many women would I make cry during this forsaken holiday?

Before I ran into another person, I jetted off down the hall and the back stairs, hoping to avoid everyone. The nearer to the kitchen I got, the more the mansion smelled of fresh-baked bread, honey cakes, and strong tea. Though I was hungry, I couldn't think of eating until I fixed things with Monroe.

I headed out into the cool but mild September morning. Though the sun was peeking through the clouds, the air was damp, and a thin layer of dew rested on the lawns and paths. I took the path that led to Monroe, the path I should have figuratively taken last night. But now I wasn't sure how to traverse that route. I wanted nothing more than to be with Monroe, but it seemed more complicated than ever.

Before I reached Longbourn, Mr. and Mrs. Bennet, followed by each daughter, walked out of the house, dressed in their riding habits. Monroe trailed right behind her *parents*, glued to the woman playing Jane. Monroe looked lovely in her honey-colored habit, a cream chemisette with frilled collar peeking out. She looked every bit the part of her idol, Elizabeth.

Jane was the first to see me. She turned while whispering animatedly to Monroe.

Monroe's red and puffy eyes lasered in on me. A deep sadness emanated from her and punched me in the gut. I'd seen her cry plenty of times, but I'd never been the reason for her tears until now, and it killed me. The scathing looks from Mr. and Mrs. Bennet didn't help either. They circled around Monroe, shielding her from me.

As noble as that was, it wouldn't prevent me from approaching Monroe. I was not one to be easily intimidated. Not to say I didn't have some reservations, but that was only because I had no idea what I should do. I had mucked things up, and I wasn't accustomed to that.

"Good morning," I said to the group.

Each person in the company sneered at me. Apparently the entire Bennet household knew of last night's disaster and thought ill of me. Not that I blamed them. I supposed it was apropos, considering the *Pride and Prejudice* storyline. In the story, Mr. Darcy does eventually win the family over in the end, though that may have had more to do with his wealth than his merit. I didn't think my vast estate or large bank account would help me in this situation.

“Monroe, may I speak to you, please?” I begged like I never had. To be honest, I’m not completely sure I had ever begged for anything before.

Tears filled her eyes as she shook her head *no*.

I made to ask again, desperate to speak to her, but Mr. Bennet cut in before I could say a word. “Why don’t you all go ahead. I’d like to talk to Mr. Darcy,” he said like a protective father, in a such a terrible British accent it hurt my ears. They should have given lessons on how to speak my mother tongue properly instead of wasting time discussing how women used to wax, just like they do now. What a useless piece of information that was.

Mrs. Bennet and Jane ushered Monroe out of my reach as if they were protecting her from a predator. The other three sisters followed. The woman playing Lydia said in her cockney accent as she walked by me, “His lot always finks they are better than everyone else, don’t they?”

Kitty gave me a good once-over. “That they do, but this ’un sure is pretty.”

I didn’t think I was better than Monroe—perhaps more refined and more familiar in navigating social situations, but it was the world I’d grown up in. I didn’t hold it against her—I just knew the expectations the peerage would place on her if she were to become the Duchess of Blackthorne. If she didn’t change some habits, they would eat her alive, which was the last thing I wanted.

Mr. Bennet clapped me hard on the back, making me wince. “You sure stepped in it last night, buddy. Been there with the Mrs. more times than I can count.”

No need to ask what I’d stepped in. I caught the gist of it, and he wasn’t wrong. I hated the public airing of dirty laundry, but I needed to know what Monroe had said to him. It might help me make amends. “Is Monroe all right? What did she say?”

“Let’s walk and talk. I’m hungry.”

We traversed the path, walking slowly as Mr. Bennet shook his head at me. “*Unconventional.*” He whistled low. “That was a poor word choice.”

“It was better than *laughable* or *ridiculous*, like the article called her,” I defended myself.

“She read the article,” he informed me.

I cringed, knowing how it must have hurt her. “And?”

“What do you think? It crushed her, as did you.” He didn’t mince words.

“That wasn’t my intention.”

“I’ve found that kindness is always more important than intention,” he schooled me.

A sense of shame filled me, but my pride forced me to refute him. “I was trying to be kind by protecting her from further incidents.”

Mr. Bennet shrugged, not buying my excuse. “I don’t think you’ll have to worry about future incidents.”

Dread washed over me. “What are you saying?”

“I’m saying there are some things you can’t come back from. This might be one of those times.” He then moved on, leaving me more unsettled than I’d ever been.

His ominous warning weighed heavily on my chest. I didn’t want to imagine my world without Monroe in it. It would be, at the very least, bleak.

My heart begged to know: Was there no hope for Monroe and me?

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# TWELVE

***"I could easily forgive his pride, if he had not mortified mine."***

## MONROE

WHISPERS AND SIDE-EYED GLANCES accompanied me when I entered the dining hall. No doubt several, if not all of them, had seen the article. Winnifred had probably distributed copies. Strangely, though, she didn't seem elated. In fact, she looked kind of miserable, slumped in her chair near Lady Catherine at the end of the table, sipping her tea. I wondered what had her so down.

My ex-fiancé looked more than happy, speaking quietly with Charlotte and obviously flirting with her. It validated my sneaking suspicion that he hadn't come here for me. So why was he here? Unless, maybe, he wanted to humiliate me too. He could take a number.

Lady Catherine zeroed in on me and curled her thin lips. Determined now, more than ever, to be the very best Elizabeth I could be, I smiled at her, though I wanted to go back to my room and bawl my head off. But my head hurt from crying all night, and I had something to prove to myself. Admittedly, I also really loved the riding habit, and even though I felt as if my world had shattered, it seemed a waste not to show it off.

I was an embarrassment to the person I loved most, and now the entire world knew it. The expression on Fitz's face in that awful tabloid photo said it all—my behavior horrified him and made him uncomfortable, and his words had confirmed it last night. I was apparently laughable. Granted, I did look ridiculous in the article's photo, but why should anyone care how many bonnets I choose to wear? Why did I suddenly care? My dad always told me not to try to fit in where I didn't belong, because the opposite of belonging was trying to fit in, and I'd lived by that principle. But I thought I'd belonged with Fitz, at least as his friend. I'd been wrong. So, so wrong.

And now I worried that all these people were right about me. Was I one of the silly girls in *Pride and Prejudice*?

I vowed to channel Elizabeth this week, despite my heart breaking from losing my best friend, my person. Sadly, I recognized I had never before experienced such a proper, all-encompassing kiss, and would now never experience one again. Why did he have to kiss me and show me what I'd been missing out on?

As daintily as I could, I took my seat, even though I wanted to crawl out of my skin. The whisperings and glances weren't going anywhere.

Jane squeezed my hand under the table to lend me some support. She and Mr. and Mrs. Bennet had been amazing last night, just letting me sob and speak incoherently about how blindsided I felt. This was supposed to be a dream trip, but it was turning into a nightmare. Maybe I really was on *Fantasy Island*, except everyone on *Fantasy Island* got a happy ending and I couldn't see how that would be possible in my case. The only thing I had going for me was pretending to be an amazing Elizabeth. I'll tell you this: I couldn't wait to reject Mr. Darcy when he proposed. And I didn't care how nice Pemberley was. He could keep it. I'd actually been to Fitz's estate plenty of times, and it was the loveliest place on earth. Even though his mother hated me and tried to make me feel unwelcome, Fitz always made me feel as if I'd come home. Ugh. I couldn't think about it—it all felt like a lie now.

The liar—and best kisser in the galaxy—snuck in unbeknownst to me and stole the empty chair next to me. I smelled his expensive cologne with hints of bergamot and vanilla before he said a word. The stares and whispers intensified, especially among the staff.

"Monroe," Fitz whispered in my ear while taking my hand, clasping it between his own. "Please let me make amends," he pleaded. "Tell me how to fix us."

Oh, how I wished he could fix us, but I didn't think it was possible. How could we go back to what we were when it all felt like a lie now? And he didn't want to fix us. He wanted to fix me. Wasn't that the gist of last night's revelation? Fix me so I fit into his world.

I willed myself not to feel our connection as I turned toward him and ripped my hand out of his. "You need to leave. You're drawing attention to me, and I know how much you abhor that. I would hate to embarrass you

even more than I already have." My voice crackled with the emotion I was doing my best to keep under control.

His beautiful face went ashen.

"Mr. Darcy," Lady Catherine called. "As my honored guest and nephew, I must insist you sit next to me. I must have my share of the conversation."

*Yes, please go,* I silently begged him. I couldn't have him sitting this close and looking as if he'd just lost his world too. It was confusing to me.

"I wish to remain near Elizabeth," Fitz responded resolutely to her, and stayed seated by my side.

A hush went over the crowd.

I might have found his declaration romantic had I not known how he really felt about me. I could distinctly hear the list of all the things he wanted me to change about myself.

Lady Catherine rose in a menacing stance, red in the face for being put in her place. No one put people in their place better than Fitz. I had firsthand knowledge now, and let me tell you, it was beyond brutal.

"Now that we are all here, let us go over our schedule for the day," Lady Catherine spoke in her most regal tones. "But before we begin, a most alarming report has come to my attention this morning. One of the watchmen told me that he heard a romantic pursuit last night near the stables."

Half the table snickered. That sounded much more salacious than Lady Catherine probably meant. Even I had a hard time keeping a straight face.

"This we can't have. It besmirches all that Jane Austen stood for." Lady Catherine shook with fury. "I must remind you that we will not tolerate sneaking out at night. Well-bred, single ladies and gentlemen must never be alone with each other. Remember, you promised to abide by the rules and immerse yourself in the *Pride and Prejudice* experience." Her dark eyes scanned the table, scrutinizing everyone, but of course they eventually landed on me.

Believe me, I had had a very real *Pride and Prejudice* experience last night. Like I said, Fitz *spoke Darcy* incredibly well. If ever I felt like Elizabeth Bennet, it had been last night. If only I had thought to quote her eloquently by telling him, *"I might as well inquire why, with so evident a design of offending and insulting me, you chose to tell me that you liked me against your will, against your reason, and even against your character?"* I

supposed I would get my chance to use that line on day five when we acted out Darcy's first proposal scene.

Doing my best Elizabeth impression, I didn't act rattled by Lady Catherine's scrutinizing gaze. Instead, I kept my head held high, even though I'd never felt more like a loser in my life. Rationally, I knew I shouldn't let other people's opinions of me shape how I felt about myself, but I had never experienced humiliation on an international level before. And to know my best friend agreed with the criticism made me feel the sting of it all more keenly.

Lady Catherine thankfully shifted her gaze and moved on. "Now, let's go over our schedule for today. After breakfast, we will meet at the stables for a quick course on outdoor etiquette, and then we will immediately progress to riding lessons. Once riding lessons are over, we will return for tea and a light luncheon, followed by rehearsals for key scenes. I hope you each have memorized your lines. It is imperative that you do this to make sure all our guests have the best possible *Pride and Prejudice* experience. Do not let me or Jane Austen down," she cautioned.

Why did I feel like I was destined to let them down, despite having memorized my lines and watching all the versions of *Pride and Prejudice* available dozens of times, hoping to capture the essence of Elizabeth.

Lady Catherine continued her meticulous review of the day's schedule, which I think most of us—at least the women—had memorized. I knew that those of us staying in Longbourn were excited to start finally acting out the scenes we had adored for most of our lives. Even Lydia and Kitty admitted to being enamored with the world of Jane Austen. I had a feeling they weren't as brash as they had initially appeared to be. Meanwhile, the men looked longingly at the honey and plum cakes waiting to be devoured on the table. Well, all save Fitz, who was staring longingly at me every time I glanced his way. It was both unnerving and confusing.

I begged myself to let my courage rise when people intimidated me. Not to say that Fitz was trying to intimidate me—to be honest, I wasn't sure what he was trying to do, but his eyes refused to leave me. I could feel them on me.

"I think that is all. Tuck in," Lady Catherine instructed.

"I don't think I can eat." Jane held her stomach. The poor thing was so nervous about the riding lessons.

“It will be fun,” I tried to assure her, while not being entirely convinced myself. I loved to ride, but riding sidesaddle in a long dress would probably be difficult.

“Uh-huh,” she said like she was Mariah Carey hitting all those unattainable high notes.

Fitz refused to be ignored any longer. “Monroe, that article was undeniably unfair, and I categorically disagree with it. I apologize sincerely for putting you in this position. I’ll see if Kingston can have the article removed.”

With a deliberate slowness, I turned to glare at him. “If only he could make me unsee the look of disdain on your face directed toward me in the photo.”

Fitz’s face fell. “You read it wrong.”

“I wish I had, but your expression in the photo and your words last night said it all. I embarrass you.”

He tried to disagree, but I wouldn’t let him.

“The thing is,” my voice wavered, “the article wouldn’t have bothered me so much if I’d had my person—you—in my corner.” I was beginning to realize that I’d never really cared what people thought of me because those who mattered most thought the world of me—why should I care what people who didn’t know me thought?

“Monroe.” Fitz took my hand. “I’m always in your corner.”

“Apparently you’ve been standing there judging me as much as the people who took that photo.”

Fitz’s wide eyes said he was horror-struck at the thought, but he didn’t disagree.

“What’s worse is to know you hid your supposed feelings from me all this time because you didn’t believe in me. I can’t be with someone who doesn’t believe in me.” As friends or as lovers.

“Nor should you. I would never want that for you,” Fitz spoke calmly, but he appeared rattled as he stood and walked away.

I watched him go and take my broken heart with him. It was then I realized I’d given him my heart long ago. How had I missed that?

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# THIRTEEN

***"I have been a selfish being all my life, in practice, though not in principle."***

## FITZ

"REGENCY SOCIETY EXPECTED WOMEN TO ride daintily and gracefully," Lady Catherine pompously orated from underneath an umbrella that some poor staff member held over her. She stood on a small platform in the field next to the stables, where several footmen dressed in period attire stood waiting near well-groomed and expensive horses. They weren't as fine or as expensive as mine, but they still impressed me. Lady Catherine, of course, would not be riding any of them, as she'd already declared that it would be improper for her to do so, considering her station. Bollocks, in my opinion. My bet was she couldn't ride sidesaddle.

"I expect no less from you. There will be no riding the horses astride or showing off ankles or calves."

"Yeah, that'd be a real shame for someone to see these sexy ankles," Lydia snickered, trying her best to drop her cockney accent, while lifting her habit, revealing thick ankles. "All the boys would come running."

Monroe stifled a giggle next to me. She had begrudgingly remained by my side, as I was determined not to let her push me away, even if I deserved it. When we'd arrived at the stables, I'd followed her wherever she stood, and she had finally given up, at least for now.

Her words during breakfast pricked me and had given me a great deal to contemplate. Had I intentionally kept myself from her for ignoble reasons? Was I as proud as, or even more proud than, the character I was playing? I admit to being a cold, uncaring bastard most of the time, but I'd never believed I behaved that way toward Monroe. If anything, she brought out a side in me I had never known. Yet I wasn't sure I had ever let myself lean

into that side of me. Had I allowed my pride and vanity to keep us apart? The thought vexed me. I loved Monroe, but I was beginning to wonder if I'd failed to believe in her the way I should.

"I'm sure many of you think that riding sidesaddle is uncomfortable, but . . . ," Lady Catherine barreled on.

We'd already been outside for a good half hour listening to her pontificate on outdoor etiquette, the importance of women wearing gloves and bonnets, how a gentleman should be a good listener, and how he should never touch a lady's bare skin, not even on her hand.

I wished I'd touched more of Monroe's skin last night, and kept my mouth on hers instead of putting a proverbial foot in mine. I worried Mr. Bennet was right. There were some things you just couldn't come back from. The thought sickened me. Is this how Mr. Darcy felt after his first proposal to Elizabeth? Did he feel as if all hope was lost? If only Monroe had a sister I could save from Mr. Wickham—something that would allow me to get back in her good graces. Along those lines, I wondered if I should warn the woman playing Charlotte to stay away from Tony. I noticed she'd glued herself to his side. Tony seemed to enjoy the attention and made sure to flaunt it in front of Monroe. I planned on putting an end to his game as soon as I found out which one he was playing.

"The fact of the matter is," Lady Catherine continued, "riding sidesaddle is quite comfortable, and you can be just as in control as you would be riding astride."

"Then why don't the men do it?" Kitty grumbled in front of us. It was a fair question.

"We will have Mrs. Gardiner demonstrate, with the help of a footman and mounting block, how to properly mount a horse and how easy riding sidesaddle is." I believed Mrs. Gardiner was a paid staff member.

Monroe strung her arm through Jane's as they watched Mrs. Gardiner mount the horse, maintaining the dignity Lady Catherine demanded. It was obvious Jane was uneasy about the prospect of riding a horse. Of course, Monroe did her best to comfort her. But the man playing Bingley seemed to be irritated she wouldn't just refuse to do it. I was with him. If Jane was that uncomfortable, she should stand up to Lady Catherine. After all, we were the guests here. Lady Catherine, however, treated most everyone like her subjects.

“You’ve got this,” Monroe assured Jane. “I promise not to help you. We all know how embarrassing that could get.” She laughed, but I could hear the ache in her voice from suppressing that part of her character.

What had I done? It was never my intention for Monroe to lose herself because of me or to make her think she was an embarrassment. All I wanted for us was to be together and for her to be respected.

I took Monroe’s hand, hoping the right words would come to me, but she was quick to pull away from me.

“I’m going to get a closer look. Excuse me,” she said to Lydia and Kitty as she brushed past them, closer to the field, away from me.

Tony took the opportunity to sidle up to me. “I see all’s not well in paradise. That article . . .” He whistled low.

I clenched my fists, wanting to beat him to a bloody pulp. Even more, I loathed myself for never telling Monroe what a prick I thought he was because I couldn’t or wouldn’t admit how I felt about her. As calmly as I could, I turned toward him. “Did you ever love her?”

“I still do, but uh . . . you know she can be a lot, and it’s not like her career was really going places.”

“You broke up with her over how much money she makes?” I seethed.

He tugged on his collar. “It’s complicated.”

“You make me sick.”

“From the looks of your face in that photo, Monroe makes *you* sick.” He stormed off.

His words left me feeling sucker punched. Monroe didn’t make me sick. I was only sick for worrying what others would think of her at the airport. I had to make Monroe believe that.

“Everyone, choose a horse,” Lady Catherine called. “Immerse yourself in the experience. Become your character.”

“Become my character. Become my character,” Jane chanted, her voice shaking.

*To hell with my character,* I thought. I wouldn’t wait around for months for some stroke of luck to put me back in Monroe’s good graces. The thought of waiting even seconds seemed torturous. I pushed my way through the other guests to find Monroe near the chestnut Haflinger. It was a smaller breed of horse, perfect for dressage. People know them for their kindness and intelligence. It was a perfect choice for Monroe. I knew of no

one as kind as she was, and she possessed an innate intelligence often overlooked by others—including me.

A footman stood ready to assist Monroe, but I stepped forward. “Please allow me.”

The footman immediately retreated.

Monroe wrinkled her nose at me. “I don’t need your help.”

“Regardless, I want to help you.”

“Are you saying you think I need help?”

I let out an exasperated sigh. “That’s not what I’m saying.” I bent down and held the stirrup steady for her.

“I don’t even know why you want to be seen with me.” She stepped up on the mounting block and slipped her delicate foot, silhouetted in brown leather boots, into the stirrup.

I did the ungentlemanly thing and ran my hand up her skirt, letting my fingers skim her toned calf.

Her breath hitched. “What are you doing?”

“What do you think I’m doing?” My fingers danced down her silky skin, where goose bumps appeared.

“Um . . . ,” she stuttered. “That’s not very proper or duke-like.”

“I’ve never shown you my *duke* side, but I’d like to.”

“Don’t even try to be sexy with me. We both know that I’m not in your league,” she snapped while perfectly mounting her horse, making sure to keep her right leg resting against the horse’s left shoulder.

Did I ever want to be sexy with her. Instead, I did the gentlemanly thing and adjusted her skirt to make sure it covered her legs, but I refused to let her go. “Monroe, after everything we’ve been through, are you really willing to let our relationship go?” I pleaded to know.

Her eyes welled with tears. “I don’t even know now if what we had was real.” She snapped the reins and trotted away from me.

How could she think that? Of course it was real. It had been the most real thing in my life. I headed for the nearest unoccupied horse, a great black beast. Without a second thought, I mounted the animal and chased after Monroe, who had headed toward the lake. I passed Jane and noted her gripping tightly to the reins of her horse, trying to coax it to move. She kept saying things like, “Nice horse, nice horse.”

It was probably for the best, I told myself as I cantered toward Monroe.

Monroe sat tall and dignified in the saddle, obviously trying to prove to herself she was worthy of the role she was playing, even though Elizabeth, according to the book, was not a horsewoman. More and more I began to fear what life as a duchess would do to Monroe—the stiffness of her expression wasn't her. I wanted her smiles and irreverent laughter. I wanted her.

Monroe noticed me approaching and diverted her horse around the tranquil lake with a smattering of lily pads and leaves from the nearby trees that would soon change as autumn approached. Normally, Monroe would have squealed with delight over the lily pads—she thought they were the cutest. What I would give for that now.

I took Monroe's side, my horse keeping pace with hers, and though I could tell the beast wished to dart across the field, I held him steady. "Monroe, we need to talk. I'm not letting you go without a fight."

"I don't understand why."

"Because I lo—"

A cry of terror permeated the air. It was Jane. Her horse was galloping across the field, with her barely hanging on.

Monroe made to follow her, but she hesitated with a second thought. Deep anguish filled her beautiful features. "I don't want to be an embarrassment or make it worse. But . . . my mom," she cried, conflicted. "I have to help." She snapped the horse's reins and flew after Jane.

Chuffing hell, this had the makings of a disaster. Where was that Bingley chap? Or a member of the staff? I raced after Monroe, hoping to beat her to Jane.

"I'm coming, Jane!" Monroe shouted, her bonnet flying off her head. "Hold on, it will be okay."

I watched in horror as Monroe tried to swing her right leg to the right side mid-gallop so she could ride astride like she was Annie Oakley. For a moment, it appeared she knew exactly what she was doing as she rushed to Jane's aid. I wasn't sure what she planned to do once she reached Jane, but it didn't matter. My world stopped when Monroe's horse reared up with no warning, and before Monroe had a good foothold, it tossed her violently to the ground.

I pulled up on my horse's reins. But before the beast halted, I jumped off and ran to Monroe crumpled on the ground, not moving. I couldn't get

to her fast enough. “Please help!” I shouted, not knowing what I would find when I reached her.

“Monroe.” I threw myself next to her on the damp ground. Her dark hair had fallen out of the hairpins and spilled all around her. Gently, I brushed her hair away from her face, careful not to move her and fearing the worst. Her eyes flitted open for an almost imperceptible second.

“Fitz,” she moaned before her eyes fell closed again.

I took her hand. “Monroe, hold on. Please,” I said frantically, begging her. “I love you,” I said the words I’d been holding back for years, hating myself for all the wasted time. Time? It’s all I wanted now—more time with Monroe.

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# VOLUME TWO

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# FOURTEEN

***"We do not suffer by accident."***

## MONROE

OH, MY HEAD HURT ALMOST as much as my pride. Why couldn't I ever help anyone without making a spectacle of myself? I was so embarrassed, I didn't want to open my eyes. "Oops! . . . I Did It Again" could be my theme song. Unfortunately, I knew I couldn't keep my eyes closed forever. Fitz sounded alarmed and kept saying strange things to me. I should probably see what that was all about, except I didn't feel like I could face Fitz, knowing this would just add one more item on his list of things I needed to change about myself. The new bullet point would read: *Don't act like Calamity Jane in a Buffalo Bill's Wild West show.* I really thought my leg was going to make it around. Honestly, I'd quite impressed myself, until . . . well, the horse reared up, and I found myself lying on the damp, musty ground.

"Madam, madam. Are you all right?" Fitz asked.

Why was he calling me *madam*? I guess he was trying to stay in character?

Now, however, would probably be a good time for him to call me Monroe, considering my entire body might be broken, or at least my head, considering how hard it pounded. And I was pretty sure I'd heard him say he loved me—unless I had a traumatic brain injury and I just imagined that.

"Darcy, shall I call for help? Have a servant fetch the apothecary, Mr. Jones, or perhaps her father?" Zane asked in his best Charles Bingley voice. "That is Longbourn there, and I believe she is one of the Bennet sisters I have heard so much about. I think she must be one of the older two sisters. She is very pretty." Wow, Zane was really leaning into his part. Again, maybe not the best time. Based on my headache, I was pretty sure I needed a doctor and not an apothecary. And who was Mr. Jones? I mean, I knew he

was the apothecary in *Pride and Prejudice* who treated Jane, but I didn't remember him being part of the cast at Pride and Prejudice Park. Had Lady Catherine forgotten to introduce him? And I wasn't sure how calling for Mr. Bennet would help. I thought he'd said he was an architect, but maybe he knew first aid.

I waited for Fitz to reply, something to the tune of, *"She's not merely pretty—she's the most beautiful woman of my acquaintance, and you'd better damn well call 999 for an ambulance."* The number 999 was like 911 in the States. But surprisingly, Fitz said none of those things. Instead, I felt strong arms around me, lifting me up.

"Are you sure you should touch her?" Zane sounded alarmed. "No one has properly introduced you. What a scandal this could be."

Okay, he was taking this way too far. Shouldn't he be saving Macey? Although I had to admit, his perfect elocution impressed me. He hadn't even used one contraction. Jane Austen would be so proud, as she used them only sparingly in her writings.

"We cannot just let her lie here," Fitz responded.

I supposed I should probably open my eyes now, considering I was in Fitz's arms. He wasn't holding me very tightly, though, almost as if he were afraid to hold me too close. Was Lady Catherine staring him down for touching me? But Fitz wouldn't care what she thought. Or did he now?

I steeled myself, ready to see the disappointment from my latest blunder in Fitz's eyes, even though all I wanted was to curl into him and have him make it all better, like he always did. Sadly, I wasn't sure there was a way to make things better this time around. I wasn't talking about my aching head and body—hopefully a little rest, some ice, and ibuprofen could fix those things. But that still left me with a devastated heart.

Bravely, I opened my eyes. "Fitz," I moaned, wishing his coat didn't feel so scratchy against my cheek. And I found it odd that he smelled like rose water now, when earlier he smelled like bergamot and vanilla. Maybe I did have a brain injury and it affected my olfactory sense. Yikes.

"Pardon me, madam, to whom are you referring?"

I lifted my pounding head off Fitz's chest to flash him an annoyed look. This was taking things too far. "Fitz, stop messing around. I don't feel well."

Fitz stared at me. His gray broody eyes were unsettled and even confused. If I didn't know better, I would say that he didn't recognize me.

Oh my gosh. Was my face disfigured? “Fitz, what’s wrong with my face?” I pleaded for an explanation.

His eyes went from confused to . . . irate. Why was he angry? Was it because I’d messed up my face and now we wouldn’t be able to project the perfect image?

“Madam, I am not used to being addressed so informally. I am Mr. Fitzwilliam Darcy.”

I couldn’t help but snort laugh. “Ha ha. Right. And I’m really Elizabeth Bennet.”

“So you are, Elizabeth Bennet,” Zane said brightly. “Your father came to call on me at Netherfield Park a fortnight ago.”

“I don’t remember that line being in the script,” I said, more than confused.

“Script? My dear lady, I feel the fall from your horse has addled your brain,” Zane replied, apparently unwilling to drop the Bingley act. I didn’t know what had gotten into him, but hopefully it meant he was stepping it up for Macey.

Anyway, I had my own man to worry about. I reached up and brushed my fingers across Fitz’s smooth cheeks that I swore had been perfectly stubbly just moments ago, before I decided to do the impossible—actually help someone.

Fitz startled and held me away from his body. “Madam, I must ask you to refrain from touching me with your ungloved hand.”

First, where had my gloves gone, and second, what the heck? “Okay, Fitz, this is ridiculous. You just said that you loved me—at least I thought you did. I think we’re a little beyond worrying about ungloved hands. You thoroughly kissed me last night, and just a few minutes ago, you were being all sexy with me, telling me I haven’t seen your *duke side* yet, which admittedly, I really want to see, even though I think you’re a jerk.”

“How dare you accuse me of kissing you and sharing words of love. And to speak of basket weaving in front of me is unconscionable.” Fitz sounded appalled.

I couldn’t help but giggle, even though it hurt that Fitz wouldn’t acknowledge the kiss or his confession of love. He’d once told me that in the Regency era, they would use euphemisms like *basket weaving* instead of saying *sex*. To sound so disgusted by me saying *sexy* was downright silly,

considering I'd known him since we were sixteen and I'd heard him say some vulgar things himself over the years.

"Darcy, be kind to her. She is obviously injured and does not know what she is saying. She is even speaking with a strange accent," Zane admonished him.

Strange accent? And I darn well knew what I was saying. I didn't care if I was saying it in a French accent. I went to say so, but as I looked around, I realized that everything looked different. Instead of neatly manicured grounds, tall grass and harvested fields surrounded us, and the lake had shrunk to the size of a duck pond. There wasn't even a lily pad in sight. The forested area seemed smaller too. Stranger than that was all the houses save one—Longbourn—were gone. There, the Georgian-style house stood alone, with its brick facade and the ivy creeping up the sides of the house. It looked like I'd left it this morning, except for some chickens running around loose and the sound of mooing in the background. Where had the livestock come from? And why did it feel cooler?

Maybe I'd hit my head harder than I thought. I fell against Fitz. "Something is wrong. Terribly wrong. I think I need a CAT scan."

"Cat scan?" Zane laughed. "I fear she really is unwell. She is talking nonsense. Best call for a doctor and not the apothecary."

Yes, yes, I needed a doctor.

Thankfully, Fitz held me closer, making me feel more secure. I think he might have even smelled my hair. I hoped there was no mud or grass in it. My bonnet was obviously gone, my hair pins had fallen out, and the coiffure that our lady's maid had so carefully fashioned this morning was in disarray. I can't say I was sorry for that—I was more of a part-my-hair-to-the-side kind of girl instead of straight down the middle. But it was fun to look like Elizabeth, especially since I couldn't find it within myself to behave like her.

When we reached Longbourn, Zane knocked on the door. I wasn't sure why—no one would fault him for just entering the premises. No one even appeared to be home. Honestly, I wanted to know where everyone had disappeared to. Was Macey okay? Had I finally given Lady Catherine an aneurysm?

I heard the door creak open and a woman's voice say, "Good day, sirs," before she gasped.

I lifted my head to let whomever it was know I was all right. Or at least as right as I could be in this situation. I found the woman playing Mrs. Hill looking at me with a pale face, doing her best to keep her composure. Oh, I must have looked awful. Maybe my head had a gash. I reached up to see if I could feel anything.

“Good day. Are your master or mistress at home? Please inform them that Mr. Bingley and Mr. Darcy are waiting with a matter of serious import. As we happened to be riding near your park, we witnessed Miss Bennet thrown from her horse. She appears to have sustained some injury.” Zane took his own sweet time explaining. More irksome was his casual manner regarding a potentially life-threatening event for me. My brain could be bleeding, for all we knew.

“Follow me,” Mrs. Hill directed. “Make haste,” she implored. Finally, someone with a sense of urgency. Leave it to a woman to be concerned. Men. Sheesh. Although, I couldn’t understand why she didn’t just call for someone to dial 999.

We entered a parlor suitable for entertaining guests, with a pianoforte and comfortable seating placed in groups. I’d played the instrument last night with Mary, helping her to loosen up and allow the passion for music to flow as her fingers glided across the keys. As we sang “The Last Rose of Summer,” I’d guided her with her inflections and given her some tips on how to stay on key. Considering Thomas Moore wrote the poem in 1805, and it’s said Jane Austen completed Pride and Prejudice prior to that, though it wasn’t published until 1813, I wasn’t sure if Elizabeth or Mary would actually have sung that song. But it was beautiful, and I felt like the melancholy nature of it was perfect for Mary. It was immaterial at that moment.

What was of greater concern was how Mrs. Bennet and all my “sisters” were out of their riding habits already and in the parlor doing needlework. Did no one care that my horse had thrown me? Had Lady Catherine sent everyone back to the house with instructions to act as if nothing had happened? Where was Lady Catherine to scold me? Or throw me out?

“Ma’am.” Mrs. Hill curtsied. “Mr. Bingley and Mr. Darcy have come to call. There has been an incident.”

An incident?

Mrs. Bennet looked up from fanning herself and cried, “Mr. Bennet! Come quick!”

Macey flew out of the chintz chair she was sitting in, letting the handkerchief she was embroidering fall to the side. “Lizzy,” she exclaimed before being dumbstruck by the presence of Zane and Fitz. Also, why was she calling me Lizzy at a time like this?

“Macey,” I said, hoping to put a stop to all this cosplay madness—we could go back to that later after I’d had a CAT scan.

“Who is Macey?” Carla laughed, doing her best Lydia.

This was no laughing matter.

“Lay her on the settee,” Mrs. Bennet frantically instructed. “Oh, my poor nerves.” She got over her nerves quickly, though, as she eyed both men and paid me no more attention. “Mr. Bingley, we heard you had gone to London to bring back a party to stay at Netherfield with you. We were hoping to see you at the Meryton assembly this evening and to have a proper introduction. You, of course, have already met Mr. Bennet.”

Where had all her motherly affection gone? She cared more about the assembly than me? Besides, we weren’t doing that scene tonight. That was tomorrow. And hello, she knew him already.

Fitz laid me on the settee. He looked relieved to do so and tried to back away as soon as possible, but I couldn’t let him go. I didn’t care that unresolved things stood between us. I’d never been more afraid in my life, and I needed him now more than ever, so I took his hand. “Alastair Fitzroy, I don’t know what you’re playing at, but this has to stop. Please.”

“Madam.” He raised his brows, shocked and appalled as he shook off my hand. “Madam, you have mistaken me for someone else.” He rushed from the room without saying a word to anyone.

It was then I knew something had gone terribly, terribly wrong.

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# FIFTEEN

***"Do not give way to useless alarm; though it is right to be prepared for the worst, there is no occasion to look on it as certain."***

## FITZ

I WATCHED HELPLESSLY NEARBY AS the paramedics assessed Monroe. The ambulance lights flashed in the field, while the rest of the guests and staff stood in shock—some stunned into silence, others crying and expressing their hopes she would be well. Monroe hadn't regained consciousness, and I feared the worst. Several minutes had passed now, and I was hearing words like *a traumatic brain or spinal cord injury* coming from the paramedics. Thankfully, she was breathing on her own, and oddly, her vitals were normal. Monroe was perplexing the medical professionals, just as she'd perplexed me for as long as I'd known her. To love someone as much as I loved her, despite knowing how complicated a romantic relationship would be, bewildered me. Yet I knew there was no one else for me except Monroe. And now I was faced with the possibility that . . . I didn't want to think about it.

But think about it I did. What if I lost Monroe? What if she never regained consciousness and she died thinking I didn't want her or love her for who she was? The thought almost brought me to my knees, but I stood, trying to stay strong for her.

"I feel awful," Jane sobbed into Bingley's chest.

"It's not your fault," he tried to comfort her, though I could tell it annoyed him that she hadn't just refused to ride the horse in the first place.

I didn't blame Jane, but I wished she had refused to ride as well. What I wouldn't give right now for Monroe to be telling me off. She did it so well, and I deserved it.

The insufferable Lady Catherine tapped me on the arm. “I hate to disturb you at such a time, but I must think about the park and the experience for the rest of our guests. I do hope you will stay on as our Mr. Darcy. Chances are there isn’t much you can do at the hospital. We will find you another Elizabeth.”

“I would be more than happy to take Monroe’s place.” Winnifred raised her hand, not looking abashed at all for her gross misconduct.

I had never felt such contempt in my life. There was no hiding my *resting Darcy face*, as Monroe would say. If only she were awake to say it, so I could pretend to be annoyed by it. My eyes narrowed and lips curled as I turned to face the awful women. “I can’t believe either of you has the audacity to worry about such trivial things while Monroe,” my voice hitched, speaking her name, but I regained my composure, hoping I would have the chance to break down in private, but needing for now to be strong for Monroe. “ . . . lies there hurt. How badly, we don’t know. Winnifred, I thought we were better friends than that,” I scolded her. “I thought you were a better person.”

Winnifred’s face burst into flames of red to match her auburn hair, but she said nothing in her defense.

“As for you,” I rounded on Lady Catherine. “You have been nothing short of vile to Monroe.”

Her mouth fell open, and she spluttered incomprehensible words, trying to defend herself.

“Monroe has dreamed for years of coming to this place, and you have treated her more than unfairly. Why? Because she doesn’t fit some mold?” My own words pierced what little heart I had. I felt disgusted with myself. Had I withheld myself from Monroe because she didn’t fit the *mold* of the peerage? “Her biggest crime was being excited to be here and wanting those around her to enjoy this fantasy along with her. But all you could do was look down your nose at her. So, no. If Monroe can’t be my Elizabeth, I will not be Mr. Darcy. I don’t give a damn who you get to replace me.”

Lady Catherine’s eyes watered while her hands shook so much, she clasped them together. “Well,” her voice trembled. “I am sorry that you feel this way.”

“You should be sorry for how you treated Monroe.” But not as sorry as I was for how I had treated her. “Don’t expect me to recommend this place.” I strode off.

“Your Grace, please wait. I can make it right,” Lady Catherine called after me, but I ignored her.

I wasn’t sure what she could do—nor did I care. All I wanted was for Monroe to be well and open her gorgeous eyes again.

I watched as they placed Monroe on a stretcher with her neck in a brace and her face covered with an oxygen mask. She looked absolutely helpless. “I thought she was breathing on her own,” I said, gutted, feeling as if I needed an oxygen mask of my own. All the air in my lungs had disappeared.

“She is, Your Grace,” the female paramedic answered. “The oxygen is just a precaution until we can get her to hospital, have her evaluated by a physician, and run some tests.”

“I want her taken to the private hospital in town.” I would call in a set of specialists from around the world to see her if I had to. Money would be no object.

The male paramedic nodded.

“I’m coming with you,” I stated, not allowing any room for argument. Sometimes it was good to be a duke.

“Yes, Your Grace.”

“Hold up,” Tony yelled, jogging over to me.

“What do you want?” I snapped.

Tony stared, ashen faced, at Monroe as they hoisted the stretcher into the back of the ambulance. “She’s going to be okay, right?”

“Do you really care?”

“Yes,” he murmured, as if he hated to admit it.

I didn’t bother with a response before stepping up into the ambulance and squeezing myself between the medical supplies and Monroe. “My love.” I took her cold, delicate hand and held it between my own. For the first time in my life, I didn’t know what to say, and for the first time in many years, tears rolled down my cheeks as I prepared for the worst.

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# SIXTEEN

***"Think only of the past as its remembrance gives you pleasure."***

## MONROE

I LAY THERE ON THE settee, feeling stunned and mostly ignored. I knew with all my heart that despite what had transpired between Fitz and me in the last twenty-four hours, he would never have left me. This understanding sent wild theories running rampant through my mind. I had four hypothetical explanations: I was in a dream, or maybe a nightmare. But as hard as I tried, I couldn't wake up, even after telling myself several times to awake, so I didn't take that as a good sign. Next on my list was being trapped in some weird space-time continuum. Highly unlikely, considering I didn't watch or read much science fiction and I'd never really understood any of Einstein's theories. I didn't even really know what *space-time continuum* meant. That led me to my third conjecture that perhaps Pride and Prejudice Park really was *Fantasy Island* and Mr. Roarke had granted me my wish to be an Elizabeth, as in the actual Elizabeth Bennet. Except I didn't remember hopping on a plane and flying to a tropical island, or meeting Mr. Roarke. However, Great Britain is technically an island, so maybe Lady Catherine was filling in for Mr. Roarke. I was really hoping for this option, minus the part where I learn uncomfortable lessons about myself. But it was better than my last and least favorite option, that my toxic trait had finally done me in—as in, I hadn't survived the fall. If that were the case, was I in heaven or hell?

Could one actually consider *Pride and Prejudice* to be heaven? I mean, hello, Mr. Darcy. Yes, please. I'd take him for eternity, especially if he looked like my Fitz. Maybe that's how God worked. He gave you your greatest desire. But then that would mean . . . I really was dead. I touched

my arms, body, and head. They all hurt. It didn't hurt after you died, right? So maybe this was *Fantasy Island* or a dream I could never wake up from?

One thing I knew for sure—I wasn't in Kansas anymore. If only I had some ruby slippers. Just for kicks and giggles, I closed my eyes and quietly said "There's no place like home" three times. No luck. I remained in the parlor watching Mrs. Bennet fangirl all over Mr. Bingley. She prattled on about how happy she was that he'd let Netherfield as she gripped Jane, making sure she stayed front and center. Jane kept looking pensively at me as if she wanted to come to my aid, but Mr. Bingley certainly seemed taken with her as he smiled and laughed easily. The guy definitely wasn't Zane, who hadn't exactly embraced his character since arriving at Pride and Prejudice Park. Lydia and Kitty giggled in the corner, and Mary played a morose tune on the pianoforte, missing notes here and there. They all acted as if nothing had happened. I started to question if anyone in this peculiar place genuinely cared that I'd been injured.

To answer my question, Mr. Bennet rushed in and came straight to me, kneeling in front of the settee. He still bore a resemblance to Idris Elba, but he had a paternal air reminiscent of Davis Gray, which thankfully didn't draw me to him in a Freudian sort of way. That would have been all sorts of disgusting and would have me needing therapy if I ever found my way out of this. Assuming I could escape this place. Whatever this place was. But on the upside, heaven had to have a few therapists. *Please, don't let me be dead.*

"My dearest Lizzy." Mr. Bennet placed his chilly hand on my warm brow. "I heard you took a nasty fall from Ladybird. I had Hill call for Mr. Jones."

Ladybird was the horse's name in Pride and Prejudice Park, which made this all the more confusing.

"I told her not to ride. She is no horsewoman, unlike our dear Jane," Mrs. Bennet made sure to point out to Bingley, which only reaffirmed to me that this wasn't the cosplay cast. Laila Gray would never have behaved in such a manner, even if we were acting out a scene. And this hadn't been included among the scripted scenes. It honestly wasn't even in the book, although I suppose it could have been—we don't know much about what happened in the fortnight between the announcement of Bingley letting out Netherfield and the Meryton assembly. I'm sure Elizabeth didn't fall off a horse, as Mrs. Bennet pointed out that she was no horsewoman. But in real

life—my life—I was a better horsewoman than Jane, I mean Macey. Oh, poor Macey—I hoped she hadn't fallen off her horse too. It all felt so confusing.

"I should be off to find Darcy," Mr. Bingley said in a rush.

I cringed, thinking about my interaction with Mr. Darcy—he probably thought I was a mental case. I needed to figure out a way to fix that when I saw him again. Hopefully he would chalk it up to a head injury, but he had to be wondering why I'd bring up the word *sexy* in conversation, or where I'd even learned such a phrase. I know some scholars, including Fitz, argued that the Regency era saw some cultural shifts regarding sex, but it was still not proper for the daughter of a gentleman to speak or act in such a manner. Case in point—look at how Mr. Darcy had behaved when I touched his hand with my bare skin. Admittedly, this was a bit of a bummer. Although it obviously wasn't included in Austen's story, I had really hoped that Darcy and Elizabeth had some passionate make-out sessions—off page—before they wed, sans gloves.

"You must promise to return." Mrs. Bennet sounded positively desperate.

"I shall." Mr. Bingley smiled at Jane.

Jane blushed and bowed her head.

"Miss Bennet, may I be so bold as to ask you for the first two dances tonight?" Mr. Bingley mumbled.

"Yes!" Mrs. Bennet answered for Jane.

"Very well." Mr. Bingley dashed off.

Jane flashed me a mortified look but said nothing. It wasn't surprising. In the novel, Jane hadn't been good at sticking up for herself either.

I wanted to ease her mind, but my head hurt, and I was still freaking out about this unexpected plot twist in my life, or un-life. Was that even a word? *Please, please, don't let me be unalive.* Before being actively engaged in this strange place, I should probably first work out why I was there. If it was like a space-time continuum thing, I was toast. I couldn't even wrap my mind around a reason why that would happen. It would be easier to figure out if it ended up being a *Fantasy Island* episode. That would be obvious. I was here to become the best Elizabeth I could be, and to learn something horrid about myself that would teach me a moral lesson—you know, more horrid than being unable to truly help anyone, or my best friend offering me his heart, if only I changed everything about myself.

There was still the remote possibility it was a dream and none of this really mattered, except I couldn't wake up, and that was exponentially bad. Finally, if I was dead and this was heaven, well, I guess I should get my man, I mean Mr. Darcy, and live happily ever after. It might be the only way I could ever have Fitz. Would Mr. Darcy kiss like Fitz? Yes, please.

Poor Fitz; what must he be thinking and doing right now? Despite the harsh things he'd said to me last night, I knew it would crush him if I died or disappeared. But in his anguish, he probably still thought this would never have happened if I'd listened to him and followed his plan for me. Was he right? Did I need to stop helping people? Is this what I was supposed to learn here?

As soon as Mr. Bingley exited, Mrs. Bennet turned toward me, her brows furrowing and nose wrinkling. "You foolish girl. How could you fall off your horse in front of Mr. Bingley and his friend, Mr. Darcy? I must find out more about that gentleman—Mr. Darcy," she said more to herself. "His clothes and manners show he must have five thousand or more a year. Thank heavens Mr. Bingley seems taken with Jane," she exclaimed.

"Jane, Jane, Jane," Kitty grumbled under her breath in the background.

Mary played the pianoforte louder, as if she, too, were weary of hearing Jane's praises sung.

I'd never given much thought to how the younger sisters felt, constantly hearing about Jane's beauty. Not that Jane didn't deserve the praise—she is lovely—but maybe that was part of the reason they sought attention in less healthy ways. Of course, Lydia was a favorite of Mrs. Bennet's, as well, but her mother and father didn't consider her the beauty they did Jane.

"Perhaps it was fortunate your mishap brought an admirer for Jane," Mrs. Bennet snapped. "Look at you, though, covered in mud—always mud with you. I told my brother and sister not to waste their money buying you a riding habit."

I supposed she was talking about Mr. and Mrs. Gardiner.

"My dear," Mr. Bennet said in a strained voice. "I think it best if you retire to your rooms before the assembly. Think about your nerves."

I got the feeling she was getting on his nerves.

"The assembly." Mrs. Bennet lit up. "I cannot wait to tell Lady Lucas that Mr. Bingley has honored Jane with the first two dances."

"Yes, yes," Mr. Bennet chuckled. "We love to make sport for our neighbors."

Jane finally came to my side, sat on the settee, and took my hand. She wore a muslin dress in light blue with a satin sash just below her bustline. Her hair was fashioned in a modest updo with a few curls framing her face. “Are you all right, Lizzy?”

No, I wasn’t all right. I just wanted to go home. I wanted Fitz, the jerk. Tears pricked my eyes, but I managed to say, “I am well.”

“Why has your voice changed?” Jane sounded concerned.

Dang it. I probably sounded very American. With a Midwestern accent at that. I don’t think the Midwest even existed in this time period. “No need to worry.” I switched to mimic Jane’s tone and accent, hoping I sounded like Elizabeth. “I think it was the shock of the fall.” Boy, was I ever shocked.

“Now you sound more like yourself,” Jane said, relieved.

“Mary, please stop playing.” Mrs. Bennet rubbed her head. “I think I will rest.” She swept out of the room with no thought for me at all.

“Let us get ready for the assembly.” Lydia pulled Kitty out of the room.

Mary sighed, grabbed a book, and muttered while exiting, “I do not understand all the excitement about the assembly. I would much rather read a book. The mind is, after all, our truest companion.”

I couldn’t help but giggle.

“There go the three silliest girls in the country.” Mr. Bennet shook his head before pressing his hand to my cheek. “Are you sure you are well, my dear?”

“Yes, Papa,” I said. The words came naturally, even though I wished for my own father. Had Fitz told him yet of my accident or demise?

“Very well. I count on your intelligence and spirit around here. I am going to see when we should expect Mr. Jones. If you are in pain, I think your mother may have a store of laudanum.”

Uh . . . laudanum is opium. Yikes. But it did kind of explain a lot about her character. “That will not be necessary.” I had to keep reminding myself not to use contractions and to speak in a proper British accent.

“Good girl.” Mr. Bennet kissed my brow before he stood and wandered off.

I hoped the apothecary didn’t come. I could probably heal myself better than he could, especially if he was going to prescribe laudanum for the pain.

Jane patted my hand.

“Do I look awful?” I asked her, desperate for a mirror to examine myself.

“No. Just a few twigs and leaves in your hair.” Jane carefully plucked them out.

“I think I frightened Mr. Darcy.”

Jane smiled. “I think so. I am sure, though, he understands you were not yourself when you said those strange things and called him a different name. Who is Alastair Fitzroy?”

I bit my lip, trying not to cry. How did I explain who he was to me? I wasn’t sure I would ever see him again, and the thought pierced me so deeply, my chest hurt from how hard my heart pounded. The words didn’t come, so I asked Jane a question instead. “What did you think of Mr. Bingley?”

Her smooth cheeks pinked. “He is very gentlemanly and quite amiable,” she seemed embarrassed to say.

“Yes,” I agreed. “He obviously found you very pretty. And he is handsome.” Not to say this was a good foundation for a relationship, but I reflected that most women didn’t have the luxury of marrying for love in the 1800s, so I counted physical attraction as a huge win in this case.

She turned a brighter shade of red. “He is pleasing to look at.”

“He is.” I squeezed her hand, thinking of all the heartache she had ahead of her where Mr. Bingley was concerned.

I wanted to tell her it would all work out in the end, but that got me thinking. Was the heartache actually necessary? I mean, I knew how the story went. I could give her a few pointers. But was this another instance of trying to help when I shouldn’t? After all, I still hadn’t ruled out *Fantasy Island*, and I wanted to become the best Elizabeth possible. But would Elizabeth stand by and let Jane get her heart torn to shreds, even knowing in the end it would work out? That was a perplexing question. I did have a terrible track record for helping anyone, but maybe that was part of the fantasy—no toxic trait. That seemed too good to be true.

Yet, this place didn’t seem like it could be true.

No. No. No. I had to stop thinking like this. All my helpful plans ended in disaster.

“Lizzy,” Jane interrupted my existential crisis. “Mama wishes for one of us to marry Mr. Bingley.”

“I know.” Believe me, I knew.

“What if it were me?” she whispered, hardly daring to say it, as if admitting it would prevent it from coming true.

Dang it. She was making me want to unleash my terrible power of trying to improve a situation while making it exponentially worse. I couldn’t help but ask myself: What if Charles Bingley didn’t have to leave Netherfield? Could Jane make Bingley believe her affections were strong enough that Mr. Darcy wouldn’t interfere with their relationship?

What was I even thinking? That wasn’t the story.

Yet . . . I was no ordinary Elizabeth. I didn’t have any pride or prejudice against Mr. Darcy, even though he had just dropped me like a sack of potatoes on the settee. But I knew under that prideful exterior, he would fall in love with me and save Lydia from Wickham—who I would not be befriending. Ooh . . . that led me down another rabbit hole. What if I could prevent that horrible situation? I could tell everyone there when Wickham showed up with the regiment that he was a charlatan of the worst sort. Of course, this was assuming I really was in the actual *Pride and Prejudice* story or *Fantasy Island*. Except this could be the *Without Pride and Prejudice* version, I thought to myself and smiled.

“What is it, Lizzy?” Jane asked, noticing my grin.

I thought of something Lizzy might say. “I was just thinking that it should be you who marries Bingley. You who sees the best in everyone and are the kindest among us.”

“Sister, you are being too kind.”

“No, Jane, I am not.” I so badly wanted to tell her to do everything in her power to make Bingley believe she cared for him, but I held my tongue, as hard as it was, for fear of failure. And for fear of what would become of me if I didn’t play my part right.

But I had to wonder . . . What part was I supposed to play, and how would this all end? Hopefully, I would be not dead.

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# SEVENTEEN

***"We all know him to be a proud, unpleasant sort of man; but this would be nothing if you really liked him."***

## MONROE

WITH THE HELP OF A footman, I prepared to step out of the carriage behind Mrs. Bennet and Jane. Several other footmen lingered about outside the modest stone assembly hall with arched windows and double doors, waiting for carriages and carrying lanterns to illuminate the dark night. I had never thought about how truly dark it would be in this time period. The scent of burning oil and candles lingered everywhere. It felt almost claustrophobic. So much so, I forgot to be amazed that I was in the very place I'd imagined and daydreamed about for years. It also might have had something to do with Lydia using a bourdaloue in the carriage—it kind of ruined the charm of the situation. I don't care how badly I had to relieve myself—I would never shove that gravy bowl–looking thing under my dress and use it in front of everyone. The fact I'd had to use a chamber pot earlier still haunted me and made me long for flushing toilets and running water. If this was a dream, I had to believe I could either make modern plumbing possible, or I would have woken up before I had to use that chamber pot.

However, I had more pressing thoughts on my mind now than the toilet situation. I was about to come face-to-face with Mr. Darcy again. Thankfully, this time I wouldn't be lying in a field with twigs in my hair and mud on my dress, though I still felt quite achy. The apothecary had been of no help. He'd mixed a tincture, claiming it would aid in my recovery, but he wouldn't tell me what was in it, so I refused it, to his dismay. But no matter how much I hurt, I had to attend tonight's assembly. I needed to set in motion my journey as Elizabeth. And even though Mr.

Darcy believed me to be a lunatic and would be snubbing me tonight, I needed to see him—to be reminded of my Fitz.

The lady's maid who had waited on Jane and me had become frustrated when I insisted on doing my own hair. I wanted to look as pretty as I could, so I styled my hair in a Grecian knot, although I did have her help me with curling the back of my hair and adding some pearls. The curling tool she used looked absolutely archaic and, frankly, scared me.

I wished I could take a picture of myself. I thought I looked quite well in the white lace-trimmed muslin dress with short puffed sleeves. At least I felt pretty. I had to remind myself that although Mr. Darcy would not find me handsome enough to tempt him, a girl had to try—especially since I already knew his heart, even if he didn't know it himself. Since I couldn't have Fitz, maybe I could have the next best thing in Mr. Darcy. And since Mr. Darcy looked like him, it might be like having Fitz there with me. They had similar personalities—including *speaking Darcy* oh so well. And how could I be the best Elizabeth without Darcy?

After being here for some hours, I'd narrowed my theories down to two possibilities: *Fantasy Island* or the least-favorite option. They were the only ones that made sense. I'd never had a dream so elaborate or one last for so long, and, try as I might, I couldn't wake up. That left me either to play out the fantasy or live for eternity with Mr. Darcy. Of course, I would be heartbroken to never see Fitz or my family again, but if I thought about it too much, it would crush me.

"Come, Lizzy, make haste," Mrs. Bennet shrieked, rousing me out of my thoughts. I stepped out of the carriage, and immediately, Mary, Kitty, and Lydia exited after me. Kitty and Lydia laughed obnoxiously and ran for the doors, while Mary looked pensive. It was then I noticed that her dress was shabbier than everyone else's and whoever had helped with her hair had been careless. That wouldn't do.

I strung my arm through Mary's as we walked in the night's chill, hoping I wasn't doing anything I shouldn't. In the book, the Meryton assembly was basically described quickly and almost after the fact. Jane Austen left out many details. So maybe Elizabeth had helped Mary fix her hair. Regardless, it didn't seem right that Mary should look so dowdy compared to the rest of us. Unless she wanted to be that way, but I had a feeling it bothered her.

Mary narrowed her eyes at me incredulously. "What is this?"

So maybe they weren't the closest of sisters. "I was just thinking that perhaps I could help you with your hair. Some of it seems to have fallen out."

Mary's cheeks flushed, and she went on the defensive. "Well, no one had time to help me."

"That is terrible," I commiserated with her. "I would like to help you now." Assuming I could. Should I even try?

"Why?" she asked suspiciously.

"Because we are sisters, and it is only right."

Her features softened, but she didn't say anything. She only gave me a slight nod.

As soon as we entered the assembly hall, the sounds of lively chatter and laughter filled the air. I breathed in the scent of beeswax and mulled wine with hints of the floral-scented perfumes everyone seemed to be wearing. At least it didn't smell like body odor, or worse, like I'd been afraid it might. Perhaps I shouldn't have worried. I recalled a conversation that Fitz and I once had about the Regency era. I was ever curious about it, given my obsession with Jane Austen novels. He said it was probably a lot less smelly than most people thought, especially among gentlefolk. My heart ached for him to be there, to help calm my fears like he always had. To kiss me again—no, no, no. We could have no more of that; I embarrassed him.

I focused back on the sights before me and what a vision it was. The ballroom, with its gleaming polished-wood floors, seemed to invite every step to be taken with grace. Elegant candle chandeliers hung from the ceiling, casting a warm and gentle light that bathed the room in a delicate glow. Several people gathered in groups, chatting animatedly, anticipating the merriment ahead. This was really happening. Who needed Pride and Prejudice Park when you could have the real thing? You know, unless I was D-E-A-D.

Mrs. Bennet had begun gossiping already with Lady Lucas and Elizabeth's aunt—Mrs. Phillips, I believed. They looked like the staff members who I swore played them in Pride and Prejudice Park. My mind was doing some trippy things here. No doubt she couldn't wait to tell them that Mr. Bingley had already asked Jane for the first two dances, and that we'd all met Mr. Darcy.

Charlotte appeared. Yep, she looked like the Charlotte from Pride and Prejudice Park, except she didn't seem so stupid as to want to hook up with my ex-fiancé. I still wished I knew why Tony had shown up on our would-be honeymoon, but I had more important mysteries to solve, like why I was living the actual *Pride and Prejudice* story.

"Lizzy." Charlotte approached Mary and me and kissed me lightly on each cheek. "You are looking exceptionally pretty tonight." She sounded all astonishment.

"Charlotte," I said affectionately, praying I was right and wondering if I looked so different from the real Elizabeth. "Thank you. I hope you are well?"

"Are you well?" she asked, concerned. "It is rumored you fell off your horse and were rescued by none other than Mr. Bingley and his friend."

Wow. That got around quickly.

"Well. Yes."

Charlotte's brow quirked, intrigued. "You must tell me about Mr. Darcy," she whispered. "Some say he has ten thousand a year."

I wanted to roll my eyes, but I refrained, reminding myself Elizabeth would have found that noteworthy as well. "I need to help Mary with her hair," I responded, not knowing what to say about Mr. Darcy. The real Elizabeth would have probably felt slighted by his behavior and most definitely embarrassed about how I had acted in her stead. I hoped no one but Mr. Bingley knew about the basket-weaving thing, or our awkward conversation where I'd informed Mr. Darcy that we'd kissed and that he loved me.

Charlotte looked surprised that I wished to help Mary. Ugh. Was I doing Elizabeth all wrong?

"Go on without me," Mary said miserably.

"Let us all go into the cloakroom," I suggested, pointing at the small room off to the side, filled with benches and the walls lined with pegs. "I can fix your hair there while we talk."

Both women seemed to find it odd but followed me anyway.

Once in the room that was thankfully void of anyone else at the moment, I had Mary sit on one of the benches. Charlotte stood near, eyeing me as if she wondered if I were truly okay.

I went to work on Mary's hair, removing the poorly placed pins, trying not to be grossed out by the excess styling lotion she'd used. I hoped this

wasn’t inappropriate behavior and nothing horrible happened to Mary because I fixed her hair. Oh gosh, I probably shouldn’t have been doing this. But she seemed so sad.

“Is Mr. Darcy as handsome as the rumors say he is?” Charlotte whispered.

“Yes,” I responded, while Mary said, “I would not say there was anything extraordinary about him.”

I wanted to ask her if she was blind, but then I remembered that in the book she fancied Mr. Collins. A little too late, but all the same, she wanted him. Oh gosh, another crazy thought hit me. What if I helped Mary get Mr. Collins and found someone more suitable for Charlotte so she didn’t have to encourage her husband to always spend time tending his gardens? This was assuming I even got that far into the story. But what was I even thinking? Did I think I knew better than the queen of literature, Jane Austen? Of course not. I was the person who made pregnant mothers miss their flights and broke up couples at the airport. And let’s not forget that my picture was in the *Daily Mail*, along with a scathing article about how ridiculous I was. Once again, I was going to scrub my mind of these insane thoughts. I would be a proper Elizabeth.

“Hmm. Well, I will judge for myself tonight.” Charlotte sat down on the bench. “I hope he likes to dance. There are always more ladies than men.”

“He does not,” I said before I could stop myself.

Charlotte and Mary both gave me sideways glances.

“What I meant to say,” I laughed, “is that he is not acquainted with anyone here, so I imagine he will not wish to dance except with those in his company.” I blathered on like an idiot while trying to get Mary’s hair into a chignon.

Charlotte tilted her pretty head. I don’t care what Mrs. Bennet thought—Charlotte wasn’t plain. She had sparkling green eyes and neatly styled sandy-brown hair. When she smiled, it was genuine and warm, much different from the version I knew in real life. Wait. Was this my real life now? I was so confused. Regardless, this version of Charlotte looked at me like I was a nutjob. Maybe I was.

“I hear Mr. Bingley already asked Jane for the first two dances. I do not see why Mr. Darcy would be any different,” Charlotte noted.

Oh, he was different, all right. I offered Charlotte a placating smile, knowing it would seem odd for me to continue to disagree.

It didn’t take me long to fix Mary’s hair. It wasn’t perfect, but at least it worked better with her delicate facial features, and it looked tidier. *Please, please, let it stay and not embarrass her.* Knowing my track record, I probably shouldn’t have helped her.

When we left the cloakroom, a small ensemble started to play a lively tune I believe modern-day Lady Catherine had called “Mr. Beveridge’s Maggot.” I only remembered it because of the odd title. But it meant this would be a country dance. Sadly, I didn’t really feel like dancing. My body ached, and I wasn’t sure jumping around was going to make it feel any better.

However, watching Jane stand up with Bingley lifted my spirits. Mrs. Bennet stood to the side in a dither, talking too loudly to Lady Lucas and Mrs. Phillips and saying things she probably shouldn’t, like, “Mr. Bingley is rich, you know. Five thousand a year. Jane and Mr. Bingley look well together, do they not?”

Mary and Charlotte, who hadn’t left my side, obviously heard her and giggled. I didn’t find it funny at all because I knew the problems it was going to cause for Jane and even Elizabeth—the real one, and maybe me too.

Watching Jane and Mr. Bingley reminded me that if Bingley was here, it meant Mr. Darcy had to be as well. My heart skipped several beats as I scanned the crowd for him, needing to see him. He was a link to Fitz in some cosmically weird way.

It didn’t take long to spot him across the ballroom, standing tall and aloof, making a cravat look oh so sexy and trying not to make eye contact with anyone. It was very much how Fitz used to behave in school. He didn’t want to accidentally give anyone an inkling he might be interested in speaking to them, even our professors. It took everything in me not to run to Mr. Darcy and beg him to help me out of this situation, but then I remembered he wasn’t my best friend. And who could forget our disastrous meeting earlier in the day? How could I recover from that?

But as if he knew I was peering at him, his eyes met mine. Instead of turning away in disgust like I assumed he would, his gaze penetrated me so deeply, I froze and held my breath. The moment didn’t last long. He shook his head as if bothered and then forced himself to look away.

I didn’t have time to process what had just happened because a man I didn’t know approached me as Mary, Charlotte, and I skirted the edges of

the dance floor. He gave me a slight bow. “May I have the honor of this dance?”

“Oh, uh. I do not mean to dance tonight. I am not feeling well. Perhaps you could dance with my friend or sister.” I pointed to Mary and Charlotte, feeling so out of place. I wanted the script I’d memorized for Pride and Prejudice Park. Was I supposed to know this man? Was it rude to decline? I knew Elizabeth danced at the assembly in the book. Not every dance, but she did stand up a few times.

The man blinked as if I’d stunned him. “Er, all right.” He turned to Mary, who looked ever so pleased about the attention, even though it was secondhand. “May I have the honor of this dance?”

Mary paused pensively as if she were having an internal debate, like it would go against all she stood for if she danced. So, I did what big sisters do—I replied on her behalf, “She would be honored.”

Mary threw me a scathing glance, but it quickly softened into a smile.

“How odd,” Charlotte said as soon as the couple left. “Mary hates to dance. She would rather play the pianoforte or reflect on her moral inclination.”

Reflect on moral inclination? Well, that sounded like loads of fun. I wanted to say that it was probably a defense mechanism because Mary wasn’t sure of herself and probably had middle child syndrome, but I didn’t think those terms would mean a thing here. But, crap, did Mary’s change mean I was already ruining the story and my chances of leaving this place? Or was I going to have to live for eternity knowing I’d ruined one of the greatest novels of all time? That sounded like something that would happen to me. Look what I’d done in my real life—I could have been part of the UK peerage. Not that I ever really wanted to be, but that’s not the point.

“And you surprise me, Lizzy.” Charlotte and I weaved in and out among the spectators. “Declining Mr. Rutledge. His father is one of the wealthiest men in the county, and he is set to inherit. And I dare say Mr. Rutledge is most handsome too.”

I supposed he was handsome, but I only cared about one man tonight—the man I could feel staring at me. Don’t ask me how, but I knew it. It was like feeling Fitz’s eyes on me.

Charlotte and I found seats not far from Mr. Darcy and none other than Caroline Bingley, who had planted herself as closely as she could to him. I assumed the other woman was Mrs. Hurst. There was no Mrs. Hurst at

Pride and Prejudice Park, since it was such an insignificant part, but they looked like sisters, both with auburn hair and haughty attitudes. Also, their velvet dresses spoke of which character they were in the story. And dang it if Caroline didn't look like Winnifred. Ugh. Why?

I could only imagine what the real Lady Winnifred was doing right now. In the event that I was, in fact, dead, she would probably be throwing a party and trying to comfort Fitz. No doubt she and Fitz's mum would be downright gleeful and probably picking out a wedding dress for Winnifred. In the event that I was still alive, I didn't know what would currently be happening to my body. Maybe it was still lying in the field? If that was the case, Winnifred would probably try to stomp on my head and call it an accident.

While we sat there, a few more men asked me to dance. I declined each time, to Charlotte's dismay and shock.

"You seem to be a favorite tonight," she said, surprised. "Even more so than Jane."

I wrung my gloved hands. "I cannot imagine why."

Charlotte surveyed me carefully. "There is something different about you, Lizzy." She seemed as perplexed as I felt.

I was grateful when the next man who asked me to dance extended his invitation to Charlotte, once I again declined. It gave me more time to observe Mr. Darcy. I wanted to apologize to him but knew I couldn't approach him without a proper introduction, and I kept thinking about what Lady Catherine had said at Pride and Prejudice Park—*"A lady must never force a man to pay attention to her."* However, I believed Mr. Darcy was paying attention to me. Each time I stole a glance his way, I found him staring at me. Of course, he would divert his gaze every time I caught him. It was kind of fun, except for the possibility that I wasn't handsome enough to tempt him.

After the next set of dances was over, the ballroom became a flurry of activity as partners were exchanged and people headed for the refreshments. I noticed that all my sisters and Charlotte had found new dance partners. Mary beamed with pride at being asked once again. I was more than happy her hair was holding up beautifully. Maybe this once, I could help someone, even if it was just a small thing. More interesting to me was Mr. Bingley coming to talk to Mr. Darcy.

Was this the moment of the slight? Should I move closer so I could hear it? It was my job in the story to relay it to my friends and Mrs. Bennet so she could tell Mr. Bennet and anyone else who would listen to her about her distaste for Mr. Darcy. That way, everyone would start to abhor him. At least, that's how the story is supposed to go. Jane Austen intended it that way. This wasn't *Without Pride and Prejudice*, although I didn't feel very proud of myself at the moment, and I held no prejudices against Mr. Darcy. He'd only behaved earlier like a man of his time would if a woman said the things I had—things that now mortified me.

Who was I to trample on greatness? Maybe Fitz was right. I had to stop trying to fix everything. The thought hurt so deeply, I felt it in my toes. I replayed every failed attempt to help someone in my head like a horror film, starting with my beautiful mom, whose life had been tragically cut short, to Macey, terrified on her horse. For once in my life, I was going to do the right thing. I would not go off script. I would finally be an Elizabeth. *The* Elizabeth, even.

I stood to move closer to Mr. Bingley and Mr. Darcy, who were talking quietly between themselves. I imagined Mr. Bingley scolding his friend for not dancing, especially when there were so many ladies without partners. Mr. Darcy was probably lamenting that Mr. Bingley was dancing with the only handsome woman in the room. Mr. Bingley would reply she was the most beautiful creature he'd ever beheld, and he would say I was very pretty. Of course, Mr. Darcy wouldn't agree. He wouldn't want to stand up with a woman whom other men had slighted. Except . . . no one had slighted me. I'd done the slighting. But he probably didn't know that.

Anyway, I was already feeling the sting of rejection before it even happened, even though I knew he would change his mind. Maybe it was because Fitz had just recently broken my heart.

I steeled myself and moved closer to hear the awful words, *"She is tolerable, but not handsome enough to tempt me."* I stood and waited and waited, but I couldn't overhear them.

Mr. Bingley turned toward me, smiling. "Miss Bennet, it is good to see you up and well."

Wait . . . that wasn't in the story. He was supposed to leave Mr. Darcy and dance with Jane again.

I curtsied, not knowing what else to do. "Thank you, Mr. Bingley. And may I also give thanks for rescuing me? I fear I may have said some foolish

words and acted in a manner unbefitting a young lady." That was putting it mildly, but I needed Mr. Darcy to know I wasn't a lunatic. I mean, some might disagree on that point—you could ask the *Daily Mail*, but the *Daily Mail* didn't exist yet.

Mr. Bingley laughed good-naturedly, but Mr. Darcy's face was impassive and didn't reveal a thing.

"We certainly do not fault you, Miss Bennet," Mr. Bingley said cheerfully.

I wasn't sure Mr. Darcy agreed. His careful study of me was unnerving, but at least he hadn't run off.

"Please allow me to properly introduce you to Mr. Darcy," Mr. Bingley offered.

Uh . . . okay. I didn't see this coming. I was trying to do things by the book here. Literally by the book. But how could I refuse? It would only make me look like a bigger nutjob. I was sure he would slight me after, right?

"Miss Bennet," Mr. Bingley continued, "may I introduce you to Mr. Fitzwilliam Darcy of Derbyshire." He said nothing of his estate, Pemberley.

Mr. Darcy gave a proper bow. When he raised his head, he made sure to make eye contact. Oh, what contact it was. His broody gray eyes went straight through me. It was as if Fitz inhabited his body, and I wanted Mr. Darcy now more than ever.

"Mr. Darcy, this is Miss Elizabeth Bennet."

I curtsied perfectly. "It is an honor to meet you properly." Truer words I had never spoken.

"The honor is mine, Miss Bennet," Mr. Darcy replied.

Oh, baby, a shiver went through me. I don't know what was happening, but I was here for it. Sorry, Jane Austen. I did try to stick to the book.

The ensemble started to play "La Belle Catherine," making Mr. Bingley startle. "I must be off." He left Mr. Darcy and me to stare awkwardly at each other.

I wasn't sure what I was supposed to do, but I felt as if every eye in the ballroom was on us. Was it improper for us to be so close? We weren't touching, but I was drawing his attention toward me. I turned to leave, feeling flushed and foolish.

"Miss Bennet, would you honor me with this dance?" Mr. Darcy asked.

Say what? Maybe I *was* dreaming.

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# EIGHTEEN

***"Had I been in love, I could not have been more wretchedly blind! But vanity, not love, has been my folly."***

## FITZ

"HOW IS SHE?" KINGSTON STARTLED me.

I squeezed Monroe's hand and ran my thumb over her smooth skin as I sat in the dim hospital room, lit mostly by monitors, listening to the rhythmic beeping of machines telling me she was alive. It had been hours since she'd fallen off that damn horse, and still she hadn't woken. "I don't know," my voice croaked from repeatedly begging Monroe to open her beautiful eyes.

Kingston stepped closer. "I brought you a change of clothes and some food, sir."

The faint smell of my favorite curry dish wafted my way. "Thank you, Kingston," was all I could offer. I felt no inclination to eat or even change out of the ridiculous costume I was wearing. I couldn't take my eyes off Monroe, covered in medical paraphernalia. Everything from a nasal cannula to electrodes placed on her gorgeous head.

"Have the doctors given you any information?" Kingston was hesitant to ask.

"Only that she puzzles them." I could relate. She'd been puzzling me for years. "They can't find anything wrong with her. Her brain activity appears normal, and she's breathing on her own. There's no swelling in her brain as far as they can tell, no broken bones, nothing other than her EEG waves showing that she's dreaming. Yet she won't wake up. It's not a good sign," I stammered, not wishing to admit it.

Kingston set the bag of food and the garment bag on the small couch in the room before pulling up a chair next to me.

I appreciated his calm presence more than he would know—he had a quiet confidence about him. Monroe called him a super babe. She said he reminded her of Gerard Butler in his prime, whatever that meant. I'd probably rolled my eyes when she'd mentioned it, but if truth be told, I found how she saw others endearing. Even if I admit to being a tad jealous she thought my estate manager was attractive.

"Don't give up on her, sir."

"I'm not. I can't. Especially after . . ." I was ashamed to admit to Kingston what I had said to her the night before.

"What is it? What happened?" Kingston was more than concerned.

"I hurt her. I told her she was too unconventional, and like a prat . . . I . . . I mentioned things she might want to think about changing for our image."

Kingston's face fell slack.

"It's not the worst part. She thinks I kept myself from a relationship with her because I was embarrassed by her, that I don't believe in her."

"Is that true?" Kingston didn't mince words.

"Of course not. Maybe . . . ," I half conceded, wishing for it not to be true. "I was trying to protect her."

"Pardon me for saying this, sir, but Miss Monroe doesn't need your protection. She only needs your acceptance."

Kingston was right, and his words packed a punch. I fell back in my chair, still gripping Monroe's hand. "I don't want there to be any more articles in the *Daily Mail* about her," I lamely defended myself.

"You are the Duke of Blackthorne, sir. If you accept her, that holds more weight than some silly rag. And I don't think Miss Monroe would care who did or didn't accept her, as long as you did."

I swallowed hard, feeling as if I'd just received a scolding—a much-deserved one. "She said as much." I stared at the sleeping beauty, not stirring at all. "What if she never wakes up and I can't tell her how sorry I am? How much I love her?"

Kingston offered me a small smile. "She'll wake up for that. I think she's been waiting years to hear that, and she wouldn't miss it."

I raised a brow. "You think she's been waiting for me?"

Kingston shook his head as if to say I was dense. "I've known you both for seven years now." Kingston had worked for my father before I inherited the title. "It's been clear to me every time you bring Miss Monroe home that

there was something special between the two of you. Relationships like yours don't come along every day, sir. To be so comfortable around another person is a rare gift. But I could tell she tempered her feelings for you, and for good reason." There he went again, sounding cross with me. "Your family is . . . well . . ." He thought the better of whatever he'd been going to say and instead murmured, "They're different from Monroe."

"You mean she's love and sunshine and we're proud berks?"

Kingston cleared his throat. "Those are your words, sir, not mine."

I scrubbed a hand over my face, knowing he'd say the same and possibly worse about my family, and he'd be right. "My pride has cost me most dearly," I admitted. "All the years I've wasted," I lamented. "And now she . . ." I couldn't say the words.

"She'll come through. You'll see." Kingston was more optimistic than me. "She's probably having a very pleasant dream about helping someone."

I chuckled as I imagined her running around with ten bonnets on her head, helping whomever she could to her heart's content. "I wish I had told her how much she's helped me throughout the years we've known one another instead of being a prick and telling her it would help our image if she didn't try to rescue everyone she came across." Why couldn't I have just said, *"You're the first person I wake up thinking about and the last person on my mind before I fall asleep. Yours was the voice I needed to hear and the hand I needed to hold when I lost my father and had to take on this damn title. No one makes me smile like you or helps me to see the good in the world like you do."*

Kingston's brow crinkled in a disapproving manner. "Perhaps, in that case, she hasn't yet woken up because she's trying to process living life without you. That can't be an easy prospect for her. Sometimes we need our dreams in order to sort through things."

I think I would rather have had Kingston slug me—his words landed a much harder punch than any fist. "Do you think I can bear the thought of being without her? I love her. I've always loved her," my voice hitched unnaturally.

"I apologize, Your Grace. I've overstepped my bounds. There is no question in my mind that you love her. It's been evident to me for years. Miss Monroe is an exceptional woman, and I think she helps people far more than she realizes." He sounded as if he were speaking from personal experience, but he didn't elaborate.

It made me wonder what he and Monroe talked about during their weekly calls. Did they discuss my sister? Was Kingston in love with Anna? I didn't ask, not sure Kingston or Anna would wish me to pry. My only response was, "Monroe is the best person I know."

Kingston nodded. "I apologize if I upset you. It wasn't my intention."

"I deserve your censure."

"You did say I could speak my mind." He grinned.

"I did."

We both stared at Monroe for a moment in silence, watching the rhythmic rise and fall of her chest. I hoped she was having the sweetest dreams, and that I was part of them—that somewhere deep inside she knew how sorry I was and that losing her would be the greatest tragedy of my life.

"Sir," Kingston was hesitant to speak. "I'm not sure if this is a good time, but I have some news about Miss Monroe's ex-fiancé."

I raised Monroe's hand and kissed it. "What news?"

"It appears that Tony Baker is not actually a guest at Pride and Prejudice Park. He is on their payroll."

Shocked, I craned my head toward Kingston. "He's an employee of the park?"

"Yes, and there's more."

"More?" I was still reeling from the first bit of information. I couldn't imagine why the plumber was working for the park. Why had the park lied and said he'd paid to play Mr. Wickham?

A grim expression washed over Kingston's features. "Yes, sir. Tony Baker embezzled a hefty sum from his last employer."

"His last employer, as far as I know, is his family's plumbing business."

"That's the one, sir."

"That prick. He gaslit Monroe and made her feel as if it were her fault he was terminated, because she'd tried to help him. Sounds as if he was helping himself—it wasn't her fault at all. But why come here, of all places? I know it's not to win back Monroe."

"I don't know, sir, but I will keep digging."

"Thank you, Kingston."

Kingston stood. "If that is all, sir, I'll leave you for now." He gazed affectionately at Monroe. "She looks happy."

I studied her more closely. Her lips seemed more curved, and my heart took hope.

“She’ll wake up when she’s ready to face what’s waiting for her.” Kingston gave me a knowing look.

“I’m waiting for her,” I assured him. “I’ll renounce my title if I must. The time is ticking, but I have a week to do so.” Under the Peerage Act of 1963, I had a year to disclaim my peerage.

“Sir, excuse me for being blunt, but I don’t think for one moment that would be her wish. All she needs from you is to believe in her. In my opinion, she would be a most excellent duchess.” He turned and walked away without another word.

I gathered Monroe’s hand between my own, taking in every part of her, from the contour of her cheeks and the graceful line of her jaw to her thick, dark eyelashes that seemed to tease me. “Please, Monroe, open those always-curious and engaging eyes of yours. I’m here and I’m yours. Forgive me for my ridiculous pride, please. I need you. I want you. All of you. We can even watch *Love Never Dies* if you want, though I know it will ruin *The Phantom of the Opera* for me.” Monroe thought we should at least give it a go because she was determined to watch every musical in existence, but I’d talked her out of it. “Wake up and let me help you make your dreams come true. Let me *talk Duke of Blackthorne* to you. I’ll make you forget you were ever obsessed with Mr. Darcy.” I half expected her to wake up and extol all the virtues of her beloved hero.

When she didn’t awake, I whispered, “Be my duchess, Monroe. I believe in you.”

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# NINETEEN

***"He is a gentleman; I am a gentleman's daughter."***

## MONROE

MR. DARCY STARED AT ME, waiting for my reply. His commanding presence held me captive, along with the allure of his broody eyes and tight jawline. Yes, it was all Fitz, but this man in front of me recognized me as a woman, and his intense gaze confirmed it. He wasn't hiding from me like Fitz had, even though I'd said foolish things to him earlier.

Please don't hate me, Jane Austen. I had to dance with him. To say no to him now might completely ruin your story—my story. "It would be an honor to dance with you." I had to stop myself from giggling. The teen girl inside of me was dying. Or maybe we were both dead. Who cared? Well, I did care, but I would think about it after I danced with Mr. Darcy. It would be like dying and going to heaven, every pun intended.

Relieved, Mr. Darcy offered his arm.

Oh. My. Gosh. I was going to touch him again—albeit with gloves on, but still. This was huge.

I was so glad we'd taken dancing lessons at the park. Hopefully now I wouldn't look ridiculous. Knowing my luck, I was bound to mess things up, but so far, so good tonight. Even Mary's hair had stayed in place, and she was dancing yet again.

When I took his arm, every goose bump I owned came to life. They all said, *Hello, Mr. Darcy.*

I swear, every eye zeroed in on us as we made our way to the middle of the dance floor. Mrs. Bennet pointed and seemed almost faint with happiness. To have two daughters dance with the handsome, rich newcomers had to be more than her nerves could handle. No doubt she'd heard about the ten thousand a year.

Caroline Bingley's eyes caught mine next. Oh, she loathed me just as Winnifred did—no surprise there. I almost laughed at her wrinkled nose and the way she spiritedly whispered to her sister. No doubt they were abusing me spectacularly. I didn't expect to get an invitation to dine with them at Netherfield.

As we were dancing the quadrille, we stood in a square with a gentleman I didn't know and Jane, both of whom appeared bashful around each other. Poor Mr. Bingley couldn't ask Jane to dance again. It would go against the rules of propriety. But I noticed Bingley couldn't keep his eyes off Jane even though he was dancing with another young lady. It was kind of cute, but I worried for Jane. Though the night was turning out much better than I could have hoped, I still felt a need to be careful not to fix things and alter the outcome.

However, I had other worries at the moment—like what to talk to Mr. Darcy about. Did I remark on the number of couples or the size of the room? That was in the novel, but not until the Netherfield ball. Mr. Darcy wasn't all that chatty in the book. Oh, the book! I could talk about books or poetry. I remembered a conversation I'd had with Fitz several years ago about the types of books Mr. Darcy would have read. He'd made fun of me because I was ever curious about my fictional idol, but within a few days' time, I had a box full of books delivered to me, courtesy of my infuriating best friend. Fitz had filled the box with writings from Homer, Plato, Aristotle, Milton, Shakespeare, and Byron. Together, we'd read every work and discussed them in detail. Best book club ever. Ugh. Why did he have to ruin it all? We could have just stayed friends. But could we really? I touched my lips, thinking about the soul-stirring kiss we'd shared—the one I claimed was the most right thing I'd ever done.

Not thinking about it.

*Focus, Monroe. You are Elizabeth.*

I smiled at Mr. Darcy as he reached for my hands, and we moved four steps. I took this as my opportunity to speak to him, hoping I didn't sound like an imbecile. "Mr. Darcy, what intrigues you most about Odysseus's journey?"

He stared blankly at me as we passed between Jane and the other gentleman. Oh no, I'd said the wrong thing. Had Fitz been wrong about Mr. Darcy's reading habits? Of course my mouth couldn't leave well enough alone—I seriously had a problem. The next time we faced each other and

Mr. Darcy took my hands, which by the way was super flutter inducing, I said, “I, for one, am most intrigued with the theme of reunion and restoration.” I didn’t mention I most enjoyed Odysseus’s reunion with his wife, Penelope. That seemed a little too forward, especially given our awkward first meeting.

Mr. Darcy narrowed his eyes at me, and I wondered if he just preferred I not speak. Jane and the other gentleman both looked at me as if I were an alien. At this point, for all I knew, I was an alien. I began to feel queasy, but at the next opportunity, Mr. Darcy replied, “I am more drawn to the elements of loyalty and perseverance.” They were the exact themes Fitz admired most.

“I enjoy those also. Odysseus’s perseverance was quite admirable, as was Penelope’s loyalty.”

“Quite,” Mr. Darcy responded, seemingly astounded by me.

We said no more, but Mr. Darcy studied me for the remainder of the dance. Every glance and touch was electrifying. As weird as it sounded, it felt as if we connected on some deeper plane, that we didn’t need to speak. It felt an awful lot like my relationship with Fitz. Why did it always come back to him?

When the dance ended, Mr. Darcy bowed to me. “Miss Elizabeth,” he said my name with admiration.

I curtsied. “Mr. Darcy.” I wanted to thank him a million times over and tell him I’d fantasized about a moment like this for years, but I maintained my Elizabeth-like composure. He escorted me back to Charlotte, and I watched him walk away, feeling a lot like Cinderella after dancing with Prince Charming—euphorically happy, but with a lingering feeling that maybe it was just make-believe. Surely the carriage would turn into a pumpkin and the footmen would transform back into mice. But none of those things happened.

The assembly ended, and Jane and I found ourselves seated next to each other in the frigid carriage, both wearing knowing smiles. We would talk later in the privacy of our room, away from our sisters and Mrs. Bennet, who was beside herself.

“He has ten thousand a year,” Mrs. Bennet kept exclaiming. “Mr. Darcy was so charming and handsome. And his manners.” She sighed. “I do hope he will take a house in the neighborhood. But I hear he owns a large estate in Derbyshire. Did you see how vexed Lady Lucas was that Mr. Darcy did

not ask Charlotte to dance?" Mrs. Bennet could hardly contain her satisfaction.

I wondered, though, what this meant for the story. Mrs. Bennet should have been properly abusing him by now for snubbing me, but that hadn't happened. Hmm. I watched Mary sitting across from me as well. She gazed contentedly out the window as if she had a wonderful secret to hide. She'd danced every dance. There had been no hair or wardrobe malfunction. Had I actually helped someone? The thought gave me hope.

When we arrived at Longbourn, Lydia and Kitty ran into the house, tittering about all the men they had danced with, Mary sort of floated in and disappeared upstairs, and Mrs. Bennet rushed in, searching for Mr. Bennet. Her gown swished, and she seemed a little tipsy, swaying back and forth.

"Oh! My dear Mr. Bennet," she cried as she entered the drawing room to find Mr. Bennet reading a book near the fireplace. These events happened just as in the novel. Perhaps I hadn't changed much of anything.

"We have had the most delightful evening, a most excellent ball," she exclaimed. "I wish you could have been there. Jane and Elizabeth were so admired."

Whoa. That was not in the story. At least not the part about me.

Mr. Bennet looked up from his book, still dressed in his day clothes, and instead of being annoyed, as I'd assumed he would be, he tilted his head and gave me a questioning glance.

Jane and I stood at the door, anxious to speak alone, but I eagerly awaited Mr. and Mrs. Bennet's comments. Could I win over the heart of Mrs. Bennet?

"Not only did Mr. Bingley ask Jane to dance twice, but the man who assisted Elizabeth after her unfortunate fall, Mr. Darcy, asked Elizabeth to dance. And he has ten thousand a year. Ten thousand!" she said more forcefully, as if Mr. Bennet had not heard.

Mr. Bennet continued to study me as Mrs. Bennet prattled on.

"Mr. Darcy did not ask one other young lady to dance besides our Elizabeth, though Mr. Bingley's party comprised his sisters, both of whom were quite elegant and doted on Jane. But you should have seen the way Mr. Darcy admired Elizabeth." Mrs. Bennet seemed so overcome by all the excitement that she fell into the chair across from Mr. Bennet.

"Lizzy, what did you think of this Mr. Darcy?" Mr. Bennet paid no attention to his wife.

What should I say? I wasn't sure there were enough words to describe the larger-than-life character, a character who had impossibly come to life for me. All I could think to say was, "He is everything a gentleman ought to be." I sort of stole Jane's line about Bingley. Oops.

"And he has ten thousand a year," Mrs. Bennet added in again for good measure.

I swore I saw Mr. Bennet roll his eyes.

"Good night, Mama and Papa," I said, hoping to escape without seeming rude.

"Good night, dear Elizabeth and Jane," Mrs. Bennet called out.

Mr. Bennet seemed too shocked at the affection Mrs. Bennet had shown me to say anything.

Jane and I hurried upstairs to our room, and I was happy to discover that women's friendships were important no matter the time period. We giggled as we helped each other undress as close to the fire as we could. I had to say, I really missed central heating and air-conditioning. And flushing toilets. I eyed the chamber pot in the room's corner. If this was a dream, please let the pot turn into a proper bathroom.

The bedroom looked just as it had at Pride and Prejudice Park, right down to the beautiful wallpaper, minus the modern conveniences of electricity and plumbing.

As soon as Jane and I snuggled up in bed, we faced each other, our cheeks hurting from smiling so much. It had been a good night for the Bennet sisters.

"Lizzy," Jane sighed. "Mr. Bingley is just what a young man ought to be—sensible, good humored, lively. And I never saw such happy manners! So much ease, with such perfect good breeding."

I wanted to hug her for letting me hear this line in the flesh, just as Ms. Austen had written it. I had to give my mind huge props for recalling it all so perfectly. You know, unless I was lying somewhere without a pulse and none of this experience was my own doing. Or maybe *Fantasy Island* was just this good. Regardless, I played my part. "He is also handsome." I smiled.

Jane blushed. "But what about Mr. Darcy? Do you find him handsome?"

Oh yeah. I bit my lip. If there were a hottest eligible bachelor in Regency times, he would win hands down. "Very much so."

“He seemed quite taken with you. I think it surprised him to see how well read you are. If truth be told, I do not remember you reading Homer.”

I curled more into myself. “Really? I love Homer, Milton, Shakespeare, Byron,” I babbled on.

“I thought you fancied Ann Radcliffe.”

“Oh, I do. I love a good gothic novel.” Thank you, Fitz, for being a history and literature professor. I’m not sure I would have known of Ann Radcliffe otherwise. “Do you think Mr. Darcy has read Radcliffe’s *The Romance of the Forest*?” I laughed.

Jane gasped. “Oh, Lizzy, I do not think it is the kind of book Mr. Darcy would read.”

“Right, of course.” Apparently humor was a bit different here. It made me wish for Macey. I wondered how Macey was doing.

Jane recovered quickly from my misstep. “Do you think Mr. Bingley and Mr. Darcy will come to wait on us again?”

I took Jane’s delicate hands. “Dear Jane, Mr. Bingley most certainly will come again.” *Do not try to fix it. Do not try to fix it.* I so badly wanted to give her advice about how she should behave around Mr. Bingley. She was obviously smitten with him, but they hardly knew each other. Granted, this was a different day and age, and I knew they were meant to be. *Resist, resist, resist.*

“What about Mr. Darcy?” Jane asked, saving me from myself.

I didn’t dare hope that he would come to Longbourn to wait on me. Surely he’d heard Mrs. Bennet going on about his wealth, gloating that I was the only young woman Mr. Darcy danced with. Besides, it wasn’t part of the story. At least not yet. Jane hadn’t even tried to help me see the good in Mr. Bingley’s sisters yet. “I do not know,” I answered truthfully.

Jane gave me a mischievous smile. “Lizzy, do you believe you are in danger of falling in love?”

I was in love. There was no denying it. And it was more dangerous to my heart than I ever imagined. I thought of Fitz, of course. It was no wonder I’d kept my feelings so hidden, not even realizing they existed. Deep down, I knew it would spell the end for our friendship, so I protected myself and us. But despite my best efforts, we were over, and I could hardly stand the thought. It left me feeling completely empty.

Maybe that’s why I’d come to this place, wherever this place was. Maybe it was the only place I could safely open my heart and be with Fitz,

a.k.a. Mr. Darcy. The question was, could Mr. Darcy fall in love with me?

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# TWENTY

***"They walked on, without knowing in what direction. There was too much to be thought, and felt, and said, for attention to any other objects."***

## MONROE

SOME EXCITEMENT STILL LINGERED THE next morning as we ate breakfast in the cozy dining room, enjoying fresh breads and jams on a neatly set table. Hints of strong coffee and teas wafted in the air. I honestly hadn't realized how many servants the Bennets had. They bustled about the estate, attending to the house and its inhabitants. Mrs. Hill ran a tight ship and bossed those under her around with authority.

The temptation to improve the Bennets' story niggled at the back of my mind as I observed the domestic scene. Lydia and Kitty tittered between themselves about the men they'd danced with at the assembly, and I found myself wanting to discourage Mr. Bennet from allowing all his daughters out into society at the same time. Kitty and Lydia were too young—they should think of unicorns and puppies, not husbands. Mary sat on one side of me humming a tune, slightly off-key. Would it be helpful to give her some voice and pianoforte lessons? Was that going too far? Jane sat on the other side of me, sighing happily while sipping her tea. Mrs. Bennet kept replaying the previous night's events, so much so that she didn't even care when Kitty kept coughing. Apparently her nerves did just fine when the chance of two of her daughters making good matches seemed possible. Mr. Bennet kept his nose in a book between bites of his hearty breakfast, doing his best to ignore it all.

Meanwhile, I wondered what was going on at Pride and Prejudice Park. Today, assuming time was the same wherever I was, they would reenact Jane's visit to Netherfield. I wondered who was playing Elizabeth. Was Fitz

still playing Mr. Darcy? He wouldn't do that if I was dead, would he? Of course he wouldn't. My demise would devastate him, that I knew.

Before I could think about it too much, a bell rang, bringing everyone to attention. I didn't know what it meant but pretended to be eager like everyone else. Within several seconds, Mrs. Hill entered, carrying a letter on a tray. "A letter for the elder Miss Bennets has arrived from Netherfield."

"Oh!" Mrs. Bennet fanned herself. "Jane and Lizzy, make haste and read it."

Mrs. Hill offered the letter to Jane.

With shaking hands, Jane lifted the neatly folded letter and broke the wax insignia.

Nerves coursed through me. This was totally going off script. If Lady Catherine were here now, she would be having a complete meltdown, and would no doubt blame me for all of it. I mean, I guess I was to blame, but it's not like I planned on being dropped into this story by some strange, unknown means. I was trying my best to embody the best version of Elizabeth under the circumstances.

Jane carefully unfolded the letter. As she read it, I caught glimpses of beautiful calligraphy strokes on the page. Oh gosh, I hoped I didn't have to write any letters soon. We hadn't gotten to any of the letter-writing classes at the park. I would worry about it later.

*We request the pleasure of Miss Jane Bennet and Miss Elizabeth Bennet at dinner tomorrow eve at seven o'clock at Netherfield Park.*

How mysterious. *Who is* we*?* I wondered while the table erupted in loud chatter. Mrs. Bennet jumped up like a spring chicken, not to say she was all that old—she couldn't have been much older than early forties. "Hill, Hill, you must help me get ready." No doubt she wanted to set off to Lucas Lodge, or perhaps to Mrs. Phillips, to tell them the news.

"Papa, may we have the carriage?" Jane asked.

I expected Mrs. Bennet to push us to go on horseback—there was always a decent chance for rain this time of year—but she said, "Of course you may," before Mr. Bennet had time to answer.

Mr. Bennet caught my attention, his lips pressed together as if thoughtfully contemplating this turn of events. "Lizzy, what do you make of this?"

Believe me, I was the last person to ask. "I do not know." For all I knew, only Miss Bingley and Mrs. Hurst would be our hostesses, but I had a

feeling that wasn't the case. Did Mr. Darcy truly wish to dine with me tomorrow? If so, did this make me the best Elizabeth ever, or the worst?

"Hmm. Well, of course, you must go," Mr. Bennet responded.

"Yes, of course they must," Mrs. Bennet screeched.

"Why were we not all invited?" Lydia complained.

"Because you are silly and ignorant, like most girls," Mr. Bennet stated.

Mrs. Bennet didn't correct him but ran off with Mrs. Hill, her bonnet flapping.

I stood, feeling as if I could do with a good walk to clear my head. Elizabeth was fond of walking, after all. As was I.

Mr. Bennet grabbed my hand as I moved past him. "Lizzy, what do you hide?"

Did he know I wasn't really his daughter? "Uh . . ." I didn't know what to say. I was hiding some pretty big secrets, like that magic might really exist, or that when you died, you went to *Pride and Prejudice* instead of heaven. Or maybe you just went into your favorite novel, whatever that was. Yikes, I felt sorry for the horror crowd, if that was the case. Could you imagine living in a Stephen King novel for eternity?

"What do you mean?" I stammered.

Mr. Bennet narrowed his eyes. "Only that you do not seem amused by the attention paid to you. Does that mean you hold some affection for this Mr. Darcy?" His tone indicated some concern, like a father who wasn't ready to let his daughter go.

How to answer that question? Truthfully, I did hold a lot of affection for Mr. Darcy. He was my first crush, and now for him to resemble the man I'd loved for almost half my life only endeared him to me more. "I hardly know him, Papa." That was true. You can only know someone so much from reading about them. "And who is to say that he will be there tomorrow when we dine at Netherfield?"

"Lizzy, you would be a fool to believe that, and you are no fool."

That was debatable. Ask the *Daily Mail*. "I will do my best not to be."

His brow furrowed. "I have seen no evidence to the contrary."

I smiled, more determined than ever to be the best Elizabeth.

He patted my hand. "Now there is a good girl. Be true to your heart, Lizzy." With that, he picked up his book and went back to ignoring the world around him.

It’s all I’d ever wanted to be—true to my heart. Or at least to act with my heart in the right place. I’d tried, I really had. Unfortunately, it always seemed to end in disaster. Then there was also the little matter that I’d actually hidden from the depths of my heart.

I really needed to walk now, to make sense of this all.

I put on a bonnet and slipped into a spencer jacket before heading out the door to who knows where. With my luck, I’d surely get lost. Or maybe not. I only made it a few yards from the house before I saw Charlotte Lucas walking up the gravel lane. She stopped and grabbed her side as if she had a stitch. I wondered how far she’d had to walk.

“Hello, Charlotte.” I waved.

“Lizzy,” she said brightly, her cheeks rosy from the cool air that was saturated with humidity. At least it wasn’t raining. “Where are you headed? Netherfield?” she teased.

“Uh, no.” I could only imagine the gossip at Lucas Lodge and in town. Mrs. Bennet was sure to add to it soon enough. “I was going for a walk in the . . .” I scanned the area quickly and pointed across the lane. “In the orchards.” The leaves were just turning to shades of yellow and orange.

She approached me and strung her arm through mine. “I will join you. We have much to talk about.”

As much as I wished to clear my head, this was probably a good thing, seeing as I had no idea where I was going. Maybe this way I could covertly ask how to walk to town or, you know, Netherfield, for when Jane fell ill there. That would still happen, right? I wanted those days to spend with Mr. Darcy, getting to know him better, and okay, maybe to vex Caroline Bingley, just a little. That desire was more because she looked like Lady Winnifred than because of her rudeness toward me, which I knew didn’t make any sense—but then, none of this did.

“Mr. Darcy honored you last night. You are the only lady he danced with.” She didn’t sound jealous, merely curious. I was sure it was odd that I’d received the attention. Nowhere in the book did it talk about Lizzy having any attachments prior to Mr. Darcy.

“It was unexpected.” Like the biggest shock of my life, right after who the mother turned out to be in *How I Met Your Mother*.

“Mr. Bingley’s sisters seemed much surprised by it. I overheard them saying that he had not meant to dance at all except with those in his party. Just as you surmised,” she added, but thankfully didn’t ask me to explain

how I had known. “Although he did not dance with either Miss Bingley or Mrs. Hurst. Curious, is it not?” She gave me a sly grin, obviously hoping for me to divulge my feelings on the matter.

I took a moment to respond, listening to the crunch of the rocks beneath our feet. The leather half boots I wore weren’t all that comfortable, and I had to walk with care. What I wouldn’t give for a little arch support. But how could I complain when I was at Longbourn? The picturesque countryside, with rolling hills dotted by a few cottages, was everything I’d imagined it would be. The gardens boasted roses and stems of hollyhocks that had probably bloomed with vibrant colors earlier in the year.

Hollyhocks covered Fitz’s estate every spring and summer. I loved how many hummingbird hawk-moths they attracted, and was probably overly giddy about it for Fitz’s taste, though he never complained about how often I extolled the magic of the graceful insects. I missed my best friend.

“That is odd. I wonder what changed his mind,” I responded, hoping to stave off the emotions swelling inside me regarding Fitz. It was weird to think that Charlotte would probably be my BFF here, emphasis on the *forever* part if I was D-E-A-D. Did that mean I should invite her over for tea and to embroider a pillow together?

“Oh, Lizzy, do not be so modest.”

“I assure you, it is not modesty.” The man was supposed to have snubbed me in a big, big way. “Although—” I grinned, feeling as if I should tell her the news of this morning before Lady Lucas did. “An invitation to dine at Netherfield tomorrow arrived at breakfast for Jane and me.”

Charlotte gasped. “Will the gentlemen be there?”

I nodded. “I believe so.”

“My advice to you, Lizzy, is to remember that in nine cases out of ten, a woman had better show *more* affection than she feels.” Was that her catchphrase? She’d said the same thing to Elizabeth regarding Jane.

I wanted to tell her that was terrible advice, but she went on to say, “Women must always help men on in these matters.”

I giggled, even though I didn’t mean to. Not to say men couldn’t be dense in matters of the heart, but women could be too. Look at me. My best friend had supposedly been pining for me for years, and I hadn’t had a clue. Then again, he had hidden it well.

Thankfully, Charlotte didn’t take offense. “Lizzy, I am being practical. Mr. Darcy is a man of fashion and wealth.”

“But we know nothing of his character yet,” I said smartly, even though I knew darn well that he was a man of noble character.

Charlotte leaned into me. “True, but as far as I can tell, happiness in marriage is entirely a matter of chance.”

It was no wonder that she ended up married to a man she obviously didn’t care for. I was familiar with her story, but to experience it all firsthand had me feeling very sorry for her, and for a moment I forgot to play along with the story. “Charlotte,” I said affectionately. “Happiness in marriage and life is a matter of choice.”

She blinked as if I were speaking a foreign language. “Our circumstances limit our choices, dear Lizzy,” she reminded me.

I could hear the heartbreak in her voice, which in turn broke my heart. I wanted to give her options, but how did I do that? There I went again, trying to fix things.

While we walked toward the orchard, I tried my best to avoid thinking of ways to find some single handsome men with excellent character whom I could introduce to Charlotte. But the fixer in me couldn’t help it. It was ridiculous, of course. Especially considering I didn’t really know anyone here. I wasn’t really Elizabeth Bennet, and Jane Austen would probably roll over in her grave if she could hear my thoughts.

“I do believe, though, that you will have a choice, Lizzy.” She pointed to a man trotting our way on a fine steed. And by man, I mean *the man*. What was it about a man on a horse in a cravat and coat? Oh, baby, come to Mama. *Do not say that out loud*, I reminded myself, but smiled because I totally would have said it out loud to Fitz. You know, if he hadn’t been a jerk. But back to reality, I mean my dream, or fantasy, or . . . my afterlife. What was Mr. Darcy doing here? We were way, way off script. I wanted to yell out that it wasn’t my fault this time.

Mr. Darcy edged his horse forward at a faster pace until he reached us. My heart leaped. Every time I was near him, it was like having a missing piece of myself returned to me.

Mr. Darcy lowered his head in a slight bow upon his arrival. “Miss Bennet, Miss Lucas.”

“Mr. Darcy,” I said so breathily, I sounded like a fangirl. Okay, I was a fangirl.

Charlotte nudged me in an *I told you so* sort of way.

“We are walking,” I said lamely, flustered by his presence. “I like to walk,” I added, because I liked to make things as awkward as humanly possible.

Mr. Darcy dismounted his horse in a swift, sexy move. “I wonder if I might join you.” He was all confidence—just like you-know-who.

Oh, heavens, yes. Thankfully, that didn’t come out of my mouth, but neither did any other words. I just stared at Fitz, I mean Mr. Darcy. A silly thought came to me—maybe if Mr. Darcy and I got this party started, he wouldn’t mind if I called him Fitz, since his name was Fitzwilliam. Probably best to save that one until after we were married, though. Oh gosh, would I really get to marry him? I was getting way ahead of myself.

Charlotte came in clutch and spoke for both of us. She really was my BFF here. “We would be delighted.”

“Yes,” I blurted inelegantly.

Mr. Darcy gave me a hint of a smile before leading his horse to a nearby apple tree. A few rotten apples clung to some of the branches.

Charlotte and I exchanged meaningful glances while Mr. Darcy tied his big black steed to the tree. I kind of wished she could skedaddle, but I thought of what Lady Catherine had said about the rules of this time period. It would be scandalous for Mr. Darcy and me to be alone together. *Scandalous but yummy,* I thought. *Stop thinking that way, Monroe. You are Elizabeth now.* When Lydia shockingly ran off with Wickham, Elizabeth had been beside herself with worry, believing the scandal would ruin her family. Speaking of which, I should probably try to prevent that unfortunate event. What would it say about my character if I didn’t? I would worry about that after I made a fool of myself in front of Mr. Darcy.

It didn’t take long for him to join us. When he did, Charlotte did the best thing under the circumstances and held back while Mr. Darcy and I set off to walk through the orchard. Fallen leaves and soft ground muted our footsteps. The air smelled faintly of decay and apple cider.

“Are you well after your fall?” Mr. Darcy asked, making sure not to walk too closely.

“Yes, I am well. Thank you once again for coming to my aid. And again, I apologize for anything untoward I may have said.”

“It is understandable.”

I’m glad someone understood it.

“I must inquire, though, how you came to know Alastair Fitzroy.”

Did he really need to inquire? But wait a second . . . “Do you know him?” What were the odds there was some guy running around in *Pride and Prejudice* with that name? Was he like an unnamed extra?

Mr. Darcy dipped his chin and looked down his nose at me with such severity, I shivered. Yep, I blew it. I knew I would.

“When you mistook me for him, I thought his name sounded familiar, and then remembered reading in the paper that the King had bestowed upon him the title of the Duke of Blackthorne.”

Crap! That’s right. Alastair had told me that one of the King Georges had given his ancestor and namesake the dukedom that Fitz inherited last year.

“I read it in the paper too,” I mumbled, like an idiot. What was I doing? Did Elizabeth Bennet read newspapers? I don’t remember that being mentioned in the book.

“You read the papers?”

I mean, if you counted online news sources, yes. It was important for me to stay up to date on world events and politics because Fitz loved to talk about those things, and I loved him. I hadn’t known how much I loved him until recently, but that was neither here nor there at the moment. Right now, I was screwing up the quintessential love story of all time—it was probably best to focus on that train wreck.

“Occasionally I do,” I stammered. “I feel it is important to stay current on local events and politics.” That was true in my real life, but schnikeys, what was I even saying? But did I stop there? Oh, no. “I just read about the new Duke of Blackthorne the other day and must have become confused after I fell off the horse.” That was it. Game over. Mr. Darcy would never speak to me again—I was the worst Elizabeth ever.

Mr. Darcy took a moment to study me with his broody, narrowed eyes, while Charlotte coughed in that *Danger, Will Robinson* sort of way. She probably thought I’d lost my mind too. It would be a miracle if I didn’t get sent to an asylum. I’d read my history—they weren’t good or helpful places during this time period.

My heart raced so hard, it made me feel lightheaded. But then . . . something unexpected happened.

Mr. Darcy smiled—the kind of smile that reached his eyes, the kind of smile that made you feel weak in the knees, like the way I felt now.

“Miss Bennet, it is rare to be acquainted with a woman who finds interest in matters outside of music, art, dancing, and fashion. You see, I value a keen mind overall.”

That wasn’t exactly romantic, but it was better than *“You’re insane.”*

“And you believe I have a keen mind?” I didn’t know what else to say. No man had ever paid me such a compliment.

“I do.” He smiled, and we walked on. “I was wondering if you have read *The Republic* by Plato and what your thoughts are on the allegory of the cave.”

It wasn’t exactly what I was expecting, but perhaps it was the start of a beautiful relationship.

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# TWENTY-ONE

***"He began to feel the danger of paying Elizabeth too much attention."***

## MONROE

"I AM SO NERVOUS." JANE fussed with her dress as we sat close to each other in the carriage. FYI, I think I'd over romanticized carriage rides. Whiplash, anyone? Not that I was complaining too loudly—hello, I was living out my fantasy. At least I thought I was living. The jury was still out on that one. And what a fantasy it has been so far. I'd spent two hours walking with Mr. Darcy yesterday, discussing not only the allegory of the cave, which seemed apropos considering the subject of our limited perception of reality—and did I ever feel my limited perception right now—but also speaking about his family. He was the most vocal about his sister, Georgiana. It was cute to see how proud he was of her. Of course, I knew from the novel that she was sixteen and an accomplished young woman, but what I hadn't expected was his concern regarding his role as a good guardian. He changed the subject quickly, though. I think it made him uncomfortable to expose any weakness, especially to someone he didn't know well.

I took Jane's hand. "You need not be nervous. It is plain to see that Mr. Bingley holds you in high regard, so be yourself." Yes, I did understand the hypocrisy in my words. But I was trying to be someone else for noble reasons. "There is no need for you to be shy about who you are. You are the kindest creature." She truly was; she was the peacemaker of the Bennet family, and she'd been sweet enough to brush my hair last night and let me ramble on about my time with Mr. Darcy.

I feared I was going way off script with that advice, but what was I supposed to say? *"You should be more reserved, Jane, so Mr. Bingley leaves you for months while you torture yourself about your feelings and his?"*

Perhaps I should have said nothing, but it seemed unfair, considering what was going on with Mr. Darcy and me. I mean, it wasn't all that exciting. Dang Regency rules. Mr. Darcy was all sorts of proper, and the whole chaperone thing was kind of a bummer—not to say anything would have happened. Don't get me wrong, though, I thoroughly enjoyed my time with him. And despite missing my non-horsehair toothbrush, running water, electricity, lattes, and everyone I cared about, I was having a great time. Okay, so I was a little homesick, but was I ever rocking this Elizabeth thing.

Mr. Darcy had even sent me a book this morning, *The History of Tom Jones, a Foundling*, along with a letter that read:

*Dear Miss Bennet,*

*I do hope you will enjoy the book. While it is a work of fiction, I believe the way Henry Fielding explores human nature might be of some interest to you. I look forward with anticipation to discussing his words with you.*

*Yours sincerely,*

*Fitzwilliam Darcy*

It wasn't as romantic as Fitz's letter, but I was freaking giddy about it. It's not every day a girl gets a letter from the real Mr. Darcy. Honestly, Fitz and Mr. Darcy were so similar, even with their taste in literature. I'd spent most of the day reading the book, which was very much like watching a soap opera. Poor Tom was not all that lucky in love, and I'm not sure Sophia truly deserved him, given she had only married him after he'd inherited money and land, but what did I know?

I knew that Fitz would have found a great deal of value in its study. The wit and satire were right up his alley—he was all about eighteenth century literature. As for me, I kept thinking someone should make it into a musical. Fitz would definitely roll his eyes about that. But I also thought about how Fitz would have seen the deeper meaning in the story, about how we place people in society based on birth, wealth, and education.

Strangely, *Pride and Prejudice* had many of the same themes. Mr. Darcy didn't even realize how much his own story had been a matter of modern-day study. It's the reason we end up loving him so much, because he overcame his pride and saw Elizabeth for who she was and not the circumstances in which she'd been born.

I'd always admired Fitz because he prided himself on the station he made for himself, not the one to which he was born. And I used to believe he looked at the individual, not the class in which society had placed them.

But maybe I'd been wrong. I feared now that during the entirety of our relationship he'd seen me as unequal to him, a stain on his reputation, even.

Jane patted my hand. "I am so happy you are with me, Lizzy. With you by my side, I feel less intimidated."

"Do you speak of being intimidated by Mr. Bingley or his sisters?"

"His sisters," she mumbled, embarrassed. "They are so accomplished. And do you see how beautifully they dress? People say Miss Bingley plays and sings like an angel. I surely do not play half so well. What if they ask me to perform?"

I didn't know who these people were that Jane spoke of, but I highly doubted Miss Bingley was anywhere close to an angel. I kept that snarky thought to myself, though. "Jane, you are just as accomplished as Miss Bingley. You are just too modest. But if it makes you feel better, we can perform a duet if our guests ask you to play this evening."

Jane threw her arms around me. "Oh, Lizzy, thank you. Perhaps we could perform 'The Battle of Prague,' the song you helped Mary with yesterday."

Yep, I'd gone down that rabbit hole. However, it was more due to my role as a voice and piano instructor and the evident lack of proper instruction Mary had received. I had a sneaking suspicion Mrs. Bennet liked her even less than she liked me. Although now that I had Mr. Darcy's attention, I was becoming one of her favorites. She'd been the happiest woman in the world yesterday after she'd returned from Lucas Lodge.

"I would love to," I responded.

"You have been practicing much, Lizzy. I think you are now the finest player among us."

I gave her an uncomfortable smile.

For the rest of our ride we talked about the number of courses they might serve at Netherfield and whether it would rain before we returned home.

I looked eagerly out of the carriage window as we drove down the long gravel drive lined with majestic trees, readying us for the grandeur awaiting as we approached the house at Netherfield Park. It felt like I was entering a magical realm, like how I felt when Fitz and I had arrived at Pride and Prejudice Park. This time I wasn't waving out the window at the footmen, even though I kind of wanted to. They looked so cute just standing there, probably freezing, waiting to help us out of the carriage. But I remembered

how quiet Fitz had been in that moment. Had I embarrassed him? Was I an embarrassment?

The carriage came to a stop, and a footman opened our door to reveal a Georgian-style mansion with large sash windows and a grand entrance with a portico supported by columns. It was everything I'd imagined it would be. For all I knew, I *was* imagining it. If so, my brain cells deserved all the props. Now if only they could imagine me a hot shower.

Jane and I exited the carriage with the help of the footman. I was really hoping for Mr. Darcy. I needed a hand-flex scene in my life. And you had better believe I would take my gloves off for that. No hand flexing happened, but our hosts and hostesses greeted us in the spacious entrance hall that glowed with hundreds of candles. The candlelight made the house seem much cozier than grand. Grand it was, though, with a sweeping staircase and artwork framed in genuine gold. I wished I had my phone so I could take a picture.

But the grandest sight of all was Mr. Darcy, who seemed to be eagerly awaiting my arrival, judging by the way his eyes gave me a good once-over. That's right, Mr. Darcy was checking me out in my pretty pink dress that definitely made the girls stand out. Unfortunately, Miss Bingley had stationed herself next to him and was shooting deadly daggers at me with her eyes. She was such a Winnifred, meaning she was as gorgeous as could be, even if she had feathers sticking out of her hair. To each their own—I went with pearls.

Mr. Bingley bounced on the balls of his feet, enamored with Jane. "Welcome, welcome," he said cheerily as Jane and I handed our shawls to the butler.

Jane and I curtsied and then said in unison, like we were the Doublemint Twins, "Thank you for the kind invitation."

"Your home is beautiful," I commented.

"Yes, yes," Mr. Bingley said enthusiastically. "I credit Caroline for that."

Miss Bingley sneered at me.

"You have excellent taste, Miss Bingley," I complimented her, knowing she probably wouldn't love it.

And she didn't, judging by her pinched expression, although she replied, "You are all kindness."

“Shall we proceed to the dining room?” Mr. Bingley asked while offering his arm to Jane.

Miss Bingley immediately seized upon Mr. Darcy’s arm. Mr. Hurst escorted Mrs. Hurst. I’d always imagined Mr. Hurst as being quite a bit older than his wife, but in this place, they seemed to be only a few years apart if that. The book never states their ages. Maybe the movies had steered us wrong.

Mr. Darcy stiffened when Miss Bingley took hold of him, but he lingered back, waiting for me. “I do hope your journey was comfortable this evening,” he asked.

The carriage could do with some shocks, but I didn’t mention it. “It was. Thank you.”

“The roads here leave much to be desired,” Miss Bingley complained. She wasn’t wrong, but it was rude of her to say.

“I love the country,” Mr. Bingley said as he gazed at Jane. I liked him.

Jane blushed and smiled. They were adorbs.

Netherfield’s dining room was more like a hall and much grander than the Bennets’. It had high ceilings and velvet curtains, with a long table of fine mahogany in the middle of the room that could seat probably twenty people. Fine china dishes and silver cutlery adorned one end of the table and gleamed in the candlelight. The aroma of consommé lingered in the air—I assumed it would be the first course.

As a myriad of servants pulled out the elegant high-backed chairs with upholstered seats, Mr. Darcy shook off Miss Bingley and directed me to take the seat next to him. He sat closest to Mr. Bingley, who was at the head of the table. Jane sat on the other side of him. She cast me a furtive smile.

Miss Bingley took my other side, and her icy stare made the room feel like a walk-in freezer.

But I did as I probably should have done in real life—I ignored her. I knew I couldn’t outwit her, and in the end, if everything went according to the story, I would end up with Mr. Darcy. Her opinion didn’t matter. I should have remembered that in my real life.

“Mr. Darcy, thank you for the book. It gave me many hours of pleasure today.”

“I am glad. I feared you might have read it before.”

“I had not.” At least I didn’t think I had.

The servants glided between us, dishing up the first course. It surprised me how quietly they served, moving as if choreographed.

"What did you think of the tale, Miss Bennet?" Mr. Darcy was eager to know.

I watched to see which spoon I should use before I answered. I'd never been good with etiquette, and there was no Fitz to whisper in my ear to guide me. However, I did feel in some part as if he were helping me in this strange situation. He was the one who had taught me how to truly love literature and to look for the deeper meaning behind the words. All I'd given him in return was a love for Olivia Newton-John in *Grease*. I guess that made us even.

"I found Tom's struggle with his natural impulses, and his desire to lead a more virtuous life, fascinating. As humans, I believe we must all conquer certain natural tendencies."

"And what are some of your natural tendencies?" Mr. Darcy asked.

I felt as if this were one of those questions that was fraught with peril—there was nothing casual about it. Mr. Darcy wanted to understand me, and I knew if my answer wasn't to his liking, he would probably move on.

I clung to the napkin on my lap and thought, *WWED?* What would Elizabeth do? She would tell the truth because she wouldn't want to be with anyone who didn't love her for herself. I found myself in a precarious situation because I, too, wanted to be loved for myself. So whose truth did I tell? It had to be the only one I could—my own.

I swallowed hard before I said, "I have a tendency to try to fix situations I think are broken, even if my efforts cannot really help, or even knowing my interference might make the problem worse." I twisted the napkin even more, waiting for his response.

Mr. Darcy took his good, sweet time responding, while his gray eyes bored a hole in me. What did he see?

"Miss Bennet," he crooned ever so sexily, sounding almost as alluring as Fitz. "If we all had such natural tendencies, I believe the world would be a better place."

That was it. With those words, Mr. Darcy captured a little piece of my heart that belonged to Fitz.

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# TWENTY-TWO

***"We all love to instruct, though we can teach only what is not worth knowing."***

## MONROE

WHO WAS THE BEST ELIZABETH Bennet, you may ask? Me. That's right, baby. I don't know what happened, but in this place, I could finally help people. Like, really help them. Case in point—Mary was beautifully playing and singing Handel's "Lascia ch'io pianga" for a large group at Lucas Lodge just a week after my arrival. At least I think it had been a week. I felt like time did weird things in whatever this place was. It made me worry that I'd irrevocably altered the story and timeline somehow without meaning to. So maybe I wasn't the best Elizabeth, but to see Mary master the difficult musical piece was so gratifying, especially because her confidence had so obviously grown. We'd worked tirelessly on it every spare moment we could. You know, between me dining at Netherfield a few more times with Jane and taking walks with Mr. Darcy, Jane, and Mr. Bingley. The etiquette rules of the day really were a bummer and allowed for zero alone time.

I'd found in my life that you really get to know someone in private times. And I don't mean that in a physical sort of way. Obviously, I knew Fitz better than anyone, or at least I thought I had, and our relationship had never been physical until that kiss. Oh, that kiss. I tried to forget about it, but I couldn't. It was the kiss of a lifetime, one where you saw your past, present, and future all rolled up in one beautiful package. Now I wasn't sure I even had a future. Anyway, I digress. By private times, I meant when you are most vulnerable, saying things from your heart that you don't want shared except with the person to whom your heart is becoming attached.

Because you want that person to understand you wholly, even if it scares you.

Not to say Mr. Darcy was becoming attached to me. I only knew he thought I had a keen mind, and he enjoyed discussing books and current events, which meant I was reading like crazy. So maybe he was falling for my brain, which wasn't necessarily a bad thing. Especially given that I could really do with a good moisturizer here. Now I think I knew what they meant by losing one's bloom. It was just a lack of lotion. Jane had tried to get me to use alum water, but I'd had to explain that, given its chemical properties, it was going to cause premature wrinkles. She'd stared at me like I was a stranger. She had no idea how odd I was. That being said, I could possibly shrivel up here, so it would be a good thing for Mr. Darcy to love me for my mind and not my looks.

I looked to my left where Mr. Darcy sat close, but not too close, on a stiff-backed chair in the warm and inviting drawing room. The Lucas family had obviously taken great care to make their home comfortable for guests, with plentiful seating and a large fireplace to keep the room heated. Sir Lucas always seemed to smile or offer some refreshments to his guests.

Mr. Darcy must have felt my eyes on him, for he turned his head and offered me a muted smile. I had a feeling this wasn't really his thing, not that I blamed him. Mrs. Bennet and Mrs. Phillips sat across the room from us, and even above Mary's beautiful number, you could hear them indelicately conjecturing about the prospect of Jane and me making good matches. It was cringey to say the least, going far above and beyond the dad jokes my dad loved to tell my dates. Maybe I should have said something to Mrs. Bennet to encourage her to be more discreet. After all, I was becoming one of her favorites, so perhaps she would listen to me.

I wanted so badly to pat Mr. Darcy's leg or take his hand to let him know I wished I could ease his discomfort. Or, you know, give him a flick of my head that said, *Let's get out of here and talk or, better yet, kiss.* If Cher had taught me anything, it was this—if you want to know how he feels about you, it's in his kiss. But that dang Regency propriety was a killjoy.

What was not a killjoy was how cute Mr. Bingley and Jane were. They stood next to each other not far from the pianoforte. I swear I could see their fingers almost touch as they held their hands at their sides. I had a theory about Jane. Although her tendency was to be more on the reserved side, I believed Miss Bingley intimidated her so much in the story that she

couldn’t be herself around Mr. Bingley. But with me around, not only did Jane get to spend more time with Mr. Bingley without his sister, but I made sure to keep dear Miss Bingley in check by drawing the attention away from her and back to Jane. Jane and I had even performed a few duets while dining at Netherfield. And oh, Miss Bingley detested me for it. In fact, I was worried she would plot her revenge.

As soon as Mary finished and before anyone could clap, Lydia jumped up and said, “Mary, play something we can dance to.”

Mr. Darcy groaned, and I laughed. “I hope you do not think that I wish to dance.” Not that I wouldn’t dance with him, but I was beginning to understand what a private person he was. Much like my Fitz.

Mr. Darcy looked most relieved, but there was always the hint of a question about me in his eyes. I wasn’t sure what it meant.

“We could play cards.” I suggested, not knowing if that was proper or not.

“Miss Bennet, you are most unusual,” he said above the noise of the lively tune and the excitement of couples standing up to dance.

His comment took me aback. “I do hope you mean that as a compliment, sir,” I couldn’t help but say.

“I believe so, madam,” he said, his tone bordering between seriousness and playfulness.

Huh. This was good. Right? Well . . . it was, until Miss Bingley materialized in front of us, seemingly out of thin air.

“Miss Eliza, I wonder if I might have a word with you?”

“Yes.” I sat there waiting for her to speak, knowing darn well whatever she wanted to say, she didn’t wish it to be in front of Mr. Darcy.

“In private,” she said through a strained smile, doing her best to look well in front of Mr. Darcy. “Perhaps we could take a turn about the room.”

“Of course.” I stood, playing along because I’d always wanted to take a turn about a room. But before I walked off, I made sure to smile at Mr. Darcy. “Promise me you will not start the games without me.”

Miss Bingley tchted so well.

Mr. Darcy’s eyes widened. I’d caught him off guard again, yet he replied, “You have my word.”

Mostly satisfied and maybe even a little woozy from my exchange with Mr. Darcy, I followed Miss Bingley’s lead and began our turn about the merry room with some trepidation. I wasn’t as witty as Elizabeth, and I

knew this woman could wreck me. I did have to give her props, though, for how gracefully she sashayed. Maybe I should try to walk more elegantly.

As soon as she felt comfortable that we were out of Mr. Darcy's earshot, Miss Bingley strung her arm through mine and pulled me closer. She narrowed her eyes and clenched her jaw so tightly, I thought it might break as she began to speak. "Miss Bennet, as a friend, I wish to offer you a word of caution," she hissed.

Friend? How laughable. "What is that, Miss Bingley?"

"You should know that Mr. Darcy is destined to marry Miss Anne de Bourgh of Rosings Park, daughter of Lady Catherine de Bourgh."

Tell me something I didn't know. "And how did you come to learn this?" Miss Bingley never mentioned this in the novel, and I can't imagine her keeping it to herself if she'd had knowledge of it. Which meant I'd done something to further alter the story. What had I done? Sorry, Jane Austen. Also, was Agatha going to pop up in this place as Lady Catherine? Could I put in a request for that not to happen?

"I am well connected," Miss Bingley gloated.

"I appreciate your concern, but I wonder why you feel the need to give me such a warning." Of course, I had an inkling, but I needed to know if Mr. Darcy was indeed starting to develop feelings for me. I had to preserve that part of the story—he was all I had of Fitz. Plus, you know, it was one of the greatest loves of all time. The world was counting on me.

She stepped closer to me, appraising me with a sneer. "As unconnected as you are, I know you are not a simpleton. The attention Mr. Darcy pays you and the way he speaks of your fine eyes might give one an inflated opinion of her worth," she spat, although her voice trembled, unable to finish her thought.

"He thinks I have fine eyes?" I grinned. I'd hoped he had, but Elizabeth never hears that firsthand in the book.

"This is not a game, Miss Eliza. I would not trifle with Lady Catherine de Bourgh if I were you."

Oh, but Elizabeth was meant to trifle with Lady Catherine. Only one question remained: Was I a strong enough Elizabeth to emerge the victor? I needed to write down everything I could remember of how Elizabeth had taken her down in their epic tête-à-tête.

"Are you saying that Mr. Darcy is not a man of integrity?"

Miss Bingley's jaw dropped, appalled. "How dare you misconstrue my words."

A rush of Elizabeth swept through me. "Did I, Miss Bingley? If Mr. Darcy," I whispered, "is to be engaged to another woman, and if he is a man of integrity, there would be no need to warn me." Game, set, match. Or at least I thought.

Miss Bingley gripped my arm ever tighter. "I do not doubt Mr. Darcy's integrity. It is yours I question."

"Mine?"

"Yes, Miss Eliza. You do not think I notice your cunning ways?"

"Cunning ways?" Was she serious?

Her severe look said she was dead serious. "It is apparent that not only do you mean to orchestrate a match above your station for yourself, but for your sister as well. Your efforts to secure a husband for your friend Miss Lucas only further expose your scheming nature."

I craned my head to watch Charlotte dance with Mr. Rutledge, one of the men who had asked me to dance at the Meryton assembly. I'd learned that Mr. Rutledge's father owned the most successful mercantile shop in town, and as the eldest son, he helped run it. While Charlotte smiled and danced with enthusiasm, he glanced frequently at Mary at the pianoforte. That was unfortunate. I'd been hoping that Charlotte and he might hit it off. I admit that earlier in the evening, I'd mentioned to Mr. Rutledge that Charlotte was interested in knowing more about the mercantile shop—a day-in-and-day-out take. He'd seemed most pleased about it and had started chatting her up. Had Miss Bingley noticed that? I'd thought I'd been discreet.

Regardless, I was only trying to help a friend who believed she was over the hill at twenty-seven—which was crazy, since I was two years older than that in real life. Granted, life expectancies were a lot different here, as were societal norms. And let's not forget these women weren't properly moisturizing. They were all bound to shrivel up early.

"My only intent, Miss Bingley, is to be a good sister and friend." And, you know, to avoid totally ruining this story.

"Yes, I see what a dutiful sister you are, always putting dear Jane in the spotlight and even your sister, Mary. And you with your books and insights, it is almost as if you had someone spy on Mr. Darcy to learn all about him."

She wasn’t exactly wrong; I had the manual, so to speak, and Fitz. Oh, Fitz. Where was he when I needed him?

“Spy?” I laughed nervously as we walked slowly around the room, which had suddenly become stuffy. “What an imagination you have. Has it ever occurred to you that perhaps Mr. Darcy and I have many things in common?”

It was her turn to laugh. “Miss Eliza, you lack connections and accomplishments. Those are the things that matter most.”

I knew she was only jealous and it would be best if I held my tongue. Instead of levelheadedly walking away, I stopped and directed my gaze toward Mr. Darcy, who was staring at us with interest, and added more fuel to Miss Bingley’s fire. “Or perhaps he cares more about my figure.”

“Shocking girl,” Miss Bingley scolded me. “I have never heard anything so abominable.”

No doubt Mr. Darcy hadn’t either, but I bet he was going to.

I was the worst Elizabeth ever.

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# TWENTY-THREE

***"Follies and nonsense, whims and inconsistencies, do divert me."***

## MONROE

THE NEXT MORNING SAW A lot of excitement at the breakfast table, which seemed to be a common occurrence here. Not only had Mr. Bingley promised the night before to throw a ball at Netherfield, but the regiment was arriving in Meryton, and last but certainly not least, a letter arrived from Hunsford. A letter from Hunsford could only mean one thing: Mr. Collins was soon to appear. The timing of this seemed suspicious to me, in light of my conversation with Miss Bingley last night. But the timing of everything had been thrown off since my arrival. Maybe I really had gotten sucked into some space-time continuum thing and we were doing the *Without Pride and Prejudice* version. Except, I had let my pride get the better of me last night, and I might have been prejudiced against elegant and accomplished women.

I wasn't sure if I'd ruined my chances with Mr. Darcy last night. He wasn't a very talkative guy, and I didn't know how much pull Miss Bingley had with him. All I knew for sure was that he was an excellent whist player. Honestly, I was waiting for a letter any moment now to inform me that Mr. Darcy was returning to London, or something of the sort.

Breaking into my thoughts, Mr. Bennet announced to the room at large, "This letter from Hunsford is from the man who can turn you all out once I am dead."

Mrs. Bennet choked on the tea she was sipping, making her splutter. She dabbed her dress with a napkin, trying to remove any liquid. "Mr. Bennet, what a thing to say. Although"—she smiled at Jane and me, who sat across the table from her—"we might not be in such poor circumstances even if you died."

And who said love is dead?

Mr. Bennet didn't skip a beat. "Well, my dear, since you do not care whether I live or die, I dare say you shall not care if the heir to Longbourn, Mr. William Collins, arrives tomorrow and trespasses for a fortnight upon our hospitality."

Mrs. Bennet sat up in a dignified manner. "I most certainly do care. What is the meaning of this? Does he wish to lord it over us? I hate false friends."

"False friends indeed." Mr. Bennet held up the letter and prepared to read it.

As he began, however, something stirred uneasily in my belly. Miss Bingley knowing about the supposed attachment between Anne de Bourgh and Mr. Darcy wasn't kosher if you asked me.

*Dear sir,*

*I have been so fortunate as to be distinguished by the patronage of the Right Honorable Lady Catherine de Bourgh, widow of Sir Lewis de Bourgh, whose bounty and beneficence has preferred me to the valuable rectory of this parish, where it shall be my earnest endeavor to demean myself with grateful respect towards her Ladyship, and be ever ready to perform those rites and ceremonies which are instituted by the Church of England. To this end, dear sir, it is Lady Catherine de Bourgh's wish that I wait upon you and your family.*

I hardly heard anything that followed that telling last line. My belly swirled even more. I had no doubt that Lady Catherine was sending him to check out the situation. Seriously, what had I done? I had to try to fix it somehow—but how?

As soon as Mr. Bennet concluded, he looked over the letter at me. "What do you make of this, Lizzy?"

Why was he asking me? I tried to construe an answer based on what I knew from the book, as I hadn't exactly paid attention to the entire letter. "Well . . . it appears that this Lady Catherine de Bourgh knows of the rift between Mr. Collins's father and you, and she believes Mr. Collins should extend an olive branch, considering the entail. But because of the potential inheritance, perhaps she seems to think, in the name of family unity, that it is best that he pick a bride from among us." I sounded much smarter than I felt.

"Right you are, Lizzy." Mr. Bennet beamed.

While I appreciated the compliment, I was undeserving of it, considering it was just a good guess on my part, and I had a sneaking suspicion that there was much more to the story. In the novel, Mr. Collins came of his own volition, not at the urging of Lady Catherine.

"A clergyman?" Lydia wrinkled her nose. "I would never marry a clergyman. How boring." The girl could do with some boredom in her life—or a puppy. I would look into getting her a pet. Maybe if she had something cute and cuddly to play with, she would forget about the regiment coming into town and would never cross paths with Mr. Wickham. I had to worry about that now too. *Please, please, don't let him look like Tony.*

I glanced at Mary, who had a dreamy look in her eye. Apparently, her thoughts about clergymen mirrored mine about Theo James. I'd always thought that Mary and Mr. Collins should end up together. But was I just ruining everything further? Or was I making it better? If only I could find someone worthy of Charlotte. Ugh, look at me—I couldn't go an hour without trying to fix something. But I was in so deep now, I wasn't sure there was any turning back.

"No matter his reasoning, you had better order a good dinner tomorrow night, Mrs. Bennet," Mr. Bennet directed.

Mrs. Bennet's eyes lit up. "I will order at least three courses and invite the gentlemen at Netherfield to join us."

Oh, no, no, no, this was the worst idea ever. Mr. Collins and Mr. Darcy at dinner together was a disaster in the making. My disaster. My making.

"Mama," Jane sounded as alarmed as I felt about that idea. "I do not know if that is wise. We do not know this Mr. Collins." Jane, you smart, smart, woman.

"Or his benefactress," I added. "Should we not wait until we know their designs?"

"Designs?" Mrs. Bennet laughed. "What does this Lady Catherine have to do with us? We will show this Mr. Collins what good company we keep here at Longbourn."

My eyes pleaded with Mr. Bennet to put a stop to this nonsense, but he just shook his head. I couldn't tell if he liked the idea or if he just didn't wish to argue with Mrs. Bennet. Maybe some of both.

"The gentlemen may have other plans," I whispered to Jane. Plans like Mr. Darcy never speaking to me again. If that were the case, did this place I

was in cease to exist? What happened to me in that scenario? Did all rejected Elizabeths go to hell or get booted off *Fantasy Island*?

"We can hope," she whispered back.

That was wishful thinking. To add to the excitement, the bell rang, signaling someone was at the door.

It only took a few moments before Mrs. Hill came in and curtsied. "Mr. Darcy and Mr. Bingley have come to call on the elder Miss Bennets. They are waiting in the drawing room."

Before either Jane or I could say a word, Mrs. Bennet was off to the races, likely to make a fool of herself. I really needed to ask Mr. Bennet how they met and fell in love, assuming they'd been in love. Right now, I had another love story to worry about. I hoped Mr. Darcy's appearance this morning was a good sign—he'd said nothing the night before about calling on me. I really missed my phone and texting. It would have been nice to have a heads-up. Like, *Hey, babe, I'll pick you up in my carriage at ten sharp tomorrow morning. I'll bring the chaperone this time. PS: Don't forget your gloves.*

With as much decorum as we could muster, Jane and I stood and hustled toward the drawing room, following Lydia and Kitty, who were madly giggling.

"I am going to ask Mr. Bingley if he has decided on a date for the ball," Lydia bragged to Kitty.

"Please, do not," I begged.

They paid me zero attention.

I smoothed out my baby-blue dress, praying there was nothing in my teeth, before I entered the drawing room to find Mr. Darcy and Mr. Bingley standing by the fireplace, being accosted by *dear* Mama.

"You must dine with us tomorrow night. You will be our special guests." She failed to mention they wouldn't be the only guests.

Mr. Darcy stood sexily stoic, not saying a word. The breeches were really starting to grow on me. And that cravat was such a turn-on. But they had nothing on his gray eyes, which darted my way. In them I saw the same question from last night. I wasn't sure what he was asking or what answer he wanted to receive, but one thing I knew: he didn't appreciate Mrs. Bennet. I really needed to talk to her.

Mr. Bingley was as amiable as ever, smiling and bouncing on the balls of his feet. "We would be delighted to dine with you." He gave Jane googly

eyes. The man was smitten.

Mr. Darcy, on the other hand, did not look delighted. I think what he wished for was an escape route.

I would be happy to provide one. You know me; I love to fix things. “I need to walk to town for some ribbon for my hat.” Never thought I would say those words. Did I even have any pocket money?

“May I accompany you, Miss Bennet?” Mr. Darcy asked stiffly.

“It would be a pleasure.”

“We want to go to town too,” Kitty proclaimed.

Then Lydia, being Lydia, rounded on Mr. Bingley. “You promised us a ball last night. I think you should have it next week and invite all the officers.”

I gave Mr. Darcy an apologetic smile. Being an only child, I’d never experienced younger siblings’ antics, as my mother died when I was five and my father never remarried. I’d always felt like I’d missed out on something, but Dad loved my mother so much that he would never consider remarrying. I needed to find a man like that. Was Mr. Darcy such a man?

“What a splendid idea,” Mrs. Bennet heartily agreed with Lydia.

Mr. Bingley was obviously a people pleaser, or maybe he thought he was being a Jane pleaser. Wait—that sounded a little kinky, and let me just say there was nothing of that sort going on in this story. I was still waiting for Mr. Darcy to let me touch him without my gloves. Anyway, Mr. Bingley agreed to having the ball the next week, which was way too soon. I didn’t even know how it was possible to plan a ball so quickly. It was apparent I’d totally wrecked the timeline of the story. It was almost going as fast as the timeline at Pride and Prejudice Park, but I had gone way off script here.

I had this sinking feeling that I was running out of time to prove I was a good Elizabeth.

I did my best to get us out of the house as quickly as I could, with my reticule in hand. Thankfully, there was money in the satin bag embroidered with my initials—I mean Elizabeth’s initials. In all honesty, I missed people calling me Monroe. Where was Monroe? I mean me. The thought hurt my head and heart.

Purposely, I let my sisters and Mr. Bingley walk ahead of us in the cool morning. I needed to speak privately with Mr. Darcy. To the sounds of the rocks crunching beneath our feet and the tittering of Lydia and Kitty, I did something daring. I felt like desperate times called for desperate measures.

Without being invited, I strung my arm through Mr. Darcy's, hoping to feel connected to him and praying he would, in turn, feel the same connection. He had no idea what was on the line. Believe me, I knew it was too early to define the relationship, but something needed to be defined. It was imperative I at least know I had a shot to fulfill my role as Elizabeth. And there was no Elizabeth in the story without him.

Shocked, Mr. Darcy immediately stiffened.

Who knew something so innocent would make me feel like such a vixen? "Mr. Darcy, I apologize for being so forward." And such an idiot. *Read the room, Monroe*. I loosened my hold on him, feeling like an idiot. But something wonderful happened. He reached over and placed his hand over mine on his bicep, holding it steady. The warmth of his hand seeped through my glove, sending a zing through me.

"Miss Bennet, you . . ."

"Yes?" I said, anticipating something beautiful and reaffirming coming out of his mouth.

"You have bewitched me." He didn't sound like it was necessarily a good thing. He should have said I bewitched him, body and soul, which was much more romantic.

I made it more awkward when I said, "I am trying my best." What was wrong with me? I laughed when he didn't respond other than to appear alarmed, judging by how deeply he cleared his throat.

"What I mean to say is, I do not like the silly games that men and women sometimes play. I feel it best to be honest." You know, unless you are in love with your best friend and too afraid to confront it. That is a totally different situation. "And in the name of honesty, I must know if you are engaged to Miss Anne de Bourgh." Yep, I said it. Caroline Bingley had me rattled, as did Mr. Collins's impending arrival. For all I knew, I'd messed things up so much that Mr. Darcy was indeed engaged.

Mr. Darcy halted, his brows knitted just like Fitz's when he was angry. "How do you know of Anne?"

Uh, Anne? Did that mean he was engaged to her?

"Miss Bingley informed me of the situation last night as we took a turn around the room." Yes, I threw that dear under the bus. "She said you were to be engaged to Anne."

"She is mistaken," he said succinctly.

I smiled, though he still looked quite cross. “Then you should know that my cousin, Mr. Collins, arrives tomorrow. His benefactress is Lady Catherine de Bourgh, and, per his letter, he comes here on her errand.”

Mr. Darcy’s face turned a deep shade of red. “I wonder with whom my aunt corresponds here?”

I wanted to raise my hand and say, *“Pick me, I know,”* but I was pretty sure it was a rhetorical question. He had to know it was Miss Bingley or someone in their party. “I did not mean to upset you.”

“It is not you who upsets me.”

Ooh, this could be good. Was he going to let Miss Bingley have it? Maybe get her kicked out of Netherfield? Could I be that good of an Elizabeth? “I am glad to know.” I squeezed his arm, and we walked on.

Mr. Darcy seemed lost in his thoughts as I admired my handiwork. Jane and Mr. Bingley walked ahead of us, chatting animatedly. He’d even offered her his arm. If he didn’t make an offer of marriage soon, it would shock me.

I tried to think of something amusing to say to Mr. Darcy. Most of our conversations usually delved into deeper subjects. The only thing I could think of was, “Do you prefer cats or dogs?”

Mr. Darcy actually chuckled. “You always surprise me, Miss Bennet.”

I hoped that was a good thing, but I was too nervous to ask, seeing as I’d already pushed the envelope. “You did not answer my question.”

“I keep hunting dogs, but my sister Georgiana has a pet cat.”

“I like her already. I have a cat. Or I used to.” My voice hitched. I missed my little Mr. Darcy. He was the best kitty in the world.

“What happened to your cat?”

What could I say? I’d left him behind on earth or in another dimension? “Sadly, I do not know.”

Mr. Darcy patted my hand. “I am sorry for your loss.”

“Thank you.” This was getting weird, especially considering I’d named my cat after him.

“Miss Bennet,” Mr. Darcy said in a rush. “May I have the honor of introducing you to my sister?”

Yes! Yes! Yes! I’d struck gold. “I would be delighted to meet her.”

Mr. Darcy flashed me a rare smile—a Fitz smile, the smile he reserved just for me.

I had to suppress my ache for Fitz. Someday I was going to need therapy over this—my book boyfriend come to life, looking like my best friend and the man I loved. It was really trippy.

"You have much in common with her. She plays and sings almost as well as you."

"You think I play and sing well?"

"I have never met your equal."

That was romantic, right?

"Thank you, Mr. Darcy." I blushed.

"You are most welcome, Miss Bennet."

Just when I was feeling confident, we rounded the last bend and saw Meryton ahead. The market square was bustling with people entering and exiting shops, carrying packages. Groups of people gathered, sharing the news of the day. There was a certain charm and quaintness to it. I loved the well-worn cobblestone streets and the symmetrical facades of the shops with large windows to display goods.

"Oh, look! Some of the officers from the regiment have arrived," Lydia called.

I cringed and prayed Mr. Wickham wasn't among them. "She really needs a puppy," I lamented.

Mr. Darcy didn't laugh like I'd hoped he would. He was probably thinking she wouldn't make a good sister-in-law. He wasn't wrong.

"Lydia, Kitty, do not run off," Jane called after them in vain. She turned and gave me a pained expression.

"Headstrong girls," I said, for my pleasure. No one else found it as comical as I did in my mind. "Shall we head to the milliner's shop?" I suggested. I hoped someone knew where that was, because I had no idea.

Thankfully, Jane pointed us in the right direction. Unfortunately, it put us in the path of Mr. Wickham. And dang it, he totally looked like Tony. There he was among several officers, decked out in his bright-red regiment coat, complete with gold buttons. Even in this time period, he was handsome. Not that I was attracted to him, but it was no wonder he'd caught Elizabeth's eye, especially considering the ease with which he conversed with his fellow officers. It was all very mind-bending. Seriously, I needed a therapist to sort all this out.

"Wickham," Darcy seethed under his breath while Mr. Bingley gave his friend a knowing look.

“Who is Wickham?” I asked, as if I didn’t know.

“You need not worry about him,” Mr. Darcy said, which was disappointing. I’d hoped he would confide in me—not only because it meant he trusted me, but because it would make it a lot easier to explain to my family why we all needed to stay away from the rogue.

Because Mr. Darcy was wrong about one thing: I needed to worry about Wickham.

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# TWENTY-FOUR

***"I can assure the young ladies that I come prepared to admire them."***

## MONROE

THANKFULLY, I DIDN'T HAVE TO worry about Mr. Wickham just yet. Or maybe at all. After he caught sight of Mr. Darcy yesterday, he'd done his best to avoid us. But just to be safe, I had adamantly warned the entire Bennet household that if we wished to keep Mr. Darcy's company, we were all to stay away from Mr. Wickham. With that warning, Mrs. Bennet was totally on board. She would do nothing to interfere with a daughter marrying a man with ten thousand a year. I didn't even know what that equated to in my day, not that I really cared. I'd never been that interested in money, seeing as I had never had much.

Lydia and Kitty had pressed me for details as to why they needed to stay away from Mr. Wickham, whom they of course found handsome, but I refused to say, other than that Mr. Darcy didn't care for him. And Jane had heard from Mr. Bingley that there had been a falling-out, so that cemented it for Mama. It just went to prove that without pride and prejudice, it was easier to avert a huge crisis. Maybe I was rocking this gig after all. Although, no one would ever know how much I'd saved the family.

Today's biggest worry centered around preparations for the arrival of Mr. Collins and our dinner guests. Mrs. Bennet had instructed us to wear our finest dresses, and she'd been barking orders at poor Mrs. Hill all day. One thing I'd always admired about Fitz was how he'd treated his staff as his equals. Never did he bark orders—in fact, I think most of them would donate a kidney if he needed one. I'd actually tried to help the Longbourn staff tidy up the house today, but Mrs. Bennet wouldn't hear of it. She hadn't liked it at all when I'd taken Mary into the kitchen to help her make a potato soufflé for Mr. Collins. I thought it might make an impression in

the event he really does like potatoes. There's no actual text evidence of his affinity for spuds, because the line, "It is many years since I had such an exemplary vegetable," was from one of the movies, not the book. But I was trying to cover my bases in helping Mary get her man, assuming she wanted him after meeting him.

It disturbed Mrs. Bennet that I knew how to cook, and she made me swear I wouldn't mention it. Apparently she felt it would bring shame to the family, but what would truly bring shame was the way she boasted about Jane and me making good matches. I'd tried to talk to her about toning this kind of talk down, but not surprisingly, it didn't go well. She basically responded that it's what she lives for.

Since cooking potatoes was a no go, I encouraged Mary to brush up on some quotes from Fordyce's sermons and practice some hymns on the pianoforte. You know, just in case.

Yes, yes, I was totally leaning into fixing the story. Jane Austen probably hated me. But I hadn't asked to get dropped into a field in the middle of *Pride and Prejudice*. And it wasn't my fault Mr. Darcy had asked me to dance at the Meryton assembly. I was doing the best I could. And honestly, it wasn't half bad.

After helping Mary get ready, I returned to my room to see Jane sitting in front of the vanity. Our lady's maid, Hannah, was putting curls in her hair with the scary-looking curling iron. Both women smiled at me as I entered.

"A gift arrived for you." Jane grinned ever wider while pointing at a basket resting on our bed, a blue silk ribbon tied around the handles.

"Who is it from?"

"Oh, Lizzy, who do you think?" Jane said with a teasing air.

I zipped over to the bed, expecting to see a basket full of books. Instead, I was utterly delighted to find the sweetest kitten curled into a ball, resting in the basket. With tears in my eyes, I picked up the gray short-haired kitten that looked very much like my Mr. Darcy. I cuddled the kitten against my chest, feeling both elated that Mr. Darcy was so thoughtful, and homesick for the life I was missing in another time and place.

"Mr. Darcy must be falling very much in love with you," Jane concluded.

Could it be? "We barely know each other." I kissed the kitten's head. Was I this good?

“I think I am falling in love with Mr. Bingley,” Jane admitted. “Is that foolish?”

“No, Jane. It is not. Love has no time limits.” If I was honest with myself, I’d probably fallen in love with Fitz the moment we’d met—you know, after I’d gotten up from my epic face-plant. Now was not the time to think about it, though. I was so proud of Jane and ridiculously happy for her. My version of the story seemed to be working out okay.

Feeling good about the state of things, Jane and I went down to greet Mr. Collins, along with the rest of the household. I hoped Mr. Collins looked like the one at Pride and Prejudice Park, for Mary’s sake.

As we stepped into the entryway, Mrs. Bennet zeroed in on the kitten, curled up and purring against my chest. “Where did you get that thing?” she said in disgust.

“Mr. Darcy.”

Her tone and facial expression softened immediately. “Oh, well. Of course, you must keep the thing. Just make sure it stays out of my rooms.”

“Yes, Mama.”

“A kitten!” Lydia exclaimed. “I’ve always wanted a kitten.” She unceremoniously took the cat from me. “What is his name?”

I hadn’t thought of one yet. I definitely couldn’t go with Mr. Darcy, my first love. But what about my true love? The thought pierced my heart so much I winced. “What about Duke?”

“Yes! The Duke of Longbourn!” Lydia squealed, twirling around with my kitten. I let her keep ahold of him, given it was the first time she had behaved as a fifteen-year-old girl should. She and Kitty found some string and played with Duke while we waited. It was such a wholesome scene, I couldn’t help but smile.

It didn’t take long for the carriage bearing Mr. Collins to arrive. The entire family seemed to wait with bated breath for him to exit. As we walked outside to greet him, I noticed that the trees had all turned colors now, and some had even lost their leaves. How could that be? I hadn’t been there that long. It was weird that time did not seem consistent. Not any weirder than me being there, but still, it was odd and disconcerting.

Mr. Collins exited with all the pageantry I expected. He stepped out of the carriage, drawn by four white horses, like he was a prince about to greet his subjects. It shocked me he didn’t do a beauty-queen wave. But I was

pleased to see he was indeed the hottie from the park with his dark curly mussed hair and deep-brown eyes with long lashes.

Mary's eyes lit up when she got a good look at him. Oh, she so wanted to boil potatoes for him.

Mr. Collins first took in the house that would one day be his, then proceeded to check us all out before he said a word. By the twinkle in his greedy eyes, it seemed he was not disappointed in our appearance. I could see him calculating which one of us he would choose, as if we were pieces of meat at the market.

"Mr. Collins," Mr. Bennet greeted him with a dignified air of *Keep your eyes off my daughters.*

Mr. Collins wrenched his gaze away from my sisters and me and focused on our parents. "Mr. Bennet," he bellowed. "What a pleasure it is to finally know you."

"Yes, quite the pleasure," Mr. Bennet replied sardonically.

Mr. Collins was either dense or calculating and only grinned, not batting an eye at the slight.

"May I introduce my wife, Mrs. Bennet, and my daughters, Jane, Elizabeth, Mary, Kitty, and Lydia," Mr. Bennet made introductions. We each curtsied as our names were called.

"My fair cousins." Mr. Collins bowed. "I bring greetings from the honorable Lady Catherine de Bourgh, my patroness."

None of the women said anything. Mrs. Bennet was balling up her fists, wanting to punch him in the face. His pretty face, mind you.

"Let us get out of the cold," Mr. Bennet said as he ushered us in.

Mr. Collins, adept at elegant compliments, sidled up to Mrs. Bennet and began paying her every kindness, even though I felt his eyes scrutinizing me. He was definitely here to report back on me.

Mary took my hand and whispered in my ear, "He is handsome."

"Yes," I agreed, but now after meeting him in person, I was less sure about him than when I'd read about him.

"What a charming house," Mr. Collins pontificated as we all followed him and our parents to the parlor. "I am glad to find it in such good order."

Mrs. Bennet tchted. "Did you think it would be in disrepair?"

"No, madam," Mr. Collins exaggerated. "I hope I did not cause offense. I only meant to compliment you on your excellent home."

Right. And I was the Princess of Wales.

Mary went straight to the pianoforte when we entered the parlor and began playing “Come, We That Love the Lord.”

Mr. Collins left Mama’s side and drifted Mary’s way, like some magical force had drawn him there. “My dear cousin, how did you know this was my favorite hymn?” To our shock, or at least to mine, he began to sing like he was Frank Churchill in Gwyneth Paltrow’s *Emma*. “Come, we that love the Lord, and let our joys be known; join in a song with sweet accord.” He sang every note perfectly.

This seemed all too surreal. Was I really this good? Had I changed the course of the story so much that Mr. Collins was not only a babe but an amazing vocalist? More surprising was Mary singing along with him, their voices blending perfectly together. It was as I had always suspected—they were meant to be, even if he was a sneaky spy for Lady Catherine.

There was nothing left for the rest of us to do but sit and listen to them.

Jane and I shared several *what in the world* glances, while Lydia and Kitty played with Duke. Mr. and Mrs. Bennet gaped at Mary like they hardly knew her. Weird, since it was me they didn’t really know. I hardly knew myself anymore.

We passed the time away in this manner before our dinner guests arrived, listening not only to Mary and Mr. Collins’s duets, but to their discussions of Fordyce’s sermons as well. Mary really swooned when Mr. Collins read the following passage with such passion:

“It has been the wisdom of all nations to guard the females of their community with peculiar care. Nature and custom have alike prescribed this necessity. Accordingly, in all countries where the fair sex are well regarded, in such countries the inhabitants are most refined. For, as it has been often observed, there is no surer test of the real politeness of any people than the state of their women. Their ignorance or education, their licentiousness or delicacy, their indolence or industry, their low or liberal accomplishments—these, when fairly stated, are sufficient to show us what we are to expect in other respects. And it holds as true in morality as in mechanics, that the same causes in the same circumstances will produce similar effects.”

I would have so giggled if Fitz said something like that to me trying to woo me. Granted, it was better than the “Darcy” speech he’d given me.

With Mr. Collins and Mary so smitten with each other, I kept waiting for Mr. Roarke to show up and tell me I’d completed my fantasy of being the best Elizabeth and being able to fix things. Sure, Mr. Darcy hadn’t

proposed yet, but he'd sent me a kitten, and we seemed headed in that direction. He wanted me to meet his sister, after all.

But Mr. Roarke never came. Apparently, the fantasy, or dream, or afterlife had to go on. And go on it did. Let's just say I could guess why Mr. Roarke hadn't shown up yet to take me back to reality, because reality came to call in a big, big way.

I'd been bracing myself for Mr. Collins to fawn all over Mr. Darcy . . . but no, Mr. Collins focused all his attention on Mary during the first course of mushroom soup. Talk about love at first sight. Had he forgotten his mission to spy on me?

It certainly helped to ease my nerves as we all sat around the table, Mr. Darcy next to me.

"I have not had the chance to thank you for the kitten. I love him."

Mrs. Bennet had insisted Lydia leave him in a basket in the parlor, despite her pleas to bring him to dinner.

Mr. Darcy set his spoon down and turned to gaze at me. "You have me doing the oddest things," he admitted.

He sounded like Fitz there, whom I had forced to watch the strangest musicals of our time. "Is that a bad thing, Mr. Darcy?" Could he love me for my oddities?

"Not at all, Miss Bennet. In fact—"

I waited for him to say something amazing. I just got that kind of vibe, like a my-greatest-wish-was-about-to-be-granted kind of vibe. But a conversation between Lydia and Mr. Bingley about the Netherfield ball filtered our way and stole the moment from me.

"I do hope you will still invite all the officers, despite Mr. Wickham's being part of the regiment. Lizzy says we must stay away from him because of Mr. Darcy, but I do not think there is a way of getting around inviting him."

Oh, Lydia. I knew her words would be unwelcome.

Mr. Darcy's look of adoration for me turned cold. "What did you say about Mr. Wickham?" he seethed under his breath and for my ears only.

"Only that he seemed to make you uncomfortable, so we should avoid him."

"I do not wish for my name to be connected to his in any way."

"That is understandable, considering what he did to your sister." My hand flew over my mouth, realizing my mistake too late.

Mr. Darcy's eyes blazed with a fury I had never witnessed before. "How do you know such things?"

*What do I say? Think of something. Anything that doesn't sound as ridiculous as the truth.* But nothing came except for the tears in my eyes that threatened to spill over. "I cannot say."

Without any warning, he pushed his chair back, stood, and walked out of the room.

A deafening silence fell across the table, and all eyes landed on me.

My entire body erupted in flames from embarrassment. I couldn't focus on anyone in the room. All I could think of was how I needed to repair this. But this time, I knew there was no fixing it. I'd single-handedly ruined one of the greatest love stories of all time.

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# TWENTY-FIVE

***"You showed me how insufficient were all my pretensions to please a woman worthy of being pleased."***

## FITZ

"HELLO, YOUR GRACE. I'M DR. Taylor," an unknown man's voice interrupted my vigil over Monroe. I grew more uneasy with every minute that ticked by. We were well into the night now, and still she would not wake. She'd twitched a few times in the past half hour, and each movement made me hope she would open her beautiful eyes. But the hope vanished each time, leaving me with disappointment and even despair.

"Dr. Taylor," I croaked, my voice hoarse from begging Monroe to wake up.

The doctor, who was probably in his late thirties, pulled a rolling stool around to Monroe's other side. Monroe would no doubt be sad to have missed him—I think he's what she would refer to as *dishy*. Personally, I didn't see the appeal.

"I've been going over her test results." Dr. Taylor pulled out a penlight and manually opened Monroe's eyes to exam them. "I admit she is a bit of an enigma."

*Tell me something I don't know.*

"Physically, we can't find anything wrong with her. Her brain activity appears normal, which leads me to believe it may be more psychological."

Was he calling her mental? "What does that mean?" I sounded more defensive than I felt.

The doctor lowered his penlight and smiled. "That is not a slight. In rare cases, patients dealing with trauma or severe stress can fall into a pseudo coma. We call it psychogenic unresponsiveness. Has Ms. Wilde experienced

a recent trauma, or has she been under any undue stress? Any of those factors, combined with the fall, could account for her unresponsiveness."

I shifted uncomfortably in my seat. "We had a row before she fell off the horse. I said some things I deeply regret. Is this my fault?" The thought sickened me.

"I doubt it, Your Grace. One lovers' spat is hardly grounds for this condition."

He didn't know Monroe. I'd devastated her. This was deeper than a lovers' spat. While we had never been lovers, we were more. These last hours I'd felt that more acutely than I ever had. She was the best part of me. "So, when will she wake up?"

"That is a good question. I think the best thing for now is to make sure Ms. Wilde feels safe, and we don't forcibly arouse her."

I'd love to arouse her. Not forcibly, obviously.

"Speak gently to her," he recommended. "If she doesn't wake up overnight, I suggest we transport her to a more specialized treatment center in London."

I nodded, tortured by the thought that I was the reason for her unconscious state.

The doctor stood. "We'll keep monitoring her. I'll be back in an hour to check on her."

"Thank you."

As soon as Dr. Taylor walked out of the room, I caressed Monroe's hand that I'd held tightly for the past several hours. "Monroe," I whispered gently. "I wish I knew the right words to say to make you feel safe. You should see all the text and voice messages I've received from people who care about you. You are so loved. Your dad is on his way here. Your grams says to tell you that you are indeed her favorite grandchild." I smiled. "Of course, Anna and Kingston send their love. Several people from the park have sent flowers with the kindest of notes saying how you've touched their lives, even though they've only known you for a short time. That's a gift, Monroe. You are a gift, the best gift I've ever received. I'm sorry I ever made you question that. I love you and want to spend the rest of my life with you."

Monroe didn't stir.

Defeated, I raised her hand and pressed my lips to her smooth skin, soaking her in. Silently, I berated myself. Why hadn't I let myself love her

completely when I had the chance? I knew why, and I hated myself for it. Yes, I'd been trying to protect her. But . . . I was the product of my parents. From the time I could walk and talk, they trained me to be cognizant of appearances. Anything less than perfection was unacceptable. But what is perfection in a world that is constantly changing its definition of acceptable behavior and beliefs? Kingston was right. Why should I give a damn what anyone thinks? Who are they to me? I know who Monroe is to me. She is my everything.

"Monroe, it's not you who needs to change. It's me," I admitted out loud.

"Knock, knock," the last voice I wanted to hear interrupted my musings.

I whipped my head around to see Tony waltz in. He wore his regimental costume, minus the jacket. I doubted Agatha knew he'd escaped that asylum. "Who let you in here? Visiting hours are over."

"I have a way with the ladies," he bragged.

I would be finding out which ladies, and I would have their jobs for this. "Get the hell out of here," I whispered harshly, hoping Monroe didn't feel the tension in the room. More than anything, I wanted her to feel safe.

Tony's smug grin disappeared when he laid eyes on Monroe, covered with tubes and wires. "Is she all right? Why isn't she awake?"

"That's the question of the day." I turned away from him.

He didn't get the hint and bravely came to stand next to me. "She hasn't woken up at all?"

"No. Now, leave. This room is to remain a safe environment, and believe me when I say you are not safe here."

"You don't intimidate me," Tony spat.

"Perhaps this will," I scoffed. "I know you are an employee at the park and not a guest. How did you get them to cover that up for you?"

The prick refused to say. I would be having words with the park's board of directors over this.

"I also know you didn't lose your job because of Monroe. You were embezzling funds from your family business. I wouldn't expect any holiday invites from family this year." I couldn't resist needling him.

He cleared his throat, and from the corner of my eye, I could see him stretching his neck.

"Bit uncomfortable now, are we?"

"It's none of your damn business," Tony spluttered.

“You made it my business when you showed up for Monroe’s and my holiday.”

“One I paid for,” he grumbled.

“Ah . . . so this is about money,” I surmised.

“You owe me.”

“You’re wrong on that account, but regardless, you could have called me or sent me a bill. Why come here?” I demanded to know.

“For Monroe,” he stammered.

“We both know that’s a lie. Try again before I call security.” I turned toward him, happy to see his face drained of any color and beads of sweat on his forehead. When he didn’t answer, I deduced why. “Are we in some trouble with the law in the States?”

“I just need some cash,” he mumbled.

“You won’t be getting any from me.”

“You rich bastard,” he spewed.

“Guilty on both counts.” I’d never felt like more of a bastard. The pain on Monroe’s face last night after I’d *talked Darcy to her*, as she said, would forever torture me. There wasn’t punishment enough. “I think we are done here now. You wouldn’t want Agatha to learn you snuck out. Sounds like you need the paycheck and perhaps a place to hide out, mate.”

“I’m not your mate.”

“Right you are. Now, leave.” I turned from him and focused back on Monroe.

The imbecile didn’t move. “She will be all right, won’t she?” He sounded genuinely concerned. “She’s the best person I’ve ever known.”

That was something we could agree on, but I refused to say it.

Tony turned and walked out the door.

I cradled Monroe’s hand between my own. “Monroe, did you hear that? You are the best person. Come back to me. I love you.”

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# TWENTY-SIX

***"Till this moment, I never knew myself."***

## MONROE

MR. DARCY WAS GONE. HE didn't write to tell me. Jane had to relay the news from Mr. Bingley. That was last week. Where he went, I couldn't guess. I only knew I had single-handedly ruined one of the greatest stories of all time, and possibly my life—or afterlife. To deal with my failure, I'd taken to walking. Lots and lots of walking, much of it through mud. I couldn't bear to be in the house, as Mrs. Bennet shook her head and complained about her nerves every time she saw me. I was clearly no longer a favorite. Jane and Mary now held that honor—Jane, who was surely on the verge of receiving a proposal, and Mary, who had captured the heart of Mr. Collins, saving them all from being turned out once Mr. Bennet died.

Oh yes, Mary and Mr. Collins were smitten with each other. If they weren't singing duets, they were in deep discussion about moral reflections.

I'd been doing a lot of reflection too—contemplating things like: Why did I always make a mess of everything, and how did I get out of this place? More like, could I ever get out of this place? I'd even contemplated falling off a horse again—you know, like they do in some movies that have dream sequences. If this was a dream, it was more like a nightmare. I'd even shouted on one of my walks, "I get it now! Fixing things comes at a price. Can I please go home?" I waited for Mr. Roarke or even Agatha to show up and escort me back to Pride and Prejudice Park. No such luck. Of course, I'd prayed, but no answers there either, which made me fear I'd gone to hell. I thought I was a good person, but maybe all the disasters I'd caused in my lifetime counted against me.

I'd never felt so lost or alone in my life—or un-life. I just wanted to go home and watch *Grease* with Fitz and curl up with my cat. Not my cat here, which Lydia and Kitty had pretty much claimed as their own. It wasn't a bad thing. At least it kept their minds off the officers in town.

Sweet Jane had tried several times to discuss what had happened with Mr. Darcy. But what was I supposed to say? There was no way I could tell the truth. On top of everything else, I didn't need a trip to an asylum here, or to cause them to reinstate witch hunts in England.

Basically, all in all, it wasn't a happy time. No good humor or cheerfulness to report here, unless you counted everyone else's, and of course I did. I was pleased for Jane that I'd seemed to Darcy-proof her relationship with Bingley, and Mary and Mr. Collins were both happy. And it appeared I'd saved Lydia from an awful fate with Wickham. These were all good things. But in spite of all that, there was no happy ending because Elizabeth was still without Darcy. That was a travesty, especially because it was concrete proof I'd failed at being Elizabeth.

"Lizzy!" Charlotte called as I walked up the lane to the house. I'd been walking for hours now and was so cold, I could barely feel my extremities. My nose was so frozen, I felt as if the tip of it might fall off. Even though I was uncomfortable, I wished I didn't have to return to get ready for the Netherfield ball tonight, but Mrs. Bennet insisted I attend.

I turned to find Charlotte running my way, smiling so brightly I could feel the warmth of it.

"Hello, Charlotte." I tried to keep most of the misery out of my voice. After all, it wasn't her fault I'd basically told Mr. Darcy I was a stalker of the creepiest kind, suggesting I'd been spying on him like Miss Bingley had accused. Surely that dear had been having a great laugh at my expense for the last several days. She had probably done her best to abuse me severely in front of Mr. Darcy. It wouldn't surprise me if she'd helped him pack his belongings and sent him on his journey far away from me.

"Oh, Lizzy." Charlotte ran up to me and kissed my cheeks. "I have some news to share with you."

I perked up a bit. Had Mr. Darcy returned? "What news?"

Charlotte linked our arms together, beaming. "Mr. Rutledge has proposed."

"Really?" I hadn't thought they'd hit it off.

She wrinkled her nose, offended by my astonishment.

“Charlotte, please forgive me. I am just surprised because you have not spoken of him since you danced with him a fortnight ago.”

Her smile was back in full force. “Not that Mr. Rutledge. I speak of his father.”

Say what? When did that happen?

Without my asking, she obliged me with an answer. “After you mentioned to Mr. Rutledge that I was interested in learning more about his mercantile shop, he told his father, who has recently lost his wife. Mr. Rutledge, the father, sought me out when I visited the shop, and we fell easily into conversation. He spoke to my father just today, and now we are engaged. I know he is much older than I am, but I do believe I will be as happy with him as I would be with anyone else.”

I believed her. “Charlotte.” I hugged her. “I am truly happy for you.”

“It is all because of you.” She squeezed me tight. “I only hope you can find such happiness.”

I choked back the tears and the deep sadness brewing inside of me. But it helped me to remember that I did have a happy life. Sure, my fiancé dumped me because I tried to fix his career, and my best friend and the love of my life only wanted me if I changed myself. But on the whole, I’d been happy.

“Thank you,” was all I could think to reply.

She kissed my cheeks again and rushed off. I had to say, I hadn’t seen that relationship coming. I had a feeling Mrs. Bennet hadn’t either, and she was going to be livid that the Lucas’s daughter was engaged before any of hers. She was already upset that it had been Lady Lucas who’d gleefully shared with her the news of Mr. Darcy’s departure.

I walked into the house, the hem of my dress covered in mud. Mrs. Hill shook her head at me and barked at Hannah to help me.

Sweet Hannah followed me up the stairs while laughter rang throughout the halls. Everyone was excited about the ball. We entered the room I shared with Jane to find her already dressed in a beautiful ivory gown.

“How do I look, Lizzy?” Jane blushed.

“Like a vision.”

Jane smiled and sat down in front of the vanity. “Did you hear that Lady Catherine de Bourgh will be at the ball tonight?”

I grabbed the nearest wall for support. The last person I needed to see was Lady Catherine, a.k.a. Agatha. “Where did you hear that?”

“From Mr. Collins, of course. He received a letter today from his patroness.”

“Why would she come here?”

“She said she received a most alarming report but would say no more on the matter, according to Mr. Collins.”

“She gave no hint?” That report should have been about me, but that couldn’t be the case any longer. Mr. Darcy wasn’t here. Was he involved with someone else? It made no sense—not that any of this had. I’d basically turned *Pride and Prejudice* into some rom-com, with Mr. Collins and Mary singing all the time and me fumbling my part. I had one job here, and I completely blew it.

Jane shook her head and smiled. “But Mr. Collins is in a right state about it. He instructed us all to wear our very best.”

And that is what I did, although I wanted nothing more than to soak in a dirty, lukewarm tub all night, throwing a pity party for one. Unfortunately, that was the only kind of bath available to me in this place. You don’t know how much I missed clean, hot water and my breakup playlist. Oh, and ice cream and cookies with refined sugar. I needed them all in this post–Mr. Darcy phase.

Dressed in my prettiest pink dress, I walked downstairs to find Mr. Bennet waiting for me. “A moment, Lizzy, if you please.”

I nodded and followed him to the drawing room, where it looked like he would spend his time while we were out. A plate of cheese and bread and a bottle of wine awaited him by his chair. His night looked much better than mine—I could do with stuffing my face full of bread and cheese.

Mr. Bennet took my hand and deposited me in the chair across from him in front of the low-burning fire. He took his seat and gave me an appraising sort of look. “My dearest Lizzy, I hate to see you so unhappy. Next to being married, a girl likes to be crossed in love a little now and then. It is something to think of, and gives her a sort of distinction among her companions.”

I smiled only because I got to hear that line firsthand, but . . . “Papa,” I cried. “I do not wish to be crossed in love.”

His eyes widened in alarm as he gathered my hands in his. “Lizzy, my love. I did not know your attachment to Mr. Darcy ran so deeply.”

I wasn’t crying about Mr. Darcy. Not to say the turn of events surrounding him didn’t upset me, but it felt as if everything was closing in

on me, and I didn't know what to do. Who was I, even? "Papa, what if I am not your Lizzy?"

He tilted his head, his brow furrowed. "What do you mean, Daughter?"

I let out a long sigh. "I fear I am not who I should be."

"Lizzy, who do you want to be?" he asked sagely.

For a moment, I swear he sounded like Davis Gray, the man playing Mr. Bennet, and not *the* Mr. Bennet. That sounded super psychedelic, but I swear it was true.

I didn't get to answer him, as Mrs. Bennet strolled in and said, "Hurry, Lizzy, *it is time*." Did she sound more like Laila Gray than Mrs. Bennet? Had I finally lost it?

I stood automatically, feeling like I was in a bit of a daze. Mr. Bennet hugged me and whispered in my ear, "You are loved."

His words warmed me in a way I hadn't felt in days.

Hannah helped me into my coat before I walked out into the cold evening and entered the carriage, where everyone but Lydia was waiting. "Where is Lydia?"

"She could not bear to leave Duke," Kitty answered, pouting about it.

I smiled, relieved my "baby" sister would not attend the ball.

"Cousin, we must hurry," Mr. Collins scolded. "Lady Catherine de Bourgh awaits."

Yippee. I took my seat near Jane in the crowded carriage. At least the collective body heat helped stave off the cold.

I held Jane's hand on the bumpy ride to Netherfield, lost in my thoughts. Who did I want to be? Did I have a choice in this place?

It didn't take too long for us to arrive at Netherfield—*too long* being a relative term. I missed modern transportation. I would never complain about traffic again, if I ever made it back. I would just be thankful for the comfort of my car.

Mr. Collins practically hurled himself out of the carriage in search of Lady Catherine. As much as he'd surprised me, he was still a silly man. Mary followed after him, even though the rules of the day said Mrs. Bennet should have exited first. I wished I could have stayed in the carriage, but I feared hypothermia, so I exited after Jane, with the help of a footman.

We walked in to find a large gathering of people and an orchestra playing in the background. This was a much grander affair than the Meryton assembly. Nerves coursed through me as we made our way to the

ballroom. All my relations dispersed in different directions, even Jane. I needed her to be my emotional support person—I dreaded seeing Lady Catherine and Miss Bingley, who probably couldn't wait to lord over my head the fact that Mr. Darcy hated me.

Alone, I entered the elegantly decorated ballroom that smelled enchantingly of white roses and the earthy aroma of ivy, both of which were draped upon every surface imaginable. Soft candlelight danced and flickered, casting a warm and mesmerizing glow throughout the space. I felt as if I'd entered a fairy tale. At this point, it wouldn't shock me if that were the case.

Unfortunately, the wicked stepmother had come to call in the form of Lady Catherine. As soon as I walked into the ballroom, Mr. Collins pointed me out to her. The traitor—after I'd given him a future wife who actually liked him. Where were the thanks?

Of course, Lady Catherine looked just like Agatha. She was wearing a purple velvet gown that swished violently as she marched over to me with her Dame Judi Dench wig, not to mention her grumpy face.

What had I ever done to her? Or . . . was she finally here to inform me I was getting booted off *Fantasy Island*? Please, please, let that be it.

Nope. She was definitely not Mr. Roarke's counterpart.

"Miss Bennet," she said, haughtier than I'd ever heard anyone speak, and that was saying something since I knew Fitz's mum and Lady Winnifred.

"You can be at no loss as to why I, Lady Catherine de Bourgh, have made this journey to see you. Your own heart, your own conscience, must tell you why I came."

Uh . . . I was at a loss. Mr. Darcy hated me, and there would be no coming back from it. I knew things I shouldn't know, and there was no way he was getting over that. I responded with part of a line straight from the book. "Indeed, you are mistaken, madam. I have not been at all able to account for the honor of seeing you here, especially as we have not been formally introduced."

"Insolent girl. Walk with me."

This was going to be fun.

We walked through the crowded ballroom, and as we did, I caught sight of Mr. Bingley and Jane engrossed in conversation, clearly happy. Charlotte was there with her much-older fiancé, looking relieved she would no longer

be considered a burden to her parents. Mary and Mr. Collins headed to the pianoforte, probably to sing a number or two. The absence of Lydia running around making a fool of herself wasn't lost on me. Mrs. Bennet and Mrs. Phillips sat in quiet conversation with each other instead of drawing attention to themselves. The biggest surprise of all was Mr. Wickham in the corner, chatting it up with Caroline Bingley, who seemed to be smiling and flirting with him. What? Was I hallucinating?

It was like I had repaired every problem, even making sure Caroline Bingley got her comeuppance for being so awful. Well, I hadn't fixed everything—I'd messed up the biggest part of the story. No happy ending for Elizabeth. My heart sank.

Lady Catherine led us to Netherfield's drawing room, a place where I had spent hours talking to Mr. Darcy about politics and poetry. I'd even impressed him with my musical skill on the pianoforte in the corner of the room. How had it all gone so wrong? I'd only wanted to protect Lydia and the Bennets.

Lady Catherine wasted no time berating me once we entered the room. She turned dramatically and said, "I received an alarming report about you and my nephew."

"Which nephew?" I smirked. I mean, she could have more than one for all I knew. Jane Austen could have left that detail out of the story.

"You impertinent girl. You know I speak of Mr. Darcy."

"What about him?"

Her face turned so red, I thought it would explode. "Do not play ignorant. You know he wishes to engage himself to you."

I didn't know the source of her declaration. "I think you are mistaken."

"She is not," Mr. Darcy said.

I twirled around so fast, I felt dizzy. "Mr. Darcy," I said breathlessly as I took him in, standing by the door, looking as freaking hot as ever. That blue jacket and the cravat were totally him. His hair was even extra mussy. It reminded me so much of Fitz. They were so similar, but then, not really. Fitz would have never left me, even if I claimed to know his family's deep, dark secret. But I couldn't think of that at the moment. It was too confusing.

"Fitzwilliam," Lady Catherine screeched. "You know it was your mother's and my dearest wish for our children to be united."

Mr. Darcy kept his eyes trained on me. "I am aware, but it has never been *my* wish."

“And who is this woman? What are her connections?”

Mr. Darcy strode my way, carefully but forcefully. It was pretty dang sexy.

“This is Miss Elizabeth Bennet. I am a gentleman, and she is a gentleman’s daughter,” Mr. Darcy answered.

I think this meant I had done it. I was not only an Elizabeth, I was *the* Elizabeth.

Lady Catherine tsked in disgust and bustled out of the room.

I wasn’t sad to see her go.

“Miss Elizabeth, I apologize for my aunt’s incivility.” He stepped closer and took my hand.

My hand was covered by a glove, so it wasn’t quite as intimate as it could have been, but I wasn’t complaining. My heart certainly pitter-pattered.

Mr. Darcy drew me closer to him with the most intense gaze. “In vain I have struggled. It will not do. My feelings will not be repressed. You must allow me to tell you how ardently I admire and love you.” He *spoke Darcy* really well.

Say what? Was this really happening? Where had he been? What had changed?

I opened my mouth to speak, but Mr. Darcy wasn’t through.

“Despite your lack of connections, your mother’s irreverence, and your meddlesome ways, I cannot deny my feelings for you. Behaving in a forward manner at times, pushing your sisters into the spotlight, orchestrating your friends’ matches, and knowing things you should not are all considerations I must overlook in the face of my attachment to you.” He pulled me to him, and without warning, his soft lips pressed against mine and moved over them with such intensity, I almost forgot for a moment what he’d just said. All I could think was, *Mr. Darcy is kissing me, and he loves me.* I leaned into him and grabbed his lapels—I was totally going for it. How often do you get to kiss Mr. Darcy? Not even Elizabeth had such pleasure in the book.

Scandalously, Mr. Darcy deepened the kiss while the back of his hand gently caressed my cheek. A soft tingling sensation spread throughout my body, like a trail of electric sparks. Wow. I was the best Elizabeth ever. Except . . . I wasn’t Elizabeth. I pulled away from Mr. Darcy, allowing his

words to sink into my heart and soul, helping me return to myself even though I knew it would ruin the story.

He swallowed hard. “Forgive me for being so forward, my dearest Elizabeth.”

“I am not Elizabeth. And I do not want to be loved despite who I am.” I didn’t think she did either. Wasn’t she willing to walk away from Mr. Darcy knowing the consequences? She was true to herself, and that’s what I wanted to be. “I want to be loved for who I am.”

“Who are you?” he asked, confused.

It took me a moment to remember, but remember I did. “I am Monroe,” I cried. “I just realized that she is all I ever wanted to be. I want to be loved for my imperfections and crazy, try-to-fix-everything-only-to-fail ways. *I just want to be Monroe.*

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# VOLUME THREE

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# TWENTY-SEVEN

***"Health, good humour, and cheerfulness began to reappear."***

## FITZ

"I JUST WANT TO BE Monroe. I just want to be Monroe. I just want to be Monroe," Monroe cried in her sleep in a spot-on British accent.

Startled that she'd spoken, I jumped up from my chair, only to sit on the bed and take her gorgeous face in my hands. "Monroe."

"I don't want to be loved despite who I am. I want to be loved for who I am," she mumbled, still speaking in an accent that wasn't hers. Had her fall caused one of those rare conditions that made people speak in a different accent?

"Monroe, I love you. Please wake up."

Her eyes flew open. She looked positively bewildered. I feared she didn't recognize me.

"Mr. Darcy, you love me?" She reached up with her hand connected to the IV and skimmed my cheeks with her fingers. "Your cheeks are stubbly." She blinked, obviously confused, and tore her hand away. "I shouldn't have touched you. I'm not wearing gloves. But you just kissed me with your tongue." She rubbed her head.

She was making no sense, yet I couldn't help but chuckle. "Monroe." I took her hand. "Do you remember falling off the horse?"

Monroe thought for a moment, looking at her hand with the IV and then touching the cannula in her nose. "I'm back," she cried. "Wait. Where am I?" Her American accent suddenly returned.

Before I could answer, Dr. Taylor rushed in with two nurses—nurses who may get fired if I found they were guilty of letting Tony in here, but I would deal with that later. All I cared about now was that Monroe was awake and talking, even if she seemed confused.

The doctor and nurses moved me out of the way to examine her. I stood and moved to the end of the bed, refusing to take my eyes off her.

Her eyes darted between me and the medical personnel.

“Ms. Wilde, I’m Dr. Taylor. You gave us quite a scare. You’ve been asleep for over twelve hours now.”

“Twelve hours? That’s all? You mean it was all a dream?”

“What was all a dream?” Dr. Taylor asked calmly while the nurses checked Monroe’s vitals.

She shook her head, her cheeks turning red. “Nothing.”

“Do you remember falling off the horse?” Dr. Taylor asked.

“Yes,” she croaked. “My throat is dry. Can I get something to drink? Like clean water with ice? Lots of ice,” she said as if she’d been missing it.

*Clean water? Why would she specify* clean*?* I wondered.

“Of course.” Dr. Taylor chuckled.

One of the nurses darted off to get Monroe something to drink while the doctor continued to examine her. He had her squeeze his hand and tell him her name and date of birth. Dr. Taylor even had her recite the alphabet and count to one hundred, after she had something to drink, of course. Her mind and motor skills seemed to be in working order, though she still looked dazed.

When Dr. Taylor finished examining her, he pronounced, “You are a medical miracle, Ms. Wilde. With that said, I think it best if we run some additional tests later this morning and keep you here for a few more days for observation. I’m going to keep the catheter and IV in for now. I don’t want you to get up unsupervised, so we’ll have some food brought in for you. What would you like?”

“Anything,” she replied.

It surprised me she hadn’t balked at staying in the hospital. I thought for sure she’d want to get back to that blasted park so she could continue to live out her *Pride and Prejudice* fantasies.

Dr. Taylor stood. “Very good. I’ll be back soon to check on you. If you need anything, press the nurse’s button.”

Monroe nodded. “Thank you.”

“You’re a lucky woman.” The doctor walked off, shaking his head and muttering, “Never seen anything like this.”

As soon as Monroe and I were alone, I took up a chair at her bedside, immediately taking her hand. “How do you feel?”

“Fitz,” she breathed out. “I had the strangest . . . dream, I guess, but it seemed so real. I didn’t know if I would ever wake up . . . or make it back to reality. For a while, I thought I’d died or maybe gone to *Fantasy Island*. You know that old show I made you watch with me once when you came to visit me?”

“I remember.” I caressed her hand, trying to calm her. She seemed upset.

“It seemed like I was gone for at least a few weeks. I can’t believe it’s only early Wednesday morning.”

I wanted to tell her how sorry I was and how I’d never been more frightened in my life, but she seemed to need to recount her time asleep.

“I know this sounds crazy, but I was in the actual *Pride and Prejudice* story as Elizabeth. And you were there, playing Mr. Darcy, but you were different. At first you left me because I said words like *sexy* and you accused me of talking about basket weaving.”

“Basket weaving?” I laughed.

“You know, the euphemism for sex?” She grinned.

“I understand,” I assured her, wishing we could talk more about basket weaving. Maybe later.

“Yeah, well, Mr. Darcy didn’t like it, or at least I don’t think he did, but then he asked me to dance at the Meryton assembly. Of course, I had to say yes, but I messed up the entire story, even though I tried really hard to be the best Elizabeth and not try to fix things.” She became more and more upset.

“Darling, it’s all right.”

“No, it’s not. Or at least it wasn’t. I was able to actually help everyone. Because of me, Bingley never left Jane. And I helped Mary play and sing better, which made Mr. Collins fall for her. Did you know Mr. Collins can sing?”

“Did you turn *Pride and Prejudice* into a musical?” I teased her.

“Sort of. It was more like a wacky rom-com. The *Without Pride and Prejudice* version—you know, since I knew how the story went, but that’s not the point.”

“What is the point?” I was more than curious.

“The point is that I became the best Elizabeth ever. Lydia didn’t even fall for Mr. Wickham, although I think Caroline Bingley might have.” She smiled. “Maybe that was just wishful thinking on my part since Caroline

looked and acted like Winnifred," she grumbled her name. "She even tried to turn Mr. Darcy against me, but he gave me a kitten instead, who I named Duke, after you."

"I'm honored." I grinned.

"But Fitz," her voice cracked. "It didn't matter, because even though everyone got a happy ending because of me, Mr. Darcy didn't really want me. He said he loved me despite my meddlesome ways, which was just to say that he didn't like how I tried to fix everything, even though in my dream I could actually make things better. I should have known I was dreaming. He didn't love me for me," she said, more to herself.

I shifted uncomfortably, clinging to her for dear life. I knew where this was going and that it was time for me to face the music of my own making.

"Regardless, I still wasn't enough. Mr. Darcy was just like you. You want me in spite of who I am; you want me to change. I don't want to be loved like that, especially by you. I realized I just want to be Monroe." A single tear fell down her smooth cheek. "I know I'm not perfect, but why can't anyone just love me for me?"

Her question was clear: Why couldn't I love her for who she is, without conditions? I drew her hand up and kissed it. "Monroe, it was just a dream. You matter more to me than anyone or anything. I love you. All of you," I begged her to believe me.

She shook her head. "You withheld your heart from me all this time because I embarrass you. You, my person. How am I going to live without you?"

"Monroe, you don't have to." I sat on the bed and took her into my arms, wires and all. The thought of being without her withered me inside.

She fell against me and sobbed. "I kept thinking in the dream that if I couldn't have you, maybe I could have the next best thing—a Mr. Darcy who looks like you. But it didn't work. He *spoke Darcy* just as well as you do. And even though I made a pretty good Elizabeth, it wasn't enough."

"He sounds like a prideful arse, just like me."

"He totally was."

"Monroe." I tilted her chin enough to gaze into her watery eyes, full of heartache. I still saw my future inside of them. I wanted that future more than anything, and to ease her pain. "The reason *Pride and Prejudice* is so beloved is because it's a story of redemption. Please, Monroe, give me the chance to redeem myself. For these past several hours, when I didn't know

if you would ever wake up, it was a torture like I had never known. You are my life, the best part of me. Please, let me try to deserve you," I pleaded.

She fell back against me and clung to me, but she refused to say if she'd give me that chance. I couldn't fault her for that. The damage I'd caused was undeniable, and I knew words alone wouldn't suffice to mend it.

I stroked her hair until she fell asleep on my chest, but there was no sleep for me. All I wanted to do was hold her for the rest of my life. I lay awake thinking of how to prove myself to Monroe. How does a Mr. Darcy redeem himself?

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# TWENTY-EIGHT

***"Her heart did whisper that he had done it for her."***

## MONROE

I WOKE UP IN THE hospital bed late Wednesday morning, feeling the effects of the fall. It was a soreness and stiffness like I'd never known. I'd kind of hoped I would get to skip that part, since I'd already dealt with it in my dream. But that was wishful thinking. I felt like . . . well, like I'd fallen off a horse and hit the ground. At least I had access to modern pain relievers instead of opium. Not only was I dealing with pain, but I also had to come to terms with the fact that it had been only a vivid dream and I hadn't really been gone for well over a fortnight. Sure, I was ecstatic I hadn't died, and even grateful there was no such thing as *Fantasy Island*. It was even a relief that I hadn't proved the space-time continuum theory—sorry, Einstein. But . . . with all that good news, I also had to address why I hadn't woken up right away.

The doctor told me in the wee morning hours when they'd woken me to check my vitals that he believed it was caused by a psychological injury. *Psychogenic unresponsiveness*, he'd called it. It's caused by trauma or stress. Falling off the horse was definitely traumatic, but the possibility of losing my best friend, even more so. I suppose the dream made more sense in that light. I think I just wanted a safe place where I could be true to myself and still have Fitz in my life. Who knew I didn't really want to be Elizabeth Bennet? Although, I had to say: I rocked her. But I think more than anything, all I'd ever wanted was to be accepted for who I am. I'd forgotten that, but my brain had a funny way of reminding me.

The room came into focus, and I saw Fitz standing by the bed, dressed in his regular clothing and looking as freakishly handsome as ever.

Honestly, he really should have been number one on the hottest bachelor list.

“Hi,” I croaked, my throat dry. I felt shy around him, considering I’d admitted the dream to him and cried myself to sleep while he held me tight. He was my best friend, and I’d wanted and needed him to play that role, even though I feared for our future. I knew he said he loved me, and I loved him too. But how could we move forward when it was clear now that I was definitely not cut out to be in his noble world, and that I embarrassed him?

“Good morning.” He bent down, kissed my forehead, and lingered. Dang man, he knew I was a sucker for a good forehead kiss—I always squealed in movies when one occurred. Fitz knew all my secrets. “I have something I need to do.”

“You’re leaving me?” I didn’t mean to sound needy, but hello, I’d just woken up from some peculiar coma state that had the doctor bewildered. And regardless of our relationship status, I needed him here. “What’s so important?”

He ran a finger down my cheek. “You.”

“Then why do you have to leave?”

“You’ll see.” He smiled. “Don’t worry, darling, I’m not leaving you without company.” He looked over his shoulder and out to the hall. “You can come in,” he called.

I glanced at the door, and in walked my dad, Kingston, and Anna, who carried a beautiful bouquet of daises, my favorite flower, and a shopping bag from a ritzy store here in the UK.

“Dad,” I cried. “When did you get here?”

My goofy dad, dressed in a loud golf shirt and joggers, his thinning gray hair disheveled, rushed to my bedside. “Kingston and Anna just picked me up from the airport. Alastair made all the arrangements.”

Fitz moved out of the way and let my dad have at me. Before Dad sat on the bed and wrapped his arms around me, I mouthed “Thank you” to Fitz, who wore an air of melancholy determination. It made me wonder where he was going and what it had to do with me.

I sank into Dad’s embrace.

“Hey, kiddo.” He kissed my head. “You scared your old man. Who was I going to tell all my dad jokes to?” his voice cracked.

“I could do with a good dad joke.” I squeezed him back the best I could. It was kind of painful.

Dad leaned away and took me in, making sure I was all right. I probably looked frightful, but I hadn't had a chance yet to look at myself. That catheter was a real killjoy. But it was better than a chamber pot, so I hadn't complained.

"I have just the joke for you," Dad said, his eyes coated with a sheen of moisture. "Did you hear about the guy who invented Life Savers? They say he made a mint!"

I giggled, and everyone in the room chuckled.

"Good one, Dad."

He smiled and took my hand.

"I must be off," Fitz announced before I had time to say hello to Anna and Kingston. They were giving off some major sexual tension vibes as they stood close, but purposely not too close. Yep, I was going to try to fix that—I had to be true to myself. But, later. First, I had to deal with my own love life.

"Where are you going?" I tried to find out one more time.

"To redeem myself."

I remembered what he'd said about *Pride and Prejudice* being a story of redemption, and that's why it was so beloved. At the core, he was right. It was the ultimate redemption story for both the hero and the heroine. But what did Fitz plan to do to redeem himself? To fix our story? I mean, I'd seen his estate already, and of course it enthralled me, but I didn't need a country estate. And I didn't have any sisters to save from Wickham. So I just asked, "How?"

He winked and walked out, not saying a word.

I immediately interrogated Kingston—he always knew what Fitz was up to. "Where's he going?"

Kingston grinned. "You know I cannot betray his confidence, Miss Monroe."

"Fine. Anna?"

Beautiful Anna, with her mischievous emerald eyes and silky sandy-brown hair done in waterfall curls, tiptoed my way. "You know I would tell you if I knew." She sat on the bed next to my dad. "Which is why my prat of a brother wouldn't tell me." She handed me the flowers.

I breathed in their subtle, sweet fragrance with a hint of grassy undertones. "Thank you."

Anna held up the bag. “I also brought you some pajamas and a change of clothes.”

“You are a goddess.”

“She is,” Kingston said, but then realized he’d said it out loud and cleared his throat in a way that warned us all not to mention it.

But Anna blushed all the same.

Kingston rushed to take the flowers from me. “I’ll put these with the rest of the flowers.”

I had a room full of flowers. Fitz had told me that many of the bouquets were from my newfound friends at Pride and Prejudice Park. I wondered who was playing the roles of Elizabeth and Mr. Darcy. I hoped it was Macey and Zane.

“So, tell us how you are?” Anna asked, trying to move on from Kingston’s slip of the tongue.

Dad and I gave each other knowing looks. Even Dad knew that Anna and Kingston had it bad for each other.

I rested against the pillows, feeling achy. “I’ve felt better, but I’m alive.” Thank goodness for that.

“We are all very happy about that.” Anna patted my leg.

“I don’t know about your mum and Winnifred.” I grinned.

Anna rolled her eyes. “Yes, I heard Winnifred showed up at Pride and Prejudice Park, along with your ex-fiancé.”

“Tony is here?” Dad asked, shocked.

“Unfortunately. Though I don’t know why.”

“I can help there,” Kingston offered from the seat he had taken in the corner of the small room.

I sat up, even though it hurt. “Really? How?”

“His Grace asked me to look into it. He believed something foul was at play, and he wasn’t wrong.”

“Do tell.” I was anxious to know.

Kingston recounted how he learned that Tony had been embezzling funds from his family’s plumbing business and that he was actually working at the park.

“Are you serious? Why come here?”

Kingston leaned forward with a hint of a smile on his handsome face. He was totally a Gerard Butler type. “From what I gather from speaking to his father, he’s running from his legal troubles, and he came here to

convince His Grace to give him back the fee he'd paid for your honeymoon."

"Does Fitz know any of this?"

"Yes, madam. The man had the audacity to visit him here and ask for the money."

"I hope Fitz didn't give it to him."

"Of course he didn't," Kingston said. "But you should know that Tony's father is most thankful to you. Had you not talked to him about giving Tony more money, he might not have discovered his son's betrayal until it was too late. He had taken your words into consideration and planned to give Tony a raise, which caused him to take a closer look at the books."

"You mean Tony didn't get fired because of me?"

"No, madam. Your actions saved their family business."

"Huh." I guess not everything I tried to fix ended in a disaster.

"I'm just relieved you didn't end up with Tony," Dad said. "He wasn't and isn't the right man for you."

"Who is, then?" I asked before I thought it through.

"You know, I could do with a cup of tea." Anna jumped up.

"I'll join you." Kingston stood.

"We'll be back." Anna waved. "And when we return, we'll get you into some proper sleepwear."

"Thank you both for coming, and for being my friends," my voice hitched. I felt so loved, and so confused. Well, confused about my best friend—the man I knew I belonged with. But I couldn't see a possible happy outcome.

"Miss Monroe," Kingston said before they walked out the door. "I don't know if His Grace would want me to say this, but I think you should know that he's willing to renounce his title, if that is what you wish. I told him you wouldn't want that. But as I said, I thought you should be aware."

I turned to my dad and buried my head in his chest, tears streaming down my face. "He's such an idiot," I said half-heartedly. How dare he be so wonderful? Of course, I didn't want him to renounce his title. I didn't even know that was an option.

Dad chuckled. "He's a good kid, that one. I've always thought so." He paused before he added, "I hoped one day you two would figure out that you were the best kind of friends."

"Oh, Dad. We can't be. I embarrass him."

Dad patted my back. “He told me what happened.”

“So you saw the picture in the *Daily Mail*?”

“I did. I thought you looked great. Your grams loved it. She said she’s going to print out a copy and put it on her fridge. She’s proud of you, as am I.”

I laughed and cringed. “Why would you be? I’m a laughingstock.”

Dad leaned away from me, his kind brown eyes lasering in on my own. “Let the world laugh. What do they know? That picture says you have a heart as big as Texas. You always have. And since when do you care so much about what people think of you?”

“Since it became international news and my best friend suggested I change everything about myself in order for us to be together,” I choked out.

“Oh, honey, he doesn’t believe that.”

I opened my mouth to disagree, but Dad beat me to the punch.

“I know what he said. He told me. Of course, as your dad, I gave him a stern talking-to.”

“Sure you did. I don’t think you know how to be stern.”

Dad smiled. “Guilty, but in my defense, I did try to let him have it. However, I didn’t need to. He’s sick about what he said. And, I think, more so about what he hasn’t said over the years.”

“And what’s that?”

“That he loves you and you’re the only woman for him. That’s been apparent since you were in school together.”

“He evaded a romantic relationship with me because I embarrass him.”

“I don’t believe that. I think he was raised in a cold environment where everyone, from his parents to society, taught him to behave in a certain way. And you, my love, taught him a different way. I think he wants that way of life more than anything—he just went about it poorly.” Dad chuckled.

“I don’t know, Dad,” I whined. “Did you see his face in the photo?”

“All I saw was a man not willing to leave you, even though he was uncomfortable.” Dad tapped my nose. “Now, what does that say about him?”

“Are you taking his side?” I teased.

“I’m always on your side. The thing is, I can’t imagine Alastair not by your side, and I don’t think you want that either. I know you have some

things to work out, but my advice to you is not to let one foolish moment define the lifetime of love you two have already shared."

Whoa. Those words hit hard. But . . . "Dad, I'll make him a social outcast. I don't know if I have what it takes to hold a title."

"I don't think Alastair wishes to keep company with anyone who doesn't want to be around you. And as far as you not being worthy of a title, that's ridiculous. Aren't duchesses involved in charitable causes? I can't think of anyone who likes to help people more than you."

"You mean who causes more disasters than me?"

"Honey, look what you just found out about Tony," he growled his name. "What you thought was a disaster not only saved a family business, it saved you from marrying that louse. And the fact that you try to help counts more than you realize. Most people just need to know someone sees them and cares about them. That is your gift."

I rested my head on Dad's shoulder. "You know how to make a girl feel good and give her hope." Hope that maybe Fitz and I didn't have to say goodbye, and that just being Monroe wasn't such a bad gig at all.

"You make it easy, kid." Dad kissed my head. "Now get some rest. I love you."

"Love you too, Dad." I snuggled back into my pillow and closed my eyes, hoping I didn't fall back into some strange dreamworld. It was weird how exhausted I was after having slept for so long. Not that it was a peaceful sleep. I had been trying to save one of the greatest stories of all time.

I didn't get a lot of rest between being poked and prodded throughout the afternoon and having several tests run, including a CAT scan. Apparently, I was a medical miracle, as they couldn't find anything wrong with me. But they were going to run more tests to make sure.

Dad, Anna, and Kingston stayed with me. Once I got the all clear and the nurses removed all the medical equipment, Anna helped me into some pink silk pj's and fixed my hair. We discovered some nasty bruises on my body from the fall and a big knot on the back of my head. Only time would heal the bumps and bruises—and my heart—but I had hope for both, even though Fitz still hadn't returned and Kingston was staying tight lipped about where he was.

It wasn't until that evening while we were eating Thai takeout that Fitz strolled in, looking satisfied with himself. He came straight to me and sat on

the bed, kissing my lips like he'd just come home from work and this was old hat for us.

"Uh. Hi." I admit his brief peck of a kiss made the butterflies in my stomach not only dance, but twerk. It was way better than Mr. Darcy—not to say Mr. Darcy didn't know how to kiss.

"Hello, darling."

"I don't know if you deserve to call me that yet." Okay, yes, I loved it. It was cute that he called me *darling*, but we had some things to work out—big things.

"Oh really?" His freaking sexy left brow quirked debonairly. "Kingston, will you please turn on the telly?"

"Yes, sir." He hopped to it.

Meanwhile, Fitz took my plate of food and placed it on the bedside table before taking my hand.

I narrowed my eyes at him. "You're behaving oddly. What are you up to?"

"Just watch." He pointed to the small flat-screen TV hanging on the wall.

This was weird, but I was more than curious, especially when Kingston turned the channel to one of the evening news programs in the UK.

We all glued ourselves to the screen. The correspondents covered some key segments about parliament, the weather, and the royal family—nothing out of the ordinary. I kept glancing at Fitz, questioning why we were watching the news, but he said nothing. He just kept running his thumb over my skin and smiling to himself. Things didn't get interesting until the last segment when the woman correspondent said, "Tonight we have an exclusive interview with His Grace, the Duke of Blackthorne, Alastair Fitzroy."

We all whipped our heads in Fitz's direction—well, minus Kingston, who obviously knew about this. Fitz hated doing interviews.

"Is this about the new program you want to start at Oxford?" I asked. He'd been hoping to reach out to the community and offer free classes in history and literature.

"Just watch," is all Fitz would say.

Nothing, and I mean nothing, could have prepared me for what I saw next. There, in a posh room, across from the correspondent, sat Fitz, sporting a bonnet like it was commonplace for him to wear nineteenth-

century women's millinery—and not just any hat, but one of the actual bonnets that Grams and I had made. I couldn't help but giggle, even though my heart felt like bursting. "Fitz," I cried.

"Shh. Listen, darling," he said playfully.

Okay, fine, he could call me *darling*. I snuggled closer to him, listening intently. Nothing but the purest kind of love would have induced Fitz to do something so wholly against his nature and upbringing.

"Have you gone bonkers?" Anna laughed. "Mum is going to be flapped over this."

Oh, yeah she was.

The correspondent was doing her best to keep a straight face while she interviewed him. "In recent days, an article has been circulating regarding a woman whom some refer to as the next Duchess of Blackthorne."

They flashed the photo on the screen of me at the airport wearing all my bonnets and a couple of dresses around my neck.

I started to cringe, but then the picture flashed back to Alastair, looking ridiculous and perfect.

"Would you like to address those rumors, Your Grace?"

"Yes, but first, I would like to state that we must never tolerate bullying, whether online or in person." He adjusted his bonnet as if making his point.

I kissed his cheek, and he smiled, pleased with himself.

"To base an opinion on a photo without even knowing the context," Fitz continued, "is absolute rubbish. That image and nasty article failed to tell the actual story. The beautiful woman wearing the bonnets had given away her luggage to an injured passenger on her flight, which necessitated wearing the contents of the bag on her person."

The correspondent swallowed hard, as if she herself had judged me to be a loon. Not saying I wasn't, but people should at least get to know me before making that assessment. But she quickly recovered and sat up in a dignified manner. "What an excellent reminder, Your Grace. So . . ."—she leaned in eagerly—"will we be calling this good Samaritan the new Duchess of Blackthorne?"

The Duchess of Blackthorne. It was a scary title—one I had never wanted, but I wanted Fitz. I knew it meant having to face this fear.

"You know I don't comment on my love life." Fitz slyly smiled. "But I will say I would be the luckiest man in the world if she would have me."

Whatever was said after that, I don't know. I sat up and faced Fitz, bleary-eyed from the onslaught of tears.

Fitz gently brushed a few of them away with his thumb while giving me the most tender expression I'd ever seen. "Monroe, I am so sorry I hurt you and kept all of myself from you. There is no bigger regret in my life. I am the only one in our relationship of whom I am embarrassed. I love you, my darling friend. Most ardently," he added.

"I don't need you to *talk Darcy* to me." I looked up at him from under my eyelashes. "I was thinking I would love it more if you *talked duke* to me." Oh yes, I said that as coyly as I could.

"In that case," he crooned, "everyone out."

I blushed at the knowing looks everyone gave as they filed out.

"In a hospital bed, no less," Anna laughed on her way to the door.

It's not where I would have imagined the greatest moment of my life happening, but then again, we're talking about me, so I should have assumed it would be some place odd.

Once everyone had left and the door was closed, Fitz took me in his arms, his hand gently cradling the back of my head, making sure not to press on the bump from my fall. He entangled his fingers in my hair and drew my face closer until we breathed in each other's breaths. "Monroe, you are my best mate, my greatest love, the reason I know love exists. I want every part of you."

Every goose bump I had perked up and applauded. Fitz was good—so good. Better than Mr. Darcy, in my estimation. Sorry, Jane Austen.

"Fitz." I brushed my fingers over his warm, inviting lips, thinking of what he had just done for me and how he had always been there for me, even from the start. "You know, I'm still going to want to fix things."

He chuckled. "I wouldn't have it any other way."

"Maybe we could wear matching bonnets out in public sometime," I teased.

"No, darling." He brushed my lips ever so lightly, but I felt the emotions of it all the way to my toes.

"That's okay—I prefer you without one anyway. I love you, Fitz." I pressed my lips to his, never feeling more connected to another human in all my life. It was as if a bubble of intimacy closed around us, shutting out every sound except for the beat of our hearts. We explored the contours of each other's lips, making me ache for more. I parted my lips, inviting just

that—more of him. Of us. Fitz seized the opportunity and deepened the kiss, his fingers knotting more securely in my hair as we explored this newfound aspect of our relationship. So much love and desire and a profound sense of belonging and rightness encompassed us.

When the kiss ended after minutes of pure bliss, we found ourselves lying face-to-face, wrapped up in each other and gazing into each other's eyes in amazement.

"Is that how you *speak duke*?" I whispered. If that was the case, maybe being a duchess wouldn't be all that bad.

He nipped my bottom lip, swollen from kissing, with his teeth. "That was just a taste."

Whoa. A shiver ran through me, and I curled myself more into him. "I can't wait to see what else you have in store."

"Does this mean you forgive me?" he asked anxiously. "I am sorry, Monroe."

"I know, and of course I forgive you. Now, let's get back to our nonverbal communication." I decided the best love stories were the unspoken ones.

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# TWENTY-NINE

***"There was too much to be thought, and felt, and said, for attention to any other objects."***

## FITZ

"I CAN'T BELIEVE THE HOSPITAL let you do this." Monroe snuggled close to me on the bed Thursday afternoon. She'd had more tests run most of the morning, so I'd hardly seen her. Monroe's father, Foster, had helped me set up this little surprise for her before he left to meet some old colleagues he'd worked with back when he and Monroe had lived in the UK. I would be forever grateful he'd taken the job here. Because of that, my life had been infinitely better.

"There are some perks to being me." I clicked play on the remote I held, and a large screen came to life. Frankie Valli's voice filled the room.

"*Grease*!" Monroe squealed. "I love you so much." She kissed my cheek. Her *I love you*s had taken on a different meaning now. Everything had—even sleeping. To hold Monroe all night in my arms, knowing that she would still be there in the morning, was the most incredible feeling.

I wrapped my arms around her, letting my fingers glide down her silky arm. "Did the doctor give you any more results today?"

"The CAT scan was clear, and I've passed all the cognitive tests so far. But . . . ," she hesitated to say, "Dr. Taylor thinks I should talk to a therapist, which I'm not against. He's just worried I have some trauma I need to work through."

I cleared my throat, feeling like the world's biggest prat. "The trauma I caused?"

She snuggled closer to me. "Honestly, some of it must be from watching my mother die without being able to save her, and then wanting to make sure nothing bad happens to the people around me as a result. But I think it

was more believing I needed to be someone I wasn't. I know it sounds crazy, but that dream made me realize I don't need to be an Elizabeth or even want to be one, even though I was pretty good at it." She laughed.

I kissed her head, knowing how deeply her mother's death had impacted her and how much my words had hurt her. "Monroe, I'm sorry I made you feel that I wanted you to be someone you weren't. That was never my intention. Kingston made me see that it wasn't my protection you needed, but my acceptance. You've always had that. I just lost my head for a moment. I wanted to eliminate any barriers to crossing the friendship line with you, knowing that it would be complicated, but I went about it poorly. I was just desperate for us to be together. The thought of you falling in love again with another man gutted me—I couldn't have that."

"Tony." She shuddered. "We'll talk about him in a minute. Kingston told me what you found out about him. But first, we should acknowledge that being together probably will be complicated. I mean, your mum hates me, and you might become a social pariah because of me. And let's not forget we live in separate countries."

"Fixing the last one is easy. I'll move to the States if you'd like."

"You can't do that. How can you leave Oxford? And you'd have to renounce your title, which I know you're willing to do."

Leaving Oxford would be difficult, but I would do it for Monroe. "I take it Kingston talked to you about renouncing my title," I grumbled.

"Yes," she giggled. "I love that you would consider that, but I also know, despite the life you've made for yourself outside of your title, it's still part of you and your history. I would never ask you to give it up. Besides, how could I brag that my best friend is a duke if you disclaim?" she teased.

"I'd prefer if you called me your lover now." I was not teasing.

"Okay, lover boy," she laughed. "But seriously, are you really ready for what's coming our way?"

"Monroe." I tilted her chin with the crook of my finger until our gazes locked. "I believe we can face anything together. We always have." After thinking I'd lost her, my perspective about what was difficult had shifted dramatically.

"That's true." She contemplated for a moment. "Well, I could teach piano and voice lessons here. I could even do sessions via Zoom for my current students."

"Are you saying you want to move here?"

She tilted her head from side to side playfully. “You know how much I love the UK. And, I mean, how can we be lovers if there is an ocean dividing us?”

“That is an excellent point.” I nuzzled her nose with my own.

“Fitz,” she whispered seriously. “You mean for us to be a forever kind of thing, right? I’m not asking for a proposal right now, but if I move here, I want to know that it’s not for play—as much as I love playing with you.” She squinted her eyes and scrunched her cute button nose. “That came out wrong,” she laughed. “But you know what I mean. We’ve crossed a line we can’t turn back from, and I can’t stand the thought of us not being together.”

“Nor can I,” I interjected. “This is a forever thing.” I would propose to her now, but I wanted a more romantic setting—and I’d been hoping to use my grandmother’s ring, which I would need to ask my mother for. It was not a conversation I looked forward to.

“Wow. We really defined our relationship fast.” She smiled the smile I adored so much.

“I was thinking it took far too long, but I bear the blame for that.”

“Maybe we needed to make our mistakes in love so that we could get it right together.” She always looked on the bright side, and I loved her for it.

“Perhaps.” I brushed my lips over hers. “Or I was just a knobhead.”

“I do like that word.” She giggled before asking seriously, “What if I’m a terrible duchess?”

I brushed back her silky hair. “I think that you should make the title your own. Don’t let it define you—you define it.”

She threw her arms around my neck. “That might be the sexiest thing you’ve said to me yet.”

“I have sexier things to say,” I assured her.

“I’m all ears.” Her lips met mine. Unfortunately, there was an interruption in the form of a knock on the door.

Monroe’s lips slid off mine. “These dang nurses keep doing their jobs too well,” she said lightheartedly. She straightened up before saying, “Come in.”

I stayed on the bed with her. The nurses and doctors were used to it by now, and if they needed me to move, I would.

But it wasn’t a nurse who walked in; it was Winnifred, dressed as Miss Bingley in a velvet gown. She looked alarmed to see Monroe and me in bed

together with a movie playing in the background. “I’m obviously interrupting.” She froze by the door.

Monroe’s wide eyes said she was just as stunned to see Winnifred as I was. “It’s okay—we can make out anytime.” Monroe smirked, knowing exactly what she was doing. I couldn’t fault her—Winnifred had been nothing short of awful to her.

Winnifred held her head high, but she wrung her hands and refused to make eye contact. “Yes, I see you are clearly a couple.”

“Why are you here, Winnifred?” I asked coolly while pausing the movie. Her deplorable behavior after Monroe’s accident was something I could never forget.

“I came to apologize,” she mumbled, as if she couldn’t believe it herself. “I saw your interview during our leisure time last night, and it made me feel ashamed of my behavior.”

Monroe’s jaw dropped.

Even I was stunned by Winnifred’s admission. “I appreciate your candor.”

She let out a meaningful sigh. “I suppose candor is all we have left. I should have been more honest with myself. It was obvious you did not regard me as I’d wished for.”

Her admission eased my conscience. I would hate to think I’d strung her along or given her false hope. “I hope you find happiness,” I said sincerely.

She half shrugged. “I’m sure I will. I wish you the best of luck—you’re going to need it when you face your mother.” Her lips ticked up. “Ta-ta. I have to get back to the park.” She turned to leave, having said her piece.

“Wait,” Monroe called. “Who is playing Elizabeth and Darcy?”

“Your friend Macey, and the man she brought,” Winnifred replied, sounding displeased.

“Oh, that makes me so happy.” Monroe patted her heart. “Maybe my falling off the horse wasn’t such a bad thing after all. Maybe it even helped,” she said more to herself.

Winnifred rolled her eyes before walking out the door.

“I guess it was too much to ask that she was really sorry,” Monroe quipped.

“I think in a small way she is, but she is my mother’s pet.”

“Ugh. Your mum. Have you talked to her?”

“Not yet, but she has left me several colorful messages.” I would deal with her later.

“I won’t be able to avoid her, will I?” Monroe bit her lip.

“I’m afraid she is part of the package. If this changes your mind, I understand.”

Monroe tsked. “Are you kidding me? I trifled with Lady Catherine, which means I can certainly trifle with the dowager duchess.”

I chuckled, loving her spirit. “They are cut from the same cloth. Which reminds me: Do you wish to go back to the park? I have no doubt Agatha will allow us to resume our roles.”

She placed her hands on my cheeks and squished them in Monroe style. “I wouldn’t do that to Macey. And honestly, I feel like I experienced *Pride and Prejudice* more intimately than I ever expected.”

Monroe had spoken of it often. I’d never heard anyone speak of a dream in such detail before. It had obviously left quite an impression on her.

“Besides, I don’t want to pretend to be anyone besides Monroe and Fitz anymore,” she added.

I concurred. For the last thirteen years, all I’d ever wanted was to be Monroe and Fitz.

“But . . .” Monroe grinned. “I do want to dance with you at the ball in one of the dresses I made.”

“I do like those dresses.” Pulling her close, I wrapped my arms around her and laid us down on the bed.

Monroe giggled as we came face-to-face. “Yes, I saw you peeking when I changed in the back seat of your car.”

“Guilty,” I confessed, not ashamed in the least.

“So, will you dance with me at the ball, Your Grace?”

“You realize that will be your title one day too, my love?” I reminded her, needing to know she was on board for the wild ride ahead of us.

She gave me a wary smile. “Wow, this is getting real. I like real. But I love you even more.”

“This is excellent news.” I leaned in to kiss her.

“What about that dance?” She wasn’t letting it go.

“It would be my honor to escort *you* to the ball.”

She smiled. “Very good. Now you may kiss me.”

That was the plan for the rest of my life.

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# THIRTY

***"She began now to comprehend that he was exactly the man who, in disposition and talents, would most suit her."***

## MONROE

IT FELT WEIRD DRIVING THROUGH the gates of Pride and Prejudice Park on Sunday afternoon—so much had happened in a week's time. Here I thought I would just be living out my dreams; instead, I got a reality that was much better than anything I could ever have imagined.

Fitz's fingers curled around mine as he drove us up the long drive. He wore a cravat for my pleasure and kept his cheeks perfectly stubbly, just the way I liked them. We drove past many of the townspeople dressed in Regency period clothing, walking up the lane to attend the "wedding" and the ball afterward. It was fun that the park included them in the festivities.

Watching them walk gave me flashbacks from my vivid dream and my trips into Meryton—I still found it so strange a dream could seem so real. I swore some of the people in the lane looked familiar, but that couldn't be. Maybe I'd just seen them around town the last couple of days when Fitz, Dad, and I had been out walking. We'd rented a cute little cottage after Dr. Taylor cleared me to be released from the hospital on Friday afternoon. Since Dad was still in town, I didn't want to return to the park, even to stay the night, and miss spending time with him—especially considering I would move to the UK in the near future. How soon, I didn't know. There were things we needed to work out, like a visa allowing me to have permanent residency here and all the logistics of selling my place back home. But that was a worry for another day.

For now, I wanted to focus on being in this place with Fitz. I'd come here hoping I'd discover my inner Elizabeth, and maybe I had—just in a different way than I expected. I admired Elizabeth for her free spirit, for

following her heart, and for not seeing what was right in front of her—the man who valued her mind and heart. Her story was one of two imperfect people who learned and grew together in mutual admiration, respect, and love, even bucking the societal constraints of their day. Though I no longer wanted to be Elizabeth, I had to give her credit for the lessons she and Darcy had taught me. And for that, I would always love her. *Pride and Prejudice* would continue to live in my heart—and maybe even my own version too. After all, life was always sweeter without pride and prejudice. I think Elizabeth and Mr. Darcy would agree.

"How are you feeling, love?" Fitz asked as he put the car in park and we waited for a footman to help us out. He was still worried about me after the fall, even though the doctor had given me a clean bill of health. Dr. Taylor did advise me not to fly back home for a few more days, though. What a shame—I guess it meant I would just have to spend more time with Fitz at his estate. His mum wouldn't like that, but we would have to come to some sort of truce, she and I. That fun would begin tomorrow.

I leaned over and straightened his cravat. "I feel like the luckiest woman in the world." For that, he rewarded me with a quick peck. "People are staring at us." I bit my lip—I was trying to get used to that.

"Well, look at how gorgeous you are. They can't help themselves." Fitz smiled, knowing darn well it was because of his interview. He'd been getting a lot of attention from it. Kingston had been fielding calls nonstop from several news organizations wanting to interview Fitz, and even me.

"Nice try."

"You are gorgeous."

"And bruised." The back of my head still had a nice bump, and my back, shoulders, legs, and arms had their fair share of purple and blue areas. My pretty pink dress covered most, but there was no hiding all of them.

"It's a miracle that's the extent of your injuries."

"I know." I squeezed his hand.

A footman opened my door. He was so cute, but I didn't mention it.

Fitz came around the car and offered me his arm. Several onlookers waved at us, and a few called out, "Your Grace!" and "Monroe!"

This was so weird. Fitz and I waved as he ushered us into the main house, a.k.a. Rosings Park, a.k.a. Pemberley. "How do people know my name?" I whispered to Fitz.

"How do people know anything nowadays?" he muttered.

“People are looking me up online?” I shuddered to think of the possibility, after all the silly pictures I’d posted of myself over the years. Yikes.

“Undoubtedly,” he responded.

“That doesn’t sound kosher.”

Fitz chuckled but said somberly, “I’m afraid it’s the price of admission into my world.”

“I guess it’s a good thing I love you so much.” Note to self: scrub my social media accounts stat.

“That’s a very good thing.”

We walked into the house, and Lady Catherine immediately greeted us, all smiles now. “We are so happy you have returned. I was so worried about you, dear.” She awkwardly patted my shoulder.

Uh-huh. I wasn’t buying her 180-degree turnaround. Fitz had mentioned that he’d told her off after my accident. She probably worried he’d sink the place or give an interview that painted the park in a poor light.

Realizing I, too, was in the public eye now, I responded graciously, “Thank you.”

“Come with me to the ballroom. We are all preparing there for the grand finale.” She sashayed in front of us, her gray wig bouncing.

As we walked through the bustling halls, the sound of hurried footsteps echoed in the air. Staff members scurried around, their hands occupied with delicate vases of fragrant white roses. The sweet scent of the flowers floated in the air, adding a touch of elegance to the scene. Amid the commotion, I couldn’t help but be captivated by the enchanting aura of the place. It seemed more magical now as I entered it, without feeling the need to be anyone but myself. What a gift that was, and I owed it all to this place, my crazy imagination, and of course, my favorite book.

We entered the ballroom, which was set up with actual pews for the wedding guests. Before I could take it all in, the “Bennet family” rushed toward us. They were all dressed in their finest, especially Macey, who was in an ivory wedding gown with a gorgeous embroidered lace bodice. She was positively glowing—it must have been an enjoyable week. I couldn’t wait to ask her all about it.

Mr. and Mrs. Bennet reached me first. Fitz let go of me just in time before they both put their arms around me. “We were so worried about you.” Mrs. Bennet kissed my cheek.

Mr. Bennet gave me a mischievous smile with a twinkle in his eye. If it weren't totally crazy, I would swear that he knew about my dream and how he'd helped me remember it was okay to be myself. But that wasn't possible. He was probably just happy to see me not unalive. I was extremely grateful for that, too.

Next was Mary. She beamed at me before hugging me. "Guess who asked me out?" she whispered in my ear.

"Who?"

"Mr. Collins. I mean Sebastian."

"Really? Did you find out if he likes boiled potatoes?" I teased her.

She giggled. "I'm not sure, but I'll definitely ask."

Lydia and Kitty pushed their way in. To what must have been Lady Catherine's distress, they were not using proper British accents.

"'Ello there! You doin' awright?" Lydia asked.

"Much better now, thank you."

"You sure took a fall," Kitty said.

"Yes, I did." I kept glancing at Macey, eager to speak to her. It was weird, but I was thankful for her presence as Jane in my dream. There had been something comforting about it. Though we hardly knew each other, she was one of those people I immediately connected with. She'd shown me so much kindness after my ill-fated rendezvous in the woods with Fitz. That seemed like a lifetime ago.

Lady Catherine took the opportunity to speak to Fitz while I was otherwise engaged. I wondered what she had to say, but it would have to wait.

Finally, I got my turn with Macey. We embraced for several moments.

"You look beautiful," I complimented her.

"As do you." She gave me one more squeeze before letting go.

"How was your week?" I needed to know everything. I noticed her Mr. Darcy lingering nearby, glancing at her often. "How did it go with Zane?" I added.

She bit her lip. "Better than expected." Her tone implied that it was much, much better.

I pulled her closer to me. "Spill the tea."

She laughed. "I don't know what to say. It was good. So good, it doesn't seem real."

I knew that feeling. "Uh-huh."

“Well, how about you?” She nodded toward Fitz.

“Oh, him?” I teased. “He speaks great *duke*. Like, really good.”

Macey giggled. “I’m happy for you. The man does know how to write a good letter.”

“Yeah, he does.”

“Ooh, I do have some news you might find interesting.” She leaned in closer and whispered in my ear, “You’ll never believe who Zane and I caught making out in the stables.”

“Who?” I was more than curious.

“Your ex and Lady Winnifred.”

My eyes bugged out, and for a moment, I lost the ability to speak. “No way! Are you serious?”

“Totally serious.” Macey looked as shocked as I felt. “But,” she lowered her voice, “even more interesting is that Kitty overheard Tony telling a staff member he only came here because he’d been trying to make the park refund the money he’d paid them for your honeymoon, but they said it was impossible. Somehow, though, he’d charmed someone involved with the park, and they hatched a plan for him to come work here. Whoever this person is told him lots of rich women pay to come here and play a part and they are always looking for love.”

My mouth fell open. “So, he came to catch a rich woman?”

“Sounds like it.”

“Oh my gosh. He’s such a Wickham. How did I miss that?”

Macey patted my arm. “Don’t beat yourself up about it; he obviously knows how to charm people and make them believe he’s someone he’s not.”

Still. I felt icky. And even if I was a little giddy to know that Winnifred had made out with a plumber, I knew I needed to warn her about Tony. No one deserved that—not even Winnifred. Why she even wanted him, I didn’t know. Wasn’t he a commoner like me?

Regardless, I had to make sure Winnifred stayed clear of him and made sure the park knew what was going on. The question was, who was Tony working with at the park?

Speaking of Tony, I noticed he was doing his best to stay clear of us. Fine by me. I still couldn’t believe he’d embezzled funds from his own family. No wonder his mom had been so upset. They were seriously the nicest folks. Well, his days of hurting people were numbered. Fitz and I would make sure of it.

“My dearest Monroe,” Lady Catherine trilled while she swept in, interrupting my time with Macey. “I was telling His Grace that we would love it if you two would take your roles back for the wedding and be our Elizabeth and Mr. Darcy.” What an awful thing to say in front of Macey.

“No, thank you,” I said while looking at Macey, hoping Lady Catherine’s callous words hadn’t hurt her. Macey smiled at me gratefully.

“Well,” Lady Catherine said, taken aback. “I just thought it would be fitting.”

I reached for Fitz, and he took my hand. “We don’t want to pretend. This is the real deal.”

“All right, then.” She marched off, clearly unhappy.

“I’d better go get ready to reenact the last scene.” Macey beamed.

“Good luck.” I waved before turning back to Fitz. “I have something to tell you.” I whispered in his ear what Macey had just relayed to me about Tony and Winnifred.

Fitz stiffened, clenching his fists, but he remained calm.

“What should we do?” I asked, once I finished my tale.

“For now we will remain discreet, given we are in public.” He was treading carefully, trying to not crush my spirit. For that, I loved him.

“Fitz, I hope you know that I realize I will have to make some changes too. This isn’t all on you. Relationships are about compromising. And maybe I don’t want to rescue Winnifred right away.” I impishly grinned. Oh, don’t worry, I would talk to her before the night was over—discreetly, of course. The last thing I wanted was another picture in the *Daily Mail*.

Fitz rested a hand on my cheek. “You are incredible.”

“You’re not so bad yourself.”

Fitz offered me his arm, and I gladly took it.

“Are you sad that you missed out on this week?” he asked.

I looked around the beautiful ballroom draped in delicate garlands made of greenery and flowers. The altar up front was surrounded by even more flowers. While it was wonderful, I felt as if this week had given me something better: confidence in myself and my person, Fitz. While make-believe was important, it could never supersede reality. The best love stories are those we get to live, as messy as they are, with no guarantees of happy endings. “No.” I peered into Fitz’s broody eyes, which gazed at me adoringly. “I didn’t miss out on anything.”

Fitz leaned in and pressed his lips to mine.

“You’re going to get us in trouble for engaging in a romantic pursuit,” I mumbled against his lips.

“I intend to pursue you for the rest of my life,” Fitz said, low and sexy.

“Mr. Darcy has nothing on you.” I grabbed his jacket and laid one on him. Well, it was more of a church kiss. We were kind of in church. Regardless, he reached the depths of my being, just from the gentle touch of his soft lips moving over mine. He was that good. “We’d better find our seats,” I said as people started pouring in. Many of their eyes landed on us. I was going to have to get used to that.

Fitz guided us to the second row, where we took our seats behind the Bennets for the double wedding. It looked like some staff members had filled in for Jane and Mr. Bingley.

As they set up for the scene, it got me to thinking that maybe someday soon I would plan another wedding and honeymoon. Who would have known that both honeymoons would be with Fitz? I wondered what we could do to top this experience, including me not spending most of it in the hospital.

“Fitz,” I whispered, “where should we go on our next honeymoon?”

He looked around the sizable crowd before he faced me, his gaze intense but tender. “Somewhere with the just the two of us.”

“Just the two of us.”

That sounded perfect.

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# THIRTY-ONE

***"She had never seen a place for which nature had done more, or where natural beauty had been so little counteracted by an awkward taste. They were all of them warm in their admiration; and at that moment she felt that to be mistress of Pemberley might be something!"***

## FITZ

I GLANCED OVER AT MONROE, who was gazing out the window as we drove through the security gate leading to Blackhaven—home. I smiled, thinking of waltzing with her last night. Agatha threw a fit about it. But there was no way I was going to do some country dance where we barely touched each other. I needed Monroe up close and personal. She had been a vision last night. I don't think she has any idea how she lights up a room. And did she ever light up the room last night. In typical Monroe fashion, she tried to warn Winnifred about Tony; to her credit, she'd tried to be discreet. However, she didn't realize how much attention she was getting, and someone overheard her. That led to, well . . .

"What are you thinking?" I asked, admittedly anxious. I kept waiting for Monroe to change her mind about all of this. My interview had the unintended consequence of placing us in the limelight. It was a lot for anyone to take in, especially someone like Monroe, who never did things for show and had not grown up in the public eye. And the public eye had definitely been on her. Then there was the matter of her coming face-to-face with my mother today. It was a lot to ask.

Monroe continued to look outside the window at the woods and stream on her side of the vehicle. It was my favorite part of the property. As a boy, I would walk barefoot up and down the stream each summer, searching for smooth pebbles and trying to catch a fish with my bare hands.

“It’s just hitting me now that being with you means this could be my home.”

And that is why I love her. She never calculated or schemed, never concerned herself with my wealth. I placed my hand on her thigh. “It would honor me if you considered this your home.”

She turned and smiled, but it twisted into a grimace. “I know that, and I love that, but Fitz,” she whined, “all those pictures online this morning . . . Now everyone thinks I’m in some rivalry with Winnifred, and then Tony was arrested for stealing some of the antiques from the park. I don’t think Agatha will ever invite us back.”

That was fine by me. “I’m having a hard time seeing the downside here.” As far as I was concerned, Monroe drawing attention to what a berk Tony is was a good thing. It made Agatha search his room, just in case. The man deserved to be in jail.

“Oh, ha ha. I created another disaster, all the while trying to save Winnifred, who obviously didn’t want my help. Surely your mum has read the articles and seen the pictures that made it look like we were having a catfight. Seeing her again today is going to be like that time you gave me archery lessons and I accidentally shot an arrow through your mother’s window. Remember how I ran up there to clean up the mess but made it worse when I cut myself and bled on her rug that was a gift from the Queen? And to top it off, I knocked over the urn with her favorite dog’s ashes in it, and, not realizing what it was, I tried to sweep it up with the glass.”

I chuckled, remembering how livid Mother had been. She’d tried to get me to swear I would never bring Monroe home with me again. Of course, I made no such promise.

“Love.” I squeezed her thigh. “My mother’s opinion means little to me. She loves her dogs more than she loves me or Anna. Honestly, I’d move her to the cottage on the property if I hadn’t promised my father right before he died that I’d watch over her and let her remain in her suite. It stunned me so much to know he had any affection for anyone but himself that I readily agreed without thinking about it.”

Monroe took my hand in hers and cradled it. “I know how cold and difficult your childhood was. I wish I could make that better.”

“You have. Your warmth and love have made all the difference in my life. I hope you will bring that to this place I love, that our children will

know what it is like to be loved and cherished."

She brought our clasped hands up and kissed mine. "Do you really want to have children with me?" her voice cracked. "You've never talked about having children."

I glanced over at her. "That's because you are the only woman I've ever imagined having children with."

"You know I want lots of babies," she warned.

"I am aware and ready."

She leaned over and kissed my cheek. "Okay, fine, I'll have babies with you and live on your gorgeous estate with your evil mother." She laughed. "Of course, I'm going to try to win her over."

If anyone could win Mother over, it would be Monroe, but that might require a greater miracle than Monroe's medical miracle. "Darling, please promise me you won't let her get you down. She's a bitter woman, for reasons I don't know. She's lived as charmed a life as anyone I know, yet she's still unhappy. I would hate for her to make you unhappy. You are my priority."

Monroe settled back into her seat and thought for a moment. "You know what? We are going to make her so happy, she won't know what to do with herself. Or I'll accidentally burn the estate down trying to make her happy—it's a toss-up. Well, with my track record, you'd probably better make sure your homeowner's policy, or whatever it's called here in the UK, is up to date."

"I do love you, Monroe." Those were the only words adequate enough to express how much it meant to me that she even wanted to try. Even more, that she was willing to move here and start our life together. As a side note, I probably should have Kingston check to make sure our policies were all up to date.

"I love you too. So much." She gazed out the window as I drove around the circle drive in front of the house—a house, I hoped, that would soon be a home. The estate's stone facade had been updated over the years to include larger windows, and I'd recently renovated the pitch roof to accommodate green technology. But it still maintained its nineteenth-century character and charm.

"This feels significant," Monroe said.

I felt it too. It was different than bringing her here in years past, years when I could only hope for a moment like this. Or more accurately, when I

was too proud to think differently. I would always regret that choice. “Are you ready?”

“As ready as I’ll ever be.”

Anna and Kingston came walking out to greet us before we even exited the car.

“You know, that’s another thing I’m going to have to work on.” Monroe nodded toward Anna and Kingston, who stood close to each other, each clasping their hands as if they feared they might touch if they released them. I’d come to the conclusion that Monroe was right about the two of them. How had I missed it? Probably because I hadn’t wished to see it. That relationship would be another complicated one. But I was coming to see that complications were sometimes more a matter of perception than reality. And most of them required letting go of pride and unreasonable expectations. The Fitzroys, unfortunately, were full of both.

“Be careful,” I cautioned. “I don’t think they are ready yet.”

Monroe gave me a thoughtful look. “All right. I’ll wait for the right time. In the meantime, I need to rock your mum’s world.”

Was her world ever about to be rocked.

Kingston helped Monroe out of the car.

Anna raised her eyebrows at me. No doubt Mother had seen the online trash this morning. Monroe would be baptized by fire, as they say. It was maddening too, seeing as no one was supposed to have brought their mobile phones into the ball. Really, it had been Winnifred who made a big production out of it. I think she was so embarrassed that someone had caught her kissing a plumber and felon that she overreacted. And I don’t think she liked that Monroe, of all people, knew about it and wanted to help her. Like I said, pride complicates everything.

“Colette has prepared tea for us,” Anna commented. Colette was a member of the estate’s staff.

Monroe sidled up to me and took my hand. “Did she make her shortbread biscuits?”

“Just for you.” Anna smiled.

I was just now realizing how much happier Anna was when Monroe was around—not that I saw a lot of Anna. She traveled often and owned a flat in London. She kept her suite here, but she rarely visited. I imagined once Monroe moved in, she would visit more often.

“Cookies make everything better.” Monroe swung our hands between us as we walked through the double cedar doors.

We paused in the entryway on the polished marble floor under the crystal chandelier that had been in my family for over a century. Both of Mother’s Cavalier King Charles spaniels ran down the staircase, yipping all the way and running straight for Monroe as if they’d known she’d arrived.

Monroe crouched down, waiting for them.

I stood, admittedly nervous, knowing Mother wouldn’t be far behind. I’d only talked to her once in the past week, and that was just to let her know that Monroe was my choice and there was nothing she could do or say to change my mind about it. To say she was unhappy was a vast understatement. When I asked for my grandmother’s ring, she categorically refused to give it to me, saying I’d have to pry it off her cold, dead finger.

Mother did indeed follow her dogs. She wore a tailored navy pantsuit, her neck dripping in a diamond necklace. Grandmother’s ring was displayed prominently on her right ring finger. She never wore the ring, with its oval ruby surrounded by a halo cluster of diamonds, and I knew she was doing it just for spite. As she descended the stairs, staring coldly at Monroe playing with her beloved dogs, the air crackled with tension. Though Mother was petite and even a little frail, her narrowed pale-blue eyes said she was not to be trifled with.

“Hello, Mother,” I said as casually as possible.

She ignored me and walked straight to Monroe.

Monroe scratched each pup’s head one more time for good measure before standing and facing her opponent. Although Monroe was much taller than Mother, Mother’s contemptuous attitude added two feet to her stature.

We all stood, waiting to see what would happen. Both women sized each other up. Mother scowled, and Monroe’s face broke into a bright smile. “Oh, Mum B.” She threw her arms around Mother, who stood there stiffly, and rested her gorgeous head on top of Mother’s snowy-white hair. “We are going to be the best of friends. Two duchesses in a pea pod. By the way, I brought a bonnet for you.”

I had never loved Monroe more than at this moment. If I could, I would have married her on the spot. I knew then it would all work out. Monroe would be the finest Duchess of Blackthorne yet. English society had no idea what was in store for it. I don’t think I did either, but I couldn’t wait.

Mother untangled herself from Monroe's grasp, smoothing out her suit and looking indignant. She marched off without saying a word. When she was gone, snickers erupted from everyone, even from Kingston, who only ever showed the utmost respect for every member of our family.

I took Monroe's hand and pulled her flush against my body. "You are bloody brilliant."

"It's probably going to get bloody. She's going to be a tough nut to crack."

"You have no idea, darling." I gazed into her beautiful brown eyes. My future looked brighter than ever. Before I even thought about it, the question I'd wanted to ask her for years fell out of my mouth. "Will you marry me?" It was not the romantic setting that I'd imagined, but I had to know.

Silence fell among us.

Monroe blinked a few times as if I'd stunned her, but she quickly recovered and responded with a simple, "Yes."

Relief and hope like none other filled me. "This is most excellent news."

"The best news," Monroe said.

Anna clapped and exclaimed, "It's about time."

It was about time, and I would waste no more of it.

Monroe's lips teased my own, but before I could capture them, she smiled and quoted Elizabeth Bennet, "Now, be sincere; did you admire me for my impertinence?"

"That and more." Monroe had taught me to love without pride and prejudice. For that, I would always love her.

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# THIRTY-TWO

***"Oh, Lizzy! Do anything rather than marry without affection."***

## MONROE

"IS THIS CRAZY? ARE WE doing this too soon?" I asked my dad as I held on to him tightly and looked around the incredible, although masculine, bathroom with dark wood and stone tile. Within a few hours, I could officially call it my own, and it definitely needed a feminine touch—although the clawfoot tub was to die for. I didn't feel like Fitz and I were rushing, but some would disagree—mainly Mum B. She still hated it when I called her that.

Dad, in his tux, chuckled and squeezed me tight. "Honey, you would be crazy not to get married so soon. Take it from a man who lost the love of his life: Seize these moments and cherish them, and each other. You two kids have loved each other for so long, it only seems right."

He always knew the right thing to say. Not that I was having any doubts about Fitz, but I was nervous about taking on the title of the Duchess of Blackthorne and being daughter-in-law to a woman who refused to come to our wedding. The only thing I was doing right in her estimation was trying to keep the wedding a secret from the press. It embarrassed her to think that soon I would be part of her family.

"Thank you, Dad. I love you. So much." I kissed his cheek.

"Right back at ya, kiddo." Dad leaned away, grabbed my hands, and gave me a good once-over in my simple but elegant A-line wedding gown. His eyes filled with tears. "You look so much like your mother. She is smiling down from heaven today. You were her world."

My eyes filled with moisture. I'd thought of her so often these past couple of months, especially as I talked to my therapist. She'd been helping me work through the trauma of watching my mom die. And she'd helped

me to realize I don’t need to save the world. Not that she thinks it’s bad that I help others, but she’s trying to help me be, let’s say, more selective. Sadly, there haven’t been any new reasons to wear a bonnet in public. Maybe someday.

“I miss her,” I managed to say through the lump in my throat. “Especially today. Although, you do good hair.” Dad had gone to a hairstylist after Mom died and had her teach him how to do my hair. He was truly the best dad ever. Today, he’d done a great chignon.

Dad chuckled. “You look beautiful. You’re simply glowing.”

I did feel all lit up from the inside out. I took that as a sign that I was doing the right thing. “You’re not so bad yourself.” I straightened Dad’s bow tie. “Should we do this?”

Dad offered me his arm. “Let’s get this party started.”

I strung my arm through Dad’s, and we strode through the bathroom door to find Fitz in his room, looking oh so fine. No cravat, but dang, could he rock a tux. And his taut jawline was perfectly stubbly, just the way I loved it.

“Fitz, it’s bad luck for you to see me,” I teased.

Fitz’s eyes roved over me from head to toe. I could tell he was doing his best not to look too salaciously at me with my dad there. “I couldn’t wait any longer to see you, my bride,” the words got caught in his throat.

That was it, I was going to have to redo my makeup at this rate. Tears trickled down my cheeks.

“I’ll give you two a moment.” Dad kissed my head and skedaddled.

Fitz was to me in no time, wrapping me in his arms.

We held on to each other tightly.

“My beautiful best friend,” Fitz whispered.

“I thought we were lovers.” I giggled through my happy tears.

“We are much more than that.” Fitz leaned away just enough to gaze into my eyes.

We were definitely more than that. I wasn’t sure there was a word to explain it other than that he was my person and I was his. It had been that way since the day we met. I reached up and lightly danced my fingers across Fitz’s cheeks, wishing I could find the words to tell him how much he meant to me. They didn’t come, yet somehow he understood.

“I know,” he said. “Me too.”

“Look at us, speaking telepathically.”

Fitz smiled his dashing smile. “I love you, Monroe.”

“I love you more.”

“Impossible.” His lips brushed mine so reverently.

I let him have that one. “All right, almost husband, let’s go get hitched.”

Fitz grinned. “First, I have a surprise for you.” He took my hand.

“I love surprises.”

“Yes, I know.” He tugged me along through his bedroom and out into the hall that literally had a knight in shining armor, a medieval piece that Fitz’s family had passed down through generations. It was kind of creepy, but I hadn’t mentioned it yet.

As we passed Beatrix’s suite, I pulled Fitz’s hand and stopped. “Maybe we should give her one more chance to say no to us.” I’d been trying to get her to come for days now, knowing it would mean a lot to Fitz.

“Darling, don’t waste your breath.”

“It’s not wasted. I know you want her there.”

Fitz ran a finger down my cheek. “You are amazing.”

“So are you.” I nudged him with my hip before I knocked on Beatrix’s door. “Mum B.,” I called. “We are heading for the chapel. We’d love it if you came with us.” That was mostly true. “It’s not every day you get to see a brand-new duchess come to life.” I had to needle her a little. She’d been awful to me and had gone so far as to say I was an American abomination and I was besmirching the name of Fitzroy.

Unexpectedly, she threw open the door. This was progress—normally she just ignored me. Her beady eyes immediately landed on me, scrutinizing everything about me. Consternation filled her features as if she couldn’t find anything wrong with my dress or the way I looked.

“Well, you at least don’t look horrid.”

“Wow. How kind of you to say,” I said playfully, because I knew she wanted me to be offended. But honestly, that’s one of the nicest things she’d ever said to me.

Her face pinched, folding in on itself. “You’re still not getting the ring.”

I patted Fitz’s chest. “Fine by me. This guy is all I want.”

“Ugh,” she spat. “Be off, and don’t embarrass us.”

“No guarantees there.” I winked.

Fitz chuckled, earning him a scathing scowl from his mother before she slammed the door on us.

“That went better than I thought it would. I think I’m wearing her down.”

Fitz shook his head and grinned. “Only you would think so.”

“I’ll keep trying.”

“For that, I love you. Now, come see your surprise.”

I followed Fitz down the expansive hall until we made it to the stairs. Down below were more people than I expected. We’d kept the ceremony small on purpose, hoping it would remain a private affair.

“Fitz,” I cried when I saw not only Dad and Grams and Anna and Kingston, who were standing up for us as maid of honor and best man. But there was also Laila and Davis Gray, Macey, Zane, Calliope, Carla, and Ava, my Pride and Prejudice Park family. I’d kept in touch with everyone, feeling oddly connected to them in ways I couldn’t explain. Although I knew my dream had been just that—a dream—I still couldn’t help but feel as if each person smiling up at me had helped me remember who I was and led me to this place, here with Fitz.

“I knew you’d want them here.” Fitz kissed my cheek.

“I love you,” I said, blazing down the stairs as fast as my gown would let me to reach my “pretend” family.

Laila and Davis rushed forward to wrap their arms around me as soon as my feet hit the landing. “Our beautiful *daughter*,” they said in unison, making me smile. “Looks like you figured it all out,” Davis said mysteriously.

I leaned away from him, tilting my head. Sometimes I swore he knew about the dream, but that couldn’t be. Just for fun I said, “Yes, Mr. Bennet.”

He gave me a wink and my *sisters* greeted me next.

“Thank you for being here,” I gushed as I hugged each one.

“We wouldn’t miss it for the world.” Macey beamed with that new-love glow. Of course, I knew all about her and Zane figuring out they belonged together, but it was fun to see her so happy.

“Look at you lookin’ like a duchess.” Carla flicked her head at me.

“You look very pretty,” Ava added.

“Yes, she does.” Fitz took my side. “Thank you all for being here,” Fitz said regally. “If you all wouldn’t mind following Kingston to the cars.”

We watched our family and guests leave. I made to follow, but Fitz held me back.

“Just a moment, please.” He stared lovingly into my eyes. “Monroe,” he whispered. “Your love has ‘fixed’ me in ways I can’t enumerate. You may have fallen in front of me, but it was I who truly fell.”

I wanted to melt into a puddle of goo right there. “I love when you *talk duke* to me.”

“I can’t wait for you to *talk duchess* to me,” he groaned.

“Well then, let’s go make me a duchess, because you are exactly the man who, in disposition and talents, most suits me.”

“You had to throw a little *Pride and Prejudice* in there,” he teased.

If it weren’t for *Pride and Prejudice*, I didn’t know if we would be here.

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# EPILOGUE

**Valentine's Day**

***"You must allow me to tell you how ardently I admire and love you."***

## MONROE

I TIPTOED PAST MUM B.'s suite, only because I didn't have time today for our usual tête-à- tête—more like verbal sparring matches that Beatrix apparently lived for. She wasn't exactly the warmest mother-in-law.

It was Valentine's Day, and I'd been planning a romantic night at home in front of the fireplace with Fitz's favorite meal, and me in something sexy. Colette had just finished helping me make an Indian curry dish and decorate his library in cutesy Valentine's decorations I knew he would think were ridiculous, but that's how we rolled in this relationship. I just needed to change and grab my gift for him before he came home.

I'd given the staff, including Kingston, the rest of the night off. I'd hinted to Kingston that he should take Anna out, but they were so stubborn. Kingston's newest excuse was that Anna was too young for him. A twelve-year age gap didn't seem like a lot to me. He didn't want anyone to think that he was being untoward, but Fitz and I would never think such a thing. I could still understand his caution, even though it was heartbreaking to watch them fight their feelings. And I think some things had happened between them that they were keeping secret.

I barely made it past Beatrix's door when her pups, Alfie and Oscar, came running out, giving me away.

"Is that *you*?" Beatrix called.

That's basically how she addressed me: *you*.

"Yes, it's me, the duchess," I responded, knowing she loathed that I'd received her title. It's not like I loved it, other than it meaning I was married

to Fitz. So far, I had done nothing too embarrassing in the public eye. Other than at Viscount Phillips's Christmas party—the same viscount who had beat Fitz for hottest eligible bachelor in the UK. Still didn't agree with that assessment. Anyway, in my haste to help one of the waitstaff steady a tray of hors d'oeuvres she was about to drop, I tripped over my own feet and went hurtling into her and, well . . . It was a mess. It was a good thing Viscount Phillips has such a good sense of humor.

"Enter," she said tersely. Why she thought I wished to come into her room, I had no idea, but I knew it was best to just get it over with.

With the pooches by my side, I walked into her elegantly decorated sitting area, which was larger than most of the bedrooms in the mansion. Intricately carved tables and plush velvet furniture adorned the room. She spent most of her time holed up in here with her harp and shelves full of books. I'd heard her play it a few times, but she didn't appreciate when I mentioned how much I enjoyed it. Heaven forbid she did anything I liked.

"Can I get you anything?" I asked as soon as I walked in to find her sitting on the couch, going through a box of what looked like old letters. Mr. Darcy, my cat, was curled up next to her. Beatrix would never admit it but she loved my cat, and for some reason, Mr. Darcy loved her. It was kind of cute. I didn't draw attention to it or she would have told me to keep better watch of my cat. Little did she know, I'd seen her on more than one occasion lure my kitty into her room with a can of tuna. In fact, her room faintly smelled of tuna now.

Her head snapped up, her brow scrunching. "I wish to speak to you."

I leaned against the doorframe, hoping this wouldn't take long. "What about?"

She set the box aside and sat up tall in her silk pajamas and robe. It surprised me she was wearing pajamas so early in the evening.

"Don't think I'm not aware of everyone's opinion of me. I know you and my children believe I am a cold-hearted old woman."

That about summed it up, but I didn't argue the point. I mean, she'd refused to attend our wedding. And though it had been Fitz's grandmother's wish for him to gift his wife her wedding ring, Beatrix wouldn't hear of me wearing it. Not that I didn't love the sparkler he'd given me, but Fitz's grandmother had meant a lot to him. According to Fitz, she was much warmer than his mother. The ring would have had sentimental value, and I love sentimentality.

I said nothing. This felt like a trap, and I just wanted to get ready for my husband.

When I didn't respond, Beatrix continued with a huff. "You don't think that I used to be happy and have dreams of my own? Well, I did."

This was definitely news to me. "What dreams?" I asked.

She adjusted herself and swallowed hard. "I was in love once, too."

"I'm sure you loved Reginald." That was Fitz's father.

"Yes," she admitted. "At one time I was very much in love with him, but . . ."

"But what?" I stepped farther into the room, more than curious now.

"Things change. Love doesn't always last," she said, like she was warning me.

"But it can."

"That's what the young always think."

"I love Fitz—I mean Alastair." She hated my nickname for him. "We've loved each other for a long time."

"You were wise to become friends first," she said in a hushed tone, like she didn't want me to hear her.

Huh. She thought I'd done something smart. "I think so."

"Anyway." She took her mother's ring off her hand. "You can have this."

"Is this a trick?"

Her lips ticked up slightly. Oh my gosh, was she going to smile? I didn't know she could do that. "Just take it," she snapped.

I tiptoed toward her, a little afraid. I peeked at the letters in the box, and they seemed to be love letters from Reginald. Some of them were yellow and faded, but a few of them had hearts drawn on them. *What made them drift away from each other?* I wondered. I hesitated to take the ring out of her aged, but well-manicured, hand.

"I mean it; you can have it. My son is obviously in love with you. Quite frankly, it's nauseating how in love you two seem to be."

I couldn't help but giggle.

She wrinkled her nose. "That said, you are good for him."

"What?" I asked, stunned.

"Don't expect me to repeat it," she barked. "Take the ring and go. And try to keep it down. I don't need to hear any of your sexual escapades tonight."

I took the ring, still in shock and really hoping she'd never heard Fitz and me . . . well . . . you know. "Mum B.," I dared to say. "If you ever want to talk about what's in that box, I'm all ears."

She said nothing, but waved me away.

"I'll take that as a rain check." I pranced out of the room, carefully cradling the ring. It felt weird for me to swap my wedding ring for it. I would add it to Fitz's Valentine's Day gift and let him decide.

I rushed down the hall to our wing of the house and into our bedroom to change into the black slinky gown I'd bought for the occasion. The dress, barely more than a slip, was lying across the floral comforter. I'd added several womanly touches to the stately room with grand, dark wood furniture, including the pink parfait wallpaper with cream flowers I adored from Pride and Prejudice Park. Fitz didn't seem to mind. He'd said I was the best addition to his room.

I changed quickly and grabbed the small gift bag holding his present, carefully dropping his grandmother's ring into it. Before I walked out, I couldn't help but read the letter Fitz had left on my pillow this morning one more time. It was just a simple Valentine's Day note.

*My dearest Monroe,*

*Happy Valentine's Day. Thank you for continuing to love me without pride and prejudice.*

*All my love,*

*Fitz*

*PS: I plan on showing you more of my duke side tonight.*

Oh, baby, I could not wait.

I glided down the stairs, eager for tonight. Halfway down, Fitz opened the door, carrying a single red rose that was just starting to bloom. I don't know why, but I found that so romantic—maybe because I knew he'd picked out the perfect one just for me.

"Hello, lover," I purred.

Fitz's head snapped up, and he dropped his satchel. "Monroe," he said, like he was out of breath.

"Do you like?" I slinked down the rest of the stairs.

He met me at the bottom at lightning speed. "You are a vision." He handed me the rose before pulling me to him, smashing the flower and bag between us. His hands slid down all my curves. "Happy Valentine's Day to me."

A shiver that had nothing to do with how chilled his hands were went through me. My lips met his, and he immediately deepened the kiss, urgently twisting his tongue with mine. He pressed me against the nearest wall, and I dropped the bag and rose so that I could run my hands through his hair as his warm lips trailed kisses down my neck. I gasped when he worked his way back up and began to nuzzle my ear. It was then I remembered what his mother had said. “We need to take this into the library before your mum hears us. And I want to give you my gift before we go any further.”

“This is all the gift I need.” His fingers pressed into my bare back while he nipped my earlobe.

I held on to him, feeling woozy. So woozy. “Fitz,” I whispered, breathless. “Let’s go to the library.”

“As you wish.” He swept me up into his arms, managing to grab the gift bag too. The poor rose got left in the dust. Wild, passionate kissing ensued on our trek to the library. When we crossed the threshold, Fitz only came up for air because I’d filled the library with hundreds of paper hearts and balloons.

Fitz chuckled and shook his head.

“It kind of adds something to the broody vibes you have going on in here.”

He walked us over to the brick fireplace, where a fire was crackling nicely. I’d set a picnic blanket out in front of it. A basket full of food waited for us, but I had a feeling our food was going to get cold.

Fitz gently set me on the blanket. He shed his coat and kicked off his shoes before he joined me. He started unbuttoning his shirt.

I placed my hand over his furiously working ones. “Hold, please.” I smiled.

He groaned but stopped, his hungry eyes roving over me.

“I promise the wait will be worth it.”

“Of that I have no doubt.” His sexy smile begged me to hurry.

I reached for the bag next to me and handed it to him.

“Did you get my letter this morning?” he asked before looking in the bag.

“Uh-huh.” I felt all warm and fuzzy inside just thinking of it. As simple as it was, it was the perfect Valentine’s Day gift for me. “I was going to text

or call you about it, but I didn't want to interrupt any of your classes with my sexy words."

"Feel free to interrupt me anytime."

I smiled, knowing he meant that. "Open your gift."

He reached in and pulled out the ring first. I'd enclosed the other gift in a box. He pulled out the ring and stared blankly at it, alarmed. "Did my mother die?"

"No," I laughed. "But I about died when she gave it to me just moments ago. By the way, she thinks we are nauseatingly in love."

Fitz chuckled. "Why did she give it to you?"

I shrugged. "I don't know. Maybe she kind of likes me, or else she's cursed it."

Fitz stared at the ring. "I knew if anyone could get to her, it would be you."

"Well, I don't know about that, but today gave me some hope."

"Would you wear my grandmother's ring? It would mean a lot to me. To her. She would have loved you. She said I should only give this ring to the woman who would love me not only on the good days, but on the worst days as well."

"I love that." I held out my hands and let Fitz switch the ring he had given me to my right hand before he slipped his grandmother's ring on my left ring finger. It was a little big, but I held up my hand and admired it. "It's beautiful. I'm honored to wear it."

Fitz kissed my hand. He was such a romantic.

"There's one more gift for you. Well, for us." I grinned.

"Hmm." Fitz reached into the bag and pulled out the slender rectangular box. "This isn't a trip to Pride and Prejudice Park, is it?" he teased.

"No," I sang. "But you have to admit, we might not be here if it weren't for that place."

"Rubbish. I planned to have you regardless."

"Well, I admit, our second honeymoon in the Maldives over Christmas was better." At least I didn't fall off a horse or have any crazy dreams. "And . . . I think it contributed to what's in the box."

Fitz tilted his head, a question in his eyes.

"Open it," I encouraged, eager to see his response.

He opened the box and pulled out the pregnancy test. "Monroe," he said, astonished. "Are you—" he choked up, "pregnant?"

“Yes,” I cried. We’d decided we’d just let nature take its course since we’d known each other for years. “Are you happy?” I wasn’t sure. He seemed at a loss for words.

“Yes, love.” He snapped out of his stupor and wrapped his arms around me. “I’m more than happy.”

I fell against him. My head resting on his shoulder. “Me too. Very happy.”

I couldn’t help but think, *I am happier even than Jane; she only smiles, I laugh.*

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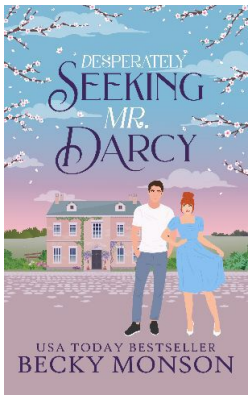


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**Jennifer Peel** is a *USA Today* best-selling author who didn't grow up wanting to be a writer—she was aiming for something more realistic, like being the first female president. When that didn't work out, she started writing just before her fortieth birthday. Now, after publishing several award-winning and best-selling novels, she's addicted to typing and chocolate. When she's not glued to her laptop and a bag of Dove dark chocolates, she loves spending time with her family, making daily Target runs, reading, and pretending she can do Zumba.

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